

GOLD MINING AND TRADE IN THE ETHIOPIAN-SUDANESE BORDERLANDS AND BLUE NILE STATE

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND AND ASSESSMENT OF THE
SITUATION IN 2019



ENRICO ILLE & MOHAMED SALAH ABDELRAHMAN

2026

© 2026 The authors.

This work is published under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives License (CC BY-NC-ND 4.0)

Cover image: Gold washers close to Qeissan, Sudan, 25 November 2019
© Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman

This book contains research conducted with the Rift Valley Institute in the frame of the X-Border Local Research Network, a component of the FCDO's Cross-Border Conflict—Evidence, Policy and Trends (XCEPT) programme, funded by UKaid from the UK government.

All views expressed in this work are solely those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect the positions or policies of the Center for Environmental and Social Studies (CESS).

Khartoum - Kampala - Cairo - Paris - Berlin

ISBN 978-3-912686-00-5



Contents

INTRODUCTION	1
PART 1: HISTORICAL BACKGROUND TO THE ETHIOPIAN-SUDANESE BORDERLANDS	2
A history of border consolidation	3
Border demarcation	3
Power politics and civil war	7
Blue Nile as province and state	9
Border trade policies and infrastructure	13
A history of borderland fluidity	20
Natural features and social exchange	21
Slavery and resettlement	26
Slavery	26
Resettlement	28
Emancipation	32
Trade and rule	34
Ethno-genesis	35
Trade	37
Rule	42
War and refuge	49
Refuge	50
Recruitment	53
Relations	54
Social definition of nationality	57
Fluidity as social discourse	57
Fluidity as social practice	59
Appendix 1: Interview with Waṭāwīt family	64
Appendix 2: Interview with sheikh	69

PART 2: EXCHANGE RELATIONS: GOLD	71
Gold sector regulation in Ethiopia	71
Mining in Benishangul	76
Exploration and licenses	76
Revenues and livelihoods	80
Locations and labour	84
Mining across the border	87
Local crossings	87
Refugees and environments	92
Paths of gold trade	94
License and legality	94
Production and profits	98
Conclusion: multiple legalities	102
PART 3: BLUE NILE STATE'S GOLD MARKETS IN 2019	104
Belguwa	107
Geographical and historical context	107
Residential and occupational structures	108
Labour and profits	112
Mines and lines	112
Shafts and shifts	114
Crushing and washing	115
Costs and benefits	116
Administrative control	121
Clashes	123
Bakori	127
Features of social and mining history	127
Mining activities	129
Market activities	132
Administrative control	134

Bulang	136
Settlement history	136
Mining	137
Operations	139
Finances	143
Administrative contexts	145
Military presence	150
Maganza	154
Working in the mines	154
Working in the market	156
Livelihoods and commerce	160
Military governance	163
 REFERENCES	 168

Introduction

Between 2019 and 2021, we documented gold extraction and distribution practices in and around the area of the former sultanate of Fazughli as part of a research framework focused on cross-border exchanges. The DFID-funded XCEPT programme defined this focus through its collaboration with the Rift Valley Institute in a component called X-Border Local Research Network,¹ for which we organised a field assessment of gold mining and trade in the central Sudan-Ethiopia borderland, between Qeissan and Kurmuk. On the Ethiopian side, we were joined by Tsegaye Birhanu, an Assosa-based political scientist, and we published the results of fieldwork conducted between March 2019 and March 2020 in 2021 (see Ille et al. 2021). However, both a historical introduction and the Blue Nile State-based information on gold mining practices remained unpublished. This book presents these previously unpublished results from our research, with a focus on the four largest gold markets.²

¹ See <https://www.xcept-research.org/about/>.

² There were further findings on smaller markets, such as Al-Deim, Ušambu and South Kurmuk, which we allude to only shortly.

Part 1: Historical background to the Ethiopian-Sudanese borderlands

The Ethiopian-Sudanese border has experienced significant fluctuations in its course and permeability throughout history, with notable differences between its northern, middle, and southern segments. The areas around Al-Fashaga have been and remain contested by farmers, armed gangs, armies, and governments of both countries; the regions near the Nile have seen relaxed border-crossing permissions for ethnic groups and families on both sides; and the Gambella region is a socially and economically integrated borderland dominated by a single group on both sides. Further inland, the situation appears different again: even in Wad Al-Mahi Locality, which was separated from Roseiris Locality, Ethiopians have a much lower, mostly seasonal presence as harvest workers, and intermarriage remains very rare. Many of them also come from Ethiopia's densely populated regions, particularly those inhabited by Amhara and Oromo communities, rather than directly from across the border. Other relations stem from violent events and subsequent displacement: for example, from the southern areas in Blue Nile state around Yabus, Sudanese fled into Ethiopia due to the wars that erupted there in 1987 and 2011, and still form large refugee camps near the town of Assosa and further south.

This chapter concentrates on the segment of the Ethiopian-Sudanese border that separates the present-day states of Beni Shangul-Gumuz and Blue Nile. It traces the recent history of this borderland, highlights the main developments in population mobility; in the subsequent chapter, we demonstrate, through the example of gold extraction and distribution, how these factors have influenced the spheres of exchange in this border region. This analysis connects to the emergence of a trader-ruler class in the 19th century, the establishment of an international border at the beginning of the 20th century based on natural resource politics, the survival strategies of people living in conditions of violent conflict, and ultimately, the impact of the gold rush in 21st-century Ethiopia and Sudan. A closer examination of Qeissan as a border market will reveal how these markets reflect not only the commercial interests of people across the border but also embody other forms of exchange—social, cultural, political—making them valuable centres for studying cross-border relations.

Instead of using 'frontier', which suggests a centre-periphery model, the term 'borderland' is preferred here, as it describes a region around an international border that is, to a significant extent, influenced by but not confined to it. This chapter thus continues a line of studies illustrating how international border lines are only one facet of social, economic, and political life in the areas they traverse. These lines are far from insignificant, since border regimes actively interfere with the mobility of people and goods – and, through nationalist ideology, with ideas – but they also form part of more complex dynamics of boundary-making and boundary-crossing in these borderlands.

A history of border consolidation

This chapter discusses the historical development of the Ethiopian-Sudanese border, focusing on political efforts aimed at its consolidation during the 20th century. It is not merely about border demarcation at the national and international levels; border consolidation also involves increasing control over the movement of people and goods. However, this does not necessarily result in less exchange, as the same volume of trade can occur with border controls and levies as with fluid boundaries. The key difference is that border-ma(r)king embodies an exclusionary claim to territorial control, with international borders playing a role in this assertion at various levels. Hence, this chapter traces the history of one such boundary—the international border—both its virtual existence on maps and its physical manifestation on the ground. The relation between them is an ongoing process of formation, affirmation, and challenge, which is more straightforward in some areas than in others.

Border demarcation

The formal establishment of the Ethiopian-Sudanese border originates from a 1902 agreement between the Ethiopian Empire and the British colonial administration in Sudan (see comprehensive background in Taha 1983). It outlined the specific territorial relationship between the two states after a turbulent 19th century: with the dissolution of the Sultanate of Sennar and the gradual integration of its southern regions into larger empires, the latter's borderland status was both altered and reaffirmed, whether during the imperial era or, after independence, between the lines of global geopolitics.

Before the Ottoman invasion, the southern part of the Sennar Sultanate was more defined by its relations with the Shilluk Kingdom and areas further east, as well as by the competition among *mukūk* (sg. *makk*). By the end of the 18th century, the main local centres of Fazughli, Keili, and Jebel Gule were situated near gold-producing regions, and the prevalent taxation in gold and enslaved not only laid the groundwork for the dominant resource governance in these areas up to the 20th century (and beyond), but also functioned as protection money to prevent raids, including those from the sultan's own troops (Medani 2010: 116).

The Ottoman rule was experienced in southern Blue Nile similarly to other 'fringes' of the conquerors' mainland in central Sudan, as the new rulers – like those before and after them – saw it as a resource reservoir, mainly for slaves and minerals, rather than an integral part of the political body. The extraction of minerals began early on after the conquest, as Isma'il Pasha extended to Fazughli from Sennar, upon request of such resources by Muhammad Ali, establishing a levy of gold on trade (Holt & Daly 2000: 47). Throughout the turbulent history of the Ethiopian-Sudanese borderland, Fazughli served as a southeastern outpost of the mainland conflicts along the Sennar-Gondar line. The extension of the Ottoman Empire to this famed centre of gold trade was thus straightforwardly extractive; an annual output of about 2 tons of gold from "tribute-

gathering expeditions scarcely distinguishable from raids” (Zewde 1976: 22) was taken from Bela Shangul, Khomosha and Keili in the early 1880s.

The Benishangul region was then somewhat affected by the early Mahdist movement but became part of the Ethiopian Empire in the 1890s (Seri-Hersch 2010: 2). During the 19th century and the first half of the 20th century, the region was characterised by a power struggle among three sheikhdoms and their ruling families. The manipulation of external powers was generally an important tool in these local politics. Abd al-Rahman Khojali, known as Tur Al-Guri, held a sphere of influence in the Mahdist empire that extended to Fazughli in the north and Fadasi in the south; Mahmud Muhammad of Khomosha used Mahdist support to capture Aqoldi / Asosa in 1886 from Al-Hassan and his son Khojali. Only a few years later, the three attempted to form an alliance against Muhammad Ahmad Al-Khannagi of Bel-Didino as he facilitated a Mahdist invasion in 1889, and Khojali Al-Hassan turned to the Ethiopian Empire for support (Zewde 1976: 23).

A new stabilization of the border began with Menelik II’s rise to power in Ethiopia in 1889, following the defeat of Italian troops at Adwa in 1896 and the final defeat of the Mahdists by British-led forces in 1898. The aim here is not to recount or summarise the complex development of the negotiations prior to the 1902 agreement. However, several points are relevant to understanding the politico-economic situation of the southern Blue Nile borderland.

Both resource and border control rationales can be observed behind Menelik II’s imperial expansion into Beni-Shangul in 1897, aimed at securing gold as well as preventing a British advance, culminating in Ras Mekonnen’s conquest in 1898 (Zewde 1976: 26-27, 76-77). During the first half of 1899, Beni-Shangul remained one of the main obstacles to reaching an agreement, and it was clear that not only gold but also access to trade routes into Sudan and to navigable parts of the Niles were part of Ethiopian interests in it (Marcus 1963: 89).

The region existed, from the imperial perspective, as a buffer zone between spheres of influence but was also subject to two different conceptions of what defines a border: one was territorially vague and described the extent to which a state can extract resources from a population, whether through permanent presence or raids; the other adhered to the principle of ‘effective occupation’ that determines which area can be claimed when drawing borders (Abir 1967: 459-460; see also Seri-Hersch 2010). British exploration teams under Gwynn testing the actual extent of Ethiopian control clearly demonstrated that the logic of effective occupation came before negotiating mapped and demarcated borders. Hence, they interpreted the absence of Ethiopian administration in Wollega province as a sign that the entire Beni-Shangul area might be included in the British colony (Teshome 2009: 349). In the end, it was a matter of political horse trading: in exchange for a commitment by the British government under Wingate not to insist on the gold-rich Beni-Shangul region, a gold-mining concession was granted to Lane, a British national, extending from Fazughli across the new border to the rivers Songa and Dabus (Zewde 1976: 68).

By 1906, the territorial boundaries of Ethiopia had assumed their current form, coinciding with the start of Menelik II's physical decline, and the 1902 agreement became part of a series of political artefacts that aimed to imply the endurance of a state enclosed by international borders (Zewde 1976: 43). But the borderland remained a disputed transitional zone throughout the remainder of the century and beyond. In fact, this clash of different notions of 'territory' and 'border' can still be observed today in border conflicts and 'violations', which delve into the question of what defines a state in relation to its subjects: is it the physical force of control at a specific time and place, or a stable spatial entity that engages in reciprocal relations – a social contract – with its citizens?

What makes the diplomatic function of the agreement so important – namely to create a binding document without closing options for effective adjustments in the future – is the geographically vague language that, according to the 1947 Paris Treaty of Peace with Italy, takes precedence over maps. While this is central to concerns about the northern section of the Sudanese-Ethiopian boundary, there is also an affected stretch in the study area, around Kurmuk, Jabal Jerok, and north of Amira (Wubneh 2016: 9, 12). The historical significance of this period cannot be overstated: as evidenced by recurring tensions in the region, the highland Emperors remain symbols of colonial suppression and the enslavement of lowland communities, just as the 'Gwynn line' frequently appears in discussions of contested claims about the legitimacy of border violations and the justification of the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD).

For Ethiopia, the early 20th century represented an initial experience of economic colonisation, where integration into the Europe-dominated global market fostered new and potentially more resilient dependencies than physical occupation (Wubneh 2016: 31). But imperial border politics in the early 20th century also incorporated the use of violence to assert local governance and enhance one's position within the hierarchy of rule. A "hybrid institutional structure legitimized the use of violence as a tool to bargain for social mobility and economic wealth" (Puddu 2017: 230). Land not colonised by highland farmers was left vulnerable to cross-border raids by local chiefs, who financed these raids to bolster their own status and imperial tributes. Furthermore, "banditry (shiftenat) was a socially accepted tool to further one individual's political career within the official hierarchy of the Empire" (Puddu 2017: 230).

The 1940s marked a more organised approach, however, where the existence of an international border as well as rules of regularised administration became more prominent. It was primarily the northern part of the Sudanese-Ethiopian border that experienced much more direct diplomatic intervention and negotiations, driven not only by changing bilateral relations but also by the impacts of rapidly expanding agricultural schemes on both sides of the border. A first Joint Boundary Commission was established in 1966 but failed to progress beyond debating how binding the 1902 treaty should be, due to several changes in Ethiopia's official position over the following years. "[I]n the meantime, the Ethiopian authorities continued to promote the settlement of farmers in the contested borderlands, while Sudanese soldiers repeatedly carried out cross-border raids against Ethiopian people and property" (Puddu 2017: 237).

Border diplomacy made little progress during brief periods of direct talks, in the mid-1960s and after the 1972 Haile Selassie visit to Sudan, as part of the negotiations for the Addis Ababa agreement of the same year. A subsequent exchange of notes contradicted the tone of the 1960s, when maintaining the status quo of mutually occupied lands was the norm; now, the imperial treaties were regarded as the basis, with a grace period and a border adjustment to the foot of mountain ranges, slightly in favour of the Ethiopian side. The 1974 revolution put these negotiations on hold (Wubneh 2016: 2). The arrival of the Derg regime and its limited control over the lands between Humera and Metemma led to open rebellion in 1977, causing a long halt. With the resurgence of civil war in the 1980s and Derg support for SPLM/A, Ethiopian-Sudanese relations entered, once again, another phase (Puddu 2017: 241).

The support from Sudan to the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF), continuing the old pattern of backing each other's rebels, led to diplomatic easing after the fall of the Derg regime. However, the 1995 assassination attempt on Hussni Mubarak led to a partial suspension of bilateral relations until 1999, when the Bashir regime supported Ethiopia in the Eritrean-Ethiopian war. The influx of refugees from Sudan's recurrent civil wars into Ethiopia and vice versa contributed to the complex cross-border dynamics (see below). In the 2000s, plans to place boundary posts were resumed, in 2007 and 2013 under Meles Zenawi and Haile Mariam Desalegn, respectively; in November 2014, leaders of both countries issued directives to set dates for border demarcation. A joint border force of Blue Nile State and Benishangul-Gumuz region was established in January 2018 to combat trade goods and arms smuggling.

Several mutual claims regarding the displacement of farmers circulated in these years. Ethiopian farmers allegedly seized Sudanese land in 1996, a secret agreement in 2007 reportedly allocated land to 17 Sudanese villages, and the late 2010s experienced ongoing clashes, radicalised cross-border theft, and other incursions. Amid the revolutionary uprising in Sudan, the Joint Sudanese-Ethiopian Higher Committee agreed in March 2019 once again to proceed with border demarcation, building on multiple bilateral agreements from April 2017 and February 2018. Meanwhile, the bilateral back-and-forth cannot be separated from the complex political processes surrounding GERD. Partial border closure in April 2019 and direct confrontations between the armies of both countries from March to June 2020 demonstrated a continuation of border uncertainty, followed by the usual vows to start demarcating the border.

Throughout the post-colonial period, the border situation never stabilised and instead reflected, similar to the border trade policies (see below), the fluctuations of bilateral relations between the central governments, including the variable support for respective oppositional armed movements. Multiple rounds of negotiations failed to resolve disputed issues, and many border areas remain highly permeable and prone to clashes, theft, and other 'transgressions'. Recurrent escalations demonstrate this lack of consolidation.

Power politics and civil war

Violent conflicts over political dominance have largely shaped the history of the borderland, as rulers and groups sought to affirm and expand their control. The broader aspects of Sudanese-Ethiopian relations have been discussed elsewhere, up to the transitional period (e.g., Young 2020), and this book does not aim to analyse the wider causes and effects of successive civil wars in the region but rather to highlight their influence on cross-border relations.

A major issue since the 1980s has been the status of SPLM/A's presence in the area. Several aspects of Derg rule prompted resistance, including the attempt to dismantle longstanding administrative and social structures and, in the 1980s, the unilateral offer to SPLM/A to use the borderland as one of its bases. The limited capacities of regional counter-movements were enhanced by support from Sudan as well as from other groups, such as the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF) and the TPLF (Young 1999: 325).

During Sudan's second civil war, the area around Kurmuk, the largest town bordering Ethiopia in this region, became – and remains – a symbol of the shifting fortunes of the main hostile parties, changing hands numerous times: SPLM/A captured and recaptured it in 1985, 1987, and 1997 (Medani 2010: 117-118; Mathijs Doop 2013: 12), and lost it again after the start of the third civil war in 2011. The population of the borderland in Blue Nile state responded variably to these shifting circumstances, with some joining either side and others fleeing to northern Sudan, Ethiopia, or South Sudan. Early counter-insurgency measures by the Sudanese government, such as Sadiq al-Mahdi's arming of militias, heightened the need to choose sides. When the Eritrean People's Liberation Front (EPLF) and the OLF became involved in Sudanese government operations in 1990, reaching into Assosa, spaces of refuge were further reduced (IRRI & NHRMO 2016: 12; see more details in the section 'War and refuge').

It is well-documented how changing relations between the central governments of Sudan and Ethiopia caused significant ruptures in SPLM/A's situation – the almost instant loss of support after the fall of the Derg regime; the 'rehabilitation' after 1995, including joint operations with the Ethiopian military in southern Blue Nile and the short-lived advances of the Sudan Alliance Forces; and another shift after 1999, along with territorial losses before and during peace negotiations (Young 1999: 334; ICG 2013: 9). The fact that beginning peace negotiations and other aspects – the eventual collapse of the Sudan Alliance Forces, the Eritrean-Ethiopian war and post-9/11 approach between the USA's and Sudan's security apparatus – changed the Ethiopian government's attitudes and weakened SPLM/A's military position again bears witness to the vital importance the cross-border anchor had for the development of the war.

At the onset of the 2011 war, the accessibility of Ethiopian space for SPLM/A-North was greatly diminished, now mostly lacking support from Ethiopia and experiencing an early loss of its former base in Kurmuk. When Malik Agar hesitated to join the conflict that erupted in South Kordofan in June 2011, he reached out to Meles Zenawi to seek his help in persuading the NCP leadership to honour the 28 June AUHIP-mediated framework agreement. Trust in Zenawi's ability to prevent war apparently also contributed to the low level of preparedness of Malik Agar's troops, leading to a significant loss of territory at

the commencement of the war. This was compounded by a considerable loss of lives, defections, soldiers becoming refugees, and even the emergence of new counter-militias, such as Kopaji (ICG 2013: 17-20). The loss of Kurmuk meant losing road access to Ethiopia, a major setback for SPLM/A-North; Qeissan was already under government control, and other border areas, such as Deim Mansour, followed in November 2011. Enclaves held throughout the war, which did not experience significant shifts in battle lines, included areas near the Ethiopian border, close to Keili (ICG 2013: 23-24).

Overall, the area maintained its character as a buffer zone, not only territorially but also in bilateral diplomatic relations, since the central government of Ethiopia avoided clearly taking this or that side and instead nurtured its status as a mediator. Meanwhile, the absence of repercussions for violent border breaches reflects the priorities of central governments, which often put bilateral stability before the lives of their citizens in these borderlands. Several incidents when SAF Antonov bombers hit targets and killed citizens on the Ethiopian side – September-October 2011, December 2011, March 2013, April 2013 – had little impact on bilateral relations, despite SPLM-N attempts to highlight them (ICG 2013: 39). Cross-border operations of outlawed groups such as the Benishangul People's Liberation Movement (BPLM), the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF), and Ginbot 7 were not effectively prevented, despite the tensions and violent events they caused in the border state (EUTF 2016: 28; Gebremichael 2011: 290-293). 'Larger' issues, such as negotiations over the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam and relations with Eritrea, continued to take precedence.

Accordingly, there is a difference between relations with 'Addis Ababa' and with the border states themselves. SPLM/A-N leaders "blame Benishangul-Gumuz authorities for facilitating Sudanese agents' activities, notably through the Sudanese consulate in the state's capital Asosa, that allegedly include efforts to undermine Blue Nile refugees' support for the SPLM-N and to encourage them to return" (ICG 2013: 40). Simultaneously, the provisions of a 1964 treaty on the extradition of criminals could conveniently be extended to these rebels (ICG 2013: 41 fn 280).

Another aspect of bilateral relations is the status of Muslims in Ethiopia (see more details in the section 'Trade and rule'). In Benishangul-Gumuz, about half of the population was Muslim, and the region's status was also linked to Muslims' long and complex history in successive state formations, as well as the 'Arab' denoter, which was more additive than substantive. During the first half of the 20th century, the organisation of Christian missions was guided partly by the protection of Orthodox Church dominance in so-called 'Closed Areas' and the concomitant subjugation of peripheral southern and western lowlands, mostly Muslim and dubbed 'Open Areas', to their activities of 'modernisation' (Fantini 2015: 126) – opposite but therefore also similar to British colonial language.

In a sense, post-Derg policies promoted a different status. EPRDF's ethnic federalism, for instance, "has inadvertently created a new political space for Muslims" (Feyissa 2013: 33), including the sub-regional government of Benishangul-Gumuz. Nevertheless, the increased involvement of the Ethiopian Islamic Affairs Supreme Council (Majlis) in local appointments of religious leaders since the mid-1990s has also fostered feelings of disenfranchisement (Feyissa 2013: 34-35). This was further compounded by the

contradiction between enforced secularism in educational institutions and partisan politics directed towards specific regional or sectarian religious groups, such as the born-again Christian leadership of the Benishangul-Gumuz National Regional State under Yaregal Ayisheshim, or the official endorsement of the al-Ahbash sect founded by Shaykh Abdallah Muhammad al-Harari (Feyissa 2013: 39).

Generally, although designed to empower those areas that had always been marginal to state power during the imperial past and the Derg regime, EPRDF's policies had highly ambiguous results in regions that had also been quite remote from state control – and development efforts – on both sides of the border, including Benishangul-Gumuz (Young 1999: 322). Nevertheless, the extent of disruption caused by interventions by central governments – however intermittent – continues to confirm the importance of bilateral relations between state formations divided by the borderline for these borderlands.

Blue Nile as province and state

Blue Nile State was established as one of Sudan's states following the reorganisation under the Federal Governance Law in 1994. It is situated in southeastern Sudan between 9°30' and 12°32' N, and 33°14' and 35°08' E. The state is bordered to the north by Sennar State, to the east and southeast by Ethiopia, and to the west and south by South Sudan. Covering approximately 38,500 km², it had a population of 832,311 according to the 2008 census. With an annual growth rate of 4.1%, an unadjusted population estimate for 2018 was 1,643,697. The state's administrative centre is Damazin, and it is divided into seven localities: Damazin, Roseiris, Wad El-Mahi, Qeissan, Kurmuk, Baw, and Al-Tadamon.

This newly created state resulted from a reduction of a much larger Blue Nile Province, which included some of Sudan's most important agricultural schemes. It represented a part of the province that was both the location of some of pre-colonial Sudan's most influential state formations and already subjected to peripheralising policies under British colonial rule. Similar to other regions seen as transitional zones between northern and southern Sudan, British colonial authorities included parts of today's Blue Nile State under the Closed District Order of 1922. This effectively "turned [them] into a peripheral zone, isolated some local groups from Sudan's educational system, and cut the area off from centres of economic and political power" (Okazaki 1997: 66). In 1938, the regions of 'primitive pagan tribes' in Kurmuk District, Maban Uduk and Koma, were transferred to the southern Upper Nile Province, which exposed them to the work of Christian missionaries. In 1953, the Uduk areas around Chali al-Fil and the Koma areas of Yabus were reclassified, mainly "for administrative convenience" (IRRI & NHRMO 2016: 11).

A different approach was applied to the northern areas regarded as a historical extension of the Funj kingdom. 'Funj', more a political than an ethnic label, can describe a self-identification of those integrated or associating themselves with the historical state. As far as the historical depth of presence is concerned, a divide between indigenous and newcomer populations plays a significant role and, in practice, is ambiguously intertwined with central government policies, akin to the native/non-native split in Ethiopia but with a different emphasis (ICG 2013: 3).

The only Sudanese census to record ethnicity, the country's first in 1955/56, applied this classification, with 98,830 of the rural council population of Southern Funj, totalling 162,592, identified as Funj tribes. Significant other groups included 20,957 from Western Sudan tribes, 12,678 West Africans, and 9,220 Ja'aliyyin (quoted after Nur 1971: 165). Funj Nazirates and the northern Funj were counted as 135,326 and 112,060 respectively. The socio-economic structure showed no nomadic pastoralists in southern Funj and only 16 sedentary animal owners, but 146,818 of 162,592 residents were cultivators, with only 4,193 in urban areas. However, the decision to group specific ethnonyms into the categories Arab, Southerners, Westerners, Nuba, Beja, and Nubian created a lack of clarity that reflects more on the statisticians' perceptions than on the sociological realities they described. The additional contradiction between language- and ethnicity-based counting has been thoroughly documented (Miller 2018).

Today, the borderlands are mostly documented within government statistical systems that assume borderlines, ethnic boundaries, and population structures as given. The 2018 projections, for example, lack any ethnic categories, similar to previous census data since 1956, but build, based on the disputed 2008 census, a numerical fiction of residential continuity by simply applying a standardised 4.1% growth rate. At the same time, the administrative units used in the census are implicitly connected to the communal administration (*al-'idārah al-ahliyyah*), placing the state under the Funj Nazirate, divided into the Ingessana Nazirate (Baw Locality), Western Nazirate (Tadamon Locality), Fazughli Kingdom [sic] (Qeissan Locality), and Keili Kingdom [sic] (southern Kurmuk).³ This also remains ambiguously linked to the so-called 'ethnic maps' used by authorities, which classify 93 specific groups into categories often not on the same level of aggregation (see table next page, translated from the original Arabic document collected by Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman in Damazin, November 2019).

The significant implications of certain categorisations will become clearer in later sections through a more historically and sociologically oriented analysis of the border-crossing groups among them. It is worth noting, however, that this 'map' divides some groups into their sub-sections (e.g., Berta), while presenting other groups as composite collectives (e.g., Funj, Fellata, Nuba). The inclusion of a location additionally suggests territorial, 'natural' home areas that, like the projections, lack a historical dimension. In a conflict zone with multiple layers of land disputes (see below), this is not a trivial observation.

³ The sheikh (*šayḥ*, pl. *šiyūḥ*) was the lowest level of communal representation (*al-idārah al-ahliyyah*) inherited from the colonial state. Higher levels were *'umdah* and, in parts of the Blue Nile State and South Kordofan, *mak* (elsewhere *'amīr*).

Ethnic group	Name of tribe (<i>qabīlah</i>)	Locations (Localities)
African tribes	Dawālah, Hamaj, Ingessana, Kadalo	Whole state
African tribes	Gumuz	Roseiris, Wad El-Mahi, Qeissan
African tribes	Jabalāwiyyīn	Roseiris
African tribes	Raqārīq	Kurmuk
African, West	Bornu, Fellata, Hausa	Whole state
Arab tribes	Ashrāf, Kamātīr, Rufa‘a Arabs (sections)	Whole state
Arab-African tribes	Funj, ‘Arakiyyīn	Whole state
Arab-African tribes	Waṭāwīt	Kurmuk
Berta	Bel-Maqdūlī, Fa-‘Ambūrū, Fa-‘Andū, Fa-Balandū, Fa-Bārū, Fa-Bīnjī, Fa-Dūqah, Fa-Fījī, Fa-Hūmaš, Fa-Hūmašah, Fa-Lāšī, Fa-Maḍī, Fa-Manzalī, Fa-Mūfah, Fa-Murjī, Fa-Našī, Fa-Nazjar, Fa-Qamandū, Fa-Quldī, Fa-Sanjī, Fa-Ṭāšī, Fa-Tījī, Murmuz	Kurmuk
Burūn	Burūn Al-Silik, Burūn Al-Surkum, Burūn Al-Zarībah, Burūn Jaraṭ, Burūn Mafū, Burūn Malkan, Burūn Mīk	Kurmuk
Burūn	Burūn Al-Šīmī	Whole state
Sudanese, Central	‘Aqaliyyīn	Whole state
Sudanese, East	Beni Amer, Hadendowa	Whole state
Sudanese, North	‘Abdallāb, Bederiyya Dahmashiyyah, Danāqlah, Fazārah, Ḥamādāb, Ḥuḍūriyyah, Ja‘aliyyīn, Kenana, Khannāqiyyah, Maḥas, Manasir, Rikābiyyah, Rubāṭāb, Rufā‘iyyah, Salbāb	Whole state
Sudanese, North	Halfawiyyīn	Damazin, Baw
Sudanese, South	Shilluk	Kurmuk, Al-Tadamon, Damazin
Sudanese, West	Bargo, Beni Halba, Berti, Daju, Fur, Habbāniyyah, Ḥumr, Jawām‘a, Kabīšāb, Marārīt, Masalit, Ma‘āliyyah, Missiriyyah, Nazahah, Nuba, Qumr, Rizeigat, Tama, Ta‘āišah, Tunjur, Zaghawa	Whole state
Uduk	Hūmā, Jumjum, Koma, Qanza, Uduk	Kurmuk

In addition, official figures tend to understate the number of their own citizens in other locations, especially when it involves refugees and displaced persons. Data gathered in November 2019 from the authorities in Damazin presents the following picture:

Sudanese in Ethiopia, South Sudan and SPLM/A-N-controlled areas

Country / Domain	Camp / Area	Population
Ethiopia	Kubri 5	8,000
	Bambashi	5,000
	Tongo	6,000
	Yūsif Bānī	4,000
Total		23,000
South Sudan	Dondarāsa	3,000
	Doro	7,000
	Al-Jumām Al-Ghanam	2,000
	Fatima Al-Kujuriyya	2,500
Total		14,500
SPLM/A area	Yābūs	12,000
	Sōda Al-Jadida	9,000
	Samrī	8,000
	Chalī Al-Fīl	2,000
	Banāmāyō	3,000
	Al-Līlī – Aws – Maqaf	6,000
	Wadaka	4,000
	Uru – Jadrān	7,000
	Al-Sam’a	3,000
Total		54,000

Since one of these numbers’ main roles is to project an impression of oversight and authority, politically influenced estimates fill the gaps created by fragile administrative structures. All these figures remain well below the figures of agencies such as UNHCR and SRRA, for example, as well as the official figures in the respective states. They also obscure the fact that more than a quarter of Blue Nile State’s population recorded in the 2008 census had become internally displaced persons (IDPs) and refugees due to war just a few years later; in 2012, SPLM/A-N’s own Sudan Relief and Rehabilitation Agency estimated the population in its areas in Blue Nile State at 80,147, with 64,550 of them being IDPs and around 200,000 refugees in South Sudan (De Alessi 2013: 88). This was further affected by government-induced displacement as part of counter-insurgency measures and the raising of the Roseiris Dam in 2013. In fact, since most people could now be classified as internally displaced, refugees, or migrants, there was a new ‘normalcy’ of residence without historical depth, and the population structure of 2018 was very different from that of 2008.

Border trade policies and infrastructure

Historically, the primary link between the borderland and larger state entities was maintained and controlled through trade routes. However, the contradiction between a scarcely controlled frontier and the vulnerability its permeability represented also meant that suppression of mobility, as a counter-measure to these unruly border-crossings, was often preferred over engaging constructively with a mobile population. The observation above that the same central governments used transgressions for their own purposes highlights the ambiguity of a border that is simultaneously closed and open for different actors in various situations.

The role of trade in local political history will be discussed in more detail below (see ‘Trade and rule’). However, it is important to note the significant impact of the border demarcation process on cross-border trade policies, which is worth highlighting here.

The new border regime affected villages that now transformed into border towns and markets. Kurmuk, for example, had only around 50 inhabitants at the time of the border agreement and had increased to 3,540 by the start of the 1970s, and “more than 70 per cent of the wage paid population of the town [were] either directly employed in the customs, immigration, quarantine, frontier security offices or indirectly accommodated in jobs related to these offices” (Nur 1971: 147-148). A combination of this accumulation of employees and border security increasing during the 1960s also led to a significant increase in trade activities. Nevertheless, documented border crossings remained few; in 1969, Kurmuk and Roseiris together had fewer than 100 people going through the procedures (Nur 1971: 161).

While the border regime apparatus expanded, actual cross-border trade activities declined due to a number of interconnected factors. The low purchasing power on both sides meant that high customs and tariffs, especially on the Ethiopian side, made official channels unappealing for low-volume trade, in addition to complicated procedures and the linguistic barrier between Arabic- and Amharic-speaking officials (Nur 1971: 186).

At the same time, new trade routes became more important, partly due to infrastructural investments further north that revived the historic Qallabat-Gondar link with the construction of an all-weather road (Nur 1971: 160; Young 2020: 10-11). Historical trade routes linked Gondar and Sennar, from where they branched to Darfur and Egypt, while also focusing on the Nile as a central transport route (Holt & Daly 2000: 8). But transport on the river was reduced by the construction of dams, such as at Roseires, similar to how the old waterborne trade routes to Egypt were cut off by the Aswan Dam; a planned waterway of 576 km from Roseires into Ethiopia was replaced by the GERD project. The only significant road works southwards occurred in the 1990s between Damazin and Kurmuk, carried out by Osama Bin Laden’s Al-Hijrah Construction and Development Co.; even a planned extension further south did not materialise as the company was not paid by the government as per the agreement (Spittaels & Weyns 2014: 35). While an asphalt road was built from Assosa to Kurmuk, with a bridge subsequently connecting to the Sudanese Kurmuk, there was nothing but a dirt road after crossing the border. Other border crossings, such as Qeissan and Al-Mahal, remained entirely without paved roads (EUTF 2016: 19). The infrastructural situation had nearly reversed since before Sudanese

independence, as roads and railways on the Sudanese side had been easier to access up to the post-colonial period (Young 1999: 325).

The railways ending in Roseiris and improved surface roads, along with agricultural investment in areas north of the Blue Nile, created more profitable market links for Sudanese cotton and Ethiopian coffee. Similar connections to the Red Sea – due to the surge of purchasing power in the newly oil-producing nations and Ethiopia being landlocked after the war with Eritrea – directed increasingly exports in this direction rather than the neighbouring countries (Nur 1971: 175; Young 2020: 10-11).

However, most areas in Benishangul-Gumuz were also barely accessible by motorised transport until the early 2010s. Improvements increased road density from 11 km / 1000 km² in 1991 to only 40.1 km / 1000 km² in 2015/16, while the national average was 95 km / 1000 km². Moving within the state was difficult and exhausting until a bridge over the Abay/Blue Nile river was built to connect its northern and southern regions (EUTF 2016: 7; see also section ‘Natural features and social exchange’).

Direct trade between the two countries was therefore very limited. From a macroeconomic perspective, the overall similarity of main agricultural products and developing industries in both countries should have led to a strategy of mutual marketing, rather than escalating trade terms, but Sudan’s main focus was on the Arab Common Market (Nur 1971: 180, 184), and the later formation of COMESA made little progress in comparison. The few goods that were of interest on the other side, such as cotton and sorghum from Sudan, and coffee from Ethiopia, were prohibited from cross-border trade (Nur 1971: 188-189).

However, it is important to examine the different treatment of border trade and international trade, as they differ in their relationship with central authorities and fiscal institutions. COMESA trade benefits from facilitations such as separating import and export values and exemption from customs, but – similar to conventional bilateral trade – it remains subject to the regulations of the Central Bank of Sudan (CBoS), the National Bank of Ethiopia (NBE), such as letters of credit. Border trade operates, nominally, through bilateral agreements (to ensure value equivalence between export and import) but without bank involvement, hard currency, certificates of origin (L/C), and with low capital requirements, while revenues from its taxation remain with the state.

Border trade is formally defined as uncertified commercial transactions between residents within 90km from the border on both sides, connected by customs points. It is generally based on local produce and helps to fill mutual gaps in the supply for these residents. This, at least, is the formalisation envisaged in the 2001 Protocol for Border Trade between Sudan and Ethiopia (Badr al-Din 2016: 24-27). Other framework provisions on the Sudanese side included the 1999 Regulation of Border Trade Organisation (*lā’iḥat tanzīm tijārat al-ḥudūd*), which was elevated to law in 2004 and amended in 2010. On the state level, specific protocols directed the relationship between authorities across the border, and state governments were fully responsible for organising crossing points and border markets, issuing trade licences and import/export permits, as well as providing infrastructure to facilitate trade (Badr al-Din 2016: 29-30; EUTF 2016: 16-17).

The 2001 agreement also involved successive market days at settlements with border-crossing points, such as Kurmuk, Qeissan, and Menza/Al-Mahal, among the first border points where border trade was introduced as an administrative practice (Haram 2016: 45; see list of official border-crossing points below).

crossing-point (Ethiopia)	crossing point (Sudan)
Kurmuk	Kurmuk
Gezen	
Abramo, Gengen	
Al-Mahal, Omedla	Jabal Nimr, Menza
Yānzā	Umm Darfā
Yābshir	Yābshir
Al-Bīrū	Qeissan
Yārdā	Ashimbo
Yabus	Yabus
Yāfta	Um Durqah, Mayās Akī

Source: EUTF 2016: 24; Badr al-Din 2016: 32

In the following years, a pattern arose where regular border trade supplied vegetables, coffee, chicken, eggs, leather shoes and cosmetics from Ethiopia, whilst soaps, sugar, mats and especially during the dry season, onions were imported from Sudan (EUTF 2016: 16-17).

However, the 2010 amendment not only introduced border trade registries but also export/import forms with expiration periods and reporting requirements to the CBoS and line ministries, thereby undermining central elements that were originally designed to facilitate low-volume local trade. In April 2015, a joint meeting between Sudanese and Ethiopian officials also defined import/export items (EUTF 2016: 31-32):

- from Sudan: plastic products (chairs, tables), kitchen utensils, jute sacks, batteries, matches, soft drinks, onions, salt, paint, bottled water, home furniture, ceramic tiles, shoes, washing powder, dates, and food items (e.g. sesame seed paste called *taḥniyyah*);
- from Ethiopia: fruits, maize, chickpeas, Ethiopian fava beans (*fūl ḥabašī*)⁴, red lentils (*ʿadis*), honey, garlic, potatoes, frankincense (*lubān baḥūr*), clarified butter (*samin*), tobacco and cigarettes, tea, agricultural tools, soap, spices, okra, ginger.

On the bilateral trade level, Proclamation No. 318/2003 established a preferential trade agreement that included the abolishment of tariff barriers and the application of the COMESA Rules of Origin Treaty and Protocol. The agreement specifically related to agricultural and livestock products, unless import or export threatened the domestic

⁴ In fact, there had been a backlash by fava bean farmers in northern Sudan already in 2012, when the import of this product was allowed by the federal government.

market (Mulugeta et al. 2007: 2). On the Sudanese side, this was ratified and detailed in the 2009 Law of External Trade Organisation (*qānūn tanẓīm al-tijārat al-ḥārijīyyah*).

The emphasis on prevention rather than support of cross-border trade occurred in several phases of recent bilateral history. In fact, the Ethiopian Ministry of Industry and Trade upheld its 2001 policy that restricts cross-border business transactions to 2000 birr and within 90 km of the border, which hampers interest in official trade channels due to high inflation in both countries and the fact that the first major hub on the Ethiopian side, Assosa, lies outside this limit (EUTF 2016: 16-17).⁵ The Sudanese government had also previously curtailed the independence of border trade: after it was disrupted following the military coup of 1989, organised border trade was resumed with Decree No. 4 of 1995, which placed external trade under the shared responsibility of customs authorities, the CBoS, and the Ministry of External Trade. In 1996, the establishment of a Border Trade Administration under the Ministry was completed, with a strong supervisory role of the CBoS regarding the trade balance (Haram 2016: 45-46).

The centralisation of trade routes through the capitals, along with security considerations, appears to play a role here. Taking another step, the Sudanese government decided in 2009 to shut down cross-border trade, after which there was a prolonged and gradual process of negotiating its restart (Badr al-Din 2016: 23). In January 2007, during the 9th Conference of the Ethio-Sudan Joint Border Development Commission in Damazin, the emphasis was on border and trade control, along with the establishment of banks, which already indicated this forthcoming step: One of the main reasons for the prohibition of border trade, decided on 23 July 2009 by the General Secretariat of the Council of Ministers (*al-qīfā' al-ʿiqṭiṣādī* no. 6), in favour of conducting transactions through banks was that independent border trade encouraged the smuggling of goods. Incidentally, it was this ban that heightened the demand and appeal for smuggling (Haram 2016: 42-43).

The rise in COMESA trade from 2009/2010 shows that the central government's decision to ban border trade with Ethiopia was an effort not only to strengthen the role of central authorities in trade but also to support large-scale capital trade. It also suggests that well-connected trade centres were favoured, as greater volume needed to be moved to ensure profitability, and the expansion of new branches of commercial banks in border states followed a similar trend. As a consequence, trade from the large agricultural schemes in Gedarif grew, while formal bilateral trade from Blue Nile State nearly ceased, with only 3 COMESA licences issued. When some exceptions were granted by the General Customs Director, such as permitting border trade up to a value of 5,000 dollars, they were administratively linked with COMESA trade, as no trade licences would be issued by the trade authorities (*ʿidārat al-tijārah*), who were also tasked with defining targeted trade volumes by the 2009 law (Badr al-Din 2016: 32-33). The limited outcomes of the preferential trade agreement of 2003 also support the view that cross-border trade policies were less about international economic relations and more about the centralisation of capital: while about US\$2.4 billion were invested by private Sudanese

⁵ It is close to the limit, as the asphalt road between Assosa and Kurmuk in Ethiopia, built in 2012, measures 97 km (field report Tsegaye Berhanu, 2020).

companies in Ethiopia in 2014, exports to Sudan amounted to only US\$29.9 million, whereas imports from Egypt had a value of US\$743 million (Young 2020: 11).⁶

Border trade decisions were also made in an opportunistic, if not entirely arbitrary, manner; for example, in 2013, the export of onions and dates was permitted for four months by the Minister for External Trade, solely to benefit a major producer of these goods. The cooperation agreement of April 2014 and the participation of the Blue Nile state government and Sudanese traders in the December 2014 trade fair in Assosa were largely symbolic at the time, although the Ethiopian state government allowed a significant volume of goods to be displayed, with full exemption from fees and customs. However, many bilateral agreements and recommendations at the state level received no response from the central governments, particularly on the Sudanese side. These include the development of better roads in Blue Nile State, the connection of electricity between the two Kurmuk towns, and the facilitation of cross-border mobility—especially for officials and traders. In addition, the war in Blue Nile State, as well as episodes of violent clashes in Benishangul-Gumuz, had their obvious impact on such propositions. The subsequent shift of trade movements to the northern side of the Blue Nile, via Menza, increased the distance to productive areas and commercial hubs in Ethiopia, especially to Assosa (Badr al-Din 2016: 33-36).

Another limiting aspect was the overlap and encroachment of several authorities on cross-border movements, including national security and the army. This was still evident in Qeissan in November 2019: a trader selling shoes, clothes, and perfumes for the Ethiopian market had to obtain confirmation from both the Head of Security of the administrative unit Qeissan and the Head of Military Intelligence of the Fourth Infantry Battalion in Qeissan in order to receive a permit from the Chamber of Commerce. Overall, ongoing security concerns meant that trade routes through Kurmuk and Qeissan remained severely restricted (as of 2020).

In this way, the Blue Nile-Benishangul borderland reverted to being administratively neglected but militarily regulated, while the infrastructural limits and relatively low economic priority of the borderland reinforced one another.⁷ As a result, the typical scenario of resource-rich regions with limited infrastructure remained, with the borderland continuing to be a significant source but not a beneficiary of such resources. Investment in trade routes soon waned, although it was investments being channelled elsewhere that ultimately caused this outcome: both the southern Blue Nile and Benishangul remained marginalised in terms of production and connectivity. However, not only did central trade policies face competition from social practices, but they also succeeded on a different level than originally intended, planned, and considered relevant.

⁶ A trade imbalance between Ethiopia and Sudan has historical roots; in 1913, Sudan's imports were £E65,608 and exports £E1,458. By 1933, imports increased to £E154,861 and exports to £E15,589. The Kurmuk-Roseiris trade point followed this trend, reaching its peak imports in 1930 at £E40,052, while exports remained very low at £E708 (Zewde 1976: 437-438).

⁷ Lack of infrastructure was even cited as a reason for the delay in border demarcation by Charles Gwynn, one of the architects of the 1902 agreement, as both surveying and demarcation labour lacked transportation (Teshome 2009: 346).

It remained a common misconception that the lack of success of the official trade routes, including the one connecting western Ethiopia with Sudan via Kurmuk, indicated a generally low level of contact between the southern Blue Nile and Benishangul (e.g., Nur 1971: 174, also Nur 1971: 185-186 on mineral trade). This misconception is an inevitable result of cross-border dynamics viewed solely through the lens of central governments and their agents. Similarly, trade routes that existed before the formation of imperial, colonial, and post-colonial states were now referred to as 'smuggling' or 'illegal trade' (e.g., Nur 1971: 186-187), rather than as methods of economic exchange with which these state formations failed to arrange. As shown by its history, people in the borderlands constantly moved between participating in and avoiding linking local production (and reproduction) with the networks of traders (Seri-Hersch 2010: 8).

The price differential resulting from the marginalisation of border regions drew exchange relations via alternative routes that actually revitalised much older pathways. The 20th century marked the end of extractive activities involving enslavement, which did not resume despite ongoing brutalities on both sides of the border. But gold mining and trade has never ceased to be a vital part of local livelihoods, and a new pattern of extraction has developed related to technological and economic developments. Furthermore, the increase in armed conflicts led to a rise in the trade of firearms, extending beyond the active arming of groups and movements by central governments (Nur 1971: 187; Gebremichael 2011: 294). The topographic conditions also favoured the movement of people and goods outside official crossing points: a long border with border posts mostly 100 km apart, numerous tracks through hilly terrain and dense forests, especially in the section between Kurmuk and Basunda (Nur 1971: 194).

Since there was a genuine economic need for products in the borderland itself, local Sudanese officials showed some leniency towards Ethiopian traders, as they had little hope of imposing high tariffs and were concerned about halting the flow of goods into the border region. In this context, social relations of commitment occurred more between officials, local leaders, lorry drivers, caravan leaders, and traders than towards a distant central government (Nur 1971: 188-189, calling it 'corruption and nepotism', also 197). In the 2000s, a situation had arisen where the movement of goods was heavily restricted by regulations, while the movement of people was nearly unproblematic (EUTF 2016: 18-19):

When Ethiopians cross the border on market days, they are required by Ethiopian border control to deposit their identity cards. Most of the prospective migrants leave their IDs and then continue their journey with the support of their brokers. This is practiced in transit points such as Gizen, Sherkole, Kurmuk and Almahl-Guba. For instance, in a market day in Guba, close to 500 people may cross the border in the name of going to the market in the Sudanese side, however many of these may not return. As the authorities do not systematically keep the records, it is difficult to have a reliable estimation about the number of people who go to the Sudan using the cross-border markets.

Not surprisingly, officially banned trade goods – cotton, sorghum, coffee – were the main items of unofficial trade in the 1960s, followed by valuables such as currency and jewellery (Nur 1971: 190). In the 2000s, the situation was still similar but involved a broader range of products, such as bamboo, alcohol, coffee, and livestock from Ethiopia, and textiles, sugar, and soap from Sudan (EUTF 2016: 16-17). In the late 2010s, goods continued to

reflect each country's supply issues: the fuel and medicine crisis in Sudan since 2018 increased the presence of imports in the markets, while low levels of industrialisation and gaps in agricultural production in Benishangul were offset with spare parts, edible oil, sugar, salt, and onions from Sudan. Sometimes the same kind of product was exchanged at different locations, such as Sudan's washing powder 'Wide', which was nearly ubiquitous in Assosa and beyond, and soap from Egypt, which found its way into Sudan. Likewise, shoes, perfume, fuel, and gold crossed the border in both directions (field observations by Tsegaye Birhanu, November 2019).

Nonetheless, announcements and initiatives to promote cross-border activities through official channels persisted. Cross-border development in both countries was planned, for example, in the GIZ project "Cross-Border Collaboration Programme Western Ethiopia / Eastern Sudan" (2018-2021, IGAD), with one of the objectives being the formalisation and expansion of cross-border trade, alongside the reduction of 'informal and illegal trade'. A persistent misalignment is also evident here: instead of adapting border policies to current mobility patterns, the focus remains on enforcing a legalistic dichotomy, and social behaviour is expected to conform to it.

This approach continues to lead towards conclusions and policies that not only bypass the people it aims to engage, but also enter morally and legally grey areas that it claims to wish to abolish: since local militarised control of mobility during times of armed conflict reduces corridors that can be taken by so-called economic migrants, an EU study on cross-border dynamics in the region came to the irritating conclusion that one has to "fear that the exodus and flight [from Ethiopia to Sudan] would increase if and when there is peace and stability in Northern Sudan" (EUTF 2016: 23). The core of this 'fear of peace' lies in a perception of geographical spaces where increasing border consolidation is the norm, and borderland fluidity is seen as an abnormality that must be addressed.

A history of borderland fluidity

Note: This chapter is based on field reports by Tsegaye Birhanu (January-February 2020), Tarig Abdelaziz and Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman (November 2019).

Following the dictum of one of the central studies of the borderland, Zewde 1976, the border agreements primarily reveal the intentions of central governments, forming the basis on which they engage with each other, an understanding already established by Gwynn. Using these agreements as a basis to tell, henceforth, bilateral stories about the borderlands the agreements divided, rephrases – and impoverishes – their shared history. This is also experienced at the Sudan/South Sudan border, which cuts through areas of vivid mobility and exchange, with maps changing the finer lines of administrative units into the stark line of separate countries.

But there is another history to be told, “[t]he history of the frontier peoples to forge their own destiny, often in manifest disregard of what the two governments regarded as their mutual boundary” (Zewde 1976, 106). Such a history is interested in borderlands as consisting of exchange relations, aligning with the principles of the African Union Border Programme that established in 2007 the basis “that a boundary can be viewed as a ‘bridge’ to facilitate interregional integration rather than as a ‘barrier’ to block interaction” (Wubneh 2016: 4). While the border politics outlined above clearly demonstrate that this remains a utopian ideal at the bilateral diplomatic and partly at the borderland level, there is a history of normalised border crossings that, although far from always amicable, can serve as a foundation to pursue such principles.

However, there is a challenge to such an alternative history, as the borderland life and how it was affected by the aforementioned demarcations are less well-documented. Two strands of research can be discerned, though: a complementary focus on local elites and their relationship to macro-political decisions, and the subaltern perspective offered by anthropological work in these areas. A common trait of both is the failure of successive central governments to establish complete control over borderlands, despite – or because of – waves of suppressive policies used to enforce border control. Nevertheless, these waves had significant impacts on people, not least because they often came with forced resettlement. Both previous studies and the present study also highlight the variability of cross-border relations: from active border conflicts characterised by violent outbursts in the northern Sudan-Ethiopia region to more amicable, often family-based permeability in the study area, to the complex history of Gambella and surrounding regions, now the South Sudan-Ethiopia borderland.

Natural features and social exchange

A first step to understanding a borderland's extent and limits is in its topographical features that facilitate or hinder mobility. The former is represented by rivers and creeks, such as in the study area Abay-Blue Nile, Tumat, and Yabus, while the latter is indicated by mountain ranges, e.g., Jabal Shafa (1,678 m) and Jabal Moguf (1,383 m). The same features are, however, also divisive and connecting, with the former characterised by large gorges or high river banks,⁸ and the latter being outliers of the Ethiopian highlands (*dega* and *woyna-dega*, 1,500m and above). Additionally, the plains and valleys between them are covered with dense forests and heavy soils that both hinder motorised transport, especially during the rainy season, and provide numerous paths for travel on foot.⁹ The tropical climate, prone to human and animal diseases such as malaria, combines with water scarcity during the peak of the dry season (November to April), when average temperatures rise to 28-34°C. These harsh conditions require a lengthy period of acclimatisation to become tolerable for long-term residence, which is one of the factors contributing to low human population density and the disdain of Sudanese riverain and Ethiopian highland populations for these areas – mountains (*jibāh*) to the former, lowlands (*kola*) to the latter.¹⁰

As indicated above, only recently have some infrastructural investments affected the options for mobility and residence created by these features. The Abay-Blue Nile gorge, which is up to 4 km deep in parts and several kilometres wide, has separated the northern and southern parts of Benishangul-Gumuz until 2012, when a 365-metre bridge was built by the China Construction Company. Before the state was established, accessibility—and consequently pathways of trade and control—had defined administrative boundaries—Gumuz areas in Gojjam, Benishangul in Wollega. The river offered transverse mobility within the limits set by navigability and later by the successively constructed dams. However, it also necessitated a 1,250 km detour via Neqemte—through Oromia and Amhara—to those moving between today's Metekel Zone and the rest of Benishangul-Gumuz, including its capital. This often made it easier for officials to meet in Addis Ababa, which is only 687 km east of Assosa. The bridge reduced the distance to Gilgil Beles to 378 km (Nur 1971: 177-178; Schlee & Watson 2009: 17; ICG 2013: 2; EnDev 2015: 38). In Blue Nile State, the first bridge over the Blue Nile was still as far as the capital Damazin, and people crossed by boats, for example at Madina 7 (field observation of Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman, November 2019).

⁸ In 1947, Enrico Cerulli still cited Conti Rossini in describing the river Dabus as “the traditional boundary between the Sudanese and the Ethiopians” (Cerulli 1947: 157).

⁹ There are also natural parks that cross the borderland, namely Dinder Park, mostly in Sudan's Sennar State, and Dangur Park in Ethiopia's Metekel zone (EUTF 2016: 18-19).

¹⁰ For both, cultural patterns in southern and south-western areas, such as throwing knives and scarification, symbolised the enslavable Other, on the fringes of high culture (Koettlitz 1900: 489).

The border marked a significant departure from both topographical and demographic links, instead following imperial ideas of spheres of influence and effective control.¹¹ Numerous cultural, linguistic, marital, and familial ties cross this border, with groups such as Gumuz and Berta sharing the borderlands as ‘Sudanese’ and ‘Ethiopians’ alike, engaging in social visits, market exchanges, and seasonal labour as they see fit. In fact, what is elsewhere called ‘informal’, ‘irregular’, or ‘illegal’ can also be seen as a constant assertion that *these* are the proper and relevant connections, and that border regimes are merely the legacy of imperial imposition by both British and Abyssinian authorities.

An observation of the various ways in which official status is or isn’t sought reveals that the population employs a subtle compromise to manage this historical contradiction: some register in the state capital, Al-Damazin, or even hold double citizenship; others only deal with border authorities who record the name of the vehicle driver or sponsor or issue a border document, translated in case someone wants to stay longer or venture further into the country; some evade any interaction with state institutions by using small roads known only to them.

Gradually moving away from the standard case of so-called ‘irregular migration’, specifically the shift or secondary migration to wealthier countries, reveals how the clear-cut distinction between what is legal and what is illegal becomes increasingly blurred into a broader understanding of various forms of social exchange.¹² Local residents rarely ventured far from home when crossing the border, and even border authorities – probably aware of its vital importance – tended to facilitate such multi-purpose visits to families, workplaces, markets, and service providers (EUTF 2016: 24). Apart from social contact and income, such visits offered compensation for weak service infrastructures at home: residents of southern Blue Nile would visit hospitals in Assosa or Al-Damazin, whichever happened to be more accessible, and a perceived lack of proper Muslim and Arabic schools and other institutions in Benishangul-Gumuz led parents to send their children to Sudan (Nur 1971: 159; Young 1999: 342).¹³

¹¹ Geographer Taha Hassan Nur found another way to express this situation, using the term ‘superimposed’ boundary to describe the neglect of cultural and other connections (Nur 1971).

¹² The most comprehensive recent study on cross-border migration, commissioned by the EU, actually examined all these different forms of mobility together and emphasised their interconnection. The authors still persisted in calling all of this ‘irregular’ migration – although it represents one of the most regular forms of mobility in the region’s history – and used terms such as ‘pretext’ and ‘exploiting cultural similarity’ to describe adaptations to restrictions imposed by national laws and official procedures. In a post-colonial and post-war context, this presents a rather uncomfortable lack of reflexivity, even if the implications of the EU’s recent migration and border control policies are set aside.

¹³ A different form of ‘service sharing’ involved telecommunication infrastructure, as networks do not respect borders and extend for tens of kilometres into both countries (EUTF 2016: 19).

Another, more economically oriented form of regular mobility was seasonal labour migration, primarily from Ethiopia to Sudan, focused on the large agricultural schemes at the Blue Nile. Many workers moved back and forth between schemes in both countries, as their seasons alternated. They used unofficial routes to enter Sudan via paths starting from Al-Mahal near Gubba and officially exited through the checkpoint at Menza / Jebel Nimr (EUTF 2016: 25).

Longer stays in Sudan – also as a hub to move on – were mainly targeted by migrants from the overpopulated or drought-affected areas of Amhara and Oromia, or – similar to Eritreans – by hopeful urban youth disconcerted by their prospects at home. However, the extent, organisation, and rhythm of such migration changed over time, often not due to changes in the immediate border areas. For example, the economic crisis in Sudan, which has worsened since 2018, has left its mark here: Sudan became less attractive for Ethiopians to work in, and many have returned.

It is this move outside socially embedded migration, driven by high hopes, that can lead to a lot of exploitation. It would, however, be inaccurate to attribute this solely or even directly to ‘irregular’ cross-border movements, since, unlike border segments further north, trafficking tended to be ‘internal’ (EUTF 2016: 26):

There are reports of internal trafficking of children in BG region. In most cases girls are trafficked for domestic labour, with some reportedly trafficked for commercial sex purposes. Boys are trafficked for child labour exploitation in Khat related services, sale of peanuts and for cattle herding. There are also reports of trafficking and abduction of boys from BG region mostly to Oromia for the purpose of cattle herding (shepherding cattle, goats and sheep). Some of the internal migration of adults from other regions to BG region has some characteristics of human trafficking. For example, workers recruited to work in commercial farms may end up jobless after their arrival because the investment project is abandoned by the investor. The workers rarely get compensation or transportation back to their place of origin, and are left stranded without the means to return home.

This issue is the more critical and intricate, as trade routes and traders’ identity was long emerging from slave trade, both to highland Abyssinia and to riverain Sudan and beyond, and whole ethnicities and power structures have been born out of this combination.

A different aspect of ‘irregular’ migration involves the numerous crossings by refugees from Blue Nile State’s conflict zones, “without notifying the authorities” (EUTF 2016: 18), or ‘escaping’ camps to find work or join family elsewhere.¹⁴ This not only fails to recognise the inadequacy of refugee camps in providing sufficient livelihoods but also overlooks that the administrative label as ‘refugee’ for people spending decades displaced in borderlands—often multiple times—does not reflect their social reality, let alone their social needs. An almost inevitable consequence for people already deprived of their homes is to make at least some use of the limited options they see, regardless of which side of the borders they are on.

¹⁴ Refugees have also been reported to act as facilitators for migration to Sudan (EUTF 2016: 24).

But the border's own transgression of people's livelihoods went deeper than that. The colonial disregard for existing settlements meant the border cut through villages and their neighbouring agricultural land and pastures. As a consequence, "some Ethiopians around the Blue Nile, the Beni Shangul and the Gallabat districts have large areas and own farms in the Sudan", and vice versa (Nur 1971: 157-158). Similar mobility patterns resistant to simple dyadic allocation are pastoralist nomadic routes, some of which persisted throughout most of the 20th century and were ultimately challenged by the dynamics of war in the region.

Social studies of the BSG-BN borderland, many of which have lasted several decades, have long recognised its complex mobilities and relations to authorities, and have offered diverse approaches. One way was to examine the different ways people have responded to and arranged with exposure to modernity, and the resulting socialities. This included a reinforced territorial and spatial understanding of social boundaries, such as bounded territories in the Ingessana Hills; a stronger concept of clan and kinship as the shared foundation of communal life, like in pre-war Uduk society; or a clearer hierarchy of status groups and their respective roles in the division of labour, with more exclusionary tendencies at the top and more inclusive tendencies at the bottom (Jedrej 2004). The latter social structure, roughly describing the relationship between ruling classes formed by riverine in-migrants' intermarriage with Berta and the populations they classified as enslaveable, is the focus of the following chapters, as it is closely connected to the history of gold mining and trade.¹⁵

A related analytical lens was to assess the 'degree of connectedness,' which incorporates the conditionality of people's environment and livelihoods with the variable impact of contact with statehood, broader political developments, and new technologies such as weaponry (Schlee & Watson 2009: 17-18). This also involves the intentional avoidance of such contact, often following a history of hostile experiences, a social response described as 'deep rural' in the literature on southern Blue Nile, and a second pillar for a more nuanced understanding of the limits to current state control.

This also highlights a key aspect of political life in the borderland, which was often defined by a choice between fleeing or submitting. This made, and to some extent still makes, allegiances fragile and 'joining' a more forceful ally rather a temporary arrangement (Young 1999: 323), but recent protectionist reactions are also increasingly radical. It is also important to view borderland fluidity not just as a 'way of life', but to relate it to a context where racial and ethnic politics often became repressive and violent, where adaptability served as "a strategy for gaining economic, political and social prestige, as well as recognition" (Medani 2010: 112). When complementarity and cooperation broke down, particularly over scarce resources, this also prompted the pursuit of alliances that offered an advantage over competitors.

¹⁵ In this book, we use the term 'in-migrants' to refer more generally to new settlers or temporary residents, as opposed to pre-existing or more permanent residents. The term is distinct from both a focus on international borders (immigration) and the simple description of mobility (migration), but it remains, of course, also relative.

Formulating integrative notions of sociality on such a basis is notoriously challenging. In some way, this was, for instance, the experience of a project by an archaeological team from the University of Madrid with the BSG government to establish a regional historical and ethnographic museum. Similar to efforts to communalise archaeological work in northern Sudan, the creation of a representative cultural display could not escape the main dynamics of cultural politics – and the economic struggles associated with it. This included the restriction of artifacts to the five official ethnic groups – Berta, Gumuz, Komo, Mao, and Shinasha – and the risk of “artificial entification” inherent in any musealisation (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 5, 12). The attempt to depict ahistorical cultural purity and clear boundaries between the five different groups was also inconsistent not only with the reality of cultural practices and artefacts, such as Muslim elites demanding the suppression of pre-Islamic items, but also operated with essentialising categories that do not reflect a rich history of cultural exchange (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 13). The insistence on a correspondence between current policies of ethnic federalism and the museum’s display – between political and cultural representation, so to speak – added to the latter’s functions of providing “a liberating narrative that settles scores with the past” (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 15), as it implies portraying current residents – Amhara and Oroma – as former oppressors. The fact that many past and present power elites of the ‘marginalised’ groups played a key role in enforcing such oppression – in the case of Berta against members of their own group and the other four groups – and still remain among the iconic figures in the region’s history, intensifies these complications (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 16). As the following sections will demonstrate, this still represents a gross oversimplification of Berta’s role in the history of the borderland.

The archaeologists still held onto the hope that a stronger emphasis on a history of resistance could promote an alternative narrative, “a praise of the frontier, of cultural coexistence and resistance, non-essentialist identities, societies against the state and egalitarian ethics, as opposed to ruthless states, ethnic exclusivism, political centers and hierarchical and aggressive polities” (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 23). They also saw, somewhat mentioned in passing, a possibility for improved cross-border relations, “enhancing international relations with the neighboring Sudan and minimizing the relevance of artificial nation-state boundaries” (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 23). They regarded meetings between officials from Sudan and from BSG as a good sign in this direction.

This noble wish, however, does not acknowledge the ongoing inadequacy of current administrative language and policies in aligning more closely with border regimes as envisioned in the AU’s Border Programme. This would require breaking free from an imperial past that established the idea of borders as dividing entities, moving towards a border regime whose main purpose is to facilitate exchange and complementarity, and to address shared challenges with collective action, beyond the occasional meetings of officials. Their vision also underestimated the radical tendencies in the borderland’s political present, a present that would need to overcome a history of violence where marking boundaries could also serve as much-needed protection.

Slavery and resettlement

Slavery

One defining aspect of the borderland's history is enslavement, reactions to it, its lasting effects, and how all these elements continue to shape social relations. Being one of the most brutal outcomes of centre-periphery concepts of state and society, the area and its population have long been regarded as a reservoir for enslaved, justified by a perceived racial and cultural inferiority (Seri-Hersch 2010: 17-18). Human beings were, well into the 20th century, among the essential commodities exchanged in local and supra-regional trade (Etefa 2006: 81).

An emphasis on this history lies in the terms *shankilla* / *shuwa*, used to distinguish lowlanders and highlanders as representations of uncivilised blackness and cruel redness, respectively (Young 1999: 322; Gebremichael 2011: 182-183; González-Ruibal 2014: 92). But this is not simply a relation of blacks' fear and reds' disgust. The latter was nourished by a deeply rooted fear among Abyssinian highland Christians of the evil spirits, *baraya*, of the lowlands, which they sought to contain by enslaving them. Meanwhile, backlash against non-indigenous newcomers to the borderlands was one of the population's responses to ongoing stigma against them in the modern states (Gebremichael 2011: 193-194).

This continuity was possible because there was never a clear break with the past. According to several chroniclers, a source of Axumite gold, Metekkel was, together with today's districts of Gubba and Wenbera and the adjacent areas south of the Blue Nile—Benishangul, further south to Gambella, Fazughli, and further south to Kurmuk—one of the most raided regions under various empires, mainly due to its position at the edges of the kingdoms of Sennar and Abyssinia, and between Arabic / Islamic and Amhara / Christian cultural areas (OSSREA 2002: 7-8). For a long time, the Gumuz populations were surrounded by hostile incursions, also by Agaw from the east and Shinasa from the south—military attacks aimed at capturing goods and people and enforcing tribute systems—often leaving, together with spreading poverty and disease, only flight as an escape for a population facing guns with bows, arrows, and spears (Etefa 2006: 15-16; Ahmad 1999: 440).

This situation also resulted in enclaves and various forms of population dispersal, with Gubba acting as an important transition point into the Sennar sultanate via Roseiris and further into Sudan. Under British colonial rule, runaway slaves and other refugees from the borderland were settled into new villages, some as military reserves, such as the one at Wadi Halfa, others as an agricultural labour pool, around Qallabat, Gedarif, and Kassala, for instance. The Roseiris Slavery Repression Department, formed in 1902, played a crucial role in this and also documented strategies of identity shift among the refugees: once they reached Roseiris, Gumuz would change their names to Arabic ones, for example, to register there, thereby strengthening their request for protection and making it impossible for officials to return them to Ethiopian masters—even if British officials were inclined to do so—since enslaved had to be claimed by name (Ahmad 1999: 441-442).

Meanwhile, imperial Abyssinian policies towards slavery persisted in a mixture of maintaining the status quo and presenting itself as a committed member of the newly formed League of Nations, which Ethiopia joined on 28 September 1923, in contradiction to the stipulations of the Brussels Act of 1890 and the Slavery Convention of 1926. Meanwhile, officially announced penalties on slavery coexisted with ongoing raids, while Christian military rulers continued to uphold their aristocratic lifestyle by colluding with Muslim merchants in exploiting 'pagan' regions that remained unchanged within a rigid social hierarchy throughout the 20th century. Accordingly, the same royal court under Ras Tafari, which had declared slave trade illegal, still ordered new slaves from Sheikh Khojali and local rulers in the borderlands (Ahmad 1999: 443-444).

The continuation of the social foundation of slavery also meant that anti-slavery measures could reduce but not eliminate the trade. In Sudan, the protected refuge for Gumuz, Berta, and Koma in the southern Blue Nile areas and elsewhere drained some of the enslaveable population from the Ethiopian side. Closed District policies along the border, up to Dinder, also reduced traffic, combined with the arrest of some central traders. But it was the Italian invasion in 1935 that altered the dynamics more significantly, as it shifted physical control over the borderlands in favour of the resident population who were compelled into military service, and slavery was, once again, declared abolished in 1942. However, not only did the influx of refugees into Sudan continue – including some Gumuz anticipating Italian-Ethiopian confrontations – but also the socio-economic and demographic effects of decades of extensive disruption, which have continued to shape perceptions of 'highland' and 'government' and their potential threats throughout the 20th century (Ahmad 1999: 444-445).

It is important to note here the position of Gubba and how its role as a bridge and entry point into areas further west – into Sudan – served as a relief for the pressure on the borderland population north of the Blue Nile. This was related to the stronger historical connection of this area to Sennar, through the *makk* of Gule, and a ruling family under *manjil* Hamdan Abu Shok (ruling 1898-1938), who saw himself as a descendant of a Funj-based dynasty and promoted a blend of trade and Islamic culture that fostered integration into the westbound trade networks and hindered the influx of highland feudalism. This rule also established its domain – in contrast to warlords further south – as a protective realm, since it prevented the enslavement of its own subjects without sacrificing the advantages of cheap agricultural and other labour sourced from enslaved from elsewhere, traded or raided from other Gumuz areas (Ahmad 1999: 438-439). Similar to Berta, there is not a single Gumuz population but rather several enclaves and groupings that were, to varying degrees, impacted by extractive activities.

This is well reflected in the heterogeneous response of the population to the Italian invasion, which showed different perceptions of what 'siding' would be the best way to survive the ensuing confrontations, "a strategy of resistance developed by populations who have been accustomed to be conquered, enslaved and looted over the centuries" (González-Ruibal 2010: 569). Some saw collaboration as a welcome resistance against the highland rulers, and the Italians' suppression of slavery – in exchange for other forms of submission – appeared to confirm this. Others, however, chose to avoid taking sides by retreating into more inaccessible areas (González-Ruibal 2010: 569).

A few elites saw their status quo threatened, as slave trade had been the foundation of their wealth and authority. In fact, Hamdan Abu Shok's son Mohammed resumed slave raids along the Yabus River and collected taxes in the form of gold after the Italians had left in 1942; several Agaw rulers had even continued to raid during the occupation. The Gubba-Qeissan trade route was cut off during the war, and cross-border trade goods still reaching Italian regions were confiscated, with special arrangements agreed upon between the British and Italian sides only up to 1938 (Etefa 2006: 83-84).

The circumstance that the basic hierarchies remained unchanged in the second half of the 20th century, combined with a much more militaristic response from Gumuz populations who had experienced advanced weaponry or, at the very least, the possibility of Highlanders' temporary defeat under Italian rule. They unleashed accumulated rage on neighbouring settlements, rather than the centres of power. From at least the 1950s, attacks escalated and partly involved strong brutality against perceived slave traders, including cutting off limbs and other mutilations. The government's response was also militaristic, involving the arming of Oromo, Shinasha, and Agaw populations, along with eradication campaigns that led to the massacre of the Debatsi clan, who inhabited the area where the town Dibate would later be founded. This merely prolonged the exchange of brutalities into the 1970s (OSSREA 2002: 17-19). It demonstrates the variability in how different parts of the population perceived these dynamics that some considered this period under Haile Selassie's rule later as "a period of relative welfare and peace" (González-Ruibal 2014: 96).

A central point to understand the fragility of 'legality' and 'legitimacy' of government is that the practical difference between various raiding parties and other forms of exploitation was minimal. Whether through open robbery or 'combatting tax evasion', the 19th-century rule that bandits (*šiftah*) could become future rulers and vice versa still held, as people continued to shift allegiances to whoever seemed to offer the most protection. It could be argued that an increase in military posts at the frontier did little to alter this dynamic, while the reopening of the Roseiris-Gubba trade route and open trans-regional agreements between Mohammad Hamdan and the Roseiris District Commissioner increased interest in smoother exchanges, possibly linked to an overall reduction in raids after the 1950s (Etefa 2006: 85, 92).

Resettlement

The emancipatory rhetoric of the Derg regime could not hide the ongoing highland-focused policy towards the borderland, and the non-consensual resettlement policies of the 1980s were mostly arranged as an extension of highland peasants' land access into Metekkel. This had also been a feature of imperial policies, with up to 10,000 households resettled across Ethiopia until 1974, as a long-term government response to the significant gaps in population density.¹⁶ But these grew to 46,000 households in the first decade of Derg rule, and the deforestation of large tracts of land for 80,000 peasants in

¹⁶ While Benishangul-Gumuz has a population density of about 14.5 persons per km², Oromia has 104.5 and Amhara 117.4 (Gebremichael 2011: 280).

Metekkel was not just an ecological act of transformation but also a symbolic erasing of forest dwellers. Most of the resettled Amhara, Kambata, and Hadiya did not stay, and the 30,000 who remained were in ongoing conflict with the Gumuz, which peaked violently in the early 1990s but still continued to flare up. In fact, resettlement did not cease under EPRDF rule, as the period between 2003 and 2007 saw the relocation of 627,000 people (González-Ruibal 2014: 96; Labzaé 2016: 204, 206).

In any case, the Derg period is particularly significant to recognise, as it was during this time that these policies brought Amhara populations as ‘regional strangers’ into western areas, especially Benishangul-Gumuz and Gambella, along with some in-migrants from Gojjam. This was followed by the territorialisation of ethno-political representation in 1994, which was especially significant for the former peripheries of the Ethiopian Empire, historically regarded as resource-rich reservoirs – and still often seen as such. The ‘regional strangers’ resulted from protective policies, known as ethnic federalism, which separated the population into indigenous/native and non-indigenous/non-native groups. While being vital to political and economic relations, these terms were never explicitly codified but indicated, through implicit consensus recorded in the regional constitution, “people who have lived in the region prior to the arrival of the highlanders in the early part of the 20th century” (Gebremichael 2011: 181).

The close link between being regarded as native and gaining political representation is evident in the fact that, in 2008, Amhara made up 21.25% of the population, second only to Berta (25.9%), yet had no political representative apart from the special *woreda* based on the Pawé resettlement scheme (in Metekel), which was established after violent clashes with Gumuz in 1993. The Amhara resettled around Assosa, for example, could only participate at the lowest level of the administrative hierarchy (Labzaé 2016: 208-209). Membership in the Benishangul-Gumuz Peoples’ Democratic Party or Benishangul-Gumuz Democratic Unity Front, a prerequisite for attaining higher positions, was restricted to ‘natives’. Amhara were limited to their ethnic branch within the EPRDF, following the principles of state governance through *qäbbäle*, a mix of Derg local state organs and the principles of ethnic federalism, similar to other continuities after the regime change (Labzaé 2016: 211-212).¹⁷ This apparent reversal of the ethno-political hierarchy was limited by the fact that the Benishangul-Gumuz Democratic Unity Front (BGDUF) had been established in 1996 by EPRDF leadership as an alternative to the Benishangul People’s Liberation Movement (see below) and was induced to adopt the political programme of the ANDM (Amhara National Democratic Movement) (ICG 2009: 17).

The system thus perpetuated and cemented the highland-lowland dichotomy, sitting uneasily with various societal dynamics. The inclusion of multiple ‘native’ groups somewhat alleviated the contradictions arising from ethnic federalism’s initial model of mono-ethnic states, and the establishment of special *woreda* addressed ethnic ‘enclaves’, but both remained rooted in a concept of political community based on ethnic exclusivity.

¹⁷ This affirmative interaction is a relatively recent development, though, as the 1990s still saw mostly non-local officials due to a lack of suitable candidates (Young 1999: 338).

This was at odds with the social fluidity of borderlands, as well as other demographic ‘complications’ of a region with a long history of displacement.

For one, slavery also led to the creation of enclaves in several parts of the country, such as farm labourers at Rogda south-west of Addis Ababa, who were enslaved as Gumuz but later considered themselves *guddifachaa* of the Oromo. Other Gumuz were abducted to Awash Valley and then returned there after being brought to Benishangul-Gumuz following 1991, in a government effort to relocate them to their ‘home’ (Etefa 2006: 16-17). Second, ethnic federalism did not guarantee unimpeded prosperity, and for many years after its introduction, there was virtually no infrastructural or other improvement in the region (Markakis 2011: 351).

This also highlights a persistent asymmetry where regional political control does not necessarily align with economic empowerment, and in the case of large-scale projects, not even a decisive say in major extractive and productive activities within the state. This can be most effectively traced by examining contradictions in land policies.

Modernisation policies have always tended not only to impose central governments’ ideas of what a modern society should be like but also to treat populations and their resources as mere material to be put to use. Accordingly, non-consensual resettlement persisted in the post-Derg era, particularly during the 2000s with extensive villagisation campaigns that ignored existing socio-spatial patterns and aimed to concentrate people and their lands, thereby freeing ‘idle’ land for cultivation and other investments (González-Ruibal 2014: 96-97). In a bitter twist of history, multinational companies had now greater success in surpassing local resistance and bypassing compensation than during colonial and imperial times: when British-based Sun Biofuels abandoned an 80,000 ha deforested and depopulated area in Metekkel in the mid-2000s because it suddenly deemed the site unsuitable for their biodiesel project, no compensation or reforestation was required, and the same area was leased to another multinational just a few years later (González-Ruibal 2014: 97-98; compare with the fate of a British mining company about 100 years earlier in section ‘Mining in Benishangul’).

The regional Land Use Proclamation of 2010 aimed to simplify – and possibly correct – the process through comprehensive land registration, but in the first five years, less than a third of the targeted plots and farmers were covered. One of the reasons was reluctance or even resistance from the resident population, who perceived their historical experience of dispossession shining through the promises of the policymakers: a ten-hectare ceiling for each household not only contradicted extensive slash-and-burn practices but also the preferred share-cropping and renting of land to non-residents, all of which was intended to be discouraged by the regional government. Furthermore, the same rationale from the 2000s to provide land to investors, mostly in Metekkel, propelled the process without addressing previous shortcomings. The fact that most investors brought workers from elsewhere—Amhara, Tigray, Oromia, but also the Southern Nations, Nationalities and Peoples’ Region—did not help to boost the process’s legitimacy (EUTF 2016: 13, 15).

Investment deals across regional borders, such as those made by Oromia state that sparked ongoing conflicts with Kamashi *woreda*, fostered this general suspicion towards large-scale land acquisitions as well as slow encroachment between farming areas. The

Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam, constructed near Gubba, began as a trade-off between centrally defined priorities and the populations' desire to maintain or improve their current situation. Still, the subsequent expansion of large-scale agricultural projects escalated tensions over land and increased conflict potential in Benishangul-Gumuz (Ficquet & Feyissa 2015: 51). The fact that Gumuz elites were often involved in such land investments demonstrates a persistent pattern of local leaders making deals with more powerful actors, even at the expense of their 'subjects', becoming a mere extension of the centre, a 'subordinate elite' (Moreda 2015: 19, Markakis 2011: 11-12).

The failure to comply with centralised distribution regulations was therefore also related to the experience of quasi-expropriation in favour of large-scale land acquisitions. Even nominally developmental programmes appeared to follow this trend, and the clear link between investment projects and the focus areas of villagisation made the government's claims of community empowerment seem superficial to those affected as well (Moreda 2015: 7). The detached view of resources by central state authorities not only perpetuated an exploitative perception of what these areas represent but also undermined the supposed emancipation of these regions in the post-1991 system, affecting both regional government and residents: "Although the federal government may have reasserted its authority over territory and people in this way, the implications of undermining the authority of local and regional state actors over the allocation, use and regulation of land resources within their jurisdictions may become a focal point of resistance" (Moreda 2015: 16).

The inevitable backlash against investors in Gumuz areas included clandestine sabotage and even murder, but also threats against in-migrant labourers; these violent responses were comparatively rare, however. Some simply returned to their old areas, while others, upon hearing of cases where the land there had already been given away, refused to leave in the first place. Still others chose to feign compliance to avoid confrontation and ended up living and cultivating in two places; some adhered to the old tactic of fleeing to less accessible areas. What appeared here was, once again, a full range of variable responses to external challenges, an array of resistance (Moreda 2015: 17-18).

But tensions still concerned the 'in-migrant' resettled communities as well. In the mid-2010s, this also became an issue of land administration, as general land registration processes were intensified and involved, at that point, the resettlement villages. Due to ethnic federalism and other sensitivities related to belonging, the registration inevitably also implied a judgment on who had become an integral, legitimate part of the region's population (Labzaé 2016: 207). The fact that the expulsion of Amhara from Benishangul-Gumuz in 2013 did not affect those in the special *woreda* shows a certain level of integration of the latter, but it also halted land registration in disputed areas, avoiding a decision on people's status within the dichotomy of land ownership (Labzaé 2016: 217).

Historical complications also affected these dichotomies: there was no straightforward equivalence between resettled and current Amhara populations, as people had either moved back or fled to Sudan from the labour-intensive schemes. The turbulent presence of several armed movements in the region contributed to this discontinuity, especially when Oromo Liberation Front forces began targeting the resident population (Labzaé

2016: 210). However, for those who had remained throughout these years, a contradiction emerged between their quasi-legal status as non-indigenous and the fact “that after more than thirty years, settlers’ descendants have many more links with the place they were born in than with their parents’ homeland. Many of them even never visited Wollo. Despite the fact that only a few learned local languages, they feel that they are locals” (Labzaé 2016: 218). Their multiple economic and social links, sharecropping, trade, etc., stood against the weight of the historical chasm created by ‘their’ role as oppressive invaders (Labzaé 2016: 219).

More recently, increasing tensions over the future of ethnically defined residence in present-day Ethiopia have also reached Benishangul-Gumuz, with multiple implications. These include recurrent clashes in Metekel Zone (e.g., April 2019, June-July 2019 after a coup attempt in Amhara), escalating tensions in and around the capital Assosa (e.g., June 2014 as a result of BPLM attacks, June 2018), and conflicts in other districts (e.g., Kamashi in late 2018).

The confrontations around Assosa, which erupted into violence in late 2018, highlight the ongoing significance of these dynamics: the resettled Amhara communities were mainly impacted by infrastructural ventures such as Assosa University, the airport, and an agricultural research centre, complemented by plans for a 1,000-hectare industrial park. These were described by ANDM leaders as an additional grievance, closely linked to a broader claim over parts of Benishangul-Gumuz, particularly Metekel Zone, as part of the historical Gojjam region. OLF-BPLM-TPLF’s historical tensions also flared up after demonstrations for Abiy Ahmed following the Meskel Square attack and led to killings in downtown Assosa between Oromo and Berta, as well as at Assosa University after anti-Tigray attacks, particularly against a TPLF investor in town in November 2018.¹⁸ The merger of the BGDUF into the Prosperity Party, as the country-wide successor to the EPRDF, in December 2019, integrated the region into Abiy Ahmed’s effort to diminish ethnic federalism. This process shaped subsequent political developments, with the first indication of these changes in a national election in 2021.

Emancipation

These conflicts were a continuation of historical animosities that still remained unresolved and were accentuated by land and other policies. From a borderland perspective, they were part of emancipation efforts, of which boundary-making was merely one among several approaches. Two of these approaches have been highlighted so far: alliance and flight. The former was a reaction to coercion or a ‘best bet’ on the more favourable side to select, and could adopt very unpredictable and shifting positions.¹⁹ The latter maintained a continuous flow to less accessible, or better protected, areas during times of conflict or in response to other problems, and numerous cross-border kinship and

¹⁸ These events were still very much evident when Enrico Ille visited Assosa in November 2019.

¹⁹ Some Gumuz, for instance, were among the multi-composited forces operating against SPLM/A-North from Kurmuk in 2011, alongside Chadian rebels who had been trained by *janjawid* in West Darfur before (ICG 2013: 23).

other ties between Gumuz trace back to temporary settlements established across the borderland (Etefa 2006: 98-100).

But other, socially complex forms of coping involved cultural adjustments that divided the ethnic Gumuz groups, which spoke different dialects and were further subdivided into several, sometimes feuding clans, as well as by various cultural practices, chiefly religion, language, and marriage. What further complicates this cultural landscape is that these characteristics may also vary according to social status within a single group or clan.

What is important to highlight about this complexity is contact identity and terminological heterogeneity. The former emphasises the significance of the tangible social environment in shaping cultural traits and practices. In the case of Gumuz groups, a significant difference can be observed between those in the Kamashi area, who, like the Shinasha, became more similar to their Oromo neighbours, and where Christian Orthodoxy spread in regions closer to the Amhara. Meanwhile, Muslim Gumuz tended to be concentrated in the Ethiopian-Sudanese borderland (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 13). The Gumuz language, with many dialects like Ganza and S'es'e, was mostly preserved in the widespread homesteads, while centres of trade and authority, such as Gubba, tended to adopt Arabic (Ahmad 1999: 434). Sister-exchange marriage, prevalent among the Gumuz in Ethiopia, has been abandoned among the Gumuz in Sudan and among groups with active cross-border marriage relations with them, such as Gubawi, Abu Ramla, and Kadalo, in exchange for bride price (Etefa 2006: 98).²⁰

The latter highlights the complex variety of ethnonyms found in the literature and in the borderland for the existing groups, a consequence of a history full of ruptures. Unlike terms that combine ethnic, racial, hierarchical, and historical notions, such as Hamaj or Funj, Gumuz can generally be constructed on a linguistic basis. One of their imminent historians described it as “the most reasonable term for the *Bägga, Sai, Sese, Gunza, Kadalo* and other related groups living on both sides of the Abbay River and the international boundary between Ethiopia and the Sudan” (Etefa 2006: 18). Similar to other collective terms, however, it is open to situational or new additions based on interpretation, as in the case of the recently associated Dats'in (Hernando et al. 2019).

These terms thus refer to a historical experience and how current populations connect with it, rather than a straightforward outcome of ethnogenesis and group formation. The irritating heterogeneity of exonyms and endonyms encountered by anyone engaging in conversations about what they and others are is also reflected in numerous naming practices in the literature, and it found a treacherous ‘solution’ in the statistical categories and lists of administrations on both sides of the border.

It is important to note that these naming practices – like the alliances – are far from arbitrary but reflect complex and often painful processes of emancipation. Slavery, for instance, continues to have a profound impact on societies, especially in defensive

²⁰ This can also be traced to material culture. Houses, for instance, tend to be more similar in the inner areas shared by Gumuz, Berta, Mao, and Komo than in the outer regions of the borderlands (González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínéz 2007: 12-13).

cultural practices and social innovations that address disconnections around individuals separated from their social world. While the term *shankalla* was outlawed only in 1974, it still retained currency long after that. In response, especially Gumuz related to the chiefdom of Gubba described themselves as Funj and used the Arabic term for freedom (*hurriyyah*) in their political discourses of emancipation (James 1988: 130, 135). This claim of a historical and linguistic link represents the creation of a connection that is significant within the context of ongoing struggles over superiority and inferiority.

What makes these interconnections so challenging, however, is that it does not necessarily resolve the struggle. An Oromo institution such as *muchu*, meaning ‘friendship’, can signify both a partnership and a subtle asymmetry: some Oromo groups’ desire to acquire gold without the knowledge, perseverance, and access to go panning in Metekkel’s and Kamashi’s rivers themselves has created an incentive to agree with resident Gumuz, rather than engaging in trade or robbery that might not end favourably for either side. The Gumuz gold washers, not knowledgeable in goldsmithery, were inclined to expand their participation in trade networks through the Oromo goldsmiths (OSSREA 2002: 27-28). The exchange did not eliminate Oromo ideology of cultural superiority or Gumuz’ past experience of displacement and enslavement but temporarily suspended hostility that might – or might not – develop into something more lasting.²¹

Trade and rule

The area south of the Abay / Blue Nile forms part of a belt of plateaus interrupted by some mountainous regions that, in various ways, lie between the Ethiopian highlands and the Sudanese plains. Multiple rivers and valleys run through it, supporting the growth of dense forests or grassy woodlands with bamboo. It is, therefore, both fertile and protective, making it an ideal environment to seek refuge in a ‘deep rural’ setting. While this is certainly part of its socio-ecological history, much of its political history was marked by trade connections and rule steeped in violence.

In case of the Berta, their social history of becoming, or ethno-genesis, strongly reflects these contradictory dynamics between closing and opening to the wider world. These dynamics were central to an equally contradictory notion of state legitimacy – and thus the legality of borders – which has persisted until today: they embody the principle of international borders contradicting social boundaries that have expanded through mobility following natural features. While Berta were historically connected to the downstream areas (*sāfil*) of the Nile, they became hill-and-valley dwellers of the upstream (*sa’īd*), between the plains in Sudan and the highland Oromo areas southwest.

²¹ In areas such as Kamashi, Gumuz were taken as slaves by Oromos at least until 1993, and students carried weapons to school (Young 1999: 336).

Ethno-genesis

The presence of Berta, as defined by their Nilo-Saharan language, in today's Benishangul is often traced back to the 17th century, using both material and immaterial evidence (Gebremichael 2011: 183; González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínez 2007: 7-8). The translation of a non-Arabic term, *bela shangul*, into an Arabic notion, *banī šanqūl*, also reflects the transformation of a culturally specific, non-Islamic object into a Bedouin genealogical principle of group naming, mirroring the historical processes by which the second term later acquired, as *shankalla*, a pejorative connotation: *bela shangul* denoted the 'rock of *shangul*', an oblong stone representing the spirit of the ancestor migrant Berta groups would carry with them wherever they went (Triulzi 1975: 55-57; Triulzi 1981: 28-30). This central spiritual element was turned into a pejorative term by the highland Christians, and, similar to terms like 'Nuba' or 'Sudanese', was extended to cover a broad range of different people perceived to be in the same category. As an exonym, it was used variably for a mountain, a border region, a sheikhdome, and finally a federal state district; this term and its implications are the focus in this section.²²

It is not the aim here to delve into the issue of origins, a discussion always closely linked with the interpretation of current relations; there are landmark historical studies on the area for that, which will be referenced. The focus is also on developments in the 19th and 20th centuries, not early migration history. However, it is relevant to briefly mention the fate of some pre-migration cultural elements.

The migration from areas further west, as well as the experience of being overpowered by other groups, are central elements of Berta's social history.²³ Both the decision to migrate and the resistance to or mediation of external influence have long been in the hands of *neri*, a diviner who could channel *shangur*, fortunes communicated through the flames of specific woods or grasses. Although ultimately superseded by Islamic practices, this institution long co-existed with or resisted such influences. It is important to remember that these influences did not only originate from northern empires but also from other contact states and peoples, such as the Shilluk kingdom, Dinka, Mao, and Koma, among others (Triulzi 1981: 26-28, 54). However, a competition emerged between healers (*mabai hes 'ein*) who could practice in a way that did not clearly contradict Islamic norms and practices, or turn to biomedicine if necessary, and the older institution of *neri*, which declined but had not vanished by the early 2000s (González-Ruibal 2014: 199).

²² This process of historical interpretation remains socially active. A family interviewed in Damazin, for example, discussed their differing opinions extensively. Some linked the name to the Berta word *shirjir*, meaning donkey, inspired by the shape of the eponymous mountain, claiming *banī* was added by Arabs. Having heard that Pharaonic rule had extended into this area, some also considered the Nubian *shankal*, meaning gold, as a possible relation (interview with Waṭāwīt family in Damazin, 29 November 2019). References to origins in Qarri have also been documented by Triulzi (Triulzi 1981: 22-23).

²³ It should be noted, however, that Berta in the Tumat valley were aware that they themselves had dislocated Mao and Koma, who had been settling there (Triulzi 1981: 23).

Another crucial element was a territorial concept of land (*etho*) that assigned specific areas to specific groups, arguably a social innovation following migration into the borderlands (Triuzli 1981: 31) and an important precursor to what can be regarded as 'protectionist' tendencies in today's societies and their application of the *kebele* system. These also relate to subsequent waves of in-migration, each adding a new layer to Berta groups' division and stratification, along with numerous terms attempting to classify people according to inferior and superior traits.

A pre-existing hierarchical structure of Berta society was strengthened when areas fell under Funj rule, which fostered the establishment of a ruling class that directed a residential shift from the mountains to the plains. This did not prevent the application of a new ethnonym, *jabalāwīyyīn*, meaning the mountain dwellers, which served as a way for Funj elites and 'Arab' subjects to distinguish themselves from these new additions to the realm. In areas closer to Sennar, such as Fazughli and Keili, Berta elites were included under the class of Hamaj within Sennar's strongly racialised system of social status codes, a term that means 'the indistinguishable ones', as the common intermarriages among Funj elites created a form of 'blood-mix' that individuals claiming Arab origins particularly sought to highlight. In the regions of Benishangul and Khomosha, attempts by 'Arab' in-migrants to uphold their claimed superior status, even after intermarrying with daughters of local Berta chiefs, led to them self-identifying as Banī Ummāyah, which the Berta later transformed into Mayu. While Islamization spread with these newcomers, they also adopted many existing cultural practices, including a form of blended Berta language which the Berta called *ndu mayu*, the mouth of the Mayu (Zewde 1976: 15; Triulzi 1981: 76-78; González-Ruibal 2014: 183).

The second half of the 18th century experienced significant unrest throughout the core and fringe areas of the Funj sultanate. Economic hardships and famines compelled many riverine peasants to become traders, moving into the borderlands in search of gold and other goods, often claiming a status there that they could never have achieved in their northern homesteads. During the 19th century, the Ottoman invasion – and especially the repercussions of the assassination of Ismail Pasha – brought even larger numbers of riverain traders and Islamic preachers claiming Arab descent into the region. Their cohabitation and intermarriage with Berta chiefs led to the emergence of the group that called itself Ashrāf, 'the noble' – and implicitly descendants of followers of the Prophet – but was rather called *waṭāwīt* by others, Arabic for 'bats', an animal that is half rat and half bird. Some Watawit families rose to a higher level of political power, and they established the main sheikhdoms of Bela Shangul in the mid-19th century, creating political structures that still exert influence today (Zewde 1976: 16; Medani 2010: 116-117; González-Ruibal 2014: 183).

The name Watawit expands the range of collective terms that describe a similar way of becoming, rather than indicating ethnic or cultural uniformity. Several groups found separately in the region, such as Rikabīyyah, Harakin, and Dawāla, also exist in 'Watawit form'. The racial and cultural distinction between the old and the new elites, a variation of the previously mentioned 'blackness' (*undulu*) and 'redness', was partly manifested

through religious terms, where the newcomers could assert greater access to ‘true’ Islam via Quranic education, and partly through trade connections, where links to Sennar and beyond placed Watawit first in administrative roles and later above the old ruling class.²⁴ Outside the political theatres, too, their different origin was long on display: during weddings, Mayu and Watawit descendants would have their grooms wear jellabiyyah and ride a donkey, the main vehicle of the petty trader, then work for the wife’s parents for three years, a practice not known among Berta proper (Triulzi 1981: 107, 114; ICG 2013: 4; González-Ruibal 2014: 186-187).

However, this transition of power was all but smooth. Ultimately, Berta and other communities were only subdued through force, and control was never entirely achieved. But not only the power of firearms, but also the spread of Islamic influence through the activities of Sufi orders, especially Sammaniyyah and Khatmiyyah, lent force to the new order, albeit within the framework of a slave-owning society. Ultimately, the relationship between ‘oldtimers’ and newcomers was one of exploitative merchants and a population fighting against enslavement. It is important not to underestimate how much this claim and rejection of cultural, racial, and economic superiority still influence the formation of political alliances today, even within groups that the official discourse terms ‘indigenous’.

Trade

At the end of the 19th century, the macropolitical structure of Benishangul was dominated by the rivalry among four sheikhdoms, all of which had emerged from trader families that gradually expanded their influence. Benishangul proper was a sheikhdom south of Qeissan under Khojali Adam and his son ‘Abd al-Rahman aka Tur el Guri. Another sheikhdom encompassed Agoldi/Assosa and was governed, well into the 20th century, by Khojali Al-Hassan. A third sheikhdom, based in Khomosha, was established by Ummad wad al-Hajj in Andu and was later ruled by Mahmud Muhammad Himmadi. The sheikhdom of Muhammad Hassan, also known as Abba Moti, was centred in Fadasi.

As previously mentioned, trade and trade networks were vital for the foundation and consolidation of these sheikhdoms. It was access to these trade networks that had led local rulers to give merchants from the Funj sultanate special treatment, a sultanate that was itself governed by its biggest merchant. In fact, the Islamic rules of trade required alliances or annexations with non-Muslim areas, and Fazughli, Keili, and Gule at the southern fringes of the sultanate became important passage points to access resources in these southern and south-eastern regions, including enslaved and gold. It is therefore no coincidence that Ethiopian Muslims, collectively known as Gābārti, dominated trade between the kingdoms of Sennar and Abyssinia, thus linking the Horn of Africa with Egypt and the Mediterranean nations. With the easing of Egyptian trade policies in the mid-19th century, the significance of connections to European traders also grew (Jedrej 2004: 713-714; Nur 1971: 170-172).

²⁴ For a more detailed contextualisation of Watawit’s status in the regions west of the borderland, see the chapter “Vampires of the borderlands” in Jay Spaulding’s *The heroic age in Sinnār* (1985/2006).

In fact, when Fazughli was made the district capital of what Ottoman-Egyptian officials called Dār al-Berta, the land of Berta, high taxation and brutal raiding parties contributed to heightening tensions and insecurity for travellers, but, unexpectedly, also led to increased trade activities. Heavily armed caravans would cross the area south of Fazughli and reach Benishangul, which became an important hub towards the productive Oromo regions of Sibü and Lega. This shift was especially noticeable when the riverine, impoverished population began to flee southwards from the exploitation by invaders, with some ultimately settling. A chain of markets was soon established, from Sennar, Karkoj, Roseiris and Fazughli to Qeissan, Kirin, Khomosha, Gogora, and Fadasi; when the Ottoman-Egyptian headquarters were shifted to Dul / Kurmuk, Agoldi / Assosa became important as a centre for a southern route. This highlights not only the significance of government outposts and their infrastructure – which was reversed in the early 20th century when railways stopped at Roseiris and the focus shifted to Gedarif and Qallabat – but also how trade can profoundly influence political structures: more than merely transporting goods, these initially petty traders evolved into advisors and administrators – especially towards the Arabic-speaking Ottoman-Egyptian regime – and eventually into rulers. At the same time, since ‘Arab’ traders were not permitted to move southward from Gondar into Oromo regions, with Gäbärti acting as intermediaries, this established an additional bridge and transitional zone—a buffer—between areas with stricter crossing rules (Triulzi 1975: 57-59; Triulzi 1981: 125-127).

The range of goods traded through these networks was extensive, and a pattern that still echoes today. Manufactured and processed goods such as cloth and Venetian beads came from Sudan, while Oromo traders brought donkeys, cattle, horses, sheep, goats, honey, sorghum, and iron. The more valuable but also officially restricted goods, especially ivory and enslaved people, were traded away from the regime’s military posts; during and after the Mahdiyyah, rifles also became part of such trade (Etefa 2006: 77-78).²⁵ This represents another sustainable pattern in the movement of goods – rather than a clear boundary between ‘smuggling’ and official trade, a mix has developed based on state policies and the structure of the value chain.

In the markets of Benishangul, the primary exchange was salt for gold in the form of rings (*waqēñ*), whether the salt came from the Ethiopian coast or via Sudan. Due to the difficulties of transporting salt to the markets, they had a comparatively high price, but the fame of the locally produced gold made it even more expensive further north, with price increases of more than 100% before reaching the market at Jeddah (Triulzi 1981: 105, 131-132).

Another important pattern originating in the 19th century is a monopoly on goldsmithing and subsequent trade that made gold profitable for local rulers and intermediaries they sold to, rather than the gold producers themselves. This had essentially two structural reasons: the low productivity of the single miners and the often violent dominance over their labour, not least due to the close link between gold mining and slavery.

²⁵ See Etefa 2006: 78-80 for similar patterns in Metekkel. Unlike the slave trade, World War II and its aftermath did not end arms trading across borders, but it has remained a lucrative business long after that (Nur 1971: 186-187).

The former resulted from the techniques that were employed, as men sieved alluvial sand and women searched for grains using vulture feather quills, with a gold content of about 1.5g per ton (Meckelburg 2016: 150):

This confirms the idea of a traditional system of production extending well into Ethiopia's modern era: In these gold districts it is very common to see men carrying a wooden traylike pan about 2 feet long and 15 to 18 inches wide. This pan is used for gold washing. A small goat-skin bag contains quills in which the gold is kept, and other apparatus. They carry also a neat native-made balance, with weights of pebbles or seeds, fitted into a small basket, by means of which they are able to ascertain fairly accurately the value of their washings. These quills filled with gold dust, or small packets of it, or gold rings of different weights, have a known value, and pass as currency throughout these districts, and there are some markets, notably that of Nago, which go by the name of "gold markets," and are frequented by merchants desirous of exchanging their commodities for gold dust.

The quills acted as local currency, but smelting was largely unknown to the miners; the traders themselves formed the rings for broader commerce. This not only placed the latter in a dominant position for market access but also significantly increased demand for the commodity to previously unknown levels. By the mid-19th century, agriculture had declined substantially, and Berta women had nearly ceased wearing gold jewellery as trade overtook what was once a peripheral good. Several processes intertwined to position gold centrally, apart from the evolving taste among Berta gold miners for consumer goods: Ottoman-Egyptian officials insisted on payment of taxes in gold, and local rulers increased production demands to ensure a steady supply of this commodity, which was now forged into bars and was also the main currency in cross-regional trade until the Maria Theresa Thaler was introduced (Triulzi 1981: 133-134; Etefa 2006: 77-78).²⁶

This rise in production also led to technological innovations. The valleys of the rivers Tumat and Adi had almost no pits at the start of Ottoman rule, but in less than fifty years, hundreds of circular shafts more than 3 metres deep were observed. Wooden trays were used, and a rainy-season activity now extended throughout the year, with men doing the digging and women handling the washing; this division of labour remained largely unchanged into the 21st century. At the beginning of the 20th century, techniques at the Dul mines had developed to such an extent that entire families worked in pit systems with standardised distances between shafts, which included stepping stones to facilitate easier extraction of material. Productivity had also increased, with about 1.4g produced daily by a married couple (Triulzi 1981: 134-135).

However, the main part of gold mining was far from being voluntary family work. Since gold formed the basis of Watawit's rising status, they forcibly entered the sector, initially forcing the Berta population to cease their agricultural practices, and then converting them into servile labourers and slaves, as they became reliant on purchasing food items and gold was the only currency they could offer (Meckelburg 2016: 120):

²⁶ This later formed the basis for a historical narrative claiming that gold had no value to people at all before the Arab traders 'discovered' it, which is an exaggeration of the previous situation that could still be observed during our fieldwork in 2019.

The *sheikh* [Khojali] not only sold slaves but more importantly used unfree labour from his subjects. His regional impact is acknowledged by the fact that people coming from the Sudanese borderlands, especially as court and military slaves, were known in Addis Ababa and beyond as *Hojale*. Some Berta also referred to themselves as “Xoyalee or Hoyalee”. “We were all *Tsugel’s* children” is a statement also found among Komo descendants to describe their relation to Khojali. The Swedish gold miner William Avenstrup who visited Khojali in Addis Ababa [...] briefly lived in the court of his son Al-Mahdi Khojali who ruled on behalf of his father and contends that the *sheikh* had over “two million slaves” as a source of manpower for gold-washing and domestic activities.

This highlights a persistent link between the physical labour of gold mining and ‘lower groups’ – extending to descriptions of it as slave labour – alongside its significant role in enriching ‘higher groups’, who, not only in this case, use it to uphold their dominance over the ‘lower groups’ who are unable to amass enough gold to change their circumstances. This was far from a localised exploitative system; in fact, slavery connected the borderland to trade networks both through Sudan and through the imperial structures of Ethiopia until the second half of the 20th century. But it is important to highlight the essential role of slavery in Watawit’s rule and its lasting effects on society.

The slave trade brought Gumuz, Berta and others not only to the imperial court but also to the riverain areas Watawit originally came from, extending as far as Nubia in northern Sudan. A crucial example to understand this trade’s connection to both origin and local rule is Sheikh Khojali Al-Hassan, based in Assosa, who dominated the trade route via Kurmuk where annually 200-500 slaves were trafficked traded; their price increased fivefold on the way through the White Nile Province. Enslaved children were also bred until they reached maturity and then brought to Addis Ababa – a system active from Emperor Menelik (from 1889) to Emperor Haile Selassie (from 1930). His wife, Al-Sitt Amna, established a slave depot in Mortosoro from which she sold enslaved to Wadi Halfa and beyond, until she was arrested in 1928; their sons continued the ‘family trade’. Agents of Khojali continued raiding the Sudanese side into the 1930s, and diplomatic efforts by British-Sudanese and Ethiopian officials to resolve the issue through a conference in Kurmuk in January 1933 failed due to the former’s overestimation of their power. Khojali outmanoeuvred them and continued to find ways to trade slaves to Ja’aliyyin traders until the Italian occupation of the border region brought this to a temporary end (Ahmad 1999: 438, 444-445). Nevertheless, even when the routes via the Nile to Egypt or through Suakin to Arabia faced restrictions due to anti-slavery measures, alternative routes were established through Ethiopia and Eritrea, with Rashaida playing a significant role in transporting enslaved out and bringing weapons in (Nur 1971: 186-187).

Actually, there were neither the means nor the interest to curb the slave trade until well into the 20th century. During the first decades of the 20th century, the slave trade remained a major activity across the border, although documented incursions were limited to a few each year, mostly raids by troops belonging to Sheikh Khojali al-Hasan against Burun and Berta populations on the Sudanese side. An early climax occurred before the border demarcation agreement but subsided when border sheikhs were armed by the British administration upon the request of Funj sheikh Idris Rajab. The years 1923-26 marked the peak of cross-border slave trade, and the subsequent anti-slavery measures in both empires had little effect on the continued prevalence of slaves and gold

being the main ‘currencies’ for tributes in the region. Although records show ‘only’ slightly over 200 slaves were traded from Ethiopia to Sudan between 1912 and 1927, this trade and the system of slavery it was built upon had a lasting impact on the development of an ethnic hierarchy. In this hierarchy, Berta, Oromo, Amam, Koma, and Burun were identified as groups subject to enslavement, and the trade in humans and gold became a symbol of local rulers’ control over their land. In fact, the turbulent armed conflicts of the 1920s were most favourable to this trade: even equivalences were established when a tribute of one slave could also be paid by one ounce/ *waqiyya* of gold (Zewde 1976: 168-169; 205-213).

As in all slave systems, there were many kinds of slaves with partly vastly differing status. In northern households, they were agricultural labourers, soldiers, domestic servants, or concubines, the latter also serving as rentable travel companions whose offspring belonged to the master (Ahmad 1999: 434). Many slaves were used locally: military slaves mined gold or forced reluctant ‘subjects’ (Ahmad 1999: 438); a few of them gained significant power, such as Tur al-Guri’s commander-in-chief, who was also his head slave (Zewde 1976: 85). Children of enslaved might also socialise with their masters’ children, particularly through shared education in Qur’an schools, which led to Islamisation in Berta society to varying degrees (Triulzi 1981: 60-61).

Outside the area, racial classification grew more significant but remained far from straightforward. For both pricing and usage, appearances and racial categorisation mattered: for the main purchasers, the riverain communities of Sudan and Egypt, similarity to ‘free folk’ reduced acceptability, especially of female slaves, and there is documentation of a daughter of a Hadendowa father and a Gābārti (Ethiopian Muslim) mother who was sold for a minimum price because she resembled a free woman – and thus a social rival in a husband’s household (Zewde 1976: 211). As with areas where they promoted Arab overlordship, the British colonial administration implicitly endorsed such racial categories; this is evident, for example, in MacMichael’s argument for a different approach to ‘more or less civilised’ Watawit compared to ‘savage’ Anyuaa and Nuer (Zewde 1976: 221).

There was thus a harsh ideological contrast between Muslim and non-Muslim, master and slave, superior and inferior, which was expressed in ethnic terms but did not have a straightforward social equivalent, as it failed to account for a complex history where socio-economic stratification could mean that enslaver and enslaved came from the same group. The different fates of sections and layers in Berta society – Watawit, Mayu, Fadasi, Jabalāwiyyīn, Fakunḵun – were also often blurred when they were labelled ‘Arabs’ or Xojali, Shogali, Kujul by long-suffering groups such as Gwama, Mao, Komo, and Uduk (González-Ruibal 2014: 189-190).

At the same time, the ideological foundation of enslavement—the assertion of superior Arab- and Muslimness—was also maintained in later political discourses. Accordingly, ‘Berta’ proper were still identified as slave descendants by our informants from formerly slave-owning groups, and descendants of the in-migrant ‘Arab’ groups still claimed a right to inherit communal representation of the area from their lineages, the male line to their Arabness.

There was also minimal revision of slavery as a historical injustice, as demonstrated by the comparison of the following two statements. The first was recorded in 1972, given by the Watawit District Governor in Assosa (Triulzi 1981: 136):

It is only the younger generation of today that has not known the sweetness of slavery. [...] A slave is your property, just like money in your pocket. Here in Asosa the only property you could be proud of was your slave. In case of danger it was the slave who saved your life. You could send him anywhere, sell him at any price, or even give him away as a present to someone. This was not a secret business but a sacred one.

An 80-year old informant in Qeissan, who still experienced the ending of slave-ownership in his family, described in November 2019 their former situation to Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman in this way:

شوية شوية بقو الرقيق عندهم اسر ونحن جينا لقينا الحال في نفس الحال. الرقيق كانوا يشتغلوا في الذهب وقدر البلقو هو بيدو هو لي سيدهم ، جدونا ما كانوا يبيعوا الذهب وبخلو هو لليوم الاسود. يجمعوا الذهب كم وقية ويبمشو جدونا لي بني شقول يبيعوا لذهب ويشترو بيها 2 او 3 فروخ (رقيق). وكان الواحد بيديك بت تشتغل ليك تولع النار أو تعمل ليك حاجات البيت أو تنوم معاك واذا ولدت منك يكون المولود تابع ليك (الوضع أشبه بمجاملة اجتماعية لمن لا يملك رقيق) وهكذا يزداد الرقيق وتتوسع مساحات الزراعة وتديهم جزء من الزراعة لمعاشهم.

Step by step, the slaves got families, and we came [i.e. were born] and found the situation the same [as today]. The slaves were working gold and submitting what they found to their master. Our grandfathers didn't sell the gold but saved it for a rainy day. When they gathered some ounces, our grandfathers went to Beni Shangul, sold the gold and bought 2 or 3 chickens (slaves). And when you were given a girl, she works for you, makes fire, or does household chores for you, or sleeps with you, and if she bore a child from you, it is yours – a kind of social nicety if you didn't own a slave [yourself] – and so slaves become more and the agricultural land becomes larger and you give them part of it for their livelihood.²⁷

Rule

The Mahdiyyah, a movement with a profound social agenda, initially involved only local elites of the borderlands, who saw it, at first, as a chance to escape the oppressive taxation systems of both the Ottoman-Egyptian and Abyssinian empires. The Khalifah, however, with a far more expansionary strategy in the east, immediately began fortifying Qallabat, and a *jihadiyyah* force under Khalil al-Khuzani was stationed at Jebel Surkum. The latter was soon appointed 'ruler' over Benishangul.

²⁷ The continued asymmetric perception of formerly enslaved groups can still be observed in his reference to their former servants as *firāḥ*, 'chicken', a term commonly used in central Sudan as well. In addition, he expressed later the opinion that no 'chicken' can become sheikh, *ṭab'an*, naturally, as the sheikhs are basically there to rule over these slaves. He also mentioned the anti-slavery measures of the Italian commanders, but not the much older British measures (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019). Another interlocutor from a formerly slave-owning group added a further claim that these areas had been *maqfūlah*, closed in the religious sense, and that the Arabs 'opened' them to Islam, implicitly justifying their claimed superior status (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019).

The local sheikhdoms responded differently, with a stronger opposition from Khomosha and Benishangul proper, and a more hesitant one from Agoldi / Assosa and Fadasi. However, Khalil's militant and exploitative approach to the region provoked a much harsher reaction, as the tax on non-Muslims, *jizyah*, also affected communities that had remained largely untouched by the changes at first. When the Mahdist expansionist drive moved into Oromo territories of Lega under Jote Tullu, with whom the Watawit had longstanding trade links, the new regime jeopardised essential interests. Most support collapsed before the final defeat of Mahdist forces by Ethiopian troops under Ras Gobana, whose campaign also marked the start of a westward expansion that would bring much of Benishangul into the highland empire. The Mahdists then shifted their approach and employed divide-and-rule strategies to weaken the united resistance of the local rulers, but they remained firmly opposed by Mahmud of Khomosha and Benishangul's Abd al-Rahman. For some years, Mahdists had limited control over the region, especially after imprisoning Khojali's father and Mahmud, while Abd al-Rahman was forced to flee and waged a guerrilla war, but the Mahdist forces never succeeded in controlling the more inaccessible parts of it. Ras Makonnen, who led troops into Benishangul in 1898 to seize control, found a country ravaged by years of warfare and depopulation, with the great houses locked in bitter struggle for supremacy (Triulzi 1981: 62-70).

This acquired new meaning during the border agreement negotiations between the British colonial and Ethiopian imperial governments. Benishangul, like other southwestern regions, continued to be governed by sheikhs who sat at the centre of commerce, also dealing with goods that came from raids openly or clandestinely approved by imperial governors. In some sense, the continuation of several severely disruptive extractive systems not only prevented trade in other goods – as no purchasing power could be accumulated – but also kept interest in increasing productive activities to a minimum (Zewde 1976: 55). To a large extent, the same can be said of the borderland up to today, and current gold mining plays a significant role in this economic conundrum.

In what became southern Blue Nile State, the potential to dominate trade also played a role. The long-term significance of the semi-clandestine survey under Gwynn has been highlighted above, and it was his second proposal to retain Qeissan, Fazughli, and Keili in Sudan that shaped the final agreement. It is notable that the status of Qeissan was not settled when the agreement was drafted but was left to a joint boundary commission, the first mention of an institution that would appear and disappear throughout the 20th and into the 21st century. It should also be noted that “the mutual pledge to encourage trade was omitted in the final draft”, although the importance and prospects of trans-border trade had been emphasised not only by the negotiating teams but also by the border governors (Zewde 1976: 92, 96).

In some ways, the new border posts enhanced the strategic importance of the border region in the eyes of the central governments; especially in the study area, notably Kurmuk, after the main border post to Benishangul was relocated there in 1910 (IRRI & NHRMO 2016: 11). However, the presence of central governments was integrated into local power politics rather than the other way around, which is why the ongoing struggle of the sheikhdoms continued to play a significant role for some time.

The Ethiopian Emperor sought to stabilise the newly occupied regions in Benishangul, and the primary sheikhs were either imprisoned or forced to flee to Sudan after the border agreement. However, this only lasted a few years, and over the following decades, Khojali al-Hassan became the main power in the region as he attempted to move, like the other sheikhs, his followers from what was now Sudan into what was now Ethiopia, while maintaining cross-border activities.

Ibrahim Wad Mahmud, brother of the ruler of Khomosha district located directly on the border, continued attacks on Burun communities even after being forced to abandon the family stronghold of Jabal Jerok, now on the Sudanese side, and move to Jabal Suri, which nonetheless offered better control over the Dul-Assosa trade route. Since he defied both British and Ethiopian pressure, the latter represented by the local governor (*dejach*) Kumsa, it took the cooperation of Sheikh Hamid Hassan of Assosa with a British expedition force to break Ibrahim's power. Conflicts with the Mahmud family over the ownership of hills on the Sudanese side, including Jabal Shima, persisted after Muhammad was released in 1913, but all his claims were ultimately dismissed (Zewde 1976: 170-175).

Hamid Hassan, Khojali's agent in Assosa, had migrated with about 600 followers to Sudan in 1904 and was later betrayed by the sheikh, who aimed to strengthen his position by ingratiating himself with the Ethiopian Emperor after his release in 1907 (Zewde 1976: 175-178). His status rose with further consolidation of power in Oromo territory on the eastern side and successful expansion into Beni-Shangul after Tur al-Guri's death in 1910. The latter event led to a split along ethnic lines, as Watawit followed his brother and Berta his son. But it was Khojali's authority over Beni-Shangul that was officially recognised in 1914 by Iyasu, then Emperor of Ethiopia (Zewde 1976: 179-180). The extradition of Muhammad Tur al-Guri and his followers from Sudan, where they had sought refuge after an armed confrontation at Mandi, was refused by the British colonial government. This was primarily because the prevailing interpretation of Khojali's rise to power was that it represented a German conspiracy during the onset of World War I, fueled by Iyasu's evident sympathies for the German-Turkish alliance (Zewde 1976: 181-184).

Khojali's rule was also far from uncontested even among Watawit outside Assosa with a greater willingness to accept Sawan Amhara's authority, except for Sheikh Nazir Ali of Hillet Beshir. A slight uncertainty about his future in Ras Tafari's Ethiopia after 1916 was soon resolved, but the main focus of local power politics remained firmly rooted in the borderland itself. The main arbitrator of tensions between the sheikhdoms of Khomosha, Assosa, and Beni-Shangul over Hillet Beshir was the British mamur of Kurmuk, not least because the clashes were resulting in more and more refugees crossing to the Sudanese side, particularly into Belwara (Zewde 1976: 184-187). The long-standing struggle for control over this vital border region was ultimately resolved in favour of Khojali, with Muhammad Wad Mahmud's capture in 1922, and Muhammad Tur al-Guri's Bela Shangul was obtained even more effortlessly by 1923. Much of the bilateral negotiation with the British colonial government took place behind the backs of refugees, whose forceful 'repatriation' was always denied but tribute was extracted for the sake of Khojali, apart from allowing the sheikh to artificially make them extraditable criminals by fabricating unpaid debts (Zewde 1976: 188-196).

Continued raids and conflicts, including among Khojali's sons, in the early 1930s led to the Kurmuk conference at the beginning of 1933 under the governor of Funj Province, C. H. Thompson, with the participation of Sheikh Khojali and local Ethiopian officials. The British assumption that raiders, subjects of the Ethiopian Empire, could be tried by them was early on refuted, while both the Sudanese government and the Foreign Office initially responded with a categorical rejection of Ethiopian and Khojali's counter-claims and demands for shared trials. The failure of the conference was yet another diplomatic victory for the old sheikh, but also a further step towards British 'Forward Policy' (Zewde 1976: 213-218). This policy considered more forceful responses to cross-border incursions, including air strikes on foreign territory. Ultimately, the expected diplomatic repercussions of such a course outweighed colonial arrogance, and a final statement to the Ethiopian government was to reaffirm its role in borderland control on its side but warned that action might be taken if such control was not effectively maintained (Zewde 1976: 218-225).

Only the Italian invasion of 1936 created new opportunities for Khojali's political enemies to gain ground against him, although he initially allied with the invaders. When Haile Selassie returned, Khojali handed over to him in the hope of gaining a better position after an expected 'liberation'. His palace was burnt down by the Italians before they built their own fort nearby (Zewde 1976: 197; González-Ruibal 2010: 564, 568). The hoped-for return to the status quo after the war also did not occur: in abolishing the system of sheikhdoms, Haile Selassie appointed an independent administrator, a governor for Assosa unconnected to any of the Berta groups (Gebremichael 2011: 195).

After the Derg period, which brought more wars and several demographic shifts, it was the times of ongoing civil wars and their spillover into the borderland that revived old power politics, especially with the rise and fall of the Benishangul People's Liberation Movement (BPLM).

The initial resistance of Berta and some Gumuz against Derg rule in the region's towns was swiftly suppressed, with the defeated fleeing to Khartoum, where they gained support to establish the Benishangul People's Liberation Movement (BPLM). Their approach to the OLF was met with demands to declare themselves 'black Oromo' and soon resulted in hostility. The TPLF responded more favourably in 1988 but did not permit the movement to join the EPRDF. In a turn of misread local dynamics, the Eritrean People's Liberation Front invaded Benishangul and handed it over to the OLF, perceived as a group friendly to the local population. But before the OLF was compelled to retreat after only two months, it destroyed Assosa's hospital and electricity generator, plundered the bank with cooperatives' deposits, and massacred 300 mostly Amhara men, women, and children outside the town, apparently in retaliation for similar violence by a Derg militia. In 1991, the EPRDF committed the same mistake, and the BPLM, which opposed Oromo dominance, was unable to prevent OLF atrocities and discriminatory policies: Amhara and political opponents were persecuted, Oromo language was enforced in schools, and the declaration that the region's population was black Oromo was meant to prepare for an independent Oromia, with Benishangul as one of its provinces. Only the violent intervention of EPRDF's army in 1992 removed the OLF from the area and established the BPLM as the main political force (Young 1999: 327-328).

However, since its inception, the BPLM has had to contend not only with competition from other ethnically based parties but also with internal divisions. One section fully endorsed the efforts by the National Islamic Front in Sudan to radicalise the Muslim presence in the borderland through military support and militaristic fundamentalist messages spread via radio, mosques, and Qur'anic schools in Benishangul, as part of its declaration of the Blue Nile province as a model for the civilisation project. As the northern origin and historic trade links offered an entry point, political recruitment by the NCP-led government tended to focus on their elites who appeared committed to maintaining the status quo, especially in former SPLM/A strongholds like Kurmuk (Young 1999: 333; ICG 2013: 5). This part of the movement was especially derived from the Watawit families, where the Khojali family still claimed a superior position, but ultimately inherited not only the rivalry between the families but also its asymmetric power relations that prevented the development of a unified structure and leadership (Gebremichael 2011: 233-234).²⁸

The internal divisions also meant that BPLM's initial dominance in the coalition party Benishangul North West Ethiopia People's Democratic Unity Party governing the new Benishangul-Gumuz state, formed in 1993, remained fragile. The 1990s saw several short-lived alliances involving BPLM, such as the Ethiopian Democratic Patriotic United Front (EDPUF) and the Ethiopian Unity Front (EUF), which "received Sudanese support and used the BPLM to assist its cross-border activities" (Young 2007: 27). A demand for self-determination by the elitist faction even preceded military escalation through attacks on government structures and the 'non-native' population.

Furthermore, the backlash from the 1995 assassination attempt also affected this region. When the EPRDF carried out a major purge of Sudanese individuals and organisations from the country, the regional government of Benishangul-Gumuz also became a target. Elements of both the regional and national governments accused of involvement with the Sudanese government were dismissed, and many leaders were imprisoned. The post-1995 hostility towards Sudan was also reflected in renewed support for SPLM/A presence on Ethiopian soil, as well as direct military assistance and training (Young 1999: 333; Markakis 2011: 348; Tadesse 2015: 338).

In June 1996, a conference was held under the leadership of the Deputy Prime Minister and decided to indicate the exclusionary tendencies in BPLM by renaming it Ethiopian Berta Democratic Organisation (EBDO). In 1998, the multi-ethnic Benishangul-Gumuz People's Democratic Organisation was established instead, as an EPRDF-affiliated party and stayed in power until the 2010s (Gebremichael 2011: 234-235; Young 1999: 334-335). The start of the Ethiopian-Eritrean war and subsequent reconciliation with the Sudanese government also led to an amnesty for former BPLM fighters, many of whom had fled to Sudan, and they returned to their home areas, mainly the *weredas* of Menge and Sherkole. This was not the end of tensions, however, and some kebeles in Menge pushed—partly

²⁸ Atom Mustafa, a descendant of *dejach* Mustafa of Menge, for instance, had only a short term as regional President due to animosity with the Khojali family in Assosa (Adegehe 2009: 161).

violently—in the 2000s for greater autonomy by establishing a separate *wereda* for themselves. (Gebremichael 2011: 257-260; González-Ruibal 2014: 194-195).

For Benishangul-Gumuz state as a whole, the subsequent period, particularly after the signing of the CPA in Sudan, brought some additional stability. Nevertheless, the situation remained unstable, and a 2005 agreement between BPLM and EPRDF collapsed after just one year, with the former receiving more overt support from Eritrea and more covert support from Sudan. While Berta were members of the regional state government, this ongoing challenge by the former BPLM, which escalated in 2008, for instance, through the killing of bus travellers near Ethiopian Kurmuk, also led to suspicions against them, and “[t]he Vice President of the regional state was suspected of being connected to the BPLM and was caught leaving for Sudan” (Gebremichael 2011: 293; also Young 2007: 36; Gebremichael 2011: 235).

Continuing military support for a revived BPLM became evident in 2012 and 2013, when they participated in anti-SPLM/A-North attacks in Sudan’s reignited civil war, as well as assaults on cross-border gold-mining sites and refugees (ICG 2013: 23, 40-41). SPLM/A-North officers reportedly complained that “it is difficult to distinguish an Ethiopian Berta rebel from a Sudanese Berta” (ICG 2013: 23), a confusion caused by a bilateral approach to the complex relationship between ethnicity and political allegiance that was also evident in the considerable number of Berta who joined SPLM/A-North during the 2011 war, alongside Ingessana, Uduk, and Jumjum (ICG 2013: 21).²⁹

It is not the aim here to delve further into the intricacies of ethno-politics in the early 2000s. However, it is important to note how claims of political dominance have continued to be justified based on historical precedents: the formerly ruling families invoked their Sudanese connections – to the National Islamic Front then as they did with the Funj sultanate in the past – but also highlighted their role in anti-Derg militarism, and old categories of superiority – whether religious or racial – have not disappeared either, and they significantly divide what is designated as one ethnic group in government and other statistics (Markakis 2011: 348-350; Gebremichael 2011: 258-259). The fact that a long period of stability was under a Gumuz president, Ato Yaregal Aysheshim (1995-2008), and that the rules of ethnic federalism brought significant sections of other smaller groups into parliament, such as the Shinasha, has often been criticised by Berta elites as ‘distortion’. However, the Berta president appointed in 2008, Ahmed Naser, was not deeply connected to the old elites in Assosa, either, having been born in Metehara in Afar (Gebremichael 2011: 239-241; see in more detail in Adegehe 2009: 162-167).

These problems of representation are not only related to “the essentially primordialist definition of ethnicity” (Adegehe 2009: 104) within a single national state, as is often

²⁹ In fact, the Popular Defence Forces coordinator for Blue Nile State was a Berta from Qeissan, Atif Yousif al-Bashir, and the Kobaji militia, active in southern Blue Nile at least until 2016, was formed in 2010 by a Jabalāwīyyīn ex-SPLA officer, Zaidan Yassin, who was – like many others who joined – in direct conflict with Malik Agar. The primary reason for its continuation, however, appears to have shifted towards combating pastoralist militias, particularly since the split of SPLM/A-North that put the much less contentious Joseph Taka in charge of these areas (Hassan 2020: 29-30).

discussed, and the concepts of superiority and inferiority are also not confined to national boundaries. Ultimately, the situation of borderland peoples has not found a satisfying solution, as they continue to be classified according to dichotomies: Sudan or Ethiopia, Muslim or non-Muslim, indigenous or non-indigenous, black or red. Concomitantly, the identification of someone as a 'foreigner'—a boundary transgressor—is a socially active process that only partly adheres to official border lines.

Another aspect, however, is the degree of economic control over resources that is ultimately also negotiated through such identification. Assosa, once a centre of Watawit economic and political power, has evolved into a supraregional urban hub where 'non-indigenous' groups hold significant influence. This situation was emphasised by former state president Ato Yaregal as a contradiction between political empowerment and economic marginalisation. In the early years of the state, this imbalance was compounded by the lack of qualified civil service staff from 'indigenous' people, despite the existence of affirmative action (Gebremichael 2011: 204-205). At the same time, control over local natural resources remained the strongest hold that old elites retained, including bamboo (Gebremichael 2011: 259-260) in Assosa Zone, and, still, gold.

War and refuge

The borderland has seen several major shifts in its population's fate, with many killed, displaced, or resettled. This chapter discusses people who arrived temporarily—some for pasture, most for refuge, some staying shorter than intended and being expelled, while others stayed longer and inadvertently became part of the resident population.

An example of the former is Mbororo pastoralists, a collective term for different groups often classified under the broad label 'Fellata' for migrants from West Africa, most of whom are Hausa or Fulbe. Other Fellata groups had attained significant positions, such as Takarir, who in the 19th century controlled Qallabāt / Metemma, a vital crossing point for the Sennar-Gondar trade route, and they extended a level of Islamic influence among the aristocracy in Ethiopia, particularly among Galla (Abir 1967: 456; Nur 1971: 160; Holt & Daly 2000: 10; Seri-Hersch 2010: 9-10, 20). Another, even more profound impact was caused by the in-migration of Rufa'a groups, some of whose leaders served as – at least nominal – agents of the Funj sultanate, such as Bashir El Gul in Dunkur and Abd al-Rahman 'Tor El Guri' in Benishangul proper (Nur 1971: 37).

Much of the 20th century brought loss of power and impoverishment to some of these pastoralist groups; others arriving during that period found themselves in various unstable situations. Pastoral Fulbe, or Mbororo, primarily came as a consequence of the British occupation of northern Nigeria in 1903 and sought refuge in other parts of the British Empire, following a well-established pilgrimage route to Mecca that traverses the northern African region. Amidst all uncertainties, some seasonal migration routes became stable, including one connecting eastern Sudan with Benishangul-Gumuz and the Upper Nile State. The complementary relationship with agricultural communities, especially through providing livestock and dairy products, remained relatively unimpeded until the 1990s, when conflicts radicalised by the civil war nurtured forms of militancy usually reserved for the groups' aristocracy.

The war not only intensified conflicts with competing pastoralist groups, such as those from Dinka settlements, but also led to more unfavourable water access terms imposed by resident communities in southern Blue Nile. Alternative migration routes towards Assosa were also short-lived, as Kurmuk and nearby areas fell under SPLA control, and Ethiopian support for the movement meant it faced few problems attacking the Fellata herds. The notorious appetite of the freely roaming large cattle of Mbororo contributed to this hostile response, which was normally offset by their high productivity. The expanding infrastructure around new oil regions in Upper Nile State ultimately moved these migratory routes further from the borderland. However, these and similar experiences made Fellata groups much more willing to be recruited and armed by the Government of Sudan and its executive forces, leading to the formation of several militias (Feyissa and Schlee 2009: 157-160, 165-166, 174; ICG 2013: 21).

However, it should be noted that the groups the rest of the population summarised as ‘Fellata’ included quite diverse communities, some quite sedentary, others more nomadic, with varying levels of pastoralism and, in the case of Hausa, a different language. Among these, and reflecting their differing relationships with other groups, there were also significant conflicts (Osman & Schlee 2014).

This is just one example from a long history of populations seeking refuge in or out of the borderland, which made it “[a] traditional hiding place for political refugees from both sides of the border” (Triulzi 1975: 55). In fact, as another example illustrates, hosting and integrating refugees has been a formative element of ethno-genesis in the region, especially among smaller groups sharing the experience of being hunted and displaced: even low-numbered, linguistically related groups can be divided into several subdivisions that reflect a fragmented history, such as Komo, Koma, Kwama, and Gwama. These are not merely phonetic variations of the names of social groups living between Benishangul, southern Blue Nile, and Upper Nile State. They were primary targets of enslavement raids by Watawit troops, for example under Sheikh Khojali, leading to their dispersal (Ahmad 1999: 437; Gebremichael 2011: 187; González-Ruibal & Fernández Martínez 2007: 11). Instead of becoming isolated, however, later refugees from slave raids and war were integrated; Koma in southern Blue Nile, for example, were joined by Ganza who had been displaced in this way, forming a single community speaking both languages, led in the early 2010s by a Koma chief with a Ganza mother (ICG 2013: 4; see also Theis 1995).

During Sudan’s second and third civil wars, which are the main focus of this chapter, this type of population movement reached new heights, and by 2016, as many as a fifth of Blue Nile State’s population had sought refuge abroad, in both South Sudan and Ethiopia (Medani 2010: 119; IRRI & NHRMO 2016: 26). This was, for many, not just a series of displacement incidents, but also compounded by displacement within the state, as part of residential dislocation that drove social groups towards fragmentation, survival crises, and dependency, often on those originally responsible for the displacement.

Refuge

The ‘exchange’ of refugees between Ethiopia and Sudan varied depending on the outbreak of conflicts. In the late 1960s, 5,000 people fled the civil war in South Sudan, compared to 300 from Ethiopia (Nur 1971: 163), but the number of Ethiopian refugees increased to about 27,000 during the turbulence of the 1970s, while Sudan’s second civil war drove several tens of thousands into neighbouring country in the 1980s. During the third civil war, Sudanese refugees in Benishangul-Gumuz numbered approximately 50,000 to 90,000, and new transit centres were established, such as the Adamazin Transit Center, managed and supplied by the Administration for Refugee and Returnee Affairs (ARRA), UNHCR, and the International Rescue Committee (EUTF 2016: 21; Husain et al. 2015: 2). Beginning 2020, so-called Persons of Concern registered at UNHCR’s Assosa office numbered 62,669, with two thirds of them ‘Sudanese’ (UNHCR Ethiopia 2020).

The recurrent waves of refugees meant that established refugee camps became social spaces of their own, with history and economic standing. Sherkole, one of four refugee camps in the region, was established in 1997 to accommodate refugees, many of whom had already been in the state for nearly a decade in open areas near residents. It was closer to the border with Sudan (40 km west) than to Assosa (47 km east), but it was connected by asphalt roads in both directions. The main crossing points – Yabus, Kurmuk, Almahal, Bamza – were also important centres of commercial exchange or, in the case of the latter, a major focal point as the location of the GERD. In the 2010s, it was much more established than other camps in terms of building stock, with houses similar to the resident population in durability and style (Birhanu 2016: 3-5, 48; see assessment of the camps Tsore and Bambasi in Vaughan et al. 2019). In many ways, its demographic structure also reflected its position, with 42.4% of the nearly 11,500 population as of December 2015 coming from Blue Nile State. About a third of them identified as ‘Funj’, probably as a distinguishing marker from the Maban (27%), Uduk (10%), and Nilotic groups in the camp. This represented a positive collective self-description, similar to how the formerly pejorative exonym ‘Hama’ was adopted by the elites of former mountain dwellers under the sultanate’s rule (Birhanu 2016: 51-52).

In a two-year plan developed for 2019-2020, the organisations of the Sudanese Refugee Response observed that most camp populations believed returning home would be desirable in the near future and that, aside from conflicts, the lack of food, employment, and education was inhibiting them. While this may result from a significant shift following the end of widespread hostilities during the previous period, there were several levels at which the terminology used – refugees, host community, area of return – failed to reflect the actual behaviour of the borderland population. In addition, the exclusionary policies in Ethiopia – and Sudan – concerning refugee-host community relations (Birhanu 2016: 54) were doing the same: in both cases, it was neither recognised that ‘home’ could extend beyond international borders nor that long-term refuge was no longer simply refuge. They also implicitly treated the presence of refugees as a temporary challenge – which was certainly a significant aspect in terms of the demographics of resource-scarce areas – but overlooked the fundamental infrastructural and economic effects that such presence can have: refugee camps served as places of employment through the Administration for Refugee and Returnee Affairs (ARRA), which “create[d] jobs for hundreds of Ethiopians” (Gebresilassie 2007: 33; see also Birhanu 2016: 64-65).

Furthermore, life in the area not only generated a different economic outlook but also fostered distinct economic practices. This concerned not only the economy of rations and the development of superior food-processing techniques, especially grinding mills. It was also the experience of wage labour and the subsequent availability of consumption goods to be bought with earned money: “I can go to the Bartas, work for them and earn some money”, as one Maban informant said in 2007 in Sherkole (Gebresilassie 2007: 43). This may also imply that ‘return’ is perceived differently by various people, and the common notion of ‘voluntary’ repatriation often obscures power relations in favour of social imaginaries promoted by those who are in a dominant position, whether ‘community leaders’ or so-called ‘heads of household’.

What is even more relevant here is that social practices already bypassed administrative barriers imposed by central authorities. Local officials relaxed policies by opening educational and health facilities to refugees, which put little strain on public resources, since 25% of organisations' spending on refugees also benefited local communities. Nevertheless, aside from the Ethiopian and Sudanese branches of the Red Cross Society, no cross-border humanitarian activities were taking place, and the former focused on family reunions rather than cross-border lives (EUTF 2016: 29).

As highlighted during health crises such as cholera in 2019 and COVID-19 in 2020, there was not only constant border-crossing between SPLM-N controlled areas in southern Blue Nile, Ethiopia, and South Sudan. The refugee camps served as key stations along the indirect route taken, whether in Assosa Zone or in Maban County. This practice complicated statistics—particularly the categories 'new arrivals' and 'returnees'—but also increased contact points. Regular commuters such as students blurred both notions even further: in February and March 2020, 1560 'returned' to the four payams under SPLM-N control (Chali, Komo Ganza, Wadaka, Yabus), most of them students whose schools in Ethiopia had been closed due to COVID-19, but also farmers came to cultivate, with only some staying (SKBNCU humanitarian update September 2019, January-March 2020).

Furthermore, 'return' is not just a matter of readiness and logistics. Like everybody, 'returnees' are political actors and are politically acted upon. The post-2005 repatriation process, for instance from Sherkole, was also linked to the census planned for the end of 2007, and the SPLM/A's access to or even influence in the camp had already created a political extension into Ethiopian territory, used to pressure or even threaten the population to 'return'. The lack of awareness and/or readiness to discuss these dynamics among local UNHCR staff also revealed a disconnect between different levels of political practice, even within an encampment setting (Gebresilassie 2007: 28-31).

On the side of the Sudanese government, return was also treated as a political issue. When a transit centre 25 km from the border was closed by Ethiopian authorities in July 2012, about 2,800 former residents refused to move to a camp further inside Ethiopian territory and instead settled in inaccessible areas along the border. Sudanese officials referred to them as 'returnees'. Authorities of both countries shared an interest in keeping these populations away from SPLM-N influence, and the official plan of the Sudanese government was to establish new villages rather than allow them to return to their original locations (ICG 2013: 26). This was merely the beginning of a far more violent stance from both administrations in the coming years, driven by the military escalation announced by then-President Omar al-Bashir during the opening ceremony for the heightened Roseiris Dam in 2013, a fitting display of the close link between militaristic politics and economic interests in unrestricted access to the region's resources (James 2014: 204).

The ARRA collaborated with Sudanese security agents and militias based in Benishangul to control cross-border movement, resulting in young men being arrested or killed and women raped when crossing in search of work, the men particularly in gold mines. Traders were also barred from entering SPLM-N areas, a community leader from Keili was detained while on his way to Assosa market, and suspicion of political activities frequently led to arrest, whether by Ethiopian or Sudanese security operating within the camps and

markets (De Alessi 2015: 48-49). In other words, 'illegal' border crossings were only situationally illegal, dictated by the political priorities of the powerful, rather than a single territorial principle.

It is here, as in other cases of political refuge, that there were reasons for defining 'origin' and belonging in a particular way, since their political implications are what made seeking refuge necessary in the first place. Several aspects thus complicate a process that aims to establish populations 'here or there' with an exclusive 'or' between them. For one, it risks describing a 'here' that is no longer just a place of refuge but, after nearly three decades of refuge, a sort of home. Second, it may well be that 'there' is not at all what is really there, and the intricate or brutal changes caused by decades of war and ongoing politics of settlement need to be taken into account. Thirdly, there is an unavoidable contradiction between a process defined by the limited understanding of bi- or trilateral relations and the lives of people that are led across borders. 'Refuge' and 'return' are not absolutes but temporary states of being somewhere, as well as the mode of mobility that brought someone there.

Recruitment

In the Sudanese civil wars, geographical location could be seen as influencing political decision-making in the conflict, as Ingessana, Uduk, and Jumjum tended to support SPLM/A, while isolated groups such as the population of Jabal Surkum attempted to align with the government. Additionally, newcomers hoped to secure a better position relative to the older communities and their claims on land and water resources. However, it is easy to overestimate the importance of following a state or larger political movement rather than focusing on the right strategy to maintain the highest possible level of independence from any external force that might claim dominance or to seek protection from potential abuse.

Looking, for example, at the different positions Maban adopted during and between the civil wars, several particular motivations can be discerned. The residential areas of Maban in the early 20th century were located between southern Blue Nile, southern Benishangul, and northern Upper Nile, geographically situated along the rivers Ahmar, Tombak, and Yabus. They have long faced raids and slave hunts from all directions, including Watawit from Benishangul, Nuer from the south, Baggara from the north along the White Nile, and Funj from Gule to the northeast (Wedderburn-Maxwell 1936: 179).

Among the linguistic groups they belonged to, the Northern Luo—which also includes the Anuak, Jumum, Raqāriq, and Jur—only the Shilluk developed an aristocratic political structure, while the others were opposed to authority beyond the level of their settlement, exhibiting a “reticence towards authority” (Delmet 2013: 246) that was certainly not softened by a history of enslavement. It was a significant consolidation when Maban were grouped in an eponymous county in Upper Nile, which was, nonetheless, only part of changing colonial redefinitions of administrative boundaries, including all southern Blue Nile areas into Upper Nile in 1938 as part of closed district policies, and reverting some areas back in 1953. Another administrative boundary delineation in 2011 created its own issues, as pastoralists from northern Sudan stayed longer than usual in

Maban's agricultural areas due to fears of losing grazing land. At the same time, refugees with livestock increased in these regions, as they had no alternatives (Craze 2013: 159-162).

When considering the recruitment of Maban into GoS-organized Popular Defence Forces, including now South Sudanese ex-SAF soldiers, it would thus be misleading to view this as an adoption of NCP's central political agenda, although many of their leaders, such as Abdallah Monti and Kamal Loma of the Maban Heroes, had strong NCP links. When they or the nominally GoSS-allied Maban Defence Forces under Johnson Khalifa and Langan Baggari attacked SPLM-N troops or Sudanese refugees from Blue Nile, they ultimately targeted perceived threats to their autonomy, whether hoping to secure a better position under NCP rule and as part of Sudan or attacking populations seen as encroaching, such as Dinka, Fellata, Ingessana, or Uduk (ICG 2013: 22, 30-31).

Instead of opposing the most fervent supporters of past slavery systems, they ultimately opted to form an alliance with them, because (James 2007: x):

communities on such a frontier are not merely changed in situ but how their people have been and still are co-co-opted into the body of the predatory state itself. Some are drawn in, and others are left out; but this is not a final or permanent severing of ties or cultural 'belonging'. Values and practices change both among those who are absorbed into the political and civil society of the core state, and among those who are excluded, or who flee the state.

Relations

Seeking refuge and recruitment are two key dynamics in shaping the multiple layers of fragmented and newly forming relations between social groups and individuals affected by war. This can be clearly demonstrated with one final example, Uduk or Kwanim pa, and what was called their 'Long Road', a stretching of people's socio-spatial trajectory, mostly involuntary in nature, to where they are "newly drawn together" (James 2007: x).

Civil war shattered communal bonds not just because people who knew and trusted each other, including relatives, chose different sides for various reasons, creating new boundaries in the borderland, whether militarily or, after peace agreements, politically. This began even before actual fighting occurred in areas where Uduk lived, as war dynamics closed in: the SPLA attacks in Maban County in 1984, the forest roads used by their soldiers to reach training camps in Ethiopia since 1985, and the armament of Rufa'a pastoralists as counter-insurgency militias in 1986. There were many individual reactions to this encroachment on the familiar, and right and wrong were unclear, whereas a long war was to harden the categories (James 2007: 65-68).

The long journey started with the initial splits in direction – some fleeing north, others fleeing south – whereupon new communities of suffering took shape. The northern 'route' led to Khartoum, while the southern one first guided many to Nasir, then to refuges across borders, including Assosa, Itang, Nor Deng, back to Nasir, and to Maiwait and Kigille. For some, the journey continued back to Chali. A new wave of fighting then caused another movement into Ethiopia, now post-Derg, passing through Kigille, Itang, Gambella, Karmi,

and finally reaching some residential stability at the Bonga Refugee Scheme in 1993. Repatriation began in 2005 with the CPA, but it lasted only as long as the fragile peace held. By 2011, Uduk were refugees once more, now considered 'experienced' refugees compared to others who were fresh to this situation (IRRI & NHRMO 2016: 28-29).

Assosa then played its own role in the evolving war, with SPLA recruiting intensively among refugees – which would remain in memory and haunt the latter in the following conflict – and the future president, Salva Kiir, empowered by a victory in Kurmuk, formed the New Funj Forces at Green Book near Tsore camp, a place that had also hosted Sadiq al-Mahdi in the 1970s. Nobody could escape the spreading war, and being situated between Kurmuk and Assosa also meant being at the front lines when Sudanese government forces – supported by anti-Mengistu movements, especially the OLF – advanced towards Kurmuk, Qeissan, and Assosa beginning in 1990 (James 2007: 118-119). These and subsequent experiences made Maban areas a more attractive choice when another war starting in 2011 caused more than half of those affected by fighting to leave again (James 2014: 203-204).

Even when the fighting between SPLA-N and SAF forces eased somewhat towards the end of 2016, another division within the SPLM-N conflict occurred, resulting in the formation of two separate wings. The complex ethno-politics within the Blue Nile forces, coupled with an apparent disconnect between commander Malik Agar and several of the local troops, fueled sectarian tendencies and radicalised tensions. These tensions resulted in the 2017 split, which was significantly more violent in Blue Nile than in South Kordofan.³⁰ The split left Uduk as majority in terms of soldiers and rank in Blue Nile but also secondary to the overall faction's political structure (ICG 2013: 33-34; Spilling_Over-Conflict_Dynamics: 34-41).

One central contention, in fact, was the choice between an approach to negotiations to achieve the fastest, most accommodating deal to end the war or to achieve the highest level of future autonomy, by self-determination or integration in South Sudan. While self-determination became a central element of the SPLM-N wing under Abd al-Aziz Al-Hilu separated from the wing dominated by Malik Agar and Yasir Arman, the situation in Blue Nile was less straight-forward. Uduk Joseph Tuka, who had been Chief of Staff in Blue Nile and led the Blue Nile section of the Al-Hilu, had long supported an exit strategy, and he and others were aware that a stipulation of the 1972 Addis Ababa agreement to decide over the fate of Chali al-Fil by referendum, similar to Abyei, had never happened, just as a meaningful popular consultation promised in the 2005 CPA. Still, the demand of an independent political future was less clear-cut, and post-2013, an integration into South Sudan was less of a welcome fate. Tensions between the wings subsided as well, with close to no clashes after February 2018, but refugee settlements and negotiations with the transitional government, after August 2019, remained separate and very different in their demands and goals (Hassan 2020: 41).

³⁰ There were also more specific conflicts involved, such as the death of Brig. Gen. Ali Bender in May 2017, who had joined SPLA only after 2005 and was killed during internal fighting at SPLA's Blue Nile headquarters; his community attributed guilt to Ingessana Lt. Gen. al-Umda. The Brig. Gen. belonged to the Nilotic Burun (Hassan 2020: 58).

These political lines, again, tell only part of the story. The experience of being refugee was shared among many, including a new generation growing up with the rhythms, approaches and skills that come with the specific forms of social organisation that refugees face. For those who had not enough time to rebuild their economic lives – or, for the younger generation, to have one in the first place – experienced aid as basic supply, apart from the precarious income from activities around camps or across borders, as outlined above. Still, Uduk who were ‘experts’ in being refugees also had easier dealing with its structures, taking positions in communal management and teaching (James 2014: 195; IRRI & NHRMO 2016: 29).

Even more, the long periods of settlement – and the initial trauma that brought them there – led kwanim pa recreate something resembling what was lost: “Twenty years after the destruction of their villages, a visitor would find much familiar in the initial appearance of everyday life among the _kwanim pa in the refugee settlements in Ethiopia; neat, clean huts framed by a few well-kept stands of maize; the language apparently flourishing, the music, song, and social world generally very recognizable. A photo of a family outside their home here might suggest that little was wrong” (James 2007: xiv). In fact, unlikely responses to their history, the surrounding ethno-politics and administrative categories can still be found, and “the basic motif of being able to convert strangers into kin remains a powerful one” (James 2009: 246).

But another historical motif is also pertinent here, namely the political responsibility of protection. In its prime, the court at Sennar served as a refuge, and in the borderlands, the “reputation and honour of politically powerful shaikhs [...] depend[ed] upon their ability to protect those who live within their orbit” (James 2009: 237). Such ‘political spaces’ were adaptable – and shaikhs’ accountability to their subjects clearly had its limits – but remained quite tangible for a long time. State territories with a cartographic definition of political space introduced a dynamic where ‘irrelevant’ but claimed fringes could suddenly become the theatre of existential struggle: the same border town, Kurmuk, which in 1965 was a heterogeneous but slow settlement that professionals stationed there considered “as a kind of exile” (James 2007: 52), evolved into a symbolic – and strategic – entry point into these realms, whether between states or between armed forces. This status, akin to colonial and imperial concerns, concentrated on stabilising central powers but primarily impacted the regions that these powers designated as ‘peripheries’.

Social definition of nationality

Fluidity as social discourse

Different waves of in-migration and population intermingling are often reflected in collective names that indicate temporal and spatial, rather than ethnic proximity: older strata of groups, summarised as Berta, distinguished themselves from in-migrants in Beni Shangul from riverine areas in later Sudan by adjusting names, such as Mayu and Watawit, which derived from the latter's euphemistic self-descriptions as Banī Ummāyah and Ashrāf. However, the new residents brought not just a new demographic element to the area, but also made their presence and trade in gold closely linked with slavery and further stratification of the local society.

Considering this aspect of Benishangul's history, the description of borderlands solely in legalistic terms of supposedly exclusive nation-states obscures the history of those who live there. What makes this significant is the close connection this 'hiding' has with practices of exploitation (Triulzi 1981: 181-182):

It is then that the Bertha, who once were *mabī adaru*, the "original people" of the region, become necessarily the undistinguishable ones (*hamaj*), people living on hills (*jabalawīn*), slave chattel (*'abīd*) and the despised inferior groups (*shānqellā*) to their Sudanese Arab or Ethiopian overlords. They become a "hidden people", disappearing from the visible history of the region whose very name changes and whose traditions emphasize the deeds and exploits of their ruling classes: the Funj, the *waṭāwīt* or the Amhara conquerors. This brings up a general point of major difficulty for the historian who attemptsp [sic] to record the history of peripheral border peoples: the existence of two layers of history, one hidden and the other visible, which are often confused in traditions and in the very minds of the informants.

However, such hierarchies are not as transparent as the statement implies. This is not just because Berta and similar groups were enslaving others themselves, for example Maban and Uduk. Group names are also used in a somewhat inconsistent and partly contradictory manner: three interviewees in Qeissan, considering themselves as people of Qeissan and descendants of Arab in-migrants, had three significantly different ways of classifying Berta. One said that there are not many Berta in Qeissan but rather Funj called after the mountains they inhabit.³¹ Another classified Funj as main group among Berta, and listed Rubatāb, Bederiyya and Waṭāwīt as main inhabitants of Qeissan.³² A third counted Jabalāwiyyīn, Fa-Agaro / Aghrāwiyyīn, Fa-Denden and Fa-Nazqar as Berta, and gold workers from Agaro and Khor Dahab as temporary visitors who outnumbered the Qeissan proper in the town.³³

This is even more astonishing, as at least three aspects exist that could consolidate these notions: first, a common language, Berta; second, the ethno-administrative hierarchy established in Blue Nile State, which places all other groups under a Funj Nazirate and

³¹ Interview of Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019.

³² Interview with resident in Qeissan, 26 November 2019.

³³ Interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019.

Qeissan under the Nāzir of Fazughli; third, the existence of ‘Berta’ as a consolidated ethnic category in Ethiopian statistics for Beni Shangul-Gumuz state.

A similar debate surrounds the name ‘Beni Shangul’, whose name we have shown to overlap with ‘Berta’, but who were claimed by an informant focused on Arab identity to have ‘preserved their Arabness’ since they arrived as Ja‘aliyyīn, Bederiyya, Ḥuḍur, Mahas, Danagla, Rubaṭāb, Majāzāb, Kitiyāb, and other groups over 200 years ago.³⁴ The role Islam plays in this claim of Arabness shows the successful blending of both through the Arabo-Islamic ideology pursued by generations of elites in Sudan’s central governments: not even the groups listed here are of an unquestioned ‘Arab’ provenance.

Two examples are provided here to illustrate such social discourses in greater detail. **Qeissan** originates from the formation by traders from northern regions settling permanently in the borderlands near Beni Shangul in the mid-19th century.³⁵ Gold, as a commodity, was central to this process; the expanding networks of jallāba across the entire region targeted these famously mineral-rich areas for exchanging goods but soon became involved in ways that still form a recognisable pattern today.³⁶

For the current descendants of these traders, their *jīdūd*, literally grandfathers, not only became involved but also altered the nature of the exchange around this resource: according to them, gold was simply gathered for household use before and only became a trade commodity with their arrival, the establishment of exchange networks around Qeissan, and eventual intermixing with the older inhabitants.³⁷ Within the hierarchy of communal representation in Blue Nile State, another interlocutor described their ongoing leadership as part of the present Funj and Fazughli nazirates, themselves claimed to be derived from a lineage dating back to the Funj kingdom. The 2007 law change that declared election as the principle for achieving communal representation was then viewed as conflicting with this ‘traditional’ principle of inherited positions, and therefore as ineffective in these areas. However, the same statement acknowledged that the Ingaz regime installed its own *‘umda* from outside the previous line, whose son then inherited the position.³⁸

For those in a historical line with in-migrant traders, the function to ‘open’ areas for trade, Islam, and larger networks or regimes they acted as agents for often remained a crucial element to claim superiority, recognising that political power came with partial

³⁴ Interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019.

³⁵ However, there was an ongoing process of in-migration that still persisted long afterwards; one informant traced his family to 1920s in-migrants from Mahas in Kerma (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019).

³⁶ One of these networks was expanded through followers of the Khatmiyya Sufi order, who transported local gold to the central markets in Medani and Khartoum (interview with resident in Qeissan, 24 November 2019).

³⁷ One of them said *kān al-nās bi-limmū al-dahab sāy wa mā ba’rifū ya‘malū bīhī shnū*, ‘the people collected gold for no reason and didn’t know what to do with it’ (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019). Another resident claimed his ancestor Hassan Wad Al-Qasī had founded Qeissan (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019).

³⁸ Interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019.

submission to larger state formations. In so far as ‘tradition’ or dynastic lines had, at the same time, a strong currency in claims of communal representation, these elements continually intertwined in strategic ways: they were economic innovators but also members of influential historical lineages – the sultanate, the Ja’al tradition, and the Islamic pedigree; they governed through inherited positions but submitted to political ‘innovation’ by the NCP regime; etc.

A more specific way in which the present situation is linked to historical narratives can be observed in a conversation with a **Waṭāwīt** family (see Appendix 1 to this part). Some interlocutors characterised 19th century slavery as punishment for disobedience to extractive state rule, which offered a noteworthy interpretation of an early monopoly on violence implemented by trade-related agents of such rule. However, the idea that representative systems, including communal administration (*al-’idārah al-ahliyyah*), should align with one’s own interests was also clearly defined, indicating a tendency to support whichever administration appears to benefit such interests rather than a generalised commitment to specific state governments and their hierarchies of representation. In fact, the specific middle position between an ‘external’ (Arabs) and an ‘internal’ (local tribes) is reflected in the narratives as what defines a special heritage, amalgamated in the complex term ‘our grandfathers’.

What is most relevant here is how both social and national borders were defined simultaneously and interconnected. Benishangul was both implicitly and explicitly extended to Fazughli and southern Blue Nile as one realm. Claiming Benishangul as historically Sudanese—belonging to Ethiopia only due to colonial agreements—was combined with the ‘Sudanification’ of the groups that were seen to constitute their own community, the Waṭāwīt. In the narratives, Funj, Jabaliwīn, Berta all represented a Sudanese past of the borderlands, stemming from the maximum extent of the Funj sultanate and the Mahdist state, as original Sudanese state formations in which all ‘Sudanese’ voluntarily participated. Additional definitions also establish a historical connection to the core of Islamic history, such as defining Funj as Umayyads who established Famaka as ‘people of Mecca’.

At the same time, one of the speakers endorsed a conventional distinction between the countries Sudan and Ethiopia, and highlighted the ability to remain connected to both countries. The high positions held by ‘some of ours’ in Ethiopia, Egypt, and Sudan, along with the proud reference to a historical link connecting their ancestor Al-Naḍīr to Menelik II, all suggest the existence of multiple nationalities, multiple strings on one’s bow as a valuable resource. This contradicted others’ complaints about Menelik’s colonial treason and the lament about a subordinate position in Sudan, for whom the ultimate golden age was when the borderlands were, allegedly, free of external domination and warfare.

Fluidity as social practice

The consolidation of an international border in these areas has resulted in several groups residing on both sides of the border, having not migrated collectively to one side or the other when the border was drawn. This was also due to a very slow development of a regular governmental presence – up to the 1950s, not more than a police station even in

the border town of Qeissan – where Roseiris and later Al-Damazin long prevailed as the first official ‘contact point’ with the borderlands.³⁹ Even in the 21st century, central governments remained mostly invisible away from major points of interest – such as the GERD or outside conflicts, such as when tensions between Sudan and Ethiopia led to border closures or other restrictions, disrupting local residents in their usual pattern of crossing borders.

In some ways, linguistic boundaries can be considered stronger markers of differentiation, such as the shared spaces of Gumuz, Berta, and Arabic speakers in Sudan and Ethiopia, compared to those excluded from these regional and supraregional *linguae francae*. Looking more closely at the dynamics around **the borderland near Menza / Al-Mahal** north of the Blue Nile, such shared spaces can be more clearly situated in the workings of border regimes and border crossing as social practice.

Conversations with people living, to some extent, on both sides of the border, revealed an interesting distinction among different kinds of borders.⁴⁰ For them, the difference between Sudan and Ethiopia was only political, as procedure (‘*ijrā*’); someone living in Al-Mahal goes to his uncle in Belguwa, not to Sudan. The existence of laws and registration was acknowledged but did not concern his mental geography much, nor his inner feelings (*al-ša’ūr wa al-wijdān*); he considers this to be a movement within his areas, within his borders (*mutharrik fī ḥudūdū*), where there are no other borders of significant relevance. There is a single belt connecting Benishangul-Gumuz to Sennar, and families are binational, are precisely not: one cousin in the Ethiopian army, another in the Sudanese army, one day in Khartoum, the next in Addis Ababa, in Medani a house, and another in Asaosa. At the market, someone will buy perfumes, creams, etc., from Al-Mahal and bring them on a motorcycle to Belguwa, where the same language is spoken.

The true border was considered to be Abyssinia (*ḥabašah*): people will say ‘we go to the *ḥabaš*’, referring to those who have no connection to the Beni Shangul region or the Blue Nile of the Funj, which includes Amhara, Tigray, and Oromo, who are not part of their country (*waṭan*). If a *ḥabašīyyah* works in Belguwa as a tea seller, she is considered a foreigner, but if someone comes from Gubba and sits with his cousin, speaking in Berta, he is not regarded as a foreigner. Similarly, Gumuz in Ethiopia might treat Oromo as foreigners; when they sit in Menza or Belguwa, nobody will assume they are from the ‘other side’, as they are considered Sudanese *prima facie*.

This difference between official and socially active categories highlights the previously mentioned fluidity of international borders and social boundaries, which stands in a

³⁹ One interviewee even claimed that security personnel would only speak with children in the past to find out information, as adults would be too unwelcoming to strangers (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019).

⁴⁰ Interviews by Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman with residents in Al-Mahal, 18 November 2019; added to by observations of field researcher Ṭāriq ‘Abd Al-‘Aziz Maḥmūd, stemming from the region.

curious contrast to the rigidity of border conflicts.⁴¹ The practical reflection of both was recurrent references to people having ‘two passports’, which simultaneously acknowledged and blurred the borderline, as practically demonstrated by numerous individuals in the borderlands who lived between Qeissan and Beni Shangul, Blue Nile and Gubba, as traders, family members, and miners.

The terms used to describe border crossings were revealing in this context. A sheikh in Al-Mahal, for instance, stated that he constantly crosses over with ‘citizens’ (*muwāṭṭinīn*) and holds citizenship in both countries. The borders were never ‘binding’ (*mā ‘indahā rabṭ*) as everyone involved was aware of cross-border family relations.⁴² Accordingly, border police were accustomed to permitting a wide range of reasons for crossing, especially if someone was accompanied by an individual with official status in the neighbouring country.

Passports, in terms of the legal process, are a prerogative of the federal governments and are subject to a more extended stay and a convincing narrative explaining the connection to the other country. However, the legal prohibition of dual citizenship in Ethiopia was not included in these considerations. If official recognition was sought, self-identification could be flexibly tailored to meet administrative expectations, and administrative Sudanese might utilise the presence of Arabic-speaking Berta in Benishangul-Gumuz to present themselves as Ethiopians, and vice versa.⁴³

Nevertheless, private relations with officials at the border didn’t significantly influence crossing; avoiding border control meant avoiding authorities. Crossing through Menza to Al-Mahal, for instance, involved passing through the Sudanese customs at Jabal Al-Nimr, a major station. Whoever had something to declare did so, but if the official route was to be bypassed, one crossed directly into Ethiopia across the open borderlands. Because the borders lacked fences or other obstacles, people could cross anywhere deemed passable, and there was no need to expect to be questioned upon arrival, as long as one could pass as Ethiopian or Sudanese, respectively.

Concerning ‘conventional’ goods, this did not imply much ‘illegal’ circulation, though. From Ethiopia, a few traders sold in the weekly markets, bringing oil, perfumes, Ethiopian coffee, and bee honey, all in small quantities. No larger trade was possible because the roads – even the ‘official’ ones – were rough; a lorry could not pass or sometimes even pickup trucks, so no larger trade was feasible, and customs were mostly there for levies rather than to balance trade. Only a few goods were traded in larger quantities, such as the washing soap powder Wide, which was stored in huge heaps in Belguwa, but even they were only sold in small amounts at a time.

⁴¹ This also provides ample scope for amusing anecdotes: one interviewee claimed, for instance, that an ‘Ethiopian’ donkey cart driver in the market is a paternal cousin of Hassan Al-Turabi (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019).

⁴² In fact, the separation of South Sudan was mentioned as contributing to a more formalised process.

⁴³ Similarly, but with greater existential significance, the practice of South Sudanese declaring themselves ‘Abyei Dinka’—even if they were Maban or Shilluk—relied on the Sudanese government’s official claim to the region to legitimise their presence in the north.

Exploring the sheikh's statements further reveals how a local resident made sense of this situation, in a mental geography that integrated but was not defined by the international border, rather by socio-cultural patches, areas, and crossing points (see Appendix 2 to this part). The sheikh's statement constantly referred to a 'here' and 'there' that connect places within the borderland to those outside, often not clearly specifying whether they related to Sudan or Ethiopia, while still considering the states, thereby making a point: the region's importance was rooted in the fact that it acted as a bridge between areas with stricter crossing rules, a buffer zone between empires, and a social world of transitions. In this social world, there were numerous exchange relations, some guided by administrative rules, some by rules of reciprocity, social ties, commercial interests, cultural commitments, and curiosity, etc.

As the discussion above demonstrated, the international border effectively negated the existence of a buffer zone, reducing it to a line, an object with negligible width and depth; however, its political existence has made it, even for central governments, a tool for bilateral negotiation and concessions, to the detriment or benefit of resident populations who nonetheless found their own ways of pushing the boundaries.

What is important here is to show how notions of 'illegal migration' or assuming the legitimacy of international borders are connected to the history of colonial invasion of social spaces, and the claim of separate (or shared) categories of people regardless of what truly binds or distinguishes them. Actual exchange relations have not diminished; border demarcation has rather complicated how local populations inhabit these borderlands, exerting an impact that a presumption of nation-state rule – and their technologies of identifying its citizens – inevitably overlook.



Menza market, about four kilometres west of the Sudanese-Ethiopian border, August 2019
(photo by Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman)

Appendix 1: Interview with Waṭāwīt family

Al-Damazin (Sudan), 29 November 2019

This interview was arranged by one of the research assistants with his extended family; the interlocutors were his older male relatives. The conversation has been translated and edited for content and reorganised to bring together statements from different speakers on the same issues.

Speaker 1: We are called Waṭāwīt [by others]. We came 200 years ago and migration was not connected to Damazin in the past, as it was a difficult area and our people (*ahl*) came from the direction of Gedarif. They came after the fall of Andalus, during the time of Abd al-Rahman I [*Al-Dāḥil*, 731-788], and arrived in Abyssinia (*al-ḥabaṣah*) and from there they came and stayed in this area. This was during the Funj sultanate (*al-sulṭanat al-zurqā* [literally 'the blue']) and after it came the campaign of Isma'il Pasha, and after it the campaign of Dafterdar, and after these campaigns the area became fragmented (*itfartaqa*) and people dispersed and the [existing] relations ended. And after more than 500 years the sultanate became weak. And the Blue [the rulers of the sultanate] were Hamaj. Part of our people came mostly for trade, including trade with slaves and all kinds of goods, and they established [large] buildings (*amārāṭ*) and inheritance (*irṭ*) and mixed (*itṣāhirū*) [with the resident population] and brought Islam and were missionaries.

Speaker 2: The area Fanjah is in Oman, and Funj were called after it. And the Abbasids expelled them and they entered into Abyssinian areas and stayed in a village called Famaka, about 15 km from Fazughli, now submerged under the water from the heightening of the Roseiris Dam, and they are Umayyads, and Amara Dunqus [the Funj ruler] is from them. Famaka comes from *fā* meaning 'men' and *makā* meaning Mecca, so it means men of Mecca. The area became famous and extended its activities and Hausa and Tavruri came this way on the pilgrimage and they exist up to now in Benishangul. Amara Dunqus belonged to the Nile and he found the most secure plan for himself in Sennar area and founded his rule with Abd Allah Jimā' and formed the Funj kingdom from Fanjah. Another narrative is that they came and married from the queen Fanjah and she gave birth to Badi Abu Shilukh who named [the kingdom] after her, [but] this is a weak narrative and its documentation is weak, only [existing] in the works of the English and the colonialists. Modern migrations came from West Africa and West Sudan, but [those from] the north, Bederiyya and Rikābiyyah and Ja'aliyyīn and Danāqlah, they are old and spread Islam early on. But this has been forgotten for a long time. They had an old feudal system, and cultivated and stored, and they had an army.

Speaker 3: The Hamaj are 'Anaj, and the Ottomans gave this disrespectful name to them. Most of the area was inhabited by one category [of people], and differentiation of the tribes was based on language. The basis [of communication] is Arabic, and the local language (*roṭānah*) is Berta, and the Funj all speak the same Berta language. All of Blue Nile and further south are lands of the Berta. Then there are the Burun areas in Kurmurk, and Uduk, and Gumuz in the east. All the other tribes, 80% [of the population] are Berta, the Jabalāwīn are Berta, the Ingessana are Berta [one of the group disagrees], and all other tribes came from other areas. The Berta have the historical presence and the land is their property.

The Berta worked [gold] in a traditional way since old times. Our grandfathers took the gold by kilo and went [to sell it] and covered their expenses and [costs of] cultivation. Būmū is a gold area close to Berber, the largest gold area. It was in the past a famous trade area for ivory and [other] goods that went to India. The traditional way of dealing with gold was that it was produced by the clans and they washed in wooden trays (*bil-qadah*) and when they weigh the gold in the evening, sometimes they will have made several kilo. They were burying the gold with the dead, there was no inheritance as it causes conflicts between the descendants and the tribes. This was a Pharaonic tradition so there will be no inter-tribal fights.

fā is a term among Berta groups meaning 'people' and they have 99 mountains and [on] all there are sub-tribes. *be/* means mountain in Berta language.

Speaker 1: We are Ja'aliyyin Kabūšiyah from upstream and we preserve this heritage and are in contact with our people in Al-Damer up to now. Our circles are tight, and we all came from one man called Al-Naḍīr. We are currently under the sheikdom of our paternal uncle (*'ammanā*) 'Isa Al-Qāḍī, belonging to Al-Kurḍī as part of the eastern areas under the *'umda* Yūssif Al-Mak.

Speaker 2: One historical personality was called Muḥammad Nāṣir, he was a leader (*ra'īs*). They called people who speak only Arabic *al-'ajāmah*. Muḥammad Nāṣir went out (*marāq*) when there was a dispute, he went to the mountains to collect taxes for the government, a tribute called *al-jabr* or *al-'atab*. The Fa-Dūga in the mountains were a large group (*šullah*) and when they heard that somebody comes to collect taxes, they contacted Nāṣir to say that the Fa-Dūga had their harvest celebration, *jad' al-nār*, that goes back to the Pharaoh['s time]. And they told him to come after the celebration to collect the taxes. One called Al-Fakī Muḥammad went to Nāṣir and told him 'your son [Muḥammad] is a coward and is not able to take from the Fa-Dūga what is due to the government'. Muḥammad answered 'I am not a coward, I will go and what happens happens'. When he went, he found the Fa-Dūga all drunk and all had gone out (*lil-ḥallā*). When they found the leader coming on horse, one said to him 'we told you not to come, now you come [anyway]?' and one throw at him a spear and killed him through the head of the horse. One said *hāmdī Allah kī*, meaning 'you killed the small God' and they were idolaters (*waṭanīn*) – this happened in

the areas beyond Fazughli – and this was during our fifth [generation of] grandfathers, during the time of Isma'il Pasha. After they said 'we killed the son of God', God (Allah) meaning the government, they said the Fa-Dūġa will not benefit [i.e. pay taxes] anymore. His [Muḥammad's] father went to the Emir Abd al-Rahman Tor Al-Guri and said 'they killed my son like this'. The Emir gave him a force to take all the Fa-Dūġa. Nāṣir thought and said 'there are children and women among the Fa-dūġa, we cannot kill them all because of one boy, I will forgive Muḥammad's blood'. He [Abd al-Rahman?] said 'I will raise a force and take the Fa-Dūġa and make them all slaves so that they will have no word [of disobedience]' and he really caught them all and made them booty to cool their blood and so all of them became slaves. Then our father Nāṣir died and they selected as leader after him Sheikh Al-Jallab Abd Allah, he became the leader.

One called Abu Ušra said to our father Nāṣir, I will give you a woman, she will give birth and have no milk to breastfeed and she was called Ḥadīm Allah [literally 'servant of God'] and our grandfather Ibrahim Nāṣir was born from her and she had no milk, indeed. His mother, who [also] gave birth to called Muḥammad, took a bath and it became that she has milk and she breastfed Ibrahim. When he grew up, he became a successful and brave guy, and our father Nāṣir said, this one I brought from a Fa-Dūġa, give him to Al-Naḍīr, and he got engaged to my father's sister (*'ammātī*) Hawa, daughter of Al-Naḍīr, and he got the late Sheikh Wad Ibrahim and his sisters. And it was not possible that he works with the 'Ajāmah or marries from them because they had beaten the Fa-Dūġa and they don't accept to marry from Sheikh Ibrahim.

Speaker 3: Society is composed here of an Arabic element and a local element from local tribes. Our grandfathers married here from the people and from the Arab groups.

The borders of Funj were after Berber area 86km south of Asosa. These were the borders of the Mahdiyya. And historically, Benishangul was a Sudanese area until the Funj period, and there are Berta and Jabaliwīn there, and all of them are Sudanese, and there are no Amhara and Tigray and Ethiopian tribes. When Muhammad Ali searched for gold and men, he arrived in that area, and the army was [composed] of Peshmerga and Bashbazaġ.

Abd al-Rahman Al-Nijūmī made the borders with our grandfathers and put the flag of the Mahdiyyah at the borders, after making a big conference with the people. There was a tribal rebellion in Fazughli and Benishangul in 1886, when the *mak* of Fazughli was ruling until Berber. With the ascendancy of the Arabs, the conflicts started, and Abd al-Rahman Tor Al-Guri rebelled in Benishangul, and Khojali Hassan in Asosa, and Sheikh Al-Naḍīr in Bashir, and all are kingdoms of Sudanese clans. In 1886, Menelik II participated like all African countries in a conference in Europe and agreed to the entry of the Europeans into Africa and appeared as new colonialist and he returned and became the man for the colonialists in Africa. When they arrived at the British queen, she

gave Menelik the green line to dominate over the areas of the Muslims, and he controlled Benishangul when the Mahdist rulers were busy with tribal revolutions [sic!]. And when the [Ethiopian] army arrived, there was a battle with Abd al-Rahman Tor al-Guri in the areas of Ilyās and [the latter] was defeated and Menelik dominated, so Benishangul was under Ethiopian rule in 1886.

The English tried to return Benishangul but they left its administration to the Ethiopians under the condition that the Berta pay in gold to the English, and the Emperor Haile Selassie went to Britain and it is documented in the Birmingham Castle that this agreement was done on [this] basis and the situation continued in this way that the Ethiopians don't enter this area. The British divided their realm on this basis and the area was named Southern Funj in 1936, and its borders are at Fadasi inside Ethiopia. The memoirs of the General Governor said that the area Benishangul has to stay under discussion. Even southern Blue Nile is composed of one kind of population, that is a mixture of Funj with Arab tribes.

Speaker 1: There are groups in the headquarter of Roseiris. Other groups are in Fazughli under *mak* Zakariyya and his sons. In Keili there is *mak* Nāyil and Bashir, and the western areas has *mak* Adham and the Kabās people. [...] All of these are fragments of the Funj sultanate.

Speaker 3: During the English period, they focussed on [the claim that] the Arab groups having dominance and tried to isolate the Arabs and if you are Northerner or Arab to enter from Roseiris to Kurmuk you need a letter from the Mamur showing how long and where you stay, so they enhanced the backwardness and closure of these areas, and this policy continued until after independence.

Speaker 1: The area was closed from early on and the closure caused us damage since the time of the English, and nobody could enter without a permit. We were Sudanese in an area called Bashir, and we called it 'area free of rule and arms' (*manzū'at al-sultāh wa al-silāh*), close to Kurmuk, south of Asosa. It was between the English and the Italians and everybody in it was afraid or he had a political problem or so. We lost people and our people migrated, we returned and stayed in the areas of Khor 'Adār and Khor Maṣfā and we were in Baw belonging to the Ingessana hills and the nazirate [of Ingessana].

Speaker 1: When the war of Malik Agar came we came to Damazin, and when we came here we became under the people of Al-Kurdī and Sheikh 'Isa and he is the sheikh of our constituency.

In the past our people (*nāsnā*) lived from the environment and we had many resources and aspirations simple, and there was no problem with pastures or water, and it is not Darfur here, as the population is small and the resources abundant, and this attracted the Darfurians. The situation made life stable and our old people didn't go to read because they had a stable situation and didn't need anything. During the last period we [started] to read [i.e. get educated].

After 1985, the century war (*ḥarb qarn*) happened and we came to Damazin. We experienced town life and our situation got difficult and we started to educate our children and search for accommodation and food. We have problems because we are pastoralists. Part of the groups of Blue Nile [still] live in the rural areas and they can benefit from the resources. Another part lives in the town and they have problems. If we return to our agricultural lands, our situation is [also] difficult because they are not safe and income became low, so we have no means to educate our children and pay for healthcare. We are still affected by the closure of areas and we should have positive discrimination but still there is nothing.

The present communal administration does not fulfil our aims and its leaders are not educated, while we are educated, and we don't accept their leadership because they don't understand the changes that happened in society, and all came by inheritance, and if there is not voting, there is no use, and we will not be able to move forward. One of the big problems is that officials and enlightened people (*mutnawwīrīn*) came to us and tried to separate the local population from the decision-making positions so we don't gain experiences how to administer our homeland, and we cannot work anything apart from army or police. We need positive discrimination for the group to benefit, the solution cannot be that each one is just running after solving his own problems alone because this won't solve the situation.

Speaker 2: [So] we Waṭāwīt are new in Sudan, we came from Ethiopia in 1980, and I brought my father from Bashir. The communal administration was for the Hamaj and Raqārīq and the people of Fazughli and specific tribes. We are not recognized since it is said that we left our authority there [in Ethiopia] and they say that Sheikh Al-Qāḍī, for instance, is a sheikh of migrants under the omdaship of the western Hamaj, and [his position] is nominal to administer his people and solve their problems. But there is no real power and our communal authority is in Ethiopia, not here: we have Al-Naḍīr Ibrahim Al-Naḍīr who was minister in Ethiopia and he is the son of the brother of my father, and currently head of the delegation to the United Nations.⁴⁴ Al-Sabīl Ibrahim Al-Marḍī was also minister. And we have family in the Egyptian army and high-positioned officials. And when somebody dies we are informed and we make a wake and then we go there. This is the situation everybody acknowledges. Three weeks ago, the sword Menelik gave to our grandfather Al-Naḍīr 180 years ago was with us, and now in Damazin with the children of Maḥmūd. Al-Naḍīr took the sword some days ago from our cousin and it is now in the house of my brother. Mun'im, son of my sister, has an important position in the Sudanese government. We stay in both countries.

⁴⁴ It is not clear who is referenced, the then present Ethiopian delegation to the UN was headed by Ambassador Taye Atske Selassie Made and none of his staff was called Al-Naḍīr.

Appendix 2: Interview with sheikh

Al-Mahal (Ethiopia), 18 November 2019

The interlocutor held a central administrative position in Al-Mahal, responsible for granting permission to proceed after entering Ethiopia from Sudan. He was also a former SAF officer and had family ties to Sinnar. The interview was translated from Arabic and edited for content, including rearrangement of statements according to the themes they address.

[We are] Qubbāwiyyīn. The language is called Abu Ramla and the mountain is called Abu Ramla. There is also the language of Al-Balūṣ, and of Kadālū, with several dialects, Ab Šākūr and Menza and Majīngā. Then there is Mūkalā up to Jabal Al-Nūr, they say their language is Qimr but there are no Qimr here, they only come to the market day. Then there are Gumuz until Assosa in Ethiopia and east of Gubba and opposite Assosa there are Berta, whose colour is yellow, and one calls Berta [also] Dawālah. Beyond Assosa there is also Menge and around it all Berta and Dawālah. The rest are Gumuz and *ḥabaš*. The Berta there also talk *ḥabašī*. Most of the Muslims here are Funj and Jabalāwiyyīn, like ‘Ayn al-Šams and Majras and Abu Al-Ḥalaṣ, until Gubba, all of them are Funj. From here northwards the language is Mūkalā, from Jabal Al-Nūr up to Ab Qubāṭ. Then further on there are [again] Gumuz.

The tribes from the Blue Nile, from this region, they are all similar, one kind of occupation, living together peacefully, Gumuz, Berta, etc., Jabalāwiyyīn, all of them have *wāzah* [wooden and gourd trumpet music], and *jad’ al-nār* and all of that. *Jad’ al-nār* was originally here and went then to Sudan, as the Funj were in Gubba and *jad’ al-nār* is theirs. They have a ‘*umda* here, the omdaship Gubba up to the north, one omdaship with all the black tribes (*al-zurqā’* [literally: the blue]). Al-Mahal itself has only a sheikh, [...] his father is Amhara (*ḥabašī*) and his mother from here. He has houses there in Sudan, and his children are there. Since long ago there was mixture, the same formation process that happened in Sudan. They learn in Amharic [here], and speak Funj, [as] Amhara is the dominant language, the language of the state. There are other languages, Berta, Jabalāwiyyīn, and Fa-Waṣḥum, and they are part of Berta, and Kadālū.

In the far past, it is said the whole place was called land of the *ḥabaša*. [But] the land here [in Al-Mahal] belongs to Gumuz and they are still there, most of them traders. From Al-Mahal to Menza is about two hours by motorcycle. Honey and soap goes from here, soap powder, shoes, clothes, sugar and edible oil come from there. Everybody works [in trade] and there are also big traders among Gumuz, and also *ḥabaš*, but Gumuz are more. Sudanese come a lot, and they give them a normal permit to work. Many stayed many years, they gave them nationality, and they married from the place, normal.

In gold [for instance], they work with devices, also shafts, they have a paper they get against some payment and work normal, [especially] if you have a device. There are cooperatives, five people, or a thousand people, with an annual licence, from the bank and official channels, and one has to bring a specific amount of gold per year, and they pay more than the market price. This season we still haven't work, don't know the price, it was here 1800 birr, so about 3000 plus over there, like 3240, very good price. [Anyway,] you can sell here or there, but most sell in Sudan. If they sell here, they change the money immediately, some send it over there. The government has also a share, but less than in Sudan. [But] everybody can work. But with the conflicts and war everybody went to their families, the people dispersed [after the conflict in Gumuz areas in 2019].

Part 2: Exchange relations: Gold

Note: This chapter is based on field reports by Tsegaye Birhanu (Benishangul-Gumuz, January-February 2020) and Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman (Blue Nile, several visits in 2019 and 2020).

Gold sector regulation in Ethiopia

Similar to other resources, there is a long history of attempts by Ethiopian central governments to increase their control over the extraction of minerals and the revenues generated from it. During the 20th century, the first attempt to increase governmental control over gold mining emerged in November 1929 with a decree that made the extraction and export of minerals, including gold, illegal without a governmental permit; a year later, the unauthorized transfer of concessions was added, and in 1931, a prohibition on prospecting in river beds was enacted, along with a proclamation establishing the Department of Mines in Addis Ababa as the sole authority permitted to issue permits, barring provincial and local rulers from doing so. As will be shown below, it was rather concessionaries' actual access to local resources that was contested (Zewde 1976: 422).

The political economy of Ethiopia's mining sector has shifted over time. Between 1974 and 1991 (Derg regime), consistent with the government's ideology of state-led development, government institutions were tasked with exploring and developing the country's mineral resources. In 1991, the fall of the Derg regime and the rise of the EPRDF brought in more market-oriented economic policies, which also impacted the mining sector. During the transitional government, the Mining Proclamation No. 52/1993, Income Tax Proclamation No. 53/1993, and Mining Regulations No. 182/1994 were issued. The Ministry of Mining and Energy of the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE), with a structure extending to lower levels of government, was responsible for developing the mining sector.

For a period, the gold sector remained peripheral; production and export were valued at US\$ 5 million in 2001 and US\$ 23.8 million in 2005. However, up to 2015, gold accounted for over 98% of mineral exports, making a significant contribution to foreign exchange earnings (Tadess 2015: 36). An assessment from the early 2010s found the mining sector making a low contribution to the national economy, with 1.5% of GDP (around 0.5 billion USD), although it comprised 19% of exports, almost solely from gold (618 million USD). Proposed scenarios indicated a potential increase to approximately 1.5 billion USD over ten years (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 2).

This development was, among other factors, related to a sharp increase in the global gold price after 2010, which drew the attention of the central government to the sector, including how to control and regulate gold production and marketing. In 2010, a new legal framework (Mining Operations Proclamation No. 678/2010) was introduced,

complementing ongoing efforts to organise artisanal miners into cooperatives. However, as noted in the 2016 five-year plan, the years following 2012 experienced significant declines in Ethiopia's main export commodities, especially coffee and gold (FDRE, National Planning Commission 2016: 16), which were then planned to be offset by increasing production by small and large companies (FDRE, National Planning Commission 2016: 106). Consequently, the production target for gold by licensed miners was expected to rise from 9,053.53 kg (2014/15) to 25,370.0 kg (2019/20), and foreign exchange earnings were ambitiously projected to increase from US\$ 343.73 million to US\$ 2.011 billion (FDRE, National Planning Commission 2016: 151). The contribution of artisanal miners was still expected to surpass that of companies, with 13,370 kg and 12,000 kg respectively (FDRE, National Planning Commission 2016: 152). In other words, "[t]he current policy framework envisions the mineral sector to be the backbone of the industry by 2020-2023" (Tadess 2015: 37).

A key requirement for such revenues, however, was a stronger control over royalties and distribution channels. This was addressed through a two-tiered approach: while the federal government is tasked with creating laws for the utilisation and conservation of mineral resources, regional states have the authority to manage these resources in line with federal laws. The federal Ministry of Mining is responsible for issuing licences to large-scale and small-scale producers of precious minerals, including gold, whereas Regional Mining Bureaus have the authority to issue and oversee prospecting, exploration, and production licences for artisanal and specialised small-scale mining. Additionally, regional states can impose and collect income taxes, royalties, and land rents from small-scale and artisanal mining activities. Conversely, the power to impose and collect income taxes and royalties from large-scale mining operations is a shared authority exercised jointly by both regional and federal governments.

For the purposes of this book, the legal and fiscal situation of so-called artisanal miners within this framework is most relevant. According to the amended Mining Operations Proclamation No. 816/2013, there are four types of gold mining licences: a large-scale mining licence is issued for 20 years with the possibility of renewal; a small-scale mining licence is initially granted for 10 years; special small-scale producers are given a licence for not more than 10 years but can be renewed; an artisanal mining licence is issued for no more than two years. Generally, the procedures for small- and large-scale operations are managed by the federal government, while artisanal and special small-scale mining are regulated according to laws and regulations at the state level, implemented by the Regional Mining Bureaus (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 66). Institutionally, the process for increasing control over the artisanal sector falls under the responsibility of the Artisanal Mining & Transaction Coordinating Directorate and the Environment and Community Development Directorate, with specific legal standards established for artisanal mining (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 66).

The first half of the 2010s experienced a notable but largely implicit shift in how lawmakers envisioned the organisation of the sector. According to the Mining Operations Proclamation (No. 678/2010), a licence for artisanal mining could be granted for three years, with two possible extensions, covering a maximum of nine years (Art. 32/3). The main focus remained on the most intensive and extensive extraction of mineral resources,

so a licence could be revoked, compensated, or relocated if another licensee appeared better equipped to achieve that goal in that specific location (Art. 32/5-7). The 2013 amendment introduced a distinction between artisanal mining and special small-scale mining, with the former defined, in Art. 2/2, as “a mining operation carried out by individuals or small and micro-enterprises which is mostly of manual nature and does not involve the engagement of employed workers.” Special small-scale miners are ‘upgraded’ artisanal miners or small- and micro-enterprises that can demonstrate “financial capacity to employ modern machineries and equipment in such operations”.

The most significant change was, however, that artisanal mining licenses were limited to a maximum of two years without the option for renewal (Art. 34/3-4), while special small-scale mining licenses could last ten years with one renewal of five years (Art. 35). Reporting requirements were also tightened, with monthly reports on production figures and quarterly sales to licensed agents (Art. 36). This also implied a near-abolition of cooperatives of artisanal miners, as two years is not a feasible timeframe for any organisation (Tadess 2015: 3), and the amendment “has deleted the relevance of the mining cooperative” (Tadess 2015: 16). This was especially true as some states had only just begun to systematically establish mining cooperatives, earliest in Oromia (2006), but only since 2010 in Amhara, SNNPR and Benishangul-Gumuz (Tadess 2015: 24). The ban on modern technology and employees, along with the lack of requirements for professional competence, all contribute to the impression that one group is targeted over another: instead of long-experienced communal miners working in their own areas where different household members take on various roles according to their abilities, there is a short-term influx of young ‘entrepreneurs’ seeking quick capital to start another venture or expand their operations (Tadess 2015: 16).

Overall, government intentions seem to have backfired: while encouraging youth to participate in mining increased artisanal mining activities – alongside reduced farmland availability and productivity, as well as in-migration – the expected creation of SMEs by these youths as a form of job generation was minimal (Tadess 2015: 24). Consequently, ‘illicit’ mining rose instead of declining, and a field survey in 2013 found 94% of operating miners to be doing so without licences (Tadess 2015: 18). In fact, ‘illegal’ miners are in an advantageous position (Tadess 2015: 18):

The latter operates its mining activities anywhere the resource is available (not confined to a specific area) even crossing boundaries of kebeles or even woredas. This shows that illegal miners have a better opportunity of accessing resources than the legally entitled miners who are restricted to one location only. There is no government attempt to control this informal practice in any of the regions visited. The situation has prompted the legal miners to follow the illegal practices to mine anywhere accessible to them. Nowadays artisan mining is dominated by unlicensed miners and licensing has become only a nominal desk work.”

The steps proposed by a MoM / WB study included improved management and control of ASM, as the current practices were “associated with some troublesome characteristics, that include informality (not being legal), social and environmental impacts”, and contents that “these activities may hinder the development of large scale mining operations.” (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 5-6). The latter clearly focused on sector development, as conflicts between resident communities and large-scale operations

were merely regarded as “significant deterrent for future investments” (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 6). However, it was also recommended to conduct better baseline studies and to clarify contradictions between federal and state land policies that tend to prioritise mining, agriculture, or conservation differently (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 6).

A related issue is local taxation. The revenue distribution is regulated in the FDRE’s constitution, Art. 97, which specifies “taxes on income derived from small and medium-scale mining operations” for the states, while large-scale operations are controlled from the centre (article 98). Generally, all mining projects require a no-cost equity share for the government; more specifically, the 2013 amendment to the 2010 Mining Proclamation set the minimum at 5%. This share, along with additional taxes and royalties, are divided between the federal and state governments based on the same size principle; while the federal income tax is fixed at 25%, regional governments can decide which taxes to impose. Additionally, royalties are “at 7% for precious metals, 5% for metallic minerals and 4% for industrial minerals” (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 6). In this context, the National Bank of Ethiopia introduced an incentive for ASM to sell to their agents by keeping its price 5% above the prevailing gold price, yielding 8t in 2013 (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 6). It should be noted, however, that a 5% royalty must be paid by any licensee to the state (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 66; see also ‘Paths of gold trade’).

A MoM / WB assessment of the situation in the gold-producing areas indicated that not only was the productivity from ASM low—reducing readiness to pay taxes—but also that most of the output was not sold to NEB agents. It should also be noted that only artisanal and small-scale miners were limited to the option of selling to the NBE, while other license holders have “the right to sell locally or export the minerals” (Proclamation, amendment 2013, Art. 44/3), and they are also exempt from customs duties (Art. 75/5). The ‘incentive’ to the artisanal sector thus also fell short of encouraging a more controlled process from the government’s perspective.

It has been argued that the introduction of the special small-scale mining license (SpecSSM) was designed to serve as a bridge and development pathway from unmechanised artisanal mining to larger and more complex forms of mineral extraction. Since Ethiopians can obtain these licences from the Regional Mining Bureaux, the typically centralised licensing process for more mechanised operations became more accessible. After a maximum of 15 years, locations that remain viable and productive could be expected to have developed enough capital and infrastructure to qualify for a regular small-scale mining license (see World Bank 2016: 81-82). The argument also aimed “to encourage Ethiopians to view artisanal mining as an economic stepping stone to a more profitable business, rather than an end in itself” (Tadess 2015: 3).

This ideology of entrepreneurship and ‘business’, however, fails to understand the realities of communal economies in low-income settings, where strengthening—or even simply maintaining—their foundations is much more urgent than seeking new opportunities elsewhere. The sudden reduction of ASM licenses to non-renewable two-year terms nearly escalated the situation by criminalising the self-organised, unregistered activities

of most miners, who cover their regular expenses with gold rather than following a business model centred on continuous growth. An expected outcome was an increase, not a decrease, in the number of miners bypassing licensing laws and the official trade system.

Given this situation, even a follow-up WB report from 2016 calls for a revision of this policy and to “eliminate the priority for [large-scale mining]” (World Bank 2016: 82) to prevent conflicts. It argues, however, that smaller licenses will have a short lifespan and should be made transferable to larger operators by consensus. The deep history of communal mining in many areas is once again ignored in favour of a conventional model of artisanal mining as a temporary gold rush dynamic. Additionally, both government policies and the latter argument fail to recognise “accumulated indigenous skill in mineral exploring and mining practices – implying a loss of huge knowledge capital” (Tadess 2015: 19). A license with a time limit is irrelevant for ‘artisans’ who, as the term suggests, practice a craft and work close to home.

As seen in cases like Tulu Kapi Gold Mining – involving the World Bank itself – the implications of large-scale operations are more complex and politically sensitive than simply ‘seeking consensus’, as they include plans for relocating populations (e.g., Ambaye 2015: 17-18, 158, 161, 166, 226-227). The controversial environmental impacts of MIDROC Gold’s Lega Dembi mine, which has been intermittently open since 2018 – with plans developed without community involvement – also demonstrate that the responsibility for harm, often attributed to ASM, can be far from organised in a way that prevents harm but rather is focused on compensation claims only addressed after lengthy audits and community backlash. In fact, major conflicts have arisen with large-scale miners rather than migrants or neighbouring communities, and not solely due to competition between mining and agriculture, or pollution: “it so happens that both the large-scale private miners and the artisan miners are officially and legally given the same sites” (Tadess 2015: 20). Interestingly, while these regulations were unfavourable towards communities mining gold as part of their livelihood, only artisanal miners were excluded from community development plans (Proclamation, amendment 2013, Art. 62/3).

In fact, these policies reflect the UNECA African Mining Vision of 2009, which envisaged ASM to be socioeconomically integrated and regulated (World Bank 2016: 79-80). In some ways, these regional policies also perpetuate the view that everything outside centralised revenue flows is to be considered ‘illicit’, ‘illegal’, or ‘irregular’. Phrases like ‘mainstreaming ASM’ seem to overlook the contradiction that while extractive activities are already a fundamental part of livelihood strategies, they are also threatened by regularisation, which could make them economically unviable.

Consequently, the level of implementation was generally low. Ethiopia’s EITI study emphasised this gap between regulations and the reality faced by most miners who, even if they obtain a license, operate “with no limit in time and boundary” (Tadess 2015: 3).

Mining in Benishangul

Gold mining has a long history in Ethiopia overall, especially in the Benishangul-Gumuz Region. However, for most involved, gold was not an empowering resource, even if individual circumstances were temporarily improved. The fact that gold, apart from times of crisis, had limited socio-economic impact in one of the oldest documented gold mining areas — an area that has attracted imperial interest for generations — shows the conditionality of that interest: only a combination of slave labour and a monopoly on trade turned gold into a source of wealth. The debate over ‘national’ versus family-level economic benefits remains central in approaches to extractive activities and their regulation.

Exploration and licenses

The gold reserves in Blue Nile State and Benishangul-Gumuz were not insignificant but fell below imperial expectations, and both were interconnected and competing with the interests of local power elites. In the decades following the Ottoman invasion, for instance, Muhammad Ali dispatched several exploration teams into the region, some of which competed with one another, and the exploits of the Austrian Russeger (1838) and the Russian Kovalevsky (1847-48) offer rare insights into indigenous mining techniques and the new installations constructed based on their findings. Kovalevsky's itinerary took him to gold-bearing sand about an hour's walk from the mountain Qeissan and the torrent of the river Tumat, beyond the mountain ridges to the torrent Khor Dahab. By then, the area was already occupied by the Sudanese governor Khalid Pasha with 3,000 men, but Kovalevsky began a systematic exploration, and his team produced around 72 grains per day using a device brought from Siberia for washing (Hill 1955: 115-116). Another plant was erected near Dul, after which the Ottoman troops moved on to Benishangul.

Crossing Khor Deis, they passed Mount Ube and Mount Umbi, ultimately reaching Khor Gadi, some distance from Khor Sorguli, where gold washing was ongoing, and eventually arrived at the trade centre of Benishangul along the route between inner Abyssinia and Khartoum, via Keili and Sennar. However, the gold content in the surrounding plains was too low to attract their interest (Hill 1955: 117-118). Further south, beyond Khor Tumat, the former commercial centre of Qammamil had been abandoned by its thousands of inhabitants after a Galla attack, but the sands of the khor were visibly gold-bearing, more than Qeissan. A march further south, to Jebel Sore, rounded off this trip, ending before Assosa was reached (Hill 1955: 118, see map on page 120). After returning to Qeissan, the installation was soon completed, and Cairo-trained engineers led the device-driven washing of, on average, 900 grains and 5t of sands, yielding another 20-21 grains per ton (i.e., 0.13-0.2 g per t), significantly higher than workings in Siberia, for instance. This link between techniques and knowledge spanning from Russia and Egypt to the mining site was welcomed by Muhammad Ali and Ibrahim Pasha, who replaced him during these years; however, Khalid Pasha, as the local ruler, abandoned the engineer-led mechanised washing process and reverted to the much less efficient, labour-intensive panning,

favouring mass labour over sophistication. His recommendation to establish a stronger presence further south was not acted upon (Hill 1955: 119).

This episode foreshadows several enduring dynamics: attempts to expand large-scale extraction projects into the region, weighing advanced extraction technologies against ongoing 'inefficient' work; the power imbalance between central authorities and local elites in physical control of—and exposure to—the situation, with differing priorities; and the organisation of extraction labour between quantity—many 'slow' labourers—and quality—a few fast machines. This period also has significant implications for cross-border interactions, as it demonstrates a time when mobility was influenced by natural features—mountains and rivers—and local (in)security—military camps/troops and roaming 'hordes'. These dynamics, which border demarcation—outlined in the previous two parts—only partially altered, impacted cross-border trade relations, including the gold trade, the focus of this part.

One of the understated aspects of colonial history is that the fame of gold-bearing areas such as the Nuba Mountains, Fazughli, and Benishangul, which are linked to the Nubian and Aksumite kingdoms, fueled imperial greed that was often not satisfied by actual gold discoveries. The gold-washing mill in Tumat, established by Ottoman-Egyptian forces and Russian-trained Egyptians, produced little compared to initial expectations. Likewise, the concession to George W. Lane, granted in 1900 in Benishangul in exchange for the British government waiving land in the border agreement, remained unused for over 20 years, as did an earlier concession to the traveller Herbert Weld-Blundell. In fact, contrary to British assumptions, successive concessions held by Italians, Germans, and French further inland proved to be much more successful ventures (Zewde 1976: 415).

Only after World War I were the concessions revived. Weld-Blundell was now chairman of the North East African Exploration Co., which had acquired Lane's concession, and the company's plans included both gold extraction in Khomosha and a sanatorium for whites from the Gezira Scheme near Mendi. However, two other British companies, Sudan Goldfields Co. and the Abyssinian Development Syndicate, targeted the same area; the former was granted permission for Dul area in 1919 and entered into an agreement with the latter. Nonetheless, the reaction of local elites to British presence shaped further contestations (Zewde 1976: 423).

The first expedition in 1920 was called off after the Sudan government inspector at Kurmuk received a hostile reply when informing Sheikh Muhammad Wad Ahmad, who was also raiding Khomosha at that time. The latter requested a high-level government representative to convey approval from Addis Ababa and a share in royalties. The company representatives, therefore, asked the central government to have Sheikh Khojali lead a campaign against the rebellious chief, but they did not wait until it was organised and instead forced their way into the concessioned land in 1921. They were misled by their self-righteous expectation that a combination of imperial passes and money would be enough to legitimise their presence, and they had to return to Khartoum (Zewde 1976: 424-425). When the campaign finally got underway, it didn't go as planned: the British forces sent to the border from Kurmuk mostly withdrew with the arrival of the rainy season, and *dajach* Kumsa, the local imperial representative, rather sided with

Muhammad. Ultimately, the confrontation ended with Muhammad's downfall in 1922, but the company was never compensated for its losses.

Sheikh Khojali also adopted an anti-British stance, likely influenced by the challenge to his slave-trade activities mentioned earlier. He had amassed about 100,000 Pound Sterling (equivalent to around £6.5 million today) at the time of his death, and "his confidence in the power of gold was absolute: he expressed regret when Emperor Haile Selassie fled the country during the Italian [sic] invasion in 1936 via Jibouti [...]; he felt that they could have taken enough gold to bribe the member states of the League of Nations and journalists to raise an outcry against the invaders and restore Ethiopia's independence" (Zewde 1976: 427). He also harboured his own geopolitical vision: an ultimately unproductive joint venture between Khojali, *dajach* Dasta Damtaw – son-in-law of Ras Tafari – and Tafari's son Asfa Wassan was attempted to be acquired by foreign investors in 1929, with Khojali specifically excluding British capital (Zewde 1976: 426-427).

A further episode took place during the Italian occupation when the Società Mineraria Italo Tedesca set up a compound and a mine at Ondonok near the Dabus River, a location still called Singore Washa – Mister's Cave – in the 2000s (González-Ruibal 2010: 553). Similar to other western frontier encampments, one of its roles was to establish a presence in defiance of British interests; another camp beyond Assosa, for example, was intended to control the Sherkole Valley, a historic trade route into Sudan (González-Ruibal 2010: 555). Although almost no gold was ever extracted, the sites of Italian presence became almost mythical parts of local mental maps, and tombs and buildings of Italians were long objects of excavation for local inhabitants expecting to find gold – and, in some cases, evil spirits (González-Ruibal 2010: 570).⁴⁵

From a 21st century exploration perspective, the borderlands lie between the highly productive industrial mine, Lega Dembi in Ethiopia, and Hassai in Sudan, where artisanal mining has done little more than scratch the surface. The topographic and geological structures of the area were already shown to include both connecting and dividing features. While mountains and ravines often block or hinder cross-country travel, they also contain numerous pathways. Additionally, they form masses beyond current national borders: the gold-bearing areas in Benishangul-Gumuz belong to a Proterozoic basement that lies between the Arabian-Nubian Shield and the Mozambique Belt, a geological landscape covering large parts of North Africa, stretching into Saudi Arabia, and most of eastern Africa (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 19).

⁴⁵ Interestingly, a man born in Qeissan in 1940 and interviewed in November 2019 was convinced that neither the British nor Italians ever showed any interest in gold (interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019).

In the late 20th and early 21st centuries, several commercial surveys contributed to the industrial geological outlook on the region:⁴⁶

- Golden Star Resources Limited (1997)
- Emerging Africa Gold (1998)
- GP Resource Mining (2011-2014)
- Caracle Creek International Consulting for Benzu Gold Mining Ethiopia (2012-2013)
- Ondonok Dabus, Centamin (2014)

The old Italian holdings repeatedly rekindled investment interest. A notable example is the work of the Ethiopia-based GP Resource Mining, which conducted studies between 2011 and 2014 in the Kuluck River and Koncha River areas of Asosa Zone, along with surrounding plains (Bullock & Morgan 2015; Bullock & Morgan 2018). In 2018, these areas were highlighted in *Geology Today* as sites that had “previously seen semi-mechanized placer gold mining during the Italian occupation of 1935–1940” in a region described as “relatively untouched” with “minor artisanal placer gold mining” by a population “mainly dependent on agriculture” (Bullock & Morgan 2018: 31). The historical reference thus suggested that the only relevant prior extraction occurred during colonial times. This implication was reinforced by a complete omission of land issues and local claims on gold resources as crucial sources of income. Ultimately, “[t]he recently improved accessibility of the Assosa area and widespread gold occurrence of this relatively untouched resource may present an ideal future gold prospecting region” (Bullock & Morgan 2018: 34).

In 2014, the Ondonok Dabus license was acquired by a joint venture of Centamin with Alecto Minerals. However, these explorations mostly ended similar to the 19th-century tours: while some local concentration levels were high enough to generate interest in exploitation, they did not reach the threshold required to establish an operation. Centamin withdrew from the joint venture in 2015 and left the country (Centamin 2016: 9).

In early 2020, the Regional Mining Bureau of BSG identified only one large-scale production license, held by MIDROC Gold for a northern part of the region,⁴⁷ and one small-scale production licence, acquired by Vintage Mining for Dangur *woreda* in Metekel

⁴⁶ There have also been more general geological surveys by the Geological Survey of Ethiopia, such as the Guba Oda Integrated Mineral Exploration Project, the ETHIONOR Beles-Diner Gold and Metals Exploration Project, and the Bure Abergele project. The Environmental and Social Impact Assessments for the Assosa-Guba road and for the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam also included assessments of mineral resources and ongoing extractive activities. Aside from these and other works by Ethiopian governmental institutions, surveys in southern BGS were conducted, for instance, by UNDP (1972) and the Metal Mining Agency of Japan (1974). In addition to the sources cited here, see an overview in Caracle Creek International Consulting’s 2013 report to Benzu Gold Mining Ethiopia.

⁴⁷ MIDROC Gold, owned by Saudi-Ethiopian businessman Sheikh Mohamed Al-Amoudi, made discoveries in Bulen *woreda* of Metekel Zone where it has held a license since 1997.

Zone.⁴⁸ Exploration was reportedly ongoing by Managem, Cipton, Nubian Gold and ASCOM, while a Chinese company began introducing refinery machines in Sherkole.⁴⁹ New exploration licenses issued in 2019, such as the Chinese YFY Mining exploring marble in Kamashi Zone and Ethiopian Shahi Dahi exploring copper in Metekel Zone, were not known or mentioned.⁵⁰

The ASCOM licence exemplifies this case: the Egyptian mineral exploration company acquired the licence in 1999 and only announced in 2011 that it had discovered a large gold deposit in BSG, which extended its similar activities in Blue Nile State. It then held five concessions, each covering an area of 8,000 km² (Zenebe 2011). In 2014, the company even announced the discovery of 30-40 tonnes of gold reserves in Kurmuk woreda (EUTF 2016: 15). By 2020, the company had no presence in the region at all, and although there is no clear evidence on this, it is difficult to ignore the political implications of an Egyptian company extracting gold near the GERD.⁵¹

Revenues and livelihoods

As it were, the main productive output comes from the artisanal sector where licensing and taxation, as outlined above, are complex issues. The lack of enforcement may also relate to the generally slow development of taxation, which arguably stems from the circumstance that “successive weak governments either did not have the capacity to collect taxes, or did not want to jeopardise their limited authority by imposing taxes on a population long used to a measure of autonomy” (Young 1999: 338), apart from considering the widespread poverty among the population that still starkly contrasts with the long history of gold-mining activities.

⁴⁸ This was an Ethiopian company established in 2014; the license permitted seven years of gold extraction on 1.1 km² in the *woreda*, and Vintage Mining collaborated with Russian experts for its operations.

⁴⁹ Interview with official of the Benishangul-Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, 13 March 2020; interview with official of the Sherkole Mining Office, 18 February 2020; compare with lists in FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 24 and Stephens 2016. In one interview, the company was called Chuwanja Fan. The only company officially listed for Sherkole was Donia Gonda Mineral Resource Co., with an exploration license from 2009, probably a subsidiary or joint venture of Beijing Donia Resources Co. In an EITI follow-up report, for 2016/17, the level of detail was greatly reduced, and MIDROC was the only company listed with a license for BSG.

⁵⁰ The actual presence of companies in the state still remained limited, although gold exploration licenses were reported to have been issued for the woredas of Menge, Sherkole, and Kurmuk (interview with official of the Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020). Their actual activities, however, remained unclear to the local officials. ASCOM was rumoured to have finally entered production after 13 years, but the Mining Agency could not verify these rumours (interview with Mining Team Leader at Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020).

⁵¹ Another company, Golden Star, had to leave BSG in late 1997 after the regional government claimed it had been infiltrated by OLF (Young 1999: 340).

In the years before 2010, this did not seem to be a major concern; the entire Water, Mining & Energy Resource Development Bureau of BSG, for instance, only held a 5.6% share of the budget in 2006/7, which decreased to 1.4% in the following year, resulting in the Bureau overspending by 40.6% (FDRE, Ministry of Finance 2010: 15, 18). However, more ambitious plans emerged after the national policy changes post-2010. During fieldwork, the Regional Mining Bureau provided the following figures for planned gold production and actual gold sales to the NBE agencies:

Year	Planned gold production (in kg)	Gold sold to NBE (in kg)
July 2015-June 2016	1500	985.9
July 2016- June 2017	1900	406.0
July 2017- June 2018	1300	43.9
July 2018- June 2019	1000	54.3

This discrepancy shows how, initially, a sizable amount of gold was brought to the NBE agency, which led to an increase in planned production. However, this was reluctantly scaled back over the following years, ultimately falling far short of the original commitment to the legal pathway (see more details in chapter ‘Paths of gold trade’). Similar to other periods in the borderland’s history, lack of investment in infrastructure also meant a lack of effective control: paved roads and electricity were largely absent from gold mining areas, and entire *weredas*, such as Sherkole and, to a lesser extent, Kurmuk, faced a similar situation. In Sherkole, the average time to reach paved roads, according to official measurements in 2014, was 38 minutes, with 68% of households having no direct access. Urban centres were 3 hours 44 minutes away. In Kurmuk, it was only 20 minutes to paved roads, and urban centres could be reached in 1 hour 15 minutes. Access to electricity was generally limited; only 2% of households in Sherkole and 11% in Kurmuk were connected to the grid, while 9% and 23% had general access to electricity, respectively (EUTF 2016: 8).

The originally envisioned method to boost both supervision and revenue collection in the artisanal sector was by establishing cooperatives. A 2016 EITI report observed that, indeed, thousands of mining cooperatives, SMEs, and development groups had been created, with BSG land areas partially covering an entire kebele (Tadess 2015: 18). At that time, the regional government had registered 81 cooperatives and 33 SMEs, with a total of 4,887 members (Tadess 2015: 25); in 2007, there were still no gold mining cooperatives at all.

However, it was not just the sudden policy shift away from cooperatives that stopped this movement towards greater integration of production and administration. The politically motivated change in statistical terminology from cooperatives to ‘self-employment’ meant that the 2015/16 Ethiopian household consumption-expenditure survey showed no sign of any member or employee of cooperatives. Because the definition of cultivation work was ‘self-employment in the formal sector’, confirmed by the description ‘on own account’, most household heads (84.3%) fit this category, most of whom are men.

However, none of them was recorded as employed in a cooperative. A similar pattern appears for all household members, with 41.4% classified as 'self-employed', and 46.4%, mostly women, listed as employed in private households—likely, along with the claim of 0% unpaid family work, as a mere redefinition of household chores. Again, no one was shown to be engaged in any cooperative (FDRE, Central Statistical Agency 2018).

Due to significant gaps between administrative linguistic and statistical practices, and the long-term trends of the population's economic activities, it remains very challenging to accurately evaluate the actual contribution of gold mining to household livelihoods and the regional economy as a whole. Over the past 25 years, only a few attempts have been made to gain a comprehensive understanding of the situation, apart from the aforementioned studies, such as an assessment by the Mines and Energy Department in 1997, whose figures have been used in ESIA's in the 2010s; the UNDESA/UNDP Poverty Reduction and Sustainable Livelihood survey focusing on artisanal mining communities (2002); the Socio-Economic Baseline Survey of Artisan and Small-Scale Mining Communities in Rural Ethiopia (SUDCA Development Consultant 2013); and the EITI study "Artisan Mining Operation. Its Economic Values" by Beyene Tadess (2015).

The context of gold mining remained largely unchanged in these assessments: agriculture and livestock production continued as the primary activities but were highly vulnerable to water shortages, diseases, and other risks. While 'indigenous' groups mostly relied on slash-and-burn farming, resettled or in-migrant groups operated on fixed fields (EUTF 2016: 11). The 2016 household survey for BGS indicated, based on 1728 households grouped into the categories BGS Rural, BGS Urban and Assosa (town), that mining and quarrying played a minimal role across all economic levels and regions, being the main economic activity for only 3% of the population. The same was also claimed for rural areas alone, highlighting issues of insufficient disaggregation and the distortions caused by exclusionary statistical categories of economic activities focused on designated household heads and not supported by other methods.

In more mixed-method approaches, mining has been shown to be an essential additional and/or compensatory activity, especially in the areas bordering Sudan and among Berta (EUTF 2016: 11). Where practised, mining represented the backbone of livelihoods, accounting for 57% of mining communities' livelihoods in BGS (Tadess 2015: 2, 18). Considering how almost ubiquitous gold mining was in all *weredas* of the state, it is difficult to imagine that these communities were nothing but a peripheral phenomenon.

How much was actually produced by how many still remains difficult to determine reliably. The 1997 estimate was that 55,000 to 63,000 miners in BSG produced 180kg annually (Birrie 2010: 42), and no more recent figures with a more solid basis are available.⁵² Since most of the ongoing production is regarded by authorities as illegal, it is not surprising

⁵² The 2013 SUDAC study used standardised estimates of productivity, indications from specific sites, and the difference between total and industrially produced gold that reached the NBE and thus official enumeration to calculate informally but not illegally produced gold and, using productivity estimates, the total number of artisanal miners. If the official channel is, however, peripheral to the gold trade (see below), then these calculations remain far from a reliable assessment of the situation.

that surveys perceived to be conducted by the government find artisanal miners more than reluctant to provide detailed production figures (Tadess 2015: 34). Aside from being distant from administrative data collection, the sharp, unpredictable fluctuations in productivity make even estimates a fleeting task: the 2013 survey suggests that a single miner in the region produces between 1 and 5 grams of gold per month (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 68); a 2010 study on Menge *wereda* found, from a sample of 130 households, an average monthly production of 1.8 grams (Birrie 2010: 66).

In any case, the low volume and unpredictable outcome of gold mining do not make it a dependable source of income, and most households appear to earn no more than the bare minimum needed to sustain the household. However, there is a significant difficulty in confirming this observation, as the limited number of studies conducted rarely related to each other's analytical categories and figures.

The overall income and expenditure levels can be considered quite low. A 2004 study cited in the GERD ESIA reported that the annual cash income of households in seven weredas, derived from crops, livestock, and off-farm income, was insufficient to cover production inputs, government taxes, and other expenses (GERD 2012: 20). The 2016 household survey divided households into country-wide expenditure quintiles and observed that 30.7% of households in BGS fall into the lowest quintile, earning 5379.48 birr or less per year, while another 20.8% are in the second quintile, earning up to 7688.06 birr annually; when counted individually, this rises to 40.7% and 22.3%, respectively, indicating that 63% of households have expenditure levels comparable to the bottom 40% nationally. Although the latter survey provided detailed insights into household expenditure composition, it offers limited understanding of the relationship between various income-generating activities.

The 2015 study on artisanal miners examined the issue through observations and discussions at the level of individual miners, estimating on a monthly basis: “quantity of mineral produced per month, number of working days in a month, number of months worked in a year and total sales of mineral during the month” (Tadess 2015: 34).⁵³ Among different gold-producing areas, the average annual income was lowest in BSG, at 4,800 birr, with additional sources of income such as agriculture and petty trade contributing only 9% and 8% to the total. The fact that the average landholding per miner was nowhere higher than in BSG (2.5 ha) completes the picture of poor households with very low productivity, relying on highly volatile income from mining that they still depend on for even basic needs—especially if agriculture cannot provide enough food and purchasing is necessary (Tadess 2015: 18, 34). The study's final comment that “a considerable number of miners have improved their lives: they have constructed modern houses and developed good household capital” (Tadess 2015: 35) seems to refer to other regions apart from BSG, or at least only a very small part of the mining communities. Whether another observation—the high occurrence of alcohol consumption and prostitution—applies to the region remains unclear as well.

⁵³ In Menge, just as in southern Blue Nile, a week was effectively the measure of production, here corresponding to a working week from Sunday to Friday, followed by a weekend when miners want to take their earnings home (Birrie 2010: 65).

The study also observed a continuing shift away from agriculture, which aligns with previous observations that both encouragement by the national government and agricultural crises in many densely populated areas drove people towards artisanal mining. Moreover, the way the sector functioned meant that most of this mining remained outside official channels for gold distribution.

There also appears to be a temporal aspect to these shifts. The most evident one is seasonal, as the lack of water during the dry season and the lean season defined the periods of the year when mining was both most feasible and most necessary. A medium-term change related to the physical nature of the deposits, in form of a shift from surface mining to deeper layers, which also altered the organisation of labour. A less obvious temporal variation involves longer periods during which conflict and regional and global trade dynamics lead to waves of mining activities that either complement or conflict with the more permanent artisan production. These dynamics are the focus of the remainder of the report.

Locations and labour

Gold is mined in all three zonal administrations of the Benishangul-Gumuz region, and apart from Pawe *woreda*, all the remaining 19 *woredas* produce gold. However, the areas bordering Sudan and South Sudan — including Mao Komo, Guba, Dangur, Assosa, Kurmuk, Sherkole, Menge, Homosho, and Oda Buldigilu *woredas* — are where gold mining and trade are most active.⁵⁴ The latter six are all located in Assosa Zone and belong to the Western Greenstone Belt (Tadess 2015: 10). When compared to 1997 (see below), they overlap with, but also expand beyond, the mining sites from that period.

Table: Mining sites in Assosa Zone in 1997

Woreda	Kebele / river
Kurmuk	Dul hode, Duta worke, Azale, Dul shetalo
Gizen	
Sherkole	
Menge	Menge river
Oda Godere	Tumat river

Source: BSG Mining and Energy Department, 1997 (quoted after FDRE, Ethiopian Roads Authority 2001: 42)

The most common type of gold sought in these areas is alluvial gold, so exploration typically follows streams, valleys, and catchments. An exploration strategy based on prioritising specific locations around occasional finds to locate deposits shifted, as early as 2015, to a more random process of trial and error, often crossing boundaries between kebeles or even woredas; at that time, an estimated 110,950 miners were active, and this number is expected to have increased since then, along with the extent of mining areas

⁵⁴ Interview with official of the Asosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020.

(Tadess 2015: 23). In BSG, surface placer mining remained common, involving the washing of river sands, but a gradual move towards underground mining has been observed, with more emphasis on digging shafts to access ores (Tadess 2015: 26).

There was a proper mining season, just before the rainy season (February-April), but it extended into the rainy season when water would be more available and students went into holidays. Since these months are also the hottest of the year, working hours were in the morning and late afternoon (Tadess 2015: 26). Few people would do this for more than six months, and only an estimated 15% worked throughout the year; the repetitive work with slow returns did not sustain all miners for long, and critical shortages and the harsh environment of the mining sites also discouraged long stays. For seasonal miners, the agricultural phases defined the time they could dedicate to mining (Tadess 2015: 29).

The specific rhythm and organisation of labour varied based on personal circumstances and goals, as well as the communal and physical structures of the operation. Changes over the past decades include a shift from family-based planning with widespread participation of women, children, and elders to individual efforts or groups of men digging shafts.

Assessments until the early 2010s mostly highlighted the former picture. Within the mining communities, mining was primarily carried out by the physically fit generation, aged between 18 and 45 years, although several family members also worked there, with 5% of children in the zones of Assosa and Metekel (FDRE, Ethiopian Roads Authority 2001: 42). On one hand, the high percentage of young people reflected the age structure of the state's population pyramid, with a base of 0-9 years that was more than twice as large as the 10-14 age group, and 55.7% were 19 years or younger (FDRE, Central Statistical Agency 2018). On the other hand, the involvement of school-aged children contributed to the ongoing high illiteracy rates. Benishangul-Gumuz saw an increase in the Primary Gross Enrolment Rate from 35.4% in 1994/95 to 88.8% in 2015/2016, but this did little to improve literacy levels, which remained around 10% in Gubba and Sherkole, and about 20% in Kurmuk (EUTF 2016: 7). In fact, enrolment rates among the so-called indigenous groups were closer to 50%, even after the number of schools teaching in their mother tongue increased to 299 in 2015, covering 78,140 children (EUTF 2016: 8). The 2016 household survey found that illiteracy rates continued to be high in rural BGS, at 61.4%.

Unlike other states such as SSNPR, Amhara, Tigray, and, less clearly, Oromia, 65-70% of women participated in the operations, although most of the digging was carried out by men. The division of labour was widely described as men typically handling digging and ore extraction, especially in the case of hard rock, while women engaged in washing and support services. Women also took on the tasks of fetching water, drawing soil from pits, and transporting ore to washing sites (Tadess 2015: 26-27; GERD 2012: 21).

Although women often handled the final extraction of gold, there was a gender disparity in mining income. A 2010 public finance review for BSG, for example, cited a government study on poverty from the mid-1990s to the mid-2000s that found husbands and fathers controlling the earnings of women in mining (Kidane & Alemu 2010: 20). The 2013 survey showed that men's income from mining was twice that of women's (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 69). Gender gaps were also visible elsewhere, such as in health

indicators and the impact of healthcare deficiencies; poor nutritional and reproductive health has long been among the most severe in the region (Kidane & Alemu 2010: 20).

It should be noted that the 2016 household survey challenged these findings, as both household income and expenditure were depicted as gender-balanced, with men contributing slightly more to income in lower expenditure households. Overall, health data was also comparable to or better than the national average, except for infant mortality, children's health, and gender empowerment, measured by household labour division and the incidence of domestic violence (see comparison in Nutrition Profile 2018 published by Alive & Thrive). In any case, the combination of task responsibilities and infrastructural shortcomings created increased vulnerability: mining communities mainly consisted of women who were not only central to agriculture, food production and distribution but also bore the brunt of household chores. Despite these responsibilities, they had limited access to land ownership and control over resources (EUTF 2016: 11).

The placement of mining activities—far from water sources and healthcare—has also increased the burden on women's child-rearing responsibilities. Governmental sources reported that in 2015/2016, Benishangul-Gumuz had 407 health posts, 45 clinics, and 6 basic healthcare services, leading to a 92% institutional coverage, with a rate of 1 physician per 41,414 people and 1 nurse per 1,022 people (EUTF 2016: 8). A 2013 health facility map by OCHA showed mining areas lacking any health facilities—specifically Sherkole and Kurmuk *woredas* and all of the Gubba *woreda*. As a consequence, some women left even newborns at home when going mining (GERD 2012: 21).⁵⁵

However, this participation has been significantly declining due to several factors that have made the work even more arduous. A 2010 study of 130 mining households in Menge *woreda* found that 40% of them had family members involved in mining, most of whom were school-aged children taken out of school by their families during peak season (Birle 2010: 61-62). By 2013, participation by both elders and children was markedly decreasing, coinciding with a decline in surface gold yields. Similar reasons were identified behind the reduced participation of women: not only rock mining but also the increasing distance between home and mining site added to the physical demands on miners, and the previously overlapping roles at both sites became less and less sustainable (Tadess 2015: 18).⁵⁶

In a way, government policies and societal dynamics moved in a similar direction: encouraging young adults to engage in short-term enterprises and changing physical conditions of gold mining sidelined other age groups and women who were household-bound. Since no economic alternative emerged, both reliance on gold mining and women's dependence on income earned by men were likely to increase.

⁵⁵ Plans to address women's situation in mining areas were already made in the late 1990s, but even then little optimism existed that they would be implemented or make a significant difference (Young 1999: 339-340).

⁵⁶ This also includes some techniques used to compensate for shortcomings at the mining site. Miners in Menge *woreda*, for example, were observed to bring alluvial sands home during the dry season to wash them using the water supplied there (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 68).

Mining across the border

Local crossings

This and the following section will revisit insights on cross-border dynamics and trace the presence of non-Ethiopians, specifically Sudanese, at mining sites in the *woredas* of Menge and Sherkole. It will relate these aspects to conflict dynamics, trade links, and social ties that are relevant to both.

All studies discussed so far have focused on recent artisanal gold-mining in Benishangul-Gumuz as an activity carried out by Ethiopians. In fact, Ethiopia's protectionist legal framework still permitted non-Ethiopians to engage in licensed artisanal mining provided they register as a cooperative society or, since 2013, as a small or microenterprise (2010 Mining Operations Proclamation, Art. 11/3c). General assessments of the situation in the region revealed that BSG was notably different from other mining areas, with an extremely low percentage of migrants (4.5%), meaning those who were neither born nor resided in the *woreda* where they mined; most of them came from neighbouring *woredas* (Tadess 2015: 19-20). As will be shown, this may well be due to a statistical fallacy within the official perspective.

Our own research into developments over the last two decades indicates that miners' cross-border mobility was, historically, normal, and was both increased and restricted in different regions during times of armed conflict. Since the late 2010s, technological innovation has accelerated, increasing the rate of surface resource depletion and intensifying competition for the remaining resources. This, in turn, has led to more exclusionary tendencies against non-residents in recent years.

Far from being universal, the level of social embeddedness played a significant role in how arrangements with residents functioned. A Sudanese individual with family ties in southern BSG, for example, became involved in gold mining while visiting his maternal uncle. However, this occurred within the existing structure, and he was required to join the *kebele's* cooperative, as "they don't want somebody just to hang around".⁵⁷

Sudanese miners crossing into Gumuz areas in northern BSG, however, experienced much harsher treatment over the years. The technological innovations that powered the gold rush in Sudan – metal detectors, engine-driven sieves, stone crushers, mercury – slowly appeared in Benishangul-Gumuz's mining areas as well, starting around 2010, carried in from Sudan. Initially, the Sudanese owner would cross over with the detector, agree with local residents on a share, and do most of the work. Since the ratio of pure surface gold was comparatively high, this was a profitable arrangement for all.⁵⁸

⁵⁷ It should also not be forgotten that cooperatives are mainly formalised extensions of communal service practices already existing, and will, as they do, take numerous different forms and conventional solutions to organisational problems (for Metekkel, see Etefa 2006: 118-120).

⁵⁸ Interview with goldsmith in Belguwa, 7 August 2019.

However, alongside increased familiarity and independence of Ethiopian miners with these technologies, as well as likely diminishing discoveries, the situation for Sudanese miners and investors became more unstable, aligning with the Ethiopian government's heightened focus on this resource. Sudanese familiar with lenient arrangements in Ethiopia's Gumuz areas found themselves increasingly pressured into less favourable terms; higher shares and exclusive access to the mine for the landowning community meant that the Sudanese owner of a metal detector could now be easily cheated or even excluded. Local leaders could now enforce—despite the risk of alerting Ethiopian military intelligence—a division into thirds among themselves, the Sudanese metal detector owners, and labourers from their own community. Furthermore, the metal detector could be seized—often for less than its market value—from the Sudanese, whose position was weakened by their 'illegal' status, thereby maximising their own economic gain.

This development seems to have happened in many ways: a miner, living in Omdurman's Thawra 17 neighbourhood, recounted how he began working with a metal detector in Gumuz areas in Ethiopia after previous experiences in South Kordofan, Northern State, and Egypt. Unlike earlier arrangements, he found Gumuz communities enforcing a policy requiring him to use the device they had obtained, in exchange for a third of the profits. In another instance, the collected material was not processed together with the outsider, who then had to accept whatever share was claimed to be his from the overall haul.⁵⁹

In late 2019, several interviewed miners had ceased going to Ethiopia for mining altogether, citing numerous instances where Sudanese workers had been pushed out or exploited, often being threatened with being handed over to Ethiopia's state authorities. Sudanese were often consulted when problems arose but were generally excluded from most operations. As a result, activities that were once normal for investors, like searching with a metal detector, have become risky and clandestine, involving self-assured or even patronising partners.⁶⁰

What might appear as an opportunistic move, however, was less drastic than the complete ban on artisanal mining by foreigners in Blue Nile State, announced in October 2016 by the Sudanese Mineral Resource Company (SMRC), the regulatory authority of the Ministry of Mining. The increased concentration of gold and the improved technical standards introduced by metal detectors attracted Ethiopians and South Sudanese, who officially took on 'presentable' roles in the sector, such as service personnel, selling tea or serving meals. Nevertheless, covert labour and arrangements with local officials continued to bring them to the mines, just as some Sudanese persisted in taking their detectors across the border illegally to search for surface gold. The ban also did not prevent 'Sudanese' Ethiopians, who frequently came and went—some with two passports, partial residence, or even property in Sudan—or border-crossing groups like the Berta and Gumuz. It was also at odds with the situation of many Sudanese with a significant

⁵⁹ Interview with prospector in Belguwa, 7 August 2019.

⁶⁰ Interview with resident in Qeissan, 26 November 2019. This even extends to the families in Sudan who will admonish those who crossed over for mining (interview with driver in Qeissan, 24 November 2019).

presence elsewhere in Ethiopia, such as Assosa or Bahir Dar, where they were involved in sectors like construction, charcoal-making, and gold mining.⁶¹

In fact, the social boundaries and ties extending beyond national borders also applied here. A group of miners from Amhara Region compared their treatment in other areas – such as Northern State – with the situation in Blue Nile State, where it was illegal for them to work in mining regardless of their administrative status. The strongest refusal they faced – whether in Ethiopia or in Sudan – was in Gumuz areas, where, according to them, they could be killed if caught searching for gold. However, working in other areas of Sudan since 2009 was, despite occasional issues with authorities, preferable to them compared to the restrictive system in Ethiopia, which had a limited licensing process requiring at least six persons to register together for a single location and forbade them from working in Sudan as well.⁶²

To explore these cross-border dynamics further, our research team examined two mining sites in Ethiopia, near Qeissan and Kurmuk, respectively.⁶³ The site visits and accompanying interviews confirmed this mixture of normalised and precarious presence of Sudanese as well.

In these areas, Berta were generally regarded as the traditional miners whose economy and skills are built around this activity.⁶⁴ When miners in Melahu spoke of the presence of many Sudanese labourers there,⁶⁵ this therefore had a rather blurry meaning: were Berta relatives from across the border meant, or miners from other regions, or the refugees who had remained in Ethiopia for more than 20 years and engaged in gold mining—illegal but locally tolerated as knowledgeable co-workers?

In any case, their shared characteristic was the risk of expulsion if discovered, a risk that materialised variably: an illegal miner from South Kordofan who had been in Melahu for nearly a year noted that not only had his administrative status never been challenged during this period, but he also felt welcomed by the local residents. Just a month later, another miner observed a decline in the number of Sudanese labourers due to expulsions.⁶⁶

⁶¹ Interview with miner from Metemma in Damazin, 13 November 2019.

⁶² Interview with group of miners from Amhara in Damazin, 15 November 2019.

⁶³ The two sites that were visited by Tsegaye Birhanu were Melahu in *woreda* Sherkole (closest to Sherkole Town, direct road connection to Qeisaan, also to Assosa via Menge), and Dulshatalo in *woreda* Kurmuk (closest to Hor Azahab Town, direct road connection to Kurmuk and Assosa).

⁶⁴ Interview with official of the Benishangul-Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, 12 February 2020; interview with Mining Team Leader at Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020.

⁶⁵ Interview with gold washer in Melahu, 18 February 2020.

⁶⁶ Interview with Sudanese miner in Melahu, 18 February 2020; interview with miner from Melahu in Assosa, 10 March 2020.

The fact that mostly unlicensed stone crushers from Sudan were widely used indicated the existence of unofficial alternatives to import and the licensing system it is based on.⁶⁷ At the same time, obstacles to mobility with machinery and tools led to a much lower level of mechanisation. Similar to the mining sites in the Qeissan area, the mines were situated in poorly accessible areas without paved roads or telecommunication networks; electricity was supplied only by generators. Transport was even more challenging, though, in the absence of motorised vehicles or even pack animals; a miner at the Dulshatalo production sites in Kurmuk *woreda* described how they carried crushed ore on their shoulders for 40 minutes to the mills.⁶⁸ In Melahu, the operations also remained largely manual, and it was common for shafts to reach 40 metres by digging, with only a few having access to jackhammers powered by generators.

The aforementioned licensing scheme categorised gold miners into unlicensed individuals and licensed entities, particularly small- or large-scale special producers, and private companies.⁶⁹ But in sparsely populated areas with a high level of mining activities, cooperatives remained the main form of local government attempts to extend control over the extractive activity. Some of these entities specifically targeted local development, such as cooperatives for unemployed youth organised by a government revolving fund.⁷⁰

Sherkole, the *woreda* directly south of Qeissan, was almost exclusively inhabited by Berta and highly specialised in gold mining, with no significant farming activities in any of its 19 *kebeles*. School children often dropped out to enter the workforce.⁷¹ With a total population of approximately 25,000, each of the 19 administrative units had its own gold producer cooperative, licensed at the regional level by the Mining Agency with a concession of 2 hectares of land for exploration and production.⁷²

⁶⁷ Interview with official of the Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020; interview with Sudanese miner in Melahu, 18 February 2020; interview with miner from Melahu in Assosa, 10 March 2020. A mechanic selling and working repairs of gold production equipment across Assosa *woreda* clearly stated that he acquired most of them from Sudan via Qeissan; he had learnt the trade from his father (interview with trader and mechanic of gold mining equipment, 24 February 2020).

⁶⁸ Interview with miner of Duleshatalo in Assosa, 11 March 2020.

⁶⁹ In fact, if licensed small-scale producers successfully pass a review of an annual audit report, they can be designated as small-scale special producers, which allows them to import gold production equipment duty-free (interview with official of the Benishangul-Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, 26 February 2020).

⁷⁰ Interview with official of the Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020.

⁷¹ One interviewee indicated that a weed problem had diminished agricultural activities in Kurmuk, Sherkole, and Menge *woredas*, further increasing reliance on gold mining and the purchase of food items from nearby production areas such as Assosa, Homosha, and Oda. *woredas* (interview with trader and miner, 11 March 2020).

⁷² Interview with official of the Sherkole Mining Office, 18 February 2020; interview with official of the Benishangul-Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, 26 February 2020. Melahu had even six cooperatives active side by side, as the most important employer in the area (interview with miner from Melahu in Assosa, 10 March 2020).

These organisational forms were also meant to regulate operational details, such as the use of chemicals. Gold washing was recently transformed by the introduction of mercury, and, legally, individual artisanal miners were still not permitted to use chemicals in the washing process; this privilege was restricted to licensed cooperatives.⁷³ Effectively, this could not be enforced due to limited monitoring capacities, and the practice might even cause worse environmental damage than in the Sudanese counterpart, as much of the gold washing occurs in flowing water, such as Tumet River in Melahu, a tributary of the Blue Nile.⁷⁴ Since the gendering of tasks followed similar patterns, with women remaining the most active in the washing process, this also meant that health effects of mercury use were gendered accordingly.

Despite administrative measures aimed at integrating a self-directed communal economy with national institutions, the main flow of means of production into Ethiopia and of the commodity back to Sudan has not been significantly interrupted; only ownership structures have shifted. Although participation in such cooperatives remained, legally, an individual choice for Ethiopians, several Sudanese miners reported here that they had no choice but to join these cooperatives as a communal representative body that, similar to the mining committees in Sudan, also regulated the payment of shares.

The key to understanding this differential treatment thus lies in the strength and limitations of communal ties, which are simultaneously at odds, in competition, and instrumentalised within the framework of central governments' attempts to increase state control while also decreasing conflict potential—something that may backfire, and has done so in the past. An official of Benishangul-Gumuz's Mining Agency clearly articulated this tense contradiction between administrative and communal rules: the close relationship between Sudanese labourers and communities in Ethiopia allows them to cross borders and work without official impediments; they simply will not be known to the immigration authorities, yet they can be punished if apprehended by these authorities.⁷⁵

It should be remembered, though, that within Ethiopia's ethnopolitics, the same applies to Ethiopian highlanders who are not permitted to mine or work in the gold mining areas. In fact, it was easier for 'Sudanese' to bypass the prohibition due to cultural, religious, and linguistic ties to the local inhabitants than for 'Ethiopians' from the highlands, who are physically and culturally more distinct.

The description of actors by their administrative nationality can therefore be misleading, as being Sudanese or Ethiopian can often be a situational identification that best fits what actors want or are willing to allow. It also overlooks an essential aspect in this context, namely that belonging is both a limitation and a resource: Berta, as administrative

⁷³ Interview with Mining Team Leader at Asosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020.

⁷⁴ Interview with official of the Benishangul-Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, 26 February 2020. In fact, a miner in Melahu stated that they acquired mercury from Sudan, thereby bypassing any regulatory system existing in Ethiopia (interview with gold washer in Melahu, 18 February 2020).

⁷⁵ Interview with official of the Benishangul-Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, 25 February 2020.

Ethiopians, can utilise their country's governmental apparatus to gain an advantage over Sudanese, while also making use of their social ties when crossing to visit their families on the other side, carrying goods that the same governmental apparatus prohibited from being exported this way. A closer examination of these market relations beyond state borders is quite revealing in that regard.

Refugees and environments

Another aspect is that focusing on people's origin can conceal the combined effect of similar behaviour by prompting interventions that have, at best, a partial impact. A case in point is deforestation in Benishangul-Gumuz, which has been linked to the presence of refugees since the 1990s, while it was caused, "more significantly, by increasing domestic demands as a result of high population growth in a savanna zone with limited wood fibre" (Young 1999: 339). Deforestation was, furthermore, a general trend at both the national and regional levels, and the former regional president Yaregal Aysheshim made it a public issue in 2007 when launching the planting of 1.5 million seedlings as part of a national tree-planting initiative (FDRE, Environmental Protection Authority 2012: 36-37; UNDP Ethiopia 2017: 5, 9). In fact, manifold conventional uses of wood contributed to the accelerating deforestation, not just clearing forests for slash-and-burn and commercial farming but also medicinal practices, many based on roots of trees (EUTF 2016: 19; Flatie et al. 2009 on medicinal plants). In this, there was much overlap with the Sudanese part of the borderlands where burning forests and cutting trees for farming, incense, and charcoal production were just as prevalent (EUTF 2016: 18-19).

The administrative fixed definition of a population resident in the area for decades as 'refugees' limited the wider impacts of deforestation initiatives. UNHCR, for example, addressed the lack of shelter and energy in Gure-Shembola and Tsore refugee camps in BSG. The latter meant that domestic energy needs were met by using forests, with an average of 4kg of wood per person per day. The intervention involved planting 65,000 trees in deforested areas and producing charcoal briquettes, clay stoves, and communal kitchens. Alternative income-generating activities were proposed within Ethiopia's Livelihoods and Economic Inclusion Strategy 2020-2021 (UNHCR Ethiopia 2020: 2-3), which was also relevant to deforestation since wood collection was a source of income. However, the intervention lacked an enabling environment: it did not compensate for limited access to land and other forms of socio-economic integration, nor did it consider the broader dynamics of deforestation.

Another environmental concern relates to mining sites. The discrepancy between administrative permission frameworks and actual needs often resulted in what authorities described as informal or even illegal activities. 'Sudanese refugees', many of whom did not see an immediate future in Sudan nor valued their recent past there, became involved in gold mining in various areas, including the sites north of Menge, where they could encounter other 'Sudanese' coming via Qeissan and its hinterland. Their role was so established that local miners would ask for mechanics by name at camps such as Tsore to assist them, and ARRA staff, legally tasked with preventing refugees from mining, seemed to at least tolerate it (Vaughan et al. 2019: 24). In essence, refugees' semi-

regulated labour fulfilled local needs rather than refugee employment as envisaged in programmes like the ‘Ethiopian Jobs Compact’, but it also proved more unstable as territorial sensitivities among miners—although rarely erupting into violence—made refugees’ acceptance dependent on various socio-political aspects.

In any case, these refugees differed little in this ‘transgression’ of their status from other former residents of Blue Nile State; many who lived in refugee camps in Ethiopia and South Sudan also crossed into the land they had fled to earn a small but vital income from gold mining that brought them a few grams of gold. Managed by a mine supervisor of the SPLM-N administration, the mining sites at the Yabus River, which flows through all three countries, produced gold that mostly ended up in markets beyond the Ethiopian border (NR 2014).

Refugees’ extractive activities were invariably mixed with the gold mining of ‘regular citizens’ at these sites, sharing the environmental impact with them. They were not necessarily passive recipients of local conventions; in fact, the use of mercury, still quite rare in the early 2010s (Tadess 2015: 38; FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 69), has recently increased, often linked to miners who had previously worked with it in Sudan. Legal requirements mandated that even artisan miners undergo brief environmental assessments, refill shafts, and replant trees after operations, while the use of machinery and chemicals was restricted to registered cooperatives and enterprises (Tadess 2015: 37). Any larger operation required a comprehensive Environmental Impact Assessment, a regulation in place since 1993. Nevertheless, a review of ESIA implementation in BSG in 2015 revealed numerous guidelines and institutions but little political commitment or resources for enforcement (EnDev 2015: 39-41). Officials did not make substantially different statements about the situation in 2020. Meanwhile, mining areas continued to be focal points of depleted forests and farmland, erosion, and vast landscapes of unfilled pits (Tadess 2015: 37). Open waters would be polluted by chemical agents, following the torrents of the rainy season into interconnected watersheds beyond political borders.

In both cases, the administrative frameworks for environmental protection failed to materialise in a meaningful way. The lack of viable alternatives meant that simple counter-measures – criminalisation, protectionism, demarcations, partial target groups, etc. – were not only insubstantial but also lacked support from those expected to uphold them, whether residents or local officials. Historical dynamics indicate that the borderland population will continue to seek solutions to their everyday survival problems wherever possible, as this is their priority, not the enforcement of borderlines.

Paths of gold trade

License and legality

In the 1930s, British colonial administrators intervened in the grain trade in the then Southern Funj district, around the rivers Yabus, Tombak, and Ahmar. The hierarchies of enslavement had left their mark in unequal trade relations between the resident populations – Maban, Uduk, and others – and Berta and Watawit traders, who bought grain using jewellery and salt. In a mix of protectionism and promotion of cash economy, the administrators banned this trade and assigned petty traders, jellaba, to villages. But the planned diversion of trade into official markets – particularly to Kurmuk – was hindered by infrastructural shortcomings, such as the shortage of donkeys for transport (Wedderburn-Maxwell 1936: 183).

Looking at trade relations in the late 2010s, this sounds very familiar, not just because donkeys remained the main means of transport for goods in this area, but also because official ideas about how trade should operate and how it can work continued to be at odds. Moving forward a few decades to the 1970s, petty traders can be seen as one of the most active groups engaged in cross-border mobility, as they “often le[ft] their families and move[d] from market to market and village to village on animal backs without any regard to the political boundary” (Nur 1971: 158). They joined the daily movements of farmers tending to their fields, interrupted by borders, pastoralists following the presence of waterholes, housewives carrying water from better sources, relatives visiting their kin or in-laws, and impoverished people fleeing taxation or debts (Nur 1971: 158).

While official trade followed the Gondar-Kurmuk route, connected to the border regime, petty trade and trade that was concealed from regional agents of central governments used these pathways, which predated border demarcation (Nur 1971: 195). This kind of trade was so deeply woven into the social fabric of the borderland that in some villages, one fifth of the population were traders. They developed a high level of organisation, utilising a creative mix of official status and unofficial trade, which is important to note: “By possessing trade licences, people who can legally claim themselves to be traders or merchants, can store large amounts of coffee, durra and wax to be eventually smuggled to and fro across the political boundary” (Nur 1971: 196).

During that period, the Sudanese currency was preferred on both sides, as it was – in contrast to the Ethiopian dollar – a means of exchange not just in official but also in unofficial markets as far as Asmara and Tasseni. The main exchange route through Benishangul, which created a link between Sudanese production areas and the Ethiopian highlands, involved the transfer of cotton and sorghum to Ethiopia in exchange for coffee and honey (Nur 1971: 157-176). Jewellery often moved from Ethiopia to Sudan via other trades: Ethiopian workers would purchase mainly gold jewellery with the money they earned in urban centres in Sudan and carry it back home as accessories to be sold in Ethiopian towns (Nur 1971: 193). The route of the journey from the highlands into Sudan followed familiar patterns of creative adaptation (Nur 1971: 196-197):

[She] usually begins her journey from Eritrea or Ethiopia by buses and lorries into the frontier towns and villages on the Ethiopian side of the international boundary. She then crosses the political boundary by animal back or on foot disguised as a Sudanese local woman. Once on the Sudan side of the boundary she can take several means of transportation to Kassala, Gedaref and Kashm el Girba towns where she concentrates upon learning as much Arabic as possible and then finds her way to the larger towns in Wadi Medani, Khartoum, Umdorman and Port Sudan.

The way gold reached Ethiopia again highlights one of the main current tactics for exporting gold from the country, exemplified by heavily gold-laden women at Khartoum Airport. The fact that only – almost exclusively licensed – goldsmiths can bring gold in such ‘acceptable’ forms underscores the complex relationship between legal and illegal movements in both directions: in the late 1990s, unlicensed Berta goldsmiths were observed forming simple rings from gold nuggets to be taken by traders to markets in Sudanese and Ethiopian towns, where the rings would be bought by licensed jewellers operating shops there (Young 1999: 339-340).⁷⁶

The main focus of policies against this unregulated cross-border gold trade as ‘smuggling’ has developed over recent decades. Initially, unregulated trade was common or at least a minor offence. It became a concern only when higher market prices and a more capitalist view of resources made the traded gold appealing to the central government. One trader, for example, reflected on the changes from the late 1980s, when he started trading gold, to the beginning of regulations in 2010: before regulation, the price of gold was generally low, around 50 birr per gram, and he operated freely. When the requirement was introduced to sell to NBE agents, while production and gold prices increased substantially, he had to obtain a license.⁷⁷

In the 2000s, with a steadily growing interest in regulating trade, efforts were made to streamline distribution into a standardised value chain connecting miners through licensed brokers to Gold Purchasing Centres (GPC), which acted as agents for the National Bank of Ethiopia. The involvement of brokers or cooperatives was essential – and ensured – since a minimum of 250g was now required for gold purchases; in fact, individual miners were explicitly excluded from direct contact with the GPC. The licensee demonstrated their commitment to this value chain by paying taxes to the Regional Revenue Authority, which had to confirm this payment before a license could be renewed (World Bank 2016: 84). However, this only secured a closed loop for gold actually distributed through the official channel, not control over its numerous alternatives.

A rare study of this specific value chain in Menge *woreda* during the late 2000s, for instance, still treated it as the only existing one, preceding several artisanal mining studies that remained silent – or at least vague – on the routes leading to neighbouring Sudan. In this idealised exchange network, eight market points connected artisanal miners with the

⁷⁶ This local goldsmithery appears to be an old craft, as rings of gold used as currency were reported for Wellaga and Benishangul at least since the late 19th century (Pankhurst 1962: 241).

⁷⁷ Interview with senior licensed gold trader in Assosa, 24 February 2020. Another step was to reduce the minimum saleable amount to 50g of gold to include small-scale traders (interview with Mining Team Leader at Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020).

National Bank of Ethiopia, linked to the global market, with an average price increase of 9.65 birr/g of gold per transaction, accumulating to an average of 67.25 birr/g: production site - village market - Shegol market - Menge market - Assosa market - Addis Ababa - NBE (Birrie 2010 2010: 69).

As shown in the previous chapter, submissions to the NBE declined sharply after a peak up to 2014, with total gold purchases by the bank across Ethiopia reaching 8,328 kg in 2011/12 and 8,387 kg in 2012/13 (Tadess 2015: 36). While there is ultimately no way to connect this either to reduced compliance or lower production, studies on artisanal mining in the mid-2010s indicated that only 39% of total production was being processed through official channels at that time (Tadess 2015: 4). Alternative suggested endpoints before export included retailers in Addis Ababa, foreign tourists, and others travelling abroad (Tadess 2015: 30).⁷⁸

It is interesting to note, however, that BSG was listed as the only region where estimated 2014 production, 1,065 kg, was close to — actually below — the NBE purchases in Assosa for the same year, 1,088.5 kg (Tadess 2015: 30-31). Nonetheless, although transactions have been subject to taxation and royalties at least since the Precious Mineral Transaction Proclamation No. 651/2001 (replaced by Ethiopian Transaction of Minerals Ratification Proclamation No. 1144/2019), this does not necessarily entail a direct engagement with tax authorities. The gap between collectable royalties (based on officially traded gold) and actually collected royalties for the same year was 3,919,481 birr (Tadess 2015: 36).

A 2016 World Bank assessment of the mining sector still reported a strong functioning of the official value chain and quoted a jeweller saying only 2-3% of produced gold was traded ‘illicitly’, a rate suspected to decrease with the opening of more GPC branches that saved the long trip to the capital (World Bank 2016: p. 84). However, this officially claimed efficiency of the system was questioned by other figures, and alternative trade routes used by both licensed and unlicensed buyers were widely known to exist (FDRE, Ministry of Mines & World Bank 2014: 69).

In 2020, officials of the Mining Agency in BSG and local mining offices could only suspect that actual gold production was constantly increasing but that most of the gold ended up in cross-border markets through parallel market exchanges and smuggling. This appeared to be a recent trend, as in 2012, shortly after heavier machinery was introduced, still 700 kg of gold was sold to the NBE from Assosa *woreda*, with decreasing amounts since then, parallel to the increase in mining activity using better equipment mostly brought in unlicensed from Sudan.⁷⁹

⁷⁸ See also the figure on p. 32, which features a simplified diagram illustrating the parallel operation of legal and illegal producers, collectors, and ultimate purchasers, all ultimately feeding into export. Brokers are suggested to be essential transitional actors between both legal spheres (Tadess 2015: 32).

⁷⁹ Interview with official of the Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020. In 2019/2020, the planned gold production in this *woreda* was 500 kg, but the half-year report showed only 14.15 kg sold through official channels (interview with Mining Team Leader at Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020). In Sherkole, planned output was 100 kg, with less

A short look at the relation between trade licenses and gold sales to the National Bank of Ethiopia shows that only the former have been adopted by traders:

Table: Actual sales to National Bank of Ethiopia compared to number of licensed gold traders in Benishangul-Gumuz region

Year	Actual sales to NBE (in kg)	Licensed traders
July 2015-June 2016	985.9	10
July 2016-June 2017	406.0	19
July 2017-June 2018	43.9	29
July 2018-June 2019	54.3	42

Source: Benishangul Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, February 2020

The data clearly indicates that issued licenses increased annually, while gold sales to the NBE declined significantly. A similar trend is observed with mining licenses: the financial year with the highest output, 2015/16, actually had only 2 licensed special small-scale producers permitted to operate heavy machinery, compared to 13 licensed artisanal miners or cooperatives allowed only manual work. Preliminary figures from the 2019/2020 fiscal year show a similar pattern with 90 licensed producers, including 17 specialised small-scale ones, which should have boosted gold production and sales to well over the planned 1 tonne. The fact that most of the gold does not go through official channels — even licensed miners and traders often do not fully comply with their license conditions — suggests that the practical difference between licensed and unlicensed work remains quite limited.⁸⁰

Given this historical persistence, in which forms of state control were incorporated into cross-border trade rather than replacing it, a deeper understanding of why governmental schemes to ‘streamline’ gold trade failed lies in a more accurate, less assumption-driven observation of how exchange relations function in the borderlands.

than 2kg officially reported until February 2020 (interview with official of the Sherkole Mining Office, 18 February 2020).

⁸⁰ Informal conversations with SMRC officials stationed in different markets in Blue Nile state revealed that the gold passing through official channels was already there only about 6% of the overall output of the state’s main mining areas, according to estimates gathered during fieldwork (Al-Damazin, November/December 2019).

Production and profits

The trade of gold from Benishangul's mining areas took place at various levels, beginning with individual exchanges between miners and traders at the mining sites, then extending to markets in nearby villages and local centres such as Sherkole Town, and further to the goldsmiths in Assosa or across the border to Qeissan and Kurmuk. There were also traders and even goldsmiths coming from Sudan to the mining sites and local markets, resulting in a situation where miners appeared to have no difficulty finding buyers, as observed in Melahu.⁸¹

In Qeissan, gold traders from Ethiopia were ubiquitous, especially during the biweekly market days, Sunday and Thursday.⁸² They would bring in gold – no other goods – to exchange it for money to buy goods, and then bring these back to the Ethiopian markets, profiting from the price difference between the markets.⁸³ Especially since the radical depreciation of the Sudanese pound began in 2018, the only relevant currencies in this exchange have been gold, the dollar, and the birr.⁸⁴ The exchange of goods for gold thus became an important method to bypass liquidity problems or incorporate them into business models.

Local interpretations of this situation vary and reflect how relations between the state and citizens are envisioned: several Sudanese in Qeissan believed that in Ethiopia, the trade of gold and carrying currency are generally forbidden and can lead to confiscation and imprisonment in Assosa, which makes smuggling through byroads into Sudan the 'smart choice'.⁸⁵ As has been demonstrated, this generalised illegality is not accurate, and an alternative explanation presents itself, which has significant implications for the relationship between local and global gold economies.

Vibrant exchange across the border can be attributed to a situation where the volume and quality of production on the Ethiopian side were superior, but the purchasing power and trade connections were stronger on the Sudanese side.⁸⁶ At the same time, the appeal of cross-border exchanges conflicted with restrictive trade regulations that still limited regular trade over the main roads to Qeissan and Kurmuk. These restrictions were further worsened by the lack of infrastructure for easy transport of bulk goods. Moving untaxed commodities across the border then appeared to be the 'smart choice', and this also

⁸¹ Interview with miner in Melahu, 18 February 2020.

⁸² Interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019.

⁸³ Interview with driver in Qeissan, 24 November 2019; interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019; interview with resident in Qeissan, 26 November 2019. Sudanese traders clearly perceived the one-sided nature of this exchange.

⁸⁴ Interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019. On 24 November 2019, the dollar was traded on average for 81.5 Sudanese pounds (SDG) on the unofficial market; on 18 April 2019, the exchange rate was still 53 SDG, amid significant fluctuations throughout the year (compare <https://al-ain.com/article/dollar-price-sudan-sunday-24-november-2019> and <https://al-ain.com/article/sudanese-pound-rises-black-market-bashir-isolation>).

⁸⁵ Interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019; interview with resident in Qeissan; 26 November 2019.

⁸⁶ One informant stated that the price difference per gram between 'Ethiopian' and 'Sudanese' gold was 500 SDG (interview with goldsmith in Belguwa, 7 August 2019).

explained the difference between slow trade through official border crossings in Kurmuk and Qeissan, and lively exchange at unofficial border markets such as Al-Deim, Menza, and, again, Qeissan.

However, the main explanation for the failure of NBE policies was viewed, by both officials and traders, in the price gap between the parallel market and the bank's incentive price.⁸⁷ It was not just that the gold price on the parallel market was higher, but also that smugglers paid in dollars while traders in Assosa and agents of the national bank paid in birr.⁸⁸ In other words, parallel market traders could jump between the local and the global market by using hard currency to profit from a price difference that benefited another parallel market, the one supplying dollars at a higher exchange rate and more easily than the national banks in both Ethiopia and Sudan.

The combined impact of the two alternative exchanges meant that the NBE price was significantly below what miners and middlemen expected to receive, expectations based on the dollar value of gold in the global market rather than the birr price the NBE calculated from it. One licensed trader in Benishangul clearly stated that they would be regarded as frauds by gold miners if they attempted to buy at NBE prices, ultimately being excluded from the market by smugglers willing to pay much higher prices, especially as the number of licensed traders and competitors was constantly rising.⁸⁹

This arrangement had structural resilience, as price increases by the NBE would merely result in a parallel rise in the parallel market.⁹⁰ This was not necessarily a conscious process, as several of the petty traders between the mining sites, village markets and licensed or cross-border traders showed themselves unaware of the way the gold will take after their transaction, and thus the price effects that go into the amount they can demand to receive.⁹¹

But it was also not solely about price; instead, the persistence of unofficial trade involved several conflicting dynamics that made not only the effectiveness but also the intentions of the supposedly unified 'official' apparatus more complicated. This is best demonstrated by areas in an administrative limbo, particularly when viewed within the

⁸⁷ Interview with official of the Benishangul-Gumuz Regional Mining Agency, 26 February 2020. In February 2020, this difference was about 200 birr per gram in Assosa *woreda* (interview with official of the Assosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020); others quoted differences up to 400 birr (interview with Mining Team Leader at Asosa Zone Mining Office, 13 February 2020; interview with senior licensed gold trader, 24 February 2020).

⁸⁸ Interview with senior licensed gold trader, 24 February 2020.

⁸⁹ Interview with gold trader, 24 February 2020.

⁹⁰ This was also connected to another structural problem: unlike Sudan, Ethiopia has no independent refinery and must send its gold to South Africa for this service (interview with gold trader, 24 February 2020).

⁹¹ Interview with trader and miner in Assosa, 11 March 2020. A detailed study on the achievement of a marketing margin by producers in Menge showed that older miners, who practised almost exclusively gold mining, among other characteristics, were in the best position to secure good prices (Birle 2010). Generally, a profit margin of 50 birr per gram for brokers in BSG was identified in a later study, with cooperatives and SMEs being better positioned to generate profits for producers (Tadess 2015: 34).

context of tightly bordered national states, such as the SPLM-N-controlled regions and the mobility from and to them, including refugee and other cross-border settlements.

The significance of artisanal mining for refugees and soldiers from these regions has been documented since at least 2013. Whether as compensation for limited supplies in refugee camps, low agricultural and livestock output, or modest salaries, the extraction provided relief during crises and was largely untaxed by SPLM-N, which focused on mechanised mining either to collect royalties or to hinder it through direct assaults. The former was mostly a response to ‘friendly’ investments, such as a rock mill purchased by a former Blue Nile resident living in the US; the latter was prompted by ‘intrusions’ from GoS-controlled areas (ICG 2013: 29).

The primary markets for much of the extracted gold were in Benishangul-Gumuz, where traders also brought food and other goods (ICG 2013: 29; IIRI & NHRMO 2016: 24); Yabus Bala, the main market for the Yabus area, for example, recorded a weekly exchange of 30-40g of gold by the end of 2012 (Gramizzi 2013: 56). Other trade routes crossed military lines via South Sudan, such as gold and gum Arabic transported from Chali Al-Fil to Maban, bartered for sugar and salt, and taken via Renk to Khartoum and the global market (Sperber et al. 2016). The latter route was part of a trilateral border-crossing zone around the river Yabus: refugees who felt unwelcome or unfamiliar with camp life in Sherkole in Benishangul-Gumuz could join relatives in Maban, South Sudan, via Yabus Bala.⁹² They may have met there traders exchanging produce from Blue Nile areas, including gold, with food items from Ethiopia, the same food items refugees found difficult to acquire or to produce themselves while still being there. At the same time, the proximity to the border made this transitional mobility slightly more secure from air raids (IIRI & NHRMO 2016: 35-37).

Although it was essential, this gold trade was also exploiting, as traders bought gold at prices far below the world market rate and even less than what they could sell it for to a GPC in Assosa. For example, in December 2012, when the international gold price was at an average of \$53 per gram, artisanal miners in Blue Nile had to accept a price of 80 birr, which was about \$4.5 (ICG 2013: 29).⁹³

Within their own circumstances, it remained a vital source of income for those displaced by war. Over the course of the war, a pattern of border crossings related to mining emerges from the SKBN humanitarian updates, all connected to hardship and food shortages, making this a last resort. A general trend developed in the southern areas, particularly the payams of Yabus and Wadaka, where people engaged in gold mining – especially during the lean season – to exchange the mineral for food and other items (SKBNCU Humanitarian Update November 2019 to February 2020). In fact, the widespread cessation of direct hostilities – following the end of air raids in late 2016 and

⁹² In 2015, reported crossing points used by refugees included Abramo, Gengen, and Kushmahal in Asosa *woreda*, Gizen/Geissan in Sherkole *woreda* and, further north, Al-Mahal in Gubba *woreda* (EUTF 2016: 26).

⁹³ See also case documented in NR 2014.

the main clashes between SPLM-N-Agar and SPLM-N-Ai Hilu in 2017 – lifted many mobility restrictions caused by insecurity (SKBNCU Humanitarian Update January 2018).

Meanwhile, food security remained heavily reliant on cross-border trade with Ethiopia and South Sudan, subject to its variations. The close connection between food security in Blue Nile and access to Ethiopian markets was emphasised after the severe floods in August 2019, which isolated these areas from each other – and led to donkeys, the primary means of transport for Ethiopian merchants, drowning (SKBNCU Humanitarian Update August 2019). Although the following dry season generally saw a stable presence of Ethiopian and South Sudanese traders in the region, economic crises across the entire area also resulted in steadily rising prices for food and other goods (SKBNCU Humanitarian Update February 2020).⁹⁴

Consequently, the COVID-19-related closure of border crossings by Ethiopian authorities starting in March 2020 began to significantly affect areas approaching the lean period (before *jubraka* harvest in August) or those generally depending on markets for food. The border closure also led to a sharp decrease in gold prices, dropping by around 50%, while the dry season's impact on water supply reduced mining productivity, resulting in a severe imbalance in the gold-for-food trade. From the SPLM/A-N side, border crossing points were viewed as passageways that facilitated closer contact with the population regarding COVID-19 emergency measures and the distribution of PPE and sanitizers (SKBNCU Humanitarian Update March 2020).

This impact on households reliant on markets worsened over the subsequent months, particularly in Komo Ganza, where 90% of households depended on purchasing food. In Wadaka, gold mining ceased to be a viable alternative as the border closure severed the link with traders. By May, hunger was widespread, especially in Komo Ganza. The partial reopening of cross-border trade for food and emergency supplies provided only limited relief, as prices continued to rise, notably for livestock (SKBNCU Humanitarian Update April and May 2020).

In terms of national laws, most of this trade can be described as illicit. However, examining actual trade routes reveals that there is, empirically, no clear distinction between 'legal' and 'illegal' trade routes; there are multiple legalities that coexist: not only did gold mined—without a GoS licence—in SPLM-N-held areas end up in the 'official' trade channels in Ethiopia and Sudan via the purchasing centres in Assosa and gold traders in Renk, who did not trace the gold back to its source or did not care about its provenance. Attacks on unwanted mining sites by militias on Ethiopian soil or in tributaries of 'Ethiopian' rivers across the border (ICG 2013: 40-41), as well as arrests of 'illegal' miners by SPLA-N (*Radio Tamazuj*, 20 February 2017)—which was itself illegal from the GoS's perspective—also marked territories of legality that are rooted in sources other than national laws.

There is another point to consider from these observations: a purely quantitative approach might suggest that cross-border trade is simply a marginal phenomenon, as production figures and trade volumes are very low, especially for national economies

⁹⁴ The fact that market prices in Yabus are given in birr shows this essential link as well.

aiming to attain a status in the global market to improve their fragile forex situation. However, as has been shown, it is structurally vital to livelihoods, and overlooking this fact means continuing to see the borderland as just a resource reserve. Leniency is therefore not necessarily a failure of control but may – intentionally or not – be an acknowledgment that more border control does not automatically result in better lives in border areas. A darker interpretation, such as neglect, would, however, confirm a historical pattern: ‘unofficial’ activities are targeted as ‘illicit’ only if they oppose larger interests. How effective this targeting is depends on various political, economic, and infrastructural circumstances, including whether the alternatives considered in capital cities align with those acceptable to local communities who rely on them for their livelihoods.

Conclusion: multiple legalities

The observations described in this chapter occur amidst the ongoing and somewhat violent redefinition of the Ethiopian-Sudanese border, whose existence is both questioned and affirmed by patterns observable in gold mining and trade. Gold trade consistently poses control challenges, as its value is highly concentrated, making even small, easily concealed amounts attractive—especially to numerous moving individuals seeking modest profits from crossing the border. Here, the largely unrestricted movement of people with recognised social ties across the border interlocks smoothly with the movement of goods: a family visiting relatives cannot easily be suspected of smuggling gold, yet they can effortlessly carry significant quantities between them.

This also highlights a distinction between traders based on pre-existing social relations required to facilitate transport and sale across the border. The growing gap between those selling on officially sanctioned markets and those smuggling is thus also a sign of strengthening cross-border ties, and the presence of larger shops operated by ‘Ethiopians’ in Qeissan stands as evidence of this.

Opposite these social ties, there are understaffed and underfunded local and regional governments that lack the logistical and institutional capacities to manage this highly mobile population. In fact, their financial resources are decreasing, and the lack of investment in infrastructure—also due to political and security considerations by central and regional governments—is one of the main reasons they cannot establish better control over the movement of goods and people.

However, this reading still falls short. In fact, staff at local level expressed fears for their position or even their safety if they attempted to implement official policies due to traders’ connections to elite politicians. This indicates that the power imbalance between them and the traders had grown so severe that they were unwilling to take risks without stronger backing from executive forces and higher authorities. This highlights that many of the involved interests, including those of government agents, are private in nature.

Two other examples illustrate how arrangements by one part of the government sabotage the work of others: in Ethiopia, centralising licensing for companies means that local officials not only lack control over their activities but are often not even informed about them. Beyond a contradiction between central and regional state bodies, this also continues a long-standing struggle for the ultimate decision-making power over natural resource extraction, which is well known in the region's history. Consequently, new boundaries—whether through new arrangements of wealth distribution or military fortification—can also serve as resources to challenge older forms of domination. In this way, the international border between Sudan and Ethiopia acted as a marker of differential treatment for some, and as a valuable resource for others.

In Sudan, it is the powerful status of centrally licensed goldsmiths that causes similar issues: their identification card exempts them from scrutiny by officials regarding the gold they may carry, a situation that is quite significant given their central role in trade.⁹⁵ This highlights not only the complex relationship between legality and legitimacy, but also that 'smuggling' titles exchange relations from a particular perspective.⁹⁶ Such 'smuggling' could also be identified within interactions among actors in the gold sector itself: a goldsmith, for example, complained about the 'theft' by gold washers who would hide gold dust under their fingernails – the same interaction could also be seen as resistance against asymmetric exchange relations.⁹⁷

It is here that the historical pattern repeats itself: a periphery for central governments, the borderlands develop internal dynamics that benefit local residents but are not independent from national or even global actors and forces. They simply bypass many of the purely symbolic administrative systems that exist as a legal framework but are not always translated in actual control on the ground. The resources that are consequently moved still find their way into networks of exchange that benefit supra-regional elites, many of whom are themselves part of the government system they refrain from sharing their wealth with.

While this partly confirms the status of local elites – such as the former slave traders of Qeissan who still dominate communal representation – gold, as a decentralised resource, also enables questioning and circumvention of historically entrenched centralised power structures. Tension between inherited status and new economic power gained through gold mining was also evident in other sites (see next chapter). Such dynamics cannot be understood simply by adopting official statistical concepts that belong to an apparatus eager to claim complete control over its citizens, rather than engaging in an open investigation of how people organise their social relations and the distribution of resources.

⁹⁵ Interview with resident in Qeissan, 25 November 2019.

⁹⁶ This difference has been discussed in relation to gold mining in the Nuba Mountains in Ille & Calkins 2013, and in several conflict areas in Sudan in Ille 2016 and Ille 2018..

⁹⁷ Interview with goldsmith in Belguwa, 7 August 2019.

Part 3: Blue Nile State's gold markets in 2019

One key research goal of our project was to trace how gold was mined and distributed from Blue Nile State, focusing on the so-called gold markets, which served as processing centres, sales points, and sources of basic supplies, as well as logistical and administrative hubs for mining sites. Some of these gold markets had developed as extensions of existing markets or settlements, while others were formalised, or more rarely established, by government authorities, particularly the Sudanese Mineral Resources Company (SMRC). We regarded these markets as highly productive field sites, not only because of their multiple functions but also because they represented a node in the gold value chain where many components and the people involved converged.

The research was conducted through several interconnected avenues, with the most significant being fieldwork organised and led by Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman. This began with a seven-day scoping visit in March 2019, followed by two preparatory field trips in June/July and August 2019, each lasting a week, to establish field contacts and pre-test a socio-economic questionnaire.

The main field trip lasted four weeks in November 2019, when Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman was joined by four field assistants who not only collected responses for the survey but also conducted their own narrative interviews and direct observations in the markets and, in some cases, at the mining sites. Maḥmūd Aḥmad Ġamāl Al-Dīn and Ṭāriq 'Abd Al-'Aziz Maḥmūd stayed four weeks in the largest of Blue Nile's gold markets, Belguwa; Mu'taṣim Yūsif Sulīmān Sa'īd Takana covered the same period in Bakori, and 'Usāma 'Umar 'Alī was in Bulang. Al-Ṭayyib 'Awaḍ Al-Ṭayyib spent 28 days in and around Maganza, during which he also obtained a permit to work as a miner and joined a working team, gathering valuable insights not only into the administrative processes but also the routines governing the labour of shaft miners. In addition to their notes given directly to Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman when he visited their field sites, we also interviewed them about their experiences in separate conversations lasting between 30 and 120 minutes each, on 22 January and 5 February 2020.⁹⁸ Enrico Ille's role in the research team was data processing and writing.

⁹⁸ There were also additional data collectors for the survey, including 'Alī 'Abd Al-Karīm Muṣṭafa from Wad Madani, 'Aḥmad 'Isa Muḥammad and Mūsa Muḥammad Al-Ṭayyib from Damazin, Ma'āwiyya 'Abd Allah from Al-Šaqālū north of Shendi, and Muḥammad Naḡīb Al-Ṭāhir from Qeissan. The survey reached a total of 3,571 respondents across four gold markets, and some of its results will be included in Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman's upcoming PhD thesis; others were published under <https://sway.cloud.microsoft/1qWc0YcdBdXIjUbh>. There is abundant imagery from the fieldwork, mostly created and stored by Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman.

The fieldwork produced the following data:

- quantitative data: statistical information (number of sites, workers, volume of minerals extracted and traded), economic profile derived from a survey with 3571 miners, migrants, and residents in four gold markets (including residential history, income structure of individuals and households, perspectives on advantages and disadvantages of mining) [analysed using SPSS];
- qualitative data: narrative and biographical interviews, participant observation, images / audiovisual material, official documents and reports [analysed using MaxQDA];
- geographical data: GPS mapping of sites (such as gold markets and mining locations) and mobility patterns (trade routes).

The following sections revisit the work conducted in the markets and connected mining sites. The main aim of these sections is to present the part of the data relevant to the regulation and taxation of artisanal and small-scale mining, which effectively reflects the forms of governance developing around extractive activities more broadly.

We thus depart from a dominant approach to view the gold sector from the perspective of companies and their affiliations. From this perspective, there was comparatively limited interest in the state; a list of licensed mining companies obtained from the SMRC Blue Nile office in 2019 listed only these concessionaires:

- Nebta (Kurmuk) [subsidiary of Egyptian ASCOM],
- Eyat (Qeissan) [an Al-Birayr family member business],
- Advanced Mining Works (Wad Al-Māhī) [SAF-linked],
- Lusail (Qeissan) [side business of Al-Doha Mining, mostly owned by business partners of a member of Qatar's ruling family].

In the same list, only the following small-scale mining licenses were recorded:

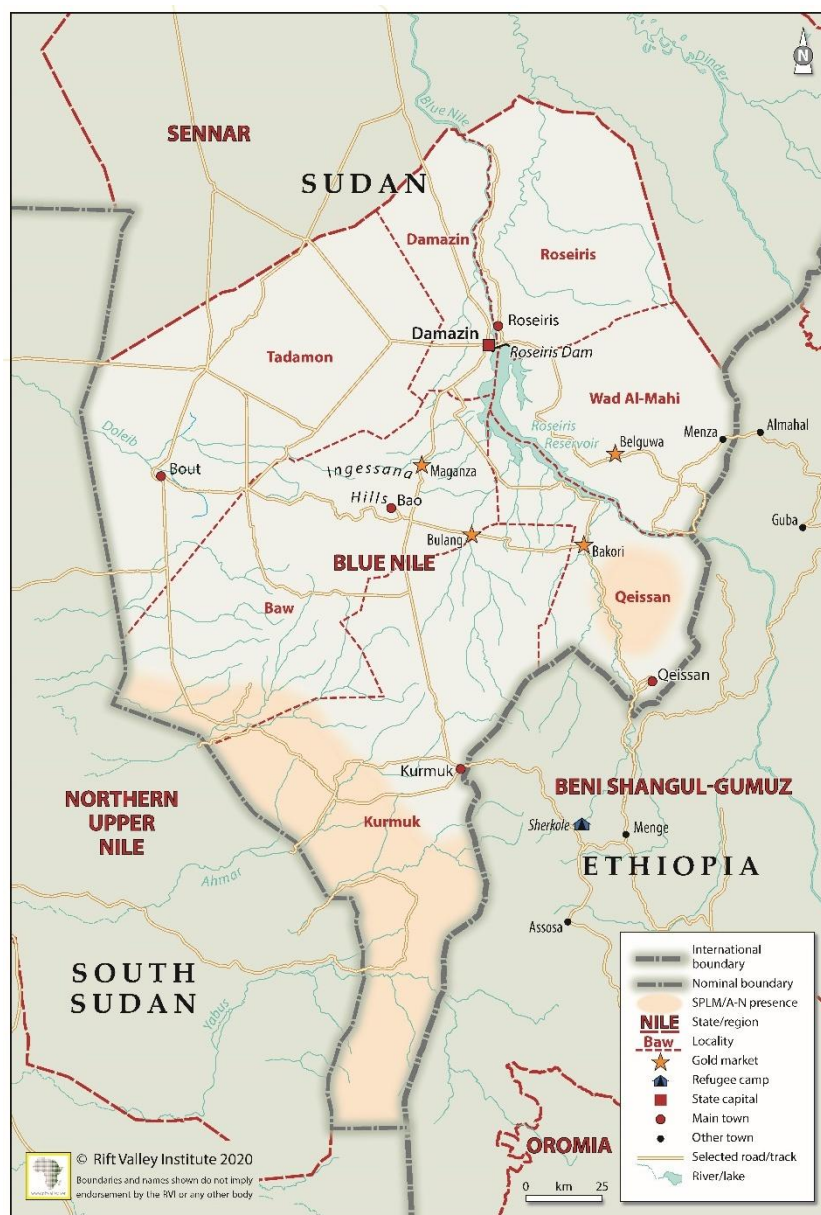
- Pluto (Wad Al-Māhī, tailings)
- Nūrmīs (Kurmuk, gold mining)
- Bāb Allah Ḥussayn (Kurmuk / Miyās, gold mining)
- Sulīmān Ḥussayn for Mining (Bao, gold mining)
- Al-Bārūnāt (Bao, gold mining)
- Smart (Wad Al-Māhī, alluvial/surface gold)
- Block 61 Blue Nile State
- Elements (Bao, tailings)

As we will show, these companies did not only represent a small part of ongoing gold production, often depending on tailings from small-scale mining. They were also either linked to or had to arrange with military governance because large parts of the state were directly or indirectly affected by recurring violent conflicts. At the same time, these conflicts were both a result of and an expression of such governance. It is therefore more important to examine the interaction between armed forces and small-scale miners closely, to understand the foundations of arrangements that would be expanded and strengthened during the present war, and to recognise the complex challenges involved in trying to move away from them.

Field sites

- **Belguwa** (Ṭāriq and Maḥmūd),
- **Bakori** (Mu‘taṣim),
- **Bulang** (‘Usāma),
- **Maganza** (Al-Ṭayyib).

Interviews conducted by Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman are referred to in black; interviews by the other field researchers are marked in blue. The ethnographic narratives summarise the impression left by the field interviews, the site interviews after their return and further discussions between the authors in late 2019 and early 2020.



Belguwa

Geographical and historical context

The largest of the formalised gold markets was Belguwa in Wad El-Mahi Locality,⁹⁹ one of the state's more populous and accessible areas, northeast of the Blue Nile and southeast of the Roseiris Dam. The mining areas reached in 2019 near the eastern Roseiris Dam resettlement villages at the Nile, called 'Madīnah' with ascending numbers (1-7); the closest were Madīnah 5 and 6, approximately 10 km to the southwest and south. Although the village and markets of Belguwa were some distance from the Locality's main road, once reaching the road, there was a connection to Damazin and Roseiris to the west, Fazughli to the south, and Almahal in Ethiopia via Menza to the east. As there was no bridge to the areas southwest of the Blue Nile,¹⁰⁰ the area remained largely separate from the southern Blue Nile areas and their conflicts.¹⁰¹

Belguwa village consisted of hamlets scattered around small markets in the lower areas of the hills, with the most prominent being Jabal Anṣār (about 620m) and Jabal Belguwa (about 570m) to the north of the settlement. In 2019, three markets formed a triangle: the main market of Belguwa in the southeast offering a wide range of goods; the transport station Jabarōna in the southwest, with kiosks, restaurants, and foodstuff vendors; and the gold market with stone mills (*sūq al-ṭawāḥīn*) in the north, along with a small commodity market providing additional services and the SMRC office.

Residence in this specific part of northeastern Blue Nile, relatively distant from the Nile, was essentially linked to mining, as it was not a place where people lived until about 30 years ago, while mining was known for much longer.¹⁰² It was along a route historically taken eastwards, towards Ethiopia, a transit area. Some also used it to gather wood, as the area was covered with forest, featuring strong trees called locally *guwa*. Combined with the Berta word for 'mountain', *bel*, Belguwa means the mountain of the strong trees.

According to the narrative emerging from the team's fieldwork, gold was discovered in the early 1990s. The first residents were Fa-Dūqā, artisanal miners who had been mining around Qeissan and Kurmuk until the civil war extended into the area in 1987, prompting them to flee to Khor Al-Qanna, east of Fazughli. Building on their previous experiences, they quickly identified gold deposits in the watercourses near local mountains but kept their knowledge of it and the resulting mining activities secret, pretending they were merely gathering wood in the same area. The initial surface gold collection later transitioned into underground mines at the edges of those mountains. The miners and their families gradually formed a growing camp around these sites, expanding their

⁹⁹ OSM location is <https://www.openstreetmap.org/#map=14/11.473333/34.726389>.

¹⁰⁰ Madīnah 7 was also called 'Umm Darfā and had a ferry that crossed the Nile.

¹⁰¹ There were exceptions to this, particularly because the partial recruitment of Fellātah groups in that area into the Popular Defense Forces placed them in direct conflict with SPLA forces.

¹⁰² In the final report of the Global Mercury Project, it was even claimed that mining had been carried out there for centuries (GMP 2007: 2). When the project was established in the early 2000s, the Belguwa-Sakatnā sites were considered likely to have existed for quite some time (Récoché et al. 2005: 42, 68).

mining efforts along family lines by including a brother, an uncle, and others into their operations.

Over the course of the 2000s, Blue Nile State became safer, and Belguwa gained recognition as a gold-producing area, attracting labour migrants from across Sudan, especially after the CPA (2005) and the start of the gold rush (2008/2009). Early successes further boosted its reputation, and by 2019, Belguwa had become both a permanent and temporary home to about 16,000 people, including not only Sudanese but also individuals from Ethiopia, South Sudan, and Chad.¹⁰³ Among them were approximately 5000 miners, of whom 600 held union cards, working in about 4000 mines, along with workers in other occupations.¹⁰⁴ In 2015, the Sudanese Mineral Resources Company (SMRC) began organising the formalisation of the local stonemill station into a gold market. Furthermore, the SAF-linked Red Rock Mining Company had been present in the area through its subsidiary Advanced Mining Works (AMW) since the early 2000s.¹⁰⁵

Residential and occupational structures

While the majority of miners was still composed of the ‘original’ mining families, a significant number of other miners had settled there with their families, while some only came for the work and left after a few years, seasonally or even after just a few working days.

To better understand their situation, a survey was conducted with 383 residents and 733 temporary miners (N=1116, 7% of the estimated population). The non-resident survey population was predominantly male (88%), with about half under 30 years old, and 7% aged 18 or younger. The majority (58%) were married, and 48% had children, with an average of 4.5 children. Approximately two-thirds had only completed primary education or basic religious education (*ḥalwah*), while 13% had no formal education at all. However, higher education generally did not result in better-paid positions such as employment with companies or owning means of production; of the 34 university graduates, 30 worked as free labourers. Nine out of ten were directly involved in extractive activities (from mining shafts to smithery and trade), with others engaged in supportive services such as transport or secondary market services like groceries and gastronomy. Among resident respondents, mining was also a dominant activity, with 73% directly involved, mostly as labourers. Their educational profile was similarly limited, with 90% reaching only

¹⁰³ Estimate of sheikh Idrīs of Belguwa, interviewed 28 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹⁰⁴ Estimate of a member of the Mine Workers Union, interviewed 28 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹⁰⁵ Being part of the nested company structures of SAF investments through the Military Industries Corporation and other vehicles, the precise nature of the concessions held by Red Rock and its subsidiaries was far from clear. The connection to Sudan Master Technologies (SMT) was well known within the industry, for example to Australia-based Gekko Systems, who supplied the Belguwa operation with so-called InLine Pressure Jigs, a grinding circuit (see post-2003 company brochure, p. 18, available under <https://www.yumpu.com/en/document/read/21536606/gekko-systems-brochure-completepdf>). In a 2014 IPIS report, it was noted that “[l]ocal populations describe the company premises as a small city with professional machinery that receives frequent visits by helicopter” (Spittaels & Weyns 2014: 38).

primary education or less; one post-graduate and six of eight graduates among them were also miners or labourers. The primary motivation reported was economic— to gain or increase income.

Of the 10 Ethiopians interviewed in Belguwa, none worked in the mines, confirming the understanding that most of those coming from Ethiopia were engaged in secondary services, with varying economic results.¹⁰⁶ A 20-year-old Amharic tea seller from the Bahir Dar area, for example, recounted how she left school in tenth grade to earn enough money to care for her sister, who had a small child. She moved to Sudan in 2017 and to Belguwa at the start of 2019, renting a sunroof (*rākōba*) from a policeman for 300 SDG a month, as she was not permitted to purchase one. Profits remained too low to return, however, with the steadily declining Sudanese pound yielding fewer Birr to send home.¹⁰⁷

Some of these moves were lateral, shifting from one mining area to another, often prompted by declining productivity or negative experiences elsewhere. A goldsmith from Sinnar previously worked in Maganza but left for Belguwa in 2012 due to insecurity and thefts there, although the profits in the latter were less favourable.¹⁰⁸ Political events had their own impact, not just concerning the widespread armed conflicts: a 24-year-old second-year student from South Kordofan left his home when universities were closed during the 2018 revolution and joined his brother to work shifts in his mine.¹⁰⁹

Some motivations were primarily social, often related to financing marriage or supporting other family members. However, there were also evaluations of different mining areas as social settings, which affected the specific choice of location: a Rashayda who had ceased camel herding in 2002 to mine in several parts of Sudan selected Belguwa in 2015 because he valued its multi-ethnic character, where racism was uncommon and living in mixed communities offered a welcome contrast to the isolation in arid regions he had previously experienced.¹¹⁰

The social and political context of the settlement remained complex, as a quick examination of the adjacent resettlement villages and their relationship to the mining operations demonstrates. Madīnah 4 had a multi-ethnic composition with several independent Fellata sheikhs.¹¹¹ Part of its Fellata population had been in the area in the early 1950s, crossing it with their livestock on the way to Ethiopia but were pushed back from there, subsequently pressurised by the Sudanese government to settle and partly gathered into Omdurman Fellata in Sennar. When the string of Madīnah 1-7 was established on the northern/eastern side of the Nile related to the Roseiris Dam, they

¹⁰⁶ This does not count the borderland populations (see Ille et al. 2021) and exceptions as documented in Salah & Ille 2020b.

¹⁰⁷ Interviewed on 7 August 2019, Belguwa.

¹⁰⁸ Interviewed on 7 August 2019, Belguwa.

¹⁰⁹ Interviewed on 15 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹¹⁰ Interviewed on 18 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹¹¹ ‘Fellata’ itself is an imprecise ethnonym summarising numerous heterogeneous origins. The term is an Arabic derivative of the Hausa word for Fulbe but is used in Sudan for a wide range of groups whose origins trace back to western Africa, including Hausa speakers. It has also been adopted as an emic ethnonym.

settled there as well, mainly engaging in agriculture and animal husbandry.¹¹² But while Madīnah 4 had no mines within its boundaries, several of its population became involved in mining, some directly working in the mines, others providing services such as transportation by motorised vehicles.¹¹³

The neighbouring Madīnah 5 presented an opposing image, following the account of a resident sheikh: ¹¹⁴ a Fellata Fūṭa community united under one leadership, they settled here around 2013 after living in the area since the 1960s, when they migrated from Omdurman Fellata in Sennar. Agriculture and livestock production were their primary economic activities, and although – or perhaps because – Madīnah 5 was closely linked to mining areas, its population was neither engaged in nor supportive of mining. This was partly due to racial attitudes towards mining labour, where wheat-coloured Fellata described it as work of ‘the blue ones’ (*zuruq*); their descendants were actively prevented from undertaking such work, and the closest involvement of community members was through transportation services, using motorcycles or tuk-tuks.

However, a larger issue was ongoing conflicts over land use with miners, the most recent of which began around 2015 with mining activities encroaching on agricultural land designated for the resettlement village. On the surface, this involved the spread of artisanal mines that filled with water and posed hazards to livestock drinking from them, reportedly causing at least 8 cattle to die. They were also dangerous for children who fall into the water and drowned or stumbled into empty shafts, which had happened five times already, as a resident of Madīnah 5 reported. Protests to the Locality authorities were without consequences, arguably because mining permits and other fees were a significant source of revenue for them.

However, a closer examination reveals the involvement of Sudan's military-industrial complex, which is crucial to assess. There was a compound of the Advanced Mining Works company adjacent to these residential areas and near the Nile. While hostility towards mining might be expected to extend to this intrusive presence, there was a strand of support for the military's presence, which introduced a noteworthy distinction between military and civilian mining.¹¹⁵ One resident even claimed that mining near the village had begun when a government soldier stationed at a nearby military camp washed himself in a watercourse and found a piece of gold there. This anecdote suggests involvement of

¹¹² ‘East’ refers to one side of the Nile, even when it flows east-west and has a northern and a southern bank geographically. The usual understanding is that the Nile flows from the south (upstream, *saʿīd*) to the north (downstream, *asfal* or *bahr*).

¹¹³ Interview with Fellata sheikh of Madīnah 4, 22 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹¹⁴ Interview with Fellata sheikh of Madīnah 5, 22 November 2019, Belguwa. He also mentioned that the older name ‘Omdurman Fellata’ was changed to ‘Maḥrībāh’ as recently as 2002, referring to a watercourse that curves around the settlement. In fact, a settlement called ‘Hadabat Machreba’ was marked on Russegger's 1843 map of the Blue Nile-Tumat confluence (https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/9/9b/Karte_der_Länder_am_Tumat_und_blauen_Flusse.jpg).

¹¹⁵ Conversely, the common complaint about ‘companies’ encroaching on agricultural land, as reflected in our survey, also referred to the small-scale miners operating close to Madīnah 5 who rented heavy machinery that was generally associated with corporate mining.

military personnel in mineral extraction, a pattern that was to emerge in other areas as well.¹¹⁶

The population of Madīnah 6 combined elements from the previous two: a diverse community largely opposed to mining in their area, both for social and economic reasons. The village was established through the relocation of several villages, such as Khor Al-Qannā (West and East), Dokkān Al-Rīḥ, Abu Shendi, and Umm Darfā'; it then had more than 1000 houses, though still fewer than the number of families relocated.¹¹⁷

The settlement can be roughly divided into 11 quarters that roughly reconstituted previous residential structures, divided between Fellata and upstream riverine groups (*qabā'il al-ṣa'īd*), such as Berta and Funj. Even more than the Fellata residents, the riverine population regarded itself as a historical constant in the area – especially in relation to the mining community at Belguwa – strengthened by a strong tendency to move little, whether for residence or for work.¹¹⁸ Labour migration was uncommon, and for many, the biggest change was the relocation, a major disruption to their lives they still found hard to accept.¹¹⁹ Compensation provided them with only small residential plots on clayey, flood-prone soil, featuring flawed or incomplete buildings, lacking expandability for future generations, and without proper water, sanitation, or electricity.¹²⁰ Farmland was inadequate, small, and unproductive, and other assets, such as fruitful trees, had not been compensated at all. For some, autonomy in food production and energy from charcoal and wood had been lost, and a historically developed social fabric was replaced by interactions with different peoples, who suddenly had to learn to live together.¹²¹

¹¹⁶ Interviewed on 23 November 2019, Madīnah 5. One of their sheikhs, Umar Idris Makki, was killed by SPLA soldiers in 1997, which led to a stronger SAF presence in the area.

¹¹⁷ It was a common complaint among residents that more families were displaced than received compensation, whether in the form of houses or otherwise. During a group discussion in Madīnah 6 on 22 November 2019, the participants mentioned that 2400 families lived in Abū Shendi alone previously. While documenting the erasure of settlements following dam construction and elevation in that region is a separate task, even a tentative list compiled by a sheikh of one of these settlements illustrates the scope: other former villages included Abū Shabash, Kayyif, Fādūdū, Al-'Awāwī, Al-'Azāzah and Fūqānī. In other areas, settlements such as Wad Al-Māḥī, Abū Dabarīn, Al-Ṭayrāyah, 'Akmah, Abū Dawāyah, Kartū, Kartūg, Bīṣāb, Malwah, Al-Raqībah and Zā'irū were also noted (interview with sheikh of Khor Al-Qannā East, 22 November 2019, Madīnah 6).

¹¹⁸ One interviewee, over 70 years old, has spent all his life moving no further from Khor Al-Qannā than Jabal Belguwa (interviewed on 18 and 22 November 2019, Madīnah 6).

¹¹⁹ However, the long-term migration history of most of these groups is also complex. The sheikh of former Khor Al-Qanna East / Wad Al-Māḥī traced his group's migration path, Al-Ḥuḍur (or Ḥaḍariyyīn Ḥawārah), to Hasaheisa just five generations ago. During this period, Wad Al-Māḥī area incorporated Bederiyyah, Rufa'ah, Ambororo, Hausa, Qūbāwiyyīn, and the Jabalāwiyyīn groups of Funj and Gumuz, many of whom were displaced from Benishangul following clashes in 1917. (interview on 18 November 2019, Belguwa).

¹²⁰ Specific complaints included the low productivity of rain-fed and irrigated manual agriculture (2 sacks of sorghum per feddān) as well as the lack of engine-driven pumps to compensate for insufficient precipitation.

¹²¹ For instance: interview with sheikh of Wad Al-Māḥī, 18 November 2019, Belguwa; group discussion with five older male residents from Abū Shendi, 22 November 2019, Madīnah 6.

In this context, mining areas, only a few kilometres away and connected by a small road from Jabarōna, did not seem to be an attractive source of income for most, again due to a mixture of cultural prejudice against the work – partly even regarded as slaves’ labour – and a preoccupation with agriculture. Those who went to the mining areas during the day were mostly in a very difficult economic situation and needed immediate income; these were mainly women and girls who engaged in *rutūt* (see below).¹²² However, one could also find those who had been mining already before relocation and partly owned shafts themselves, and among the former population of Khor Al-Qannā East / Wad Al-Māhī, a general disdain for mining didn’t appear to exist.¹²³

Labour and profits

Mines and lines

The expansion of works around a vein, once discovered, occurred through areas and ‘lines’ (*ḥuṭūṭ*, sg. *ḥaṭ*) of shafts. The approximately 4000 shafts present in Belguwa as of November 2019 had been organised into at least 10 such areas and lines, whose names reflected various social, environmental, health, economic, and political aspects of the mines and their surroundings:

- Jabal Anṣār, north-east of Belguwa market, opened and allegedly owned by Anṣār Al-Sunnah;¹²⁴
- Al-Tartarah, north-east of Belguwa market, located in an area with many *tartar* trees (*Sterculia setigera*) that were cut to allow mining;¹²⁵
- Line of Death (*ḥaṭ al-mawf*), the largest line and closest to the market, named after the frequent suffocation that occurred due to elevated sulphur dioxide before the miners found ways to identify rocks containing sulphur;
- Faisal Bank Line (*ḥaṭ bank faiṣah*), named after the good profit even workers in the shafts achieve, comparing it to going into a branch of the eponymous bank that was believed by miners to hold the government’s money in its huge vaults;¹²⁶

¹²² In the same group discussion (see previous footnote), this was described as ‘confusion’ (*ḥayrah*), taking on damaging work with little revenue, often also to the detriment of education. Additionally, the five men raised concerns that agriculture, as a family business, incurred aggregated losses due to labour force that migrated to mining, even if this affected only a few individuals; revenues from mining were insufficient to offset this loss. Another group discussion with three sheikhs from Khor Al-Qannā (23 November 2019, Madīnah 6) confirmed this peripheral status of gold work.

¹²³ According to the sheikh of Khor Al-Qannā East / Wad Al-Māhī, interviewed 18 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹²⁴ See general background in Tønnessen 2016.

¹²⁵ See its status as source of Karaya gum in Abdelgadir & Mudawi 2020.

¹²⁶ Considering that Faisal Islamic Bank was among the first Saudi investments in Sudan’s banking sector, which most benefited the economic growth of the Muslim Brotherhood, this was indeed the case, in a subtle manner.

- ‘We Were Silent’ Line (*ḥaṭ sakatnā*), named after an incident in 1997 when a SPLA officer called Butrus passed by and the miners stopped all noise [to avoid being discovered];¹²⁷ another version denoted it as *saqaṭnā*, ‘we fell’;
- Rapid Support Line (*ḥaṭ al-da‘m al-sarī*), named after the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) and its operational tactic to appear suddenly with brute force but only for a short time, which alludes to gold finds close to the surface but of limited quantity;
- Albān Jadīd, a small group of mines that did not have a high grade of gold and was flooded, so most mines were abandoned.
- Adobe Line (*ḥaṭ al-bādūbah*), named after the kind of soil in the mining area, clay appropriate to make adobe bricks, which is not usually the case where gold can be found.

Further names of these appearing and disappearing focus areas could be found with further associations, such as Guantanamo (a US prison), Madīnah 5 (a local settlement), Al-‘Ardībah (a tree species), Al-Liffah (‘the turn’) etc.¹²⁸

These lines were at different stages of a mine’s life cycle, and the varying physical characteristics of the terrains led to differences in tools, work processes, productivity, and the distribution of miners. Ġabal Anṣār, for example, was close to ‘dried up’ at the end of its life cycle. Al-Tartarah, similarly, mostly had old, previously productive mines, most of which had collapsed, but some people still worked there. Most of the workers were women and girls who benefitted from the collapsed mines whose former owners no longer claimed them; they collected dust and stones from the rims and sometimes down to 5m in the shaft, in a work called *rutūt*. Since they expected to find residues profitable to them—though not to the former owners—there was a significant number of women engaging in this dangerous work, where mines might collapse or collapse further. Some women even deliberately caused a mine to collapse to make work on the surface easier, which could cause widespread erosion since mines had been dug quite close together.

Women performed similar work in the Line of Death, although it was a considerably more active mining area with numerous productive wells and workers. It was one of several highly frequented lines at the height of their life cycle, another being Faisal Bank. The duration of such a cycle could vary greatly, from the ‘We Were Silent’ line dating back to the 1990s to the short-lived Rapid Support line, and Albān Jadīd which had been flooded.

Looking further back in the life cycle, at the beginning of a new mining area, the processes become more unpredictable and experimental. Miners noted that it is easy to start a mine when discovering an unclaimed spot, but reaching a profitable vein requires significant effort. Several workers operated in established mines to fund their search for a personal mine during their shifts; one would say *‘ana sākī bīrī*, ‘I run after my mine’, until the mine

¹²⁷ There was a period of increased military presence at that time, as SPLA was active, which, for example, resulted in the death of Fellātah sheikh ‘Umar Idrīs Makkī. SPLA also opposed several mining activities, particularly after populations were displaced from the Ingessana Hills, with NCP-allied mining companies establishing operations.

¹²⁸ There are further mining areas in the wider Wad Al-Maḥī area, which includes Jabal Al-Ramā, Jabal Mūdū, Khor Al-Sarīfah and Jabal Mūlū (interview with sheikh of Khor Al-Qanna East / Wad Al-Māḥī, 18 November 2019, Belguwa).

waradat, meaning ‘it arrived’, which was conventionally when a sack of ore contained more than a gram of gold. An example of a new area with many such ‘works in progress’ was the one called Madīnah 5, close to the settlement of the same name. It had no productive mine at that time, and workers there were simply testing the gold content in the rocks. Economic viability remained challenging to establish due to the distance to the mills, washers, and smiths.

Shafts and shifts

Besides their different ‘ages’, mining areas varied in their geological structures and how they were penetrated. Work on the surface and in shallow mines used lighter tools like the shovel (*kōrēk*) and hoe (*tōriyyah*), whereas deeper depths of 60m or more were accessed with a jackhammer.

If the surrounding rock was what was called ‘hardstone’ (*al-ḥajir al-ṣalib*), this might be a relatively simple process of splitting off rocks and drawing them up with ropes or over a ‘ladder’ formed by miners standing on each other’s shoulders. If the rocks appeared less stable, a system of wooden bases (*ṣukālāt*) would be used to support the shaft walls. In case limestone (*al-ḥajir al-jirī*) was part of the rocks, it was more complicated, as it often indicated the presence of water that had to be removed—if it didn’t suddenly pour out and fill the area or even cause the mine to collapse—and the work surface would generally become slippery and unstable.

Going deeper generally meant more dangers. Light became scarce, requiring the use of headlights; ventilation deteriorated, oxygen supplies decreased, and the risk of suffocation increased. One of the worst scenarios was a sudden rupture in the rocks releasing sulphuric gas that would instantly absorb oxygen and cause immediate death to the miners. A solution found was installing ventilators on the top side of the shaft, which constantly blew in fresh air through a ventilation shaft made from plastic sacks. If neighbouring mines were close, their crews might agree to open a ‘window’ (*nāfiḍah*) between them to improve ventilation, for instance every ten metres. With more experience, types of rock likely to carry sulphuric gases were identified early and avoided, and there was talk of a plant that could absorb the gas.

In well-staffed, productive mines, crews could work up to four shifts of 6 hours each. These crews were often fixed teams that ‘take over’ work in one shaft for a shift period, such as 10 or 20 days. At the end of this period, they would be paid out, and the next crew would move in. If the mine proved profitable, the same crew or part of it might wish to return later; then they would ‘book’ the next available shift period, which could be after 40 days or more for mines in high demand. Meanwhile, it was uncommon for workers to remain idle; many would work on their own shafts, in other mines, or engage in different jobs in the market, such as at the mills and basins. Some even continued working beyond their 6-hour shifts. This included the opportunistic collection of rocks from abandoned mines, called ‘work as *kummājī*’ (pl. *kummājīyyah*, from *kumm*, ‘small heap’), similar to *rutūt* but with the additional aspect that it was formerly regarded as theft, yet it had become a regular activity and generally denoted small-scale work that was merely ‘informal’ (*ḡayr rasmi*).

Crushing and washing

Depending on the productivity of a shaft, its subsequent shift periods, and the availability of transportation—primarily tuk-tuks and donkeys—rocks from mining would be transported to the market after a varying number of days. There, the ore was first crushed and then washed, a process that was repeated several times to extract as much gold as possible.

The mills were categorised into those using air (about 25-30) and those using water (about 40); they processed approximately 100-120 sacks daily.¹²⁹ The resultant dust is then brought to basins for ‘washing’, the extraction of gold by using water and mercury. The basins had in November 2019 an overall gold production of about 3 kg per day.

Work in these facilities was somewhat different, as it was more regular and consistent, but it remained free labour with limited employment security and social protection. Opportunistic employment was also present here. Each stage of the extraction process involved service activities that relied on free labour, often by miners trying to cover their costs or by cheaper under-age workers. An example is the cleaning of the basins once they filled with dust, known as *al-qalaʿ*, meaning ‘taking out’. This vital process produced the tailings (*kartah*), which are later sold for secondary washing and ultimately purchased by companies, via brokers, to undergo an additional extraction process using cyanide.

It is here that issues of gender and generation became most evident. The majority of the labour force was generally very young, between 18 and 25 years old. Children aged 7 to 17 were common and performed a wide range of tasks in the market. Some miners with smaller amounts of rocks employed children as *kummāǧjyyah* under sunroofs or in houses to crush stones with a hammer. Others worked at the mills, particularly *al-qubwah*, a hole under the funnel of the stone mills where dust escapes, only about one to one and a half metres deep. Children were preferred for tasks such as fastening empty sacks at the small opening, mainly because of their size and because they were willing to accept lower payments than adults; as a result, they breathed in dust for hours each day. Some collected dust around the mills to wash it themselves, hoping to find a few grains of gold.¹³⁰

Female *rutūt* miners held a distinct role in the market, partly owning their own mills and basins. As they managed the entire extraction process – bringing the ore, paying mill workers, washing themselves – they generally remained outside the main production

¹²⁹ The figures are approximate since not all of those installed were operational. One stone crusher (*daqāqāt al-ḥajir* or *tawāḥīn*), when using water, could ideally process about 10-12 sacks per day, depending on the rock type and the availability of all necessary inputs.

¹³⁰ The implications for their educational and physical futures are clear but have not been a focus in this research. However, cases have been observed where the same children used income from this work to fund their own school education if their parents were unable or unwilling to do so (shortly referred to in Salah and Ille 2020a).

chain in the markets and were thus financially quite independent, continuing a historical tradition of gold mining as part of small-scale household economies.¹³¹

The physical strain during the production process was immense, and personal protective equipment was nearly absent. All those involved in labour suffered significant physical damage, and there was no shortage of expressions highlighting how difficult, exhausting, and hazardous gold extraction work is. These included frequent complaints about skin irritations and rhinitis (*ḥasāsīyyah*), rheumatism (*ruṭūbah*), bone pain, nail corrosion, as well as widespread malaria cases, injuries from handling rocks or collapses, and digestive issues believed to be caused by drinking water contaminated with water from shafts or other polluted sources.

Costs and benefits

The value chain from mine to trade involves various distributive arrangements. To understand how those involved organise the division of profits and losses, it is helpful to consider how the operation is financed, from ownership of the means of production to covering labour and living costs. For the study area, this is also relevant since there seemed to be a consensus that not only financial profits were the primary or at least one of the main reasons for engaging in gold mining, but gold mining was often portrayed as being – at least potentially – more profitable than all alternatives. As a result, even viable options such as agricultural work on schemes in Blue Nile and Sinnar were not generally pursued instead, or only seasonally. For many of the in-migrants, an initial experiment thus became a profession and way of life.

Our survey indicates that most workers in the gold sector had enough income to make their efforts somewhat economically viable, but only very few made enough profit to significantly alter their financial situation.¹³² The distribution of profits then depended on the position in the value chain; at the lower end of the profit distribution were the free labourers in marginal services. However, the economic benefits of gold mining were not limited to those directly involved in the value chain; free labourers also earned income within the market, in cafés, restaurants, shops, with most of them coming to the area solely because of the mining activities. Women sold tea and foodstuffs, men opened

¹³¹ *Rutūt* will produce a few grains (*ḥubūb*, sg. *ḥabbah*), which sold for 320 SDG per grain in November 2019. In the conventional jewellery measurement system, which was also used here, 1 gramme of gold equals 15.432 grains.

¹³² This is based on 58.9% of mining or mining-adjacent respondents (1124 of 1909) across all markets who reported being able to cover their expenses. Fewer (42.3%) could also generate a profit from their activities. However, a control question on how these profits were used showed that only 15.1% (122) utilised these profits for savings, purchases, and other investments, mostly to cover additional expenses outside the mining-related activities; the rest only covered such expenses, thereby slightly stabilising, but not changing, their situation. Consequently, about a quarter (26.5%) of all respondents took on debt to cover all expenses related to their social lives.

butcheries, cloth shops, and other facilities. The station, local administration, and companies all contributed a few, yet individually significant, income-generating activities.

Mine workers had occasionally higher but highly irregular incomes. For many, it was therefore day-to-day labour with very different yields. However, some mine owners and crew leaders had established a kind of salary system, which – depending on the agreement – was often rather a system of regular advances on shared future profit. In this system, workers belonging to one crew may receive every two or three days 200 SDG to cover living costs (*mayz*).¹³³ One 24-year-old from South Kordofan, for instance, had joined his brother's mine and received a salary of 200 SDG every two days, which he supplemented by working as *kummāji*; both covered basic living costs, additional consumption such as cheese, shisha, and mobile phone charging, and left room for dreams to enable him to build something from the money earned in mining before returning to the studies he had left behind.¹³⁴

Their changing but generally small share of the ultimately extracted gold could still be profitable for them. However, the actual productivity of a mine depended on lucky finds and attracting a good workforce, with these factors mutually reinforcing each other. There was a very wide range of outputs; a sack of ore might yield vastly different amounts of gold. Although the sack size is nearly standardised, as plastic sacks from sugar production are used, the varying sizes and types of rocks will affect how much the sacks are filled and their weight; normally, one sack carries about 80-90 kg.¹³⁵ Accordingly, one major mine might produce more than 3kg per day, while another only yields 1kg or 500g. Small, peripheral mines may produce just a few grams to cover costs, or not even that.

After a shift, once all the collected ore has been processed and sold, the mine owner and/or operation funder will deduct administrative and processing costs, sometimes excluding production costs, and then split the remaining amount 50/50 with the crew. This ratio may vary based on agreements and the number of parties involved, but the unequal profit-sharing persists, where a larger number of workers often receive the same or even less profit than a few mine owners. The crew will subsequently review each member's expenses and distribute the remaining funds.

Still, financial risk was imminent; processing ore could cost up to 400 SDG per sack for administrative and labour fees alone, and might not yield any gold at all, which necessitated borrowing or becoming indebted to continue the operation.¹³⁶ This was why

¹³³ The money values quoted in this chapter serve as rough indicators of scale and as references for other socio-economic studies. Due to the complex exchange situation – with a large disparity between the official and unofficial rates, the latter being more significant and simultaneously far from standardised – converting them into Euro or dollar values could create a misleading impression of equivalence.

¹³⁴ Interviewed on 15 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹³⁵ The rough material and handling would render the plastic sacks unusable after a few uses, indicating a very high consumption of such sacks in mining areas. However, the present research did not explore this issue further, specifically how the trade in sacks was related to the value chain and what happened to this large volume of plastic waste after use.

¹³⁶ The prices varied greatly depending on the expected ore quality, besides the fluctuating costs for preliminary stone crushing (at the shafts), transport, washing, and the empty sacks.

cash-holding parties in the market, such as goldsmiths, served as both a safety net and a form of financial control: being a cash-based exchange, disagreements with any part of the processing pathway – the mill workers, the washers – could cause a prolonged disruption in one's operations.

The largest disparity in income distribution thus arose between those who could utilise capital to acquire means of production and finance operations, and those who could not. Accordingly, the highest profits were in smithery, brokerage, and the subsequent trade of gold outside the area, not counting secondary services which occasionally, for example in the case of water transportation, could outperform the profit margins of the mining itself.¹³⁷

After this broader overview, we can explore the gold market of Belguwa. In November 2019, the main market had 17 goldsmith shops that only partially managed ore processing and gold selling, as goldsmiths and jewellers primarily funded the production process and purchased gold after washing. This could involve the entire operation if a goldsmith was a mine owner, bought the tools, and paid for running costs, or just part of the process: for example, if someone had ore but lacked enough money for the mill and washing, goldsmiths might fund these stages.¹³⁸ If the gold grade was insufficient to cover these expenses, a state of debt arose, which seemed quite common, positioning goldsmiths centrally in finance due to their ready cash to cover costs. In fact, most of the basins belonged to goldsmiths, some to mine owners; nobody remained solely a mine or basin owner.

The basins had a similar structure, where the gold washers would take a fee from those who brought crushed ore and share it in a pre-arranged way with the basin owner. However, there were several milling and washing processes with different profit profiles. Apart from the initial crushing of ore from the mines, the dust-like residues of the first washing were subjected to several re-washing processes, each with a different profit margin depending on costs for acquiring the tailings (*kartah*).

Tailings brokers entered this market confidently, using available capital to buy *kartah* from lower-income washers to sell to those able to invest in further washings; some goldsmiths also covered this segment of the market, as they were often already in agreement with the miners but had – whether as mine owners or otherwise – no claim to the tailings,

In November 2019, an example of a cost structure for processing one sack in Belguwa market was: 50 SDG for transport from mine to market (donkey cart or tuk-tuk), 120 SDG administrative fee at entry, 100 SDG for milling, 120 SDG for washing, with a total of 390 SDG.

¹³⁷ In the entire sample of mining-related respondents (N = 1913), 69.6% reported owning a hammer, 25.4% a jackhammer, 15.5% a basin for washing ore powder (*hawq*), 4% a metal detector, 3.3% equipment to burn amalgam, 0.5% a loader, and 0.2% a mill, illustrating the overall impact of procurement costs on ownership.

¹³⁸ The processing operations also had to address supply bottlenecks, particularly in gasoline, motor oil, and mercury.

which were generally regarded as the property of the washers but were at some point claimed by the Locality.

If not directly sold to companies processing ore with cyanide, the processing of tailings involved milling and washing in water-driven mills, with the addition of mercury. The cost structure was different because more inputs were required – more mercury, more grease – and additional complications arose, such as the interaction of grease with mercury and pollution of gold by elements like antimony. The washing process was also significantly longer.

The difficulty in accurately measuring the relation between costs and profits is immense, as shown by the simple question of how much mercury was needed, which directly influenced processing costs for the miners. Much depends on the rock composition (for example, silicates like mica are easier to separate than other elements), size (nuggets require more mercury than gold dust), and the estimates made by workers of how much mercury will be needed. Even measurements were inconsistent, as reference values changed – such as the then recent shift from troy ounce (*waqiyyah*, 31.1g) to the avoirdupois ounce (28.4g) for measuring mercury – while the common unit, a lid (*ġutā'* or *ġutāyah*), was far from standardised, as was the amount of mercury used.¹³⁹ Subsequent mercury-gold ratios varied vastly, from 1g/1g to 5g/1g or higher.¹⁴⁰ However, the more gold that could be extracted in a single washing process, the more profitable it became to use additional mercury if the investor could afford it, and 1g of gold from one sack could suffice to cover the relatively low costs of purchasing tailings and paying for the processing.¹⁴¹

The integration of various elements of the value chain within a single entity created a form of control. For example, a goldsmith might own basins and a stake in a mine, cover workers' living costs during shifts and other production expenses like heavy tools and electricity, and later purchase all the gold extracted. However, the fact that multiple owners shared ownership not only of the mining and processing facilities but also

¹³⁹ According to one worker, the typical rate was ½ to 1 lid per sack, depending on gold content and rock type; limestone had a much lower rate, with ½ to 1 lid for every 5 sacks (interview with washer, 7 August 2019, Belguwa).

¹⁴⁰ Goldsmiths selling to miners might give them small amounts (e.g., up to 50g) for 'free' as part of the prefinance; otherwise, mercury was sold for 1400-1500 SDG per 100g (interview with goldsmith, 7 August 2019, Belguwa). This already yielded a good profit, as mercury cost 8000 SDG per kg from the wholesalers, and with a good mercury-gold ratio (e.g., 1g to produce 1g), this could result in 1kg of gold worth about 2,500,000 SDG. Mercury traders mixed products from Spain, Italy, and Egypt.

¹⁴¹ The tailings held by an average dump truck (*qallāb*), with a load of 16t, were sold in August 2019 for 7000 SDG. This occurred after the mining company Pluto left the market, using its connections to the authorities to monopolise tailings and set high purchase prices for others (last: 23000 SDG), while also processing them independently. At the time of the fieldwork, washing workers had the freedom to negotiate the price. The fact that Pluto was a joint venture involving a Blue Nile State NCP cadre, 'Ammār 'Uṭmān 'Alī Mūsā, and Chinese investors such as Bancheng Lin, makes this a possible achievement or at least an opportunity of the initial transitional period.

recovered some costs from the workers complicates efforts to accurately trace the distribution of profits.

There were also variations in the final quality of gold, as the specific alloy only becomes apparent during the melting process in the colour of the gold, a circumstance that led to some fraudulent practices of adulteration.¹⁴² The local selling price was close to uniform but subject to constant fluctuations, similar to the global price, and also depended on colour-coded categories of gold: green gold, with about 40% silver content, was more common in other areas (Maganza, Bakori) and had a price of 2000 SDG/g in August 2019. Purer red gold with copper, predominant in Belguwa, typically fetched around 2600-2700 SDG/g, reduced to 2500 SDG in August as many traders went on pilgrimage (*hajj*).¹⁴³ Another major event, discussed further below, was the market's closure for several months in the first half of 2019, when the price fell to 1700 SDG, as only a few traders were willing to risk coming to Belguwa.

Another source of gold was surface nuggets from Ethiopia that had been 'smuggled' in, often good, expensive pieces that were distributed by the untaxed trade through the market as well. Due to the depreciation of the Sudanese pound, this trade had become less attractive but the price was with 2700-2800 SDG/g still higher than the local product.¹⁴⁴ When gold was sent to Khartoum, which was infrequent due to low production, the prices at the central gold market (*'imārat al-qāhab*) in Khartoum were usually 100-200 SDG higher than the local price. Typically, there was a specific agent in Khartoum with whom gold producers and goldsmiths collaborated.

However, no single entity held an unquestioned monopoly over any of these processes. For example, some miners acquired the knowledge to melt gold into a trade-ready form, while some intermediary traders either bypassed the goldsmiths and bought directly at the basins, often at higher prices, or even avoided the market altogether and purchased gold directly at the mines. This not only complicated the middle structure of the value chain, as workers circumvented giving the investor or absent shaft owner their share or were in a position to withhold information on actual production; it also made it more difficult to trace how much gold was actually produced and sold in general.

Simultaneously, the increasing value chain shifted control over local natural resources to in-migrants with access to cash capital and connections to central state institutions. The disparity in tools and operation size created a divide between the older, family-based mining community and the in-migrating miners. The former continued their traditional practice from Benishangul and around Qeissan of washing gold in pans (*qadah*), avoiding

¹⁴² A goldsmith recounted an incident where three boys learned how to blend additional elements into gold from a Nuer working in the area (interviewed on 7 August 2019, Belguwa). This included, for example, copper, which was spread under the ore to increase the volume of the final alloy.

¹⁴³ Fineness was claimed to be very high, 940-960, i.e., between 22 and 24 carats (interview with goldsmith, 7 August 2019, Belguwa).

¹⁴⁴ According to a goldsmith, there was a similar arrangement between traders and smugglers and workers there, as the former provided detectors and covered other costs to be favoured in receiving the gold pieces that had been found (interviewed on 7 August 2019, Belguwa).

investment in stone mills, basins, and heavier machinery. Their identity as professional miners with centuries of experience, including 30 years in this area, led them to see the land as their domain and fostered a reluctance to change or upgrade tools and methods—possibly reinforced by a tendency towards living relatively isolated lives, detached from broader social and political influences. This resistance to adopting new techniques introduced during the recent gold rush meant that most advanced means of production—and consequently the higher profit potential—remained in the hands of the in-migrants or external investors, with their profit margins and capital accumulation remaining limited. As a result, there was almost no residential ownership of jackhammers, mills, basins, generators, or even market facilities and their goods.¹⁴⁵

Administrative control

The shift in economic power towards non-regional populations mentioned above was accompanied – though not entirely mirrored – by a change in administrative authority. This was a longer process, from initially hosting the in-migrants from Qeissan and their growing demand for autonomous status in Belguwa, to a new wave of miners from other areas, and ultimately to the establishment of a permanent presence of central government officials.

The narratives we collected suggested that nobody was living, in the sense of residing, in the area around Jabal Belguwa until 1987, when people from Qeissan and Kurmuk, Fa-Dūqā, were displaced there during the second civil war. They were hosted by the sheikhdōm (*maṣayḥah*) of Khor Al-Qannā, initially farming and cutting wood in the area, then drawn to Belguwa by the serendipitously discovered gold. A sheikh-based system for handling disputes was maintained, whether over mining, encroachment of livestock on farms, theft or rare killings, and further judicial procedures or institutional follow-up was almost unknown, partly due to the lack of road connections before the heightening of the Roseiris Dam and the absence of any police station or similar institution until a few years earlier.

The significance of this background lies in the observation that it was a system of governance that continued into the later Mining Committees (*lijān al-ta'dīn*), which was further supplemented by a Miner Union (*'ittiḥād al-ma'danīn*). This also related to the broader relationship between claims of older and new residents: the circumstance that these representative bodies were apparently dominated by Fa-Dūqā leaders, who additionally developed a closer connection with the SMRC representatives, marked another element in the struggles over governance and control in the area.

In more detail: Tension between the 'hosts' and the 'newcomer' communities arose over the claim of Belguwa's resident mining communities to have full control over mining in this area, a claim not only challenged by communal representatives in the Nile-adjacent settlements, who considered it part of the territorial *'umudiyyah* system and believed all

¹⁴⁵ When one resident bought a ventilator for his mine in November 2019, it was such a rare event that he organised a celebration with charitable servings (*karāmah*) of meat and other food.

residents were merely hosted there for the purpose of working in mining,¹⁴⁶ but also questioned by the actual practices of profit distribution described in the previous section.

The relocation of many villages due to the heightening of the Roseiris Dam has complicated a village-based system of communal representation (*al-'idārah al-'ahliyyah*), which was already a product of colonial transformation of earlier systems, where settlements were linked to a representative seat; Madīnah 6, as mentioned earlier, hosted several communities and their representatives. However, a territorial perspective on such representation persisted: Wad Al-Māhī Locality, which was separated from Roseiris Locality in 2016, consisted of the three *'umudiyyāt* of Abū Shendi East, Fazughli East and Hamaj East, further divided into sheikhdoms.

Despite attempts at political instrumentalisation under various regimes, this representational system drew its significance and authority from referencing the historical royal structure of the former kingdom of Fazughli. It was a line of inherited positions connecting the communities of former Khor Al-Qannā and Abū Shendi to the old kingdom. This self-understanding, as revealed by several sheikhs interviewed in Madīnah 6, meant that any challenge to their authority over the area was seen as denying the continued existence of this connection. For them, mining added further complications, as it required balancing this historical reference, the complex distribution of economic control, the dominant presence of the NCP regime and its institutions, and the uncertain status of armed forces, from the regionally rooted SAF leadership to the ethnopolitically tense SPLA.¹⁴⁷

Belguwa was variably situated among these *'umudiyyāt* and sheikhdoms: partly in Abū Shendi East and partly in Fazughli East, yet functioning as an almost autonomous administrative unit. Consequently, the residential communal representatives of the Nile settlements could see themselves as both included and marginalised in the management of conflicts in the mining areas, which were handled by the aforementioned committees.

The sheikh of the Belguwa community of Fa-Dūqā was, on one hand, a representative of the communal administrative system and thus fulfilled its function. However, on the other hand, he held no authority or ownership of any land within the territorial understanding but simply represented his community.¹⁴⁸ At the same time, the authority of the other communities over the areas around Jabal Belguwa had already been significantly diminished compared to the 1980s and 1990s, before the Belguwa community registered its own sheikh. An indication of the ongoing tension between formal and actual authority was that the other sheikhs and *'umad* still refused to recognise him as the full sheikh, instead viewing him only as their delegate (*wakīl*) in the area. The attempt to establish a

¹⁴⁶ A perspective expressed here by the sheikh of Khor Al-Qannā East / Wad Al-Māhī, interviewed extensively on 18 November 2019, Belguwa.

¹⁴⁷ In this case, this tension arose from the (perceived) dominance of Ingessana under Malik Agar, and the counterbalance represented by Joseph Tuka and 'Abd Al-'Azīz Al-Hīluw, similar to the situation of Uduk and Maban groups.

¹⁴⁸ The sheikh of Khor Al-Qannā stated that there had been repeated attempts over the past 20 years to formalise the geographical boundaries with the sheikhdom, but these efforts were unsuccessful due to the lack of cooperation from the older community representatives (interviewed on 18 November 2019, Belguwa).

shared committee, begun in 2018, remained contentious, particularly regarding land claims and geographical boundaries, in other words, the claim of autonomy by the ‘newcomer’ community of Belguwa. While this had not resulted in violence, disputes and court cases persisted due to these contradictions.

This was supplemented by the ‘new outsiders’ of the recent gold rush. Their economic dominance, as noted earlier, was more tangible than the symbolic competition over inherited or gained administrative authority. While far from experiencing a xenophobic backlash, in-migrant miners interviewed in Belguwa expressed the impression that local residents were not comfortable with the presence of ‘foreigners’ as competitors.

This also raises the issue of sharing revenues from gold mining, and it is here that the increasing role of government organs became significant. In 2015, the Sudanese Mineral Resources Company (SMRC) established a more permanent presence and began collecting taxes and other levies on ore brought to the gold market. The organisation of mines and collection of administrative fees remained under the control of communal representatives, but the SMRC gained a strong extractive position through a 10% profit charge on all gold processed in the market. The absence or limitation of reciprocal services, such as technical support, health services, water, etc., frustrated both miners and residential communities; far from being unaware of social responsibility concerns, they also demanded environmental protection and local benefits from resource extraction, but struggled to find pressure points to assert such claims.

A deeper layer of tensions in the area was the successive withdrawal of authority over landed resources from communal representatives to central state organs in Damazin and Khartoum, whether regarding land property or operation licenses. Both were seen as their own domains, and frequent transgressions were seen as direct challenges to their roles and rights.¹⁴⁹ In this context, the encroachment on agricultural land and the lack of control over natural resource revenues were not just economic issues. The expansion of mining into areas whose spatial and productive limits were already a sensitive issue for residents displaced by the dam heightening, and who were surrounded by hostile war dynamics, added another layer to tense relations between the state and citizens.

Clashes

A deeper appreciation of the exact nature of these underlying tensions requires a reminder of the political context. The SMRC was not only a government agency that, like most governmental bodies under the Ingāḍ regime, combined civil administration with military control by employing both geologists and national security agents. This dual role also had concerning implications in an area close to the operational spheres of armed forces, which held a strong influence over gold mining and other economic activities in different parts of the state.

¹⁴⁹ The sheikh of Khor Al-Qannā East, for instance, complained about an encroachment on his land in Ḥaymūrah by miners licensed by the federal Ministry of Mining, despite its previous registration as agricultural land. Afraid of being accused of rebellion, he did not pursue his claim (interviewed on 18 November 2019, Belguwa).

The physical presence of state organs, other than armed forces, was a relatively recent development in the area; the Locality could be deemed a relatively safe part of Blue Nile State, although a history of insecurity in the broader region had resulted in a widespread network of checkpoints and military camps. At the time of fieldwork, the gold market of Belguwa also housed the SMRC office with officials from other regions, national security agents (NISS), and four executive units: civil/criminal police (2), mining police (1), security police (1), and military intelligence (2). A police station had been established in 2016 but only acquired jurisdiction over issues such as property violations and land disputes after the events of early 2019.

The underlying tensions surfaced when the Blue Nile state government decided on 1 November 2018 to increase profit charges from 10% to 20% to fill budget gaps. The rejection of this increase was widespread among miners. While it initially caused a halt to mining activities and protests, the lack of government response to both escalated the situation: in February 2019, the offices of the SMRC and NISS were burnt down. In response, SAF forces were deployed, emptied the market, and halted most activities.¹⁵⁰

Another confrontation involved the company compounds of Pluto and Advanced Mining Works. While their status as investments close to the higher circles of the Inqāḍ regime shielded them from scrutiny and accountability for environmental and other damages they caused, the downfall of Umar Al-Bashir seemed to signal to discontented populations a possibility to assert long-lasting demands: at the end of April 2019, people living around Belguwa set fire to the gold processing facilities to halt operations, apart from renewed protests in the market. The state authorities' initial responses were harsh; the military arrested protesters, took further control of the area, and dismissed company workers who were accused of cooperating with the protesters.

The fact that it was the army, rather than one of the many military wings of national security or even civilian police, regaining control, can be attributed not only to their previous strong presence along Blue Nile's battle lines. What was evident in these events was also the dominance of SAF and the newly empowered RSF developing during the transitional period, as mentioned above, including the integration of NISS/GIS's operational units, an aspect examined more closely in the Maganza study (see below). However, despite their substantial presence during the weeks of the clashes, the army did not remain stationed in the market and instead left the situation to a reinforced police presence.

When our research team arrived at the Belguwa gold market in November 2019, everything appeared to have settled into a relaxed state: people sitting, drinking tea and coffee, engaging in light-hearted small talk, joking, and playing cards. Quarrels were uncommon, and open hostilities rare. The remaining executive forces in the area mingled easily, ate and drank with the researchers, and chatted. The distinction between the units was clear from their uniforms when worn. However, not only the civil police (*al-šurṭah al-*

¹⁵⁰ This was the situation, as it was described by residential miners during a scoping visit in March 2019. The timing of both the increase in profit charges and several waves of protests varied across subsequent interviews.

madaniyyah), which was usually plain-clothed, but also the other forces did not always wear their uniforms, which reflected a fairly relaxed attitude and the fact that they, as well as the security agents, were generally known to the people by name.

The relationship between executive forces and communal representatives, who form the Mining Committee, appeared complementary. They were not only meant to intervene in thefts, the sale of forged gold, or disputes that could escalate, but also to prevent shares of mines from being sold without involving the sheikhs. The committee was endowed with a broad range of administrative powers, from supervising contracts to setting the price of tea in the market. They also served as a link to the Locality, which provided them with official IDs and regarded them as intermediaries for all official steps miners needed to undertake, thus affirming their status as elites in the area. Problems as they arose would be discussed both with them and the Miner Union, and several arrangements, such as the shift period system described above, appeared designed to reduce tensions and the severity of competition.

But the presence of the executive forces also served as a reminder of the events and the still strained relationship between the miners and the SMRC, not merely because they were guarding the safe with the revenues. There was a general reluctance to discuss what had happened – it was never mentioned unless actively asked – and when it was, responses were cautious: miners would say that burning the offices had prompted the company to bring in some services and better personnel who were more lenient with the fees; SMRC staff would say that the army intervention had taught the people to behave better towards them.

Both statements reveal a continuation of an underlying imbalance, however. When the market was reopened a few months after the events, the SMRC began to introduce some services, such as an ambulance, whose fuel costs still had to be paid by the patients, with an 800 SDG fee per trip. While accepted as a positive outcome of the pressure they had exerted, miners remained clear about viewing this as a halfway solution unfairly burdening them, as taxpayers; but open complaints or even protests were suppressed.

A similar situation occurred with the market entry fee. After the violent protests of February 2019, the legislative council responded by setting the tax at 120 SDG per sack of ore brought to the market.¹⁵¹ But its character as a forceful, illegitimate extraction from low-income miners persisted, and half-hearted service provision, such as the ambulance, did not alter the SMRC's position as the primary target of complaints against the government presence in the market. Nonetheless, others, particularly traders for whom such fees were a negligible cost, rather welcomed the increased police and security forces presence.

In any case, both the ambulance and entry fee were subjects of an unsettled relationship between the state and citizens, which took the form of bargains rather than a reciprocal social contract. As a result, taking advantage seemed to be part of the game rather than a breach of one's obligations as a citizen.

¹⁵¹ This was meant to be implemented across the entire state; however, in August 2019, fees in Maganza were considerably lower, at 60 SDG per sack, although the military presence there also resulted in additional levies.

The 120 SDG fee was part of a series of administrative fees levied along the value chain:¹⁵²

- goldsmiths: 1500 SDG annual license (*ruḥṣah*) [Locality] and 100 SDG monthly certification fees (*taṣḍīq*) [locally]
- basins: 700-1000 SDG annually [Locality]
- commercial shops: 800-1000 SDG annually [Locality]
- small cafés and restaurants: 300 SDG quarterly, paid irregularly, depending on trips made by tax collectors and their leniency [Locality]
- SMRC: 500 SDG monthly to 6 individuals of executive forces, plus per diems (400 SDG/day = 12,000 SDG monthly)¹⁵³

Apart from the variability in fee and tax collection shown in the list, there were also many other cases illustrating that these charges were open to negotiation rather than fixed formal rules. One notable example was the exemption of women and children from the entry fee, which was a common practice—not only for individuals entering through the gates but also for those arriving with tuk-tuks and other transport vehicles. This leniency led to agreements between male miners and women to transport their ore. However, even men have been observed to gain concessions, depending on their bargaining skills and the willingness of the gatekeepers to allow them.

Nevertheless, it remained a common theme in conversations and interviews to complain about the SMRC and, by extension, the state and its institutions, summarised as *a/-ḥākūmah*, a hostile body that could mistreat them at any moment—whether as rebels, people to be removed, or suspects—an extractive force that collects taxes without providing services in return and favours companies that steal their gold. Simultaneously, they suffered from the lack of most basic services such as safe water, transportation, and nearby healthcare. In the end, all they could do was keep bargaining.¹⁵⁴

¹⁵² According to residential miners interviewed in March 2019, the fees had been 30 SDG before 2017, then successively increased to 50 SDG and 100 SDG. This last increase came after the protests of early 2019.

¹⁵³ The fact that the SMRC paid for the security forces was rarely seen as a service; at the same time, it highlights the special status that mining areas held in terms of public services, since policing would be a normal state service if Belguwa were classified as a standard residential area.

¹⁵⁴ One of the ‘weapons of the weak’ was administrative refusal. In Belguwa, only 7.2% of the surveyed miners (N=843) reported having a licence, most of whom believed it offered some kind of protection or facilitation, but none claimed to benefit from additional services. In the overall sample (N=1913), 36.8% responded positively, though their reasons were primarily to avoid sanctions or disadvantages associated with not holding a written permit.

Bakori

Features of social and mining history

Bakori was a small marketplace beside the eponymous village, serving as a transit point to Ethiopia from Damazin, accessible via Deim in the east and Qeissan in the south. It was adjacent to Khor Tumat, which extended southward into Qeissan and further into Benishangul in Ethiopia. Its history was shaped by the presence of traders, a diverse mix of groups with roots in both Sudan and Ethiopia.¹⁵⁵ The core of the population consisted of the descendants of hill communities intermingling with traders from northern Sudan, known by the exonym Al-Jabalāwiyyīn, meaning ‘mountain people’, who had been central to the slave trade until the early 20th century. While most of their descendants in 2019 relied on subsistence agriculture and animal husbandry, particularly small ruminants, Bakori was also surrounded by agricultural investment ventures, primarily owned by traders from other regions and focused on citrus fruit production.¹⁵⁶

Bakori also lies north of a cluster of areas affected by war before 2005 and after 2011, and displacement from southern Blue Nile added new layers to the resident population. Some of them, such as the Raqārīq/Āgārīq from Kurmuk, arrived during the previous war, while others, like Marāmzah from Jabal Marmaz in Ethiopia, arrived more recently. Bakori’s residential structure in 2019 reflected this influx through what became the new majority among the approximately 26,000 inhabitants: some of the newcomers’ quarters, such as Ḥayy Al-Mazād and Ḥayy Bansū, were more numerous than the older ones. This process was not without conflicts, as older segments of the population initially refused to host miners who ended up occupying and settling on land without formal papers.¹⁵⁷

In any case, the high level of mobility and the connection between multiple mining areas and gold markets through social and economic networks became quite evident. Many of the areas where the displaced settled, such as Khor Al-Dahab and Khartoum Bi-Layl, were

¹⁵⁵ A mountain or hill named ‘Bagori’ was marked on a map of Russegger in 1843, situated directly along the road to Fazughli. See https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/9/9b/Karte_der_Länder_am_Tumat_und_blauen_Flusse.jpg.

¹⁵⁶ Interview with employee of SMRC, son of ‘*umdah* in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori.

¹⁵⁷ This was the case according to an interview with an employee of SMRC and son of ‘*umdah* in Bakori (7 August 2019, Bakori), which might also reflect a more general impression that the previous residents have become the minority. A policeman in Damazin, with access to official statistics, stated that the displaced in Bakori numbered 12,000 and came from Qaranqālū, Qeissan, and Khor Al-Dahab; however, his overall population count was 35,000, so both could simply have used different definitions of ‘newcomers’ (interview 3 December 2019 Damazin). There were other quarters indicating external origins of its inhabitants, such as Ḥayy Al-Ḥuḍūr (a group of northern in-migrants) or Ḥayy Al-Jundī East and West (soldiers). Other quarters included Al-Rahaj, Al-Hadabah, Al-Šāṭī, Al-Radmiyyah, Al-Qal’ah, Abāqūnā, Al-Tajammu’, and Al-‘Ašāšīr (interview 7 August 2019, Bakori). The population was served by two health centres, five primary schools, and one secondary school (interview 3 December 2019, Damazin).

also mining regions, establishing a strong link between in-migration and gold mining.¹⁵⁸ This was not an innovation in itself, as many of these were historical gold mining areas: Belqūlā, Sheikh Ḥassan, Daldūm, Amūrū, Belābrū, Bābā Hāšim and Khartoum Bi-Layl itself. However, the perception of one of the older residents was that gold had not played a central role in Bakori before, neither socially nor commercially; rain-fed sorghum production and livestock herding were their mainstays.¹⁵⁹

The influx of new people during and after war periods since the early 2000s brought about significant demographic, technological, and economic changes related to gold mining and trade: communal gold washing in wooden bowls or troughs (*al-qadah*) for a small extra income shifted towards complex mining communities digging shafts in pursuit of life-changing profits from supraregional trade. In other words, both displacement caused by war in southern areas and the expansion of the gold rush in northern areas introduced Bakori to new dynamics within its gold value chain (see also Bulang study).

Similar to the Ingessana Hills, this process had already begun during the negotiation of the CPA, arguably linked to the start of the Darfur war. It saw an increasing influx of miners from western Sudan who introduced shaft mining, along with its associated technologies such as motorised sieves, stone crushers, and mercury for gold extraction. Simultaneously, the previously dominant search for surface gold was elevated through the introduction of mobile metal detectors, which remained the primary occupation of the resident miners from Blue Nile State.¹⁶⁰

The increased productivity of in-migrating groups also led to a shift in power relations, and their growing dominance in the extractive process did not go unnoticed. This affected not only the displaced population but also thousands of miners from across Sudan, initially often Masalit from western Sudan, some of whom settled in Bakori, then Rashaydah and Zibaydiyyah during the early phase of the gold rush, as well as people from Gezira, Gedarif, and the mining regions throughout northern and eastern Sudan.¹⁶¹

¹⁵⁸ Interview with SMRC employee [AI], 29 June 2019, Damazin.

¹⁵⁹ Interview with old resident, 21 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁶⁰ Interview with old resident, 21 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁶¹ Interview with old resident, 21 November 2019, Bakori; [interview with SMRC employee \[AI\], 15 November 2019, Bakori](#). The latter was the official directly in charge of government-miner relations in Bakori.

Mining activities

The mining areas fell into two different types of terrain that reflected variations in seasons, used technologies, and division of labour: the watercourses with alluvial gold and the mountains with underground veins. Both were divided into numerous small operational zones; among underground mining areas (roughly 1000-2000 shafts overall), there were the following with different profiles and life cycle phase:¹⁶²

- **Abāsīn/Abāsīn/Abū Asin:** was very productive for 6 months, but the lack of machinery (excavators) led to hazardous shaft digging that put workers in danger of drowning, suffocation, and/or collapse;
- **Al-Ḥarṭūm Bil-Layl [Khartoum at night]:** worked for two years and ceased in May 2019 due to low productivity;
- **Bābā Hāšim:** was the largest mine with high productivity but was halted by the commander of the 13th Brigade after repeated SPLA attacks on miners;
- **Belqūlā:** produced in 2019 enough to host thousands of miners, the grade was on average 1-2g per sack;
- **Guantānamo:** had highly productive shafts but with low quality of gold;
- **Jājā:** was problematic due to isolation, as miners were at risk from wildlife and SPLA soldiers alike;
- **Kašankrū:** had about 40 mines when military intelligence halted them for being too close to SPLA activities;
- **Qūnī:** had tough rocks that were hard to break and caused injuries and fractures.

As shown by these examples, the mines varied in their location, productivity, and the level of safety experienced by miners, leading to multiple choices when deciding where to go, even within a specific mining area. Drinking water and other essential resources might be more or less available, and a shortage could force the closure of mining sites. The longer the mines operate, the deeper the shafts must be, increasing problems with oxygen levels and requiring ventilators. This also raises the risk of shaft collapses or water ingress needing pumping, while gold grade might decrease or increase. Although heavy machinery was generally uncommon in this area due to difficult terrain hindering transportation, years of pressure from SPLA troops also restricted hydraulic excavators and loaders to only a few locations.¹⁶³ Conversely, areas rich in gold, such as Ušambo 40 km south-east of Bakori, experienced more conflicts between miners.¹⁶⁴

¹⁶² Interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori; interview with mill owner, 15 November 2019, Bakori; interview with employee of SMRC, son of 'umdaḥ in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori; interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori.

Other names were Abā Fasaṇq/Aba Falsan, Aklīlī / Uklīlī, Al-Ḥaymūrah, Al-Rahīd, Belābūlah, Belkūkū, Būfī, Ḥaṭ al-Madāris, Ḥaṭ al-Mōyah, Ḥaṭ Ibrāhīm, Ḥaṭ Ramaḍān, Ījū / Igo, Ilyās (Janūb / Janūb Ġarīb), Qaranqālū, Raḥmat Al-Tillāh, Šankarū, Šariq al-Tumat, Ušimbo/Ušambo, 'Imād Dūlū).

¹⁶³ Interview with goldsmith active in Bakori since 2017, 15 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁶⁴ Interview with police officer, 3 December 2019, Damazin.

There was also, as in similar climatic zones, a pronounced difference between the dry and the rainy season; the hot months of the dry season were the main period for shaft mining, from March to June, while the rainy season was more favourable for searching for alluvial gold: shafts would be filled with water, especially those located in watercourses; surface gold became easier to find. The interruption of transportation during the rains also caused in-migrating traders, goldsmiths, and miners to retreat to other areas inside or outside the state or to return home, while residential, communal mining continued unimpeded.¹⁶⁵

However, it was the structure and extent of the value chain that significantly influenced how fluctuations in output affected the decision to continue or halt operations. Profitability in small-scale shaft mining was assessed on a high standard, where 1g/sack (90 kg) was deemed the minimum acceptable output, corresponding to a grade of 11.1g/t that can compete with the most productive industrial mines worldwide,¹⁶⁶ and a mine producing fewer than 10 sacks of ore per day was considered below average.¹⁶⁷ What appears to be a relatively high output had to cover a quite substantial percentage of expenses, which included living costs (*al-mayz*) for the workers, tools (sacks, shovels, hammers etc.), transport, milling, washing, and administrative fees, after which a significant number of shareholders would be paid out: the main shareholders were the owner of the mine and the workers, and the general convention was a 50-50 split between them. However, the actual structure of shareholders was often more complicated.¹⁶⁸

Taking ownership of a mine was mainly a process of implementation where simply starting a shaft marked a claim, leading to the initiation of many lines. The formation of local Mining Committees by the SMRC following the formalisation of gold markets was, ostensibly, meant to introduce greater regulation into this process. Similar to the claim that this was to reduce conflicts over mines, an employee of the SMRC suggested that the subsequent change in fee collection was to resolve contradictory claims to profit shares: previously, 10% of profits were to be given to resident communities through their representatives, who claimed historical property rights and viewed mining as land custody (*ḥiyāzah*).¹⁶⁹ This was reorganised by the SMRC and enforced through the Economic Security branch of NISS by establishing the Mining Committee; the fact that the sheikh would also often serve as the head of this committee might be interpreted as meaning that the new regulation did not eliminate communal claims but simply

¹⁶⁵ Interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori; interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁶⁶ The highest recorded grade was in Ḥaṭ al-Mōyah ('Line of Water'), with 10g per sack or 111g per tonne. The World Gold Council defines a high-grade underground mine as having between 8-10g/t. In 2014, the highest gold grade in an industrial mine was 44.1g/t (<https://www.mining.com/the-worlds-highest-grade-gold-mines/>).

¹⁶⁷ Interview with employee of SMRC, son of 'umdah in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori.

¹⁶⁸ Interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁶⁹ Another form of – again ostensibly – communal claim was the compulsory task to hand over one shaft in each line to the sheikh, who would then utilise members of his own community to work for him. In some cases, up to a third of the profits were taken by the communal representatives (interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori). There were a few areas, such as Abā Falsan, where no communal claims existed.

centralised the collection of shares, provided that the involvement of the sheikh is understood, indeed, as a system of communal shares in mining revenues.

An 'owner' will often be present in the mining area; in fact, he might well be a former or even a current worker in other mines, simply increasing his overall profit if he manages to establish a productive shaft.¹⁷⁰ There were, however, dynamics of monopolisation, and examples were provided of mine owners who succeeded in bringing a large number of mines under their control by establishing themselves as central funders of the operation during the critical stage until a shaft would finance itself. This also included owning shops in the market that supplied the commodities they distributed to the workers. A similar strategy allowed goldsmiths to control large segments of the value chain, as they will temporarily cover living and other costs, and then acquire the processed gold themselves and trade it to the central markets.¹⁷¹

Low gold grades in rocks can soon put workers in debt to mill owners, washers, goldsmiths, and others; however, unlike Belguwa and Bulang, for instance, living costs were mostly regarded as shared expenses rather than advances on the workers' share.¹⁷² There was thus a crucial decision whether to include creditors or not: on the one hand, the transition to mine ownership, as shown, was much smoother than, for instance, in northern Sudan where no reliable property rights were acquired, and simply doing the work established such ownership. Additionally, the prevailing profit share distribution of 50% to the owner and the team made it already less attractive for the latter than what was customary in other areas. The inclusion of a creditor could not merely add the obligation to repay the credit but also require a deduction of a 33% profit share.¹⁷³ Conversely, low-grade operations can be quite hard to finance independently.

In comparison, the parallel activity of small-scale surface gold washing (*rūt*) remained a communal effort, where people equipped with wooden, or now metal pans, axes and more often detectors went to the creeks near their villages to wash dust for some extra income, mostly during the rainy season.¹⁷⁴ But two circumstances intertwined the two types of gold extraction. Firstly, goldsmiths and traders did not always wait for gold to reach the market in Bakori; they would often be present in the mining areas to purchase the output directly. Some meet workers with metal detectors, for example in Igo, Khor Ḥassan, and Ušambo, who sell to them directly; others encounter *rūt* workers in weekly markets where *rūt* gold is brought and bought.¹⁷⁵

¹⁷⁰ Interview with SMRC employee [AI], 15 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁷¹ Interview with miner, 21 November 2019, Bakori; interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁷² Interview with mill owner, Bakori, 15 November 2019.

¹⁷³ Interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori; interview with mobile miner working in different areas of Sudan, 23 November 2019, on the way from Bakori to Qeissan.

¹⁷⁴ Interview with employee of SMRC, son of 'umdah in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori; [interview with SMRC employee \[AI\], 15 November 2019, Bakori](#).

¹⁷⁵ Interview with SMRC employee [AI], 15 November 2019, Bakori.

A more significant overlap occurred due to the gendering of two similar activities in both strains: women mostly performed the task of washing or panning for gold, both in creeks and markets. This gender-specific labour of ‘washing’—likely also connected to other activities within the semantic field of ‘cleaning’—remained inherently different and was to a certain extent problematic because of a technological difference with serious health consequences. Washing gold in creeks involved only water, whereas in markets, washing meant using mercury as if it were water, as though the two were interchangeable. Consequently, female washers sat in basins at the market with water rarely changed, working without protective clothing or masks, constantly risking skin and respiratory exposure; frequent cases of itching and skin peeling resulted, leading many women to switch to selling tea instead. However, since they were paid fixed rates based on the labour supply rather than a share of the profits, their earnings provided only supplementary household income rather than savings for investment, much like the low output from creek-based washing.¹⁷⁶

Market activities

Besides collecting administrative fees, the primary reason for establishing gold markets was to streamline and control the gold extraction process. This was achieved by locating stone crushers, washing basins, goldsmithing activities, and trading points in a single area. These locations also serve as spatial nodes for observing extractive governance, even in smaller and less exposed structures than Belguwa — Bakori being a good example. The following shorter profile shows that, even without the socio-political issues seen in Belguwa, there were structural reasons for avoiding taxation by state authorities.

Bakori’s general market was a relatively new institution, officially established in 2010 after a fire had destroyed the few huts that had served as shops there, such as laundry centres. A gold market was opened by the SMRC in October 2016, and while it had expanded since then, it remained comparatively small and was in November 2019 the smallest of Blue Nile’s gold markets with only one office, activating only when rocks were brought in. It held regular market days on Friday and Saturday, forming part of a circular market system with Qeissan Al-’Umm (Sunday), Aklīlī (Tuesday), Madīnah 12 (Wednesday), and a large weekly market on Thursday.¹⁷⁷

¹⁷⁶ Interview with SMRC employee [AI], 29 June 2019, Damazin; interview with employee of SMRC, son of *’umdaḥ* in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori. The same situation could be observed among young teenagers who mostly worked as *jarārīn* at the mills, changing sacks and removing dust from beneath the machines. (interview with goldsmith, 15 Nov. 2019, Bakori). The impression that many not only made little profit but were also unable to cover expenses was confirmed in our survey (see above). Interestingly, among the women questioned (N=172), responses were much more positive (79% had expenses covered and 60% made a profit). However, given the small sample, which could not account for the women’s diverse situations – married/unmarried, number and circumstances of children, etc. – this highlights just one of many aspects deserving further attention.

¹⁷⁷ Interview with employee of SMRC, son of *’umdaḥ* in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori; interview with miner, 21 Nov. 2019, Bakori; interview with police officer, 3 Dec. 2019, Damazin.

The connections between the mining areas and the gold market were both vital and difficult. The only larger transport vehicles were tractors, which were hard to fuel as subsidised petrol supplies were limited due to the lack of pump stations, and commercial petrol was excessively costly. As a result, the transport of ore and groceries was among the most expensive aspects of the mining operation.¹⁷⁸ Conversely, mining areas faced challenges in reaching the market during emergencies when motorbike drivers were not suitable options.¹⁷⁹ This became even more problematic during the rainy season, and activities were greatly reduced in the market as a result; in June 2019, for example, only about 150 people remained active there.¹⁸⁰

Only three mills had been installed and were operational, reflecting the low level of activity in the market.¹⁸¹ While prices seemed lower compared to Blue Nile's other markets, there had been a steady increase during the rainy season of 2019:

- in June, one sack cost 460 SDG to process (150 SDG transport, 120 SDG entry fee to SMRC, 150 SDG mill, 40 SDG washing);
- in August, one sack cost 605 SDG to process (200 SDG transport, 120 SDG entry fee to SMRC, 200 SDG mill + 15 SDG *jarār*, 70 SDG washing).
- In both cases, 30 SDG for an empty sack had to be added.¹⁸²

There were five goldsmiths in Bakori market in November 2019; they received the mercury-gold amalgam after washing to process it and either bought the gold or took their share according to a previous agreement. The final profit to be shared, after deducting expenses, depended on the gold price, which is notoriously volatile: during the second half of 2019 alone, the gold price per gram ranged from 1600-1800 SDG around Eid al-Adha (mid-August), then dropped to 1500 SDG, only to climb again to 2000-2200 SDG until November.¹⁸³ Combined with a minimum threshold of 1g per sack and processing costs amounting to no less than 635 SDG per sack, this implies that a barely productive shaft leaves only between 865 and 1565 SDG per sack to be shared among all shareholders. With an average output of 10 sacks daily, a crew of 10 workers, and only the owner and the crew sharing the profits, this results – excluding living costs – in a daily income of between 432.50 and 782.50 SDG, or 4325 to 7825 SDG per 10-day shift period.

This rudimentary calculation underscores the wide gap between expectations of wealth and the reality of indebtedness: if living costs, sharing with others, extraordinary expenses, etc., diminish potential income from days of hard work, it becomes clear why additional external financial demands are scrutinised. At the same time, the low figures previously mentioned also highlight the contrast with potential wealth from fortunate discoveries and/or a dominant position in the value chain. This disparity between extraordinary wealth accumulation and overwhelming debts exemplifies one of the real

¹⁷⁸ Interview with SMRC employee [AI], 29 June 2019, Damazin.

¹⁷⁹ Interview with gold miner, 15 November 2019, Bakori; interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori; interview with mill owner, 15 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁸⁰ Interview with SMRC employee [AI], 29 June 2019, Damazin.

¹⁸¹ Interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁸² Interview with SMRC employee [AI], 29 June 2019, Damazin; interview with employee of SMRC, son of *'umdah* in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori.

¹⁸³ Interview with miner, 21 November 2019, Bakori.

sources of social tension, both among different groups affected by mining and towards official institutions that entered the sector with the dual aim of regulating labour and claiming their own share.

Administrative control

Bakori lay in Qeissan Locality, but its administration was conducted from Damazin, serving as both a practical and symbolic reminder that Blue Nile State was divided into different spheres of influence defined by military control. For some, particularly miners arriving from other areas, Bakori was often seen as a ‘soft’ zone where few permits were required, aside from working with devices, and compared to areas such as Maganza, this perspective may have some validity.¹⁸⁴ However, administrative structures were still pervasive enough not to see the area as ‘ungoverned’.

Five types of institutions had administrative control over mining activities: the SMRC, representing the Ministry of Energy and Mining; the Locality, representing the federal state government; the communal representatives, under the state’s Communal Administration system; the Mining Committee, serving as a link between the previous ones; and the executive forces, including national security.

The SMRC manifested in two significant ways: firstly, through the creation of the gold market with an entry fee, in 2019, this was 120 SDG per sack; secondly, through the establishment of the Mining Committee as a mediatory instrument in the mining areas. Similar to other regions, the former was perceived by miners mainly as an extractive tool, as paying the fee – reportedly without receipt or any other proof being issued – was the sole form of interaction with officials.¹⁸⁵ Especially the lack of infrastructural improvements or technical support funded by these revenues diminished this interaction to a tribute to the central government.

Communal representation was complicated by the complex social structure of the area and questions of property and wealth sharing rights. Corresponding to the multilayered and mobile social history already outlined for Belguwa, this area was governed by 32 sheikhs acting as representatives of groups such as Raqārīq, Dawālah, Marāmzah, Waṭāwīt, Berta, Kašārah, Fa-Tanzah, Fa-Qašt, among others. Additionally, groups such as Masalit and Zaghawa, who migrated into the area, also began to settle with their own claims to representation.¹⁸⁶ These were headed by a *‘umda* positioned beneath the *mak* of Fazughli, in charge of an area from Khor Ilyās to Khor Sambah.¹⁸⁷ Furthermore, Bakori bordered lands belonging to Kurmuk Locality and communities there.¹⁸⁸

The overlapping claims have already been noted above. However, what is more significant is that the SMRC established the Mining Committee as an extension, or rather a focus, of the central organs of communal representation. Its primary role was to organise

¹⁸⁴ Interview with gold miner, 15 November 2019, Bakori; interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori; interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁸⁵ Interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁸⁶ Interview with police officer, 3 December 2019, Damazin.

¹⁸⁷ Interview with employee of SMRC, son of *‘umda* in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori.

¹⁸⁸ Interview with miner, 21 November 2019, Bakori.

operations, lease tools to miners under its authority, act as a guarantor, and most importantly, to assess and resolve issues.¹⁸⁹ Nonetheless, collaboration with communal representation also intertwined this role with defining and collecting profit shares. These were, once again, centred on the sheikh.¹⁹⁰

On this basis, it is easy to understand how two opposing views about the miners' relationship with the committee were presented: in one case, the committee was regarded as a straightforward partner who simply takes a share of one mine in each line and refrains from any other form of documentation or permit.¹⁹¹ In another, the request for a share by sheikhs of the area was considered by miners as an unacceptable increase to the fee the SMRC already collected from them, and they ceased working there.¹⁹² The circumstance that local residents often described the in-migrant miners as the dominant party in gold mining highlights the imbalance of expectations and demands at play here.

Finally, all this occurred in a borderland between two military forces vying for their own balance of power. Bakori hosted, besides a police station and several security offices (Mining, Economic, Social, GIS Lieutenant), a garrison of the 13th infantry division.¹⁹³ The presence of the latter was established in response to SPLA activity north of Qeissan, near Bakori, close to Qūsū. The SPLA's lethal threat to those holding machinery and devices was not as widespread as a territorial interpretation might suggest: many residential miners continued searching for surface gold and acquiring equipment, while being more aware of which areas to avoid. This gave them an advantage over in-migrant miners.¹⁹⁴ The remote mining areas still carried a sense of fear, and armed robberies or challenges from military personnel could happen at any moment.¹⁹⁵ A curfew in the market after 5 p.m. and on any motorised movement after sunset also demonstrated the heightened alert and military rule prevailing throughout the area.

The fact that the areas with the highest reserves are located further south, around Qeissan, Bao, and Kurmuk, may suggest, at least for opportunistic miners, that peace could bring new opportunities and wealth, as it did in the early 2000s. However, there were distribution issues underlying recurring wars in these regions—issues that remain largely unresolved. The geographical imaginaries of miners roaming through Sudan and beyond in search of riches would continue to clash with local communities' ideas of what they deserve to keep. Moreover, 'peace' as merely the absence of fighting did not necessarily equate to distributional justice, and a military prerogative over areas—even after their 'appeasement'—could easily establish relations of exchange that are not much different from those before peace agreements and transitional documents were signed.

¹⁸⁹ Interview with goldsmith, 15 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁹⁰ Interestingly, the head of the local police station, interviewed in Damazin, identified the lack of oversight of communal miners and the resulting conflicts between them as some of the main issues in the sector ([interview with police officer, 3 December 2019, Damazin](#)).

¹⁹¹ Interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁹² Interview with gold miner, 15 November 2019, Bakori.

¹⁹³ Interview with employee of SMRC, son of *'umdaḥ* in Bakori, 7 August 2019, Bakori; [interview with police officer, 3 December 2019, Damazin](#).

¹⁹⁴ Interview with mobile miner, 23 November 2019, on the way from Bakori to Qeissan.

¹⁹⁵ Interview with miner, 22 November 2019, Bakori.

Bulang

Settlement history

Bulang was, historically viewed, never fully settled but experienced a sustained presence of residents due to displacement from other areas. Positioned near active war zones since 1997 and again after 2011, by 2019 there were generations of internally displaced people who had settled there, e.g. coming from Fādniyyah, Deren, Khor Ḥassan, and Dōkān.

The resulting relationship between socio-political groups, including those based on ethnicity, and land property claims is complex. Rough ethnic mapping shows land around Bulang and Khor Ḥassan divided among Raqārīq, Funj, Jabalāwiyīn, and Waṭāwīt, with some presence of Ambororo, while the end of Khor Ḥassan marks the start of Ingessana areas and further south the areas of Dawāla. The turbulent regional history also involves a boundary region where two groups, Raqārīq and Ingessana, are at odds over questions of origin and primacy, with Ingessana's historical claims overshadowed by their designation, targeting, and relocation as 'rebels,' as they made up the majority of Malik Agar's troops in SPLA.¹⁹⁶

The situation of Ingessana in Bulang reflected the consequences of this history, being largely treated as inferior and administered by a Raqārīq *ʿumda* without its own independent communal representative. The fact that Ingessana men were mainly pastoralists and Raqārīq mostly farmers indicates that the conventional categorisation as conflict between GoS-aligned pastoralists and SPLA-aligned farmers does not lead far. The distributional conflicts were more intertwined with a history of slavery, alongside the collapse of historical land regimes (such as the Funj sultanate), which conflicted with the system of communal representation and with the enduring repercussions of centralised wealth distribution networks that pervaded the gold and other economic sectors.

The main economic activities in Bulang were agriculture, animal husbandry, and communal mining, with tendencies towards specialisation by different groups: Ingessana and Ambororo as pastoralists, Jabalāwiyīn and Raqārīq as farmers, and Waṭāwīt and Dawāla as traders and gold miners. For these diverse residential groups, Bulang continued to be the main market and centre of various trades; these included charcoal traded to Damazin, and further to Sinnar and Gezira, as well as baobab fruits (*konglēs*) for markets nationwide.¹⁹⁷ Bulang was also near key agricultural regions with substantial sesame and okra production, while many local farmers mainly cultivated for their own use.¹⁹⁸

¹⁹⁶ This is reflected in historical narratives on the name 'Bulang', which is related to the Ingessana word for *nabag* (Ziziphus spina-christ, Christ's thorn jujube). Some tentative clues, which could not be explored further during fieldwork, identified Raqārīq as a subgroup of or otherwise related to Burun, an Islamised and Luo-speaking borderland group in South Sudan.

¹⁹⁷ The profit margins for *konglēs* were very high; the price increase between Bulang and Damazin alone could reach 100%, in November 2019 from 450 SDG to 900 SDG.

¹⁹⁸ The whole section is based on interviews with administrators, residents, miners in March and November 2019, among them: interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in

Mining

A large portion of the population around Bulang was involved in gold mining in some way. Looking back over the past two decades and beyond, gold mining had been a major activity for Raqārīq and Dawālah for a long time. In the areas from which many of the displaced originated, including Kurmuk, an entire village might have depended on a single mine and benefited economically from the close relationship between trade and mining.¹⁹⁹ Gold served as a reserve, buried beneath grain storages (*al-sūwaiyah*), and was incorporated into exchange activities involving dairy, agricultural, and industrial products. Money appeared to be a more recent development in these barter-based exchanges, with gold functioning as both a commodity and a form of currency.

This long history with gold can also be observed in the breadth and depth of social ideas and practices surrounding this precious metal across different phases of social life. One version of such ideas emerged during an interview with an administrator in Kurmuk who was active in several gold mining areas of Bulang, being interviewed in Kurun Kurun.²⁰⁰

Among the Dawāla, gold is called *fūdābjīnī*; Maban call it *baklū nījīn* and sometimes *tīr*. A girl born during the rainy season, when much of the gold collection takes place, can be called Tīr. Like all girls and women, she will become involved in gold collection and washing at some point and sell some of it in areas south of Kurmuk. However, most gold is stored in a pumpkin vessel called *afīmunqūt*, a vessel with a handle and a lid. Still, women don't wear many gold accessories; at most, one might wear a nose ring made of gold. But if she intends to arrange a marriage for a friend, she gives the man gold to marry her. In fact, marriage relations are full of gold bestowed on the spouses. This already begins at the wedding, after a bull has been slaughtered, when guests and family take meat and pay in gold as a contribution to the groom. On the wedding night, if the bride is a virgin, the man ties an ounce of gold into the corner of her *tōb*, and three livestock will be slaughtered. If she is not a virgin, he will cut the *tabaq* covering the food brought in the morning. In Bakori and Alyās, in Qeissan Locality, wives may display their wealth gained through gold by buying their husbands a large white donkey from Rufā'ah, cattle, white clothes, turbans, and elegant shoes. As a more overt act of boasting, some women give their men gold to distribute among other women during the days of the drum (*šatam*), so they may honour his generosity by calling him Tīr.

In Bulang, gold mining was also not new; one miner recounted how one of the still essential mining areas for small-scale manual mining (*rūt*), Mūnjīk, had been established in the early 1980s by female miners from Maṣṣah, Khor Ḥassan, Kurun Kurun, Balbūn, Kūrniyū, and Al-Haymūrah.

In this sense, the current situation was not fundamentally different. However, gold mining had never previously superseded or replaced agriculture as an occupation. Yet, the reduction of agricultural activities now occurred due to prohibitions imposed by the government concerning insecurity in war-affected areas: recurrent wars had limited the duration of undisturbed agricultural seasons, which official regulations confirmed by

Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang; interview with farmer, 13 March 2019, Bulang; [interview with secondary school teacher, 9 November 2019](#).

¹⁹⁹ Interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁰⁰ Interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang. The interview was translated and paraphrased.

forbidding any cultivation except in small fields near homesteads. Many agricultural operations had also ceased due to economic crises in the 1990s and 2010s, as communities were displaced and the workforce diminished, while costs during dry seasons rose to such an extent that farmers could not cover them. This led to a shift towards at least seasonal mining by large sections of the population who had not previously engaged in it.²⁰¹ This continued in the transitional period, combined with the hope that developments towards peace agreements give more stability and security, though not necessarily to retrack from mining but to do so in a more comfortable setting as perceived to exist on Blue Nile's eastern bank, such as Belguwa.

Such a post-war dynamic was experienced in the early 2000s, with an influx of miners not only from other parts of Blue Nile but also from western Sudan in 2004. In Khor Ḥassan, a long creek, this influx was most concentrated, and there was a shift from surface to underground mining through the introduction of shafts; other locations around Bulang, such as Gāmē and Ṣābrīn, followed suit, and after the CPA of 2005, newly accessible areas were added around Qeissan and near Dīreng.²⁰²

A new level was reached with the strong growth of the Bulang market. Originally just a village space for exchanges, a formalised market called Ṣābrīn was established in Bulang in 1992.²⁰³ Most of its shops were destroyed in a large fire during February 2011,²⁰⁴ but its slow recovery was accelerated by a gold mining rush that ensued a few years later. With unregulated milling and washing expanding around it, a new official gold market was established in 2016 approximately 5 km from the residential area of Bulang, officially inaugurated in January 2017. The old, general market was relocated there as well, under a licence granted by the Locality. A small market with a few shops evolved into a hub for the area, covering about 1 km², and garnered enough purchasing power that wholesale traders began to show interest.²⁰⁵ In subsequent years, another significant influx occurred as production declined around Bakori, while others departed during 2018, when a new market was opened in Maganza.

While the lure of new areas and discoveries is a 'natural' aspect of how opportunistic small-scale gold mining functions, its complex coexistence with residential household-based mining and other more sustained forms in areas such as Bulang requires a close examination of miners' background and motivations to understand these fluctuations and shifts.

In late 2019, Bulang village had a population of about 2500, while surrounding areas comprised roughly 20,000 inhabitants, including those involved in communal mining. Opposite them were several thousand seasonal miners whose numbers fluctuated significantly throughout the year. During the previous main season (January to March),

²⁰¹ An anecdote symbolic of this shift, shared in one of the interviews, is that even the Agricultural Director of the Locality began working in mining in Kurun Kurun (interview with investor (chromite factory in Damazin), 14 March 2019, Bulang).

²⁰² Interview with trader, 15 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁰³ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁰⁴ Interview with trader, 15 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁰⁵ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

7837 miners had been recorded by the local Miners Union, a figure that decreased sharply from May onwards as people left due to the rainy season. Before the start of the season in December 2019, only about 2000 miners were present.²⁰⁶

Since the early 2000s, underground mining has mainly been carried out by Raqārīq and miners from western Sudan, often with experience from other gold mining regions in and outside Sudan.²⁰⁷ The subsequent social structure at the shafts is complex. An SMRC official noted workers from other areas in Blue Nile²⁰⁸ but also Sennar, the Northern State, Kordofan and Darfur, while claiming that foreigners, especially South Sudanese and Ethiopians, were prohibited from working in mining.²⁰⁹

Looking back at the previous situation in Kurmuk, this marked another shift in mining practices: for example, Sudanese were (and are) working in gold mining not only in neighbouring Ethiopia but across northern and western Africa (Niger, Algeria, Mali, etc.). The official stance against foreigners in Sudan had hardened in the previous years. An administrator who had worked in Kurmuk recounted the broader circles there: not just Nima, Dajo, Zaghawa, Al-Dinu, and Masalit from Darfur but also Chadians; not just Dinka, Shilluk, and Maban from the south, but also Oromo and Amhara from Ethiopia.²¹⁰

Operations

As indicated above, demographic changes in Bulang's mining areas since the 2000s have also led to significant shifts in the techniques and knowledge used during mining operations. Essentially, these shifts involve a stark contrast between gold that is simply 'found' on or near the surface and gold that must be dug up, between the chance of stumbling upon surface gold and the need to invest considerable labour and time before establishing a successful mine.²¹¹

²⁰⁶ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang; [interview with head of mining union, 9 November 2019, Bulang](#); [interview with secondary school teacher, 9 November 2019, Bulang](#). It is interesting to note again that this seasonality is opposite to how communal alluvial gold collection operates, as the latter benefits from the rainy season.

²⁰⁷ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁰⁸ This included Abēgū, Uklīlū, Bakori, Gambarda, Dōkān, Daglūb, Madīnah 10 and 11.

²⁰⁹ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²¹⁰ Interview with the Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang. Our survey has shown that most of the 3568 respondents (69%) in the four gold markets of Blue Nile State were also permanent residents of the state, with 50% of the miners being local residents. The majority of the others were from neighbouring states such as Sinnar, Gedarif, White Nile, and Kordofan, or from Darfur. None of the miners, and only one of the overall respondents in the markets, reported being based abroad, in this case an Ethiopian; the five miners who stated they were born in Southern Sudan listed different northern states as their current residence. The notes on seasonal presence also apply here, with November 2019 still being before the main migratory period from other locations.

²¹¹ This heterogeneity of temporal commitment is one of the issues deserving further analysis, as it has implications for aspects such as structures of social and environmental care.

Impressions of surface gold in the Kurmuk area before the 2000s establish a baseline for comparing with the underground mining methods around Bulang. There, networks of permanent and seasonal watercourses (*ḥayrān*) provided sites for gold washing with pans, extracting alluvial gold with many sizeable nuggets.²¹² At that time, gold was still so plentiful that serendipitous finds were common: while cutting bamboo, digging a hole for other purposes, or after rains. In the market of Kurmuk, designed in the shape of one regular and one inverted L, water from the mountains during the rainy season would flow in two directions; gold could then be discovered on the ground after the rain and simply gathered. Around Jabal Kurmuk and Kurmuk Creek, people were collecting gold in this way at least until the 1980s.²¹³

But in Bulang, extraction techniques imported from other gold mining regions could be observed.²¹⁴ The discovery process was now mainly conducted using detectors, especially for surface gold, a method of opportunistic collection also known as *rūṭ*.²¹⁵ However, some ‘non-electronic’ techniques persisted, such as licking rocks found on the surface and broken open to feel if they are ‘hot’, and smelling them to detect a copper odour that signals gold. The *rūṭ* practice will continue until surface gold becomes scarce; however, it may still occasionally yield nuggets, some of which can even be collected from the ground, called *karkārāj*.²¹⁶

²¹² Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang. Specific watercourses still gained fame for their nuggets, such as Khor Al-Qanā, Khor Abangro, and Khor Yābūs, where a 130g nugget was found; Khor Jidād even had a reported find of 4 kg. Some washing grounds also became renowned, such as *bīr al-saydah Zaynab*, the Lady Zaynab well (interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang).

²¹³ Unless stated otherwise, all following information has been derived from the interview with the Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, on 13 March 2019, Bulang. There was apparently a wide range of popular beliefs about how finding gold can be aided; the interlocutor mentioned, for instance, that burning bee honey in a piece of cloth will make the bees follow, and following them will lead to the gold; putting gold in girls’ socks and giving them to a man for decoration will help him in his search for gold; etc. He mentioned different conditions for a prominent mining area near Qeissan, specifically Kurun Kurun, where digging in normal clay soils (*bādūbah*) was said to reveal gold veins close to the surface. After about 1.5m, a line of yellow, red, or other colours appears, which is called *aṭar al-‘araq*, the traces of the vein. Then there are small stones called Abu Sabī’a, which serve as markers indicating the presence of gold; they come in two types, one about two fingers wide and closer to the surface, and the other a compact, very firm stone found more than 4m below the ground. The soil is then washed through probing, and if two or three pieces of gold emerge, the site is estimated to yield more than two or three grammes per sack. This experimental process still allowed one person to potentially start ten mines before working on one that shows promise of being productive.

²¹⁴ Old and new mining areas were growing around the market in November 2019, the most important ones being Khor Ḥassan, Kurun Kurun, Gāmē, Munyēk, Belbūn, Ṣābrīn, Ankat and Mīf.

²¹⁵ Interview with farmer, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²¹⁶ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

A decision to open a mine could directly result from surface operations, such as if a shallow hole contained gold and showed signs that a vein extends further below. Once the decision was made to go underground, a shaft was opened with hydraulic excavators (*būklin*);²¹⁷ the introduction of loaders was a recent development and prompted its own negotiation of taxation. Then workers would be brought in to begin shift periods of 7-10 days (*fursāh*), continuing until the mine closed.²¹⁸

Afterwards, several digging tools were employed:

- *al-qalqalī* or *al-qulqulī*, an elongated iron of about 40 cm, called *ʿutla* in other areas;
- *ʿajna*, a flat tool for limestone, with a nail for harder rocks;
- hammers of different weights (1, 2, 5 or 10 kg).

Additionally, a common technique was used where hard rock was burned and then cooled with water, causing it to shatter; however, miners in Bulang allowed several days after burning to avoid suffocation, unlike the much more hurried and sometimes deadly process believed to be preferred in Bakori and Belguwa.²¹⁹ Compared to the latter, the use of heavy machinery was limited, and mining shafts remained much shallower, usually between 2 and 10 metres, with exceptional cases reaching down to 18 metres.²²⁰

Two basic types of shafts encountered here are the round ones, common in Blue Nile State, and the rectangular ones imported from western and northern regions. If the vein was very large and required more than one shaft, additional wings were opened, each operated by a separate shift, resulting in many workers per shaft; the distance between shafts was not standardised but was called *al-karkārāt*. In Kurun Kurun, the distance between shafts was 50m to accommodate wings, while in other areas it was sometimes only 10m—wider than in other regions. During the rainy season, mines were protected from rain by covering them with wood and tarpaulin, or even a hut (*kurnuk*) if there was a significant amount of gold, and filled with sacks if no creek was present.

But this shift from surface to underground gold also meant a move from manual to mechanised processing techniques that introduced new physical hazards: where there was once minimal digging and mostly work in the rain, mine workers were now at risk of suffocation and shaft collapses, and mill workers were exposed to dust, leading to more frequent cases of TB attacking exhausted lungs. However, it was the gold washing process where this turn towards pollution-heavy operations could be most strikingly observed.

²¹⁷ Interview with farmer, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²¹⁸ It was said in Bulang that a practice exists of slaughtering livestock to bless the mine before commencing work, but not too close to the mine, as stories suggest that doing so might cause the gold to vanish. The raw meat was then distributed among the workers.

²¹⁹ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²²⁰ Interview with goldsmith, 10 November 2019, Bulang. Kurun Kurun was an exception, as surface gold was exhausted there and shafts began earlier than in other areas; some shafts reached as deep as 50m, encountering water at 24m.

An almost universal phenomenon in the region was that gold washing was gendered, in that it was mostly but not exclusively done by women; in Bulang, this was added to a predominant role women had in agricultural activities as well. During the era when scooping soil was the only pre-washing step in gold extraction, the most used and iconic tool of the whole process was the washing trough or bowl (*al-qadah*), a tree trunk that was carved to form a large pan with raised edges, about 55-60 cm long, 35 cm wide, and 10 cm deep, also used to store food. The soil in and around watercourses was dug up not more than 40cm and put into the trough, adding only water to help the process of physical separation of pieces and dust of gold.²²¹

The metal pan was only introduced in the 2000s, bringing with it the use of mercury.²²² In Bulang market, this transformation occurred around 2010, when the main mines connected to the market were located in Khor Hassan, Bakori, and Mūjik. Compared to other regions and later years, the average daily production was initially low, with about half a gram or a gram per worker; at that time, a gram cost approximately 200 SDG, compared to 2900 SDG in November 2019. A small-scale tailing business could also be found here, where washers bought ore from miners to crush and wash it again, with outputs of about 0.25 g per sack.²²³

Although more men became involved in the 2010s, the number of women and children still remained high, even when only counting Bulang market.²²⁴ In March 2019, during the season, approximately 500 women were washing gold there, along with about 150-200 children, all residents of the area and none wearing protective gear such as gloves, overalls, and dust masks, which only some of the goldsmiths used.²²⁵ In addition, there were, of course, variations in how dangers and ways of protecting oneself were dealt with, aside from different aspects of what to protect from: when women began washing, some avoided saying *bismillah*, in the name of God, to prevent chasing away the devil and losing the gold rather than seeking divine protection from pollution.

²²¹ Interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Bulang.

²²² The pan still served as a measure for mercury use, with one lid (about 3g) of mercury applied to each washing pan, although some mentioned 2-6 lids per pan. While mercury efficiency, like always, depended on the specific rock structure, it was relatively low in this region, with an estimated 3-4g needed for each 1g of gold (interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang). The rocks from shafts were distinguished by the term *munyēk*, requiring more chemical treatment.

²²³ Interview with gold washer, 12 November 2019, Bulang.

²²⁴ An interviewee also pointed out another aspect of their presence: Kurun Kurun, he said, was lively because women worked there; Gāmē, a place without water and women, was not (interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang).

²²⁵ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang. Goldsmiths were, in fact, most directly affected by mercury vapours, as they were the ones burning the gold-mercury amalgam formed during washing to separate the two elements. They also used 'dissolving water' (*mōyat ḥall*, a mixture of nitric and sulphuric acid), which was not only dangerous to them but also highly corrosive and produced its own yellow-green vapour.

Finances

The implications of how service provision is organised and financed offer insights into the circumstances of extractive governance, especially since there is always the fundamental question of how the initial funding is arranged and what the subsequent labour is exerted for.

In Bulang, the costly complications began early with transportation across difficult terrain between the mines and the market. Bulang was situated between the northern regions of Blue Nile State and the embattled southern areas around Kurmuk, at an intersection within the triangle formed by Bao, Qeissan, and Kurmuk. The only roads that existed were filled with rubble and had not been asphalted beyond a short section before Deren; as a result, it was often impassable during the rainy season.²²⁶

The introduction of centralised structures for ore processing also meant longer transportation times; in fact, mills were initially located closer to the mines when first introduced in the early 2000s, a practice that continued partly even after the establishment of a mill market in 2006.²²⁷ In early 2019, the market featured 8 large mills and 5 small dry mills, 40 basin and 12 goldsmiths, with miners bringing in an average of 100 sacks, increasing during the season to 230, and 15 tractors with trailers (*tirillah*) had been licensed by the SMRC for transport.²²⁸ Nevertheless, because of the inadequate infrastructure, most tractors could only operate once a week, on Wednesdays, to attend the weekly Thursday market day.²²⁹ The price for one trip after the 2019 rainy season was 250 SDG per sack, plus fees to the armed forces (see details below); during the rainy season, up to 500 SDG per sack could be charged, as most tractors would be engaged on agricultural schemes and it could take a whole day to reach the market and return.²³⁰

The cost structure in Bulang market was similar to that in other areas: at the entrance, the SMRC charged a fee of 120 SDG per sack. The entry process varied; sometimes the fee was reduced to 100 or even 50 SDG, especially for the 'small producers'. Prices inside the market were steadily increasing: seasonal prices in 2019 were 150 SDG per sack for milling, and 50-60 SDG per sack for washing (plus 10 SDG paid to the owner of the basin).²³¹ Before the 2020 season, prices had risen to 200 SDG per sack for milling and 80

²²⁶ Interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang; interview with investor and factory owner, 14 March 2019, Bulang.

²²⁷ Interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Bulang; interview with trader, 15 November 2019, Bulang. An innovator, frequently mentioned in this context, was 'Isa 'Adam Dawī, who established what was regarded as the first mill in Bulang in 2005, still beside the creek, and from there, it served and expanded towards the mines of Khor Ḥassan.

²²⁸ These numbers keep on fluctuating with the season. In November 2019, only four mills were working, and expectations were that up to 25 will be available during the main season. Similarly, only 20 of the 40 basins were active during that time.

²²⁹ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang; interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²³⁰ Interview with miner, 11 November 2019, Bulang.

²³¹ Interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

SDG per sack for washing.²³² Considering that an empty sack costs 30 SDG, approximately 700 SDG needed to be available per sack simply to process the ore.

It is not surprising that prefinance and the distribution of costs and profits were crucial for the ultimate benefit gained from significant investment of labour and health. Share distribution was linked to the provision of means of production. In surface operations, the landowners and the device owners each received a share of anything that was found.

In underground mining, various combinations of shareholders were possible, including mine owner, funder (if separate), and workers, apart from payments to others who had the right to raise fees and taxes, including zakat. The distribution also depended on who appeared as funder or 'investor' (*mustatmir*) in the value chain, meaning who covered operational and living costs (*al-mayz*). In earlier phases of the developing sector, the shares of mine owners were still lower, about 20-30%, which later increased to equal shares of 50/50.²³³ There were also agreements regarding the output level. For example, below 1g per sack, a mine owner without an investor might simply pay out everything to the workers, minus living costs, to keep them working, while an output of 1g or more could trigger a 50/50 split after expenses.²³⁴

The involvement of goldsmiths often shifted the profit distribution to the disadvantage of the workers, not least because goldsmiths, unlike many mine owners, came from trade backgrounds and other regions, and rarely worked directly in mining. As elsewhere (see Belguwa), goldsmiths would go into business with miners from the start as investors, buying tools such as hammers, water containers, and tarpaulins for them, and covering living costs, transportation, and other expenses during the operation. Most importantly, they would act as guarantors to any trader the worker might want to engage with before making any cash profits, receiving a share of up to 10% in the profits.²³⁵ They might also intervene to obtain licenses for their 'staff', as this involved dealing with both security agents and SMRC officials.²³⁶

While establishing dependencies that are difficult to dissolve later, this arrangement provided a much-needed stabilization of the financial situation in a notoriously unpredictable market. Underground mining generally produced significantly more gold than surface operations (*rūt*), which, unless there were fortunate finds, would often average around 1g per week, whereas shaft miners think in g per sack. It was also much

²³² The prices in 2019 generally saw a significant rise, especially after the NCP government removed fuel subsidies, causing the price per gallon to increase from 100 SDG to 350 SDG. (interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang). The fact that prices did not go down but increased further after April 2019 also reflected that the economic situation continued to deteriorate.

²³³ Interview with farmer, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²³⁴ Interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²³⁵ Interview with SMRC official, 13 March 2019, Bulang; interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²³⁶ Interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang. They were also often the ones with standardised measurement technology that was key to establishing the final result, previously using pocket balances (*šankal*), now most frequently with electronic gold scales. (interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Bulang).

harder to establish a productive operation in underground mining, and seasonal fluctuations affected the output as well; more permanent participants in the gold market expected their highest profits only during the main season, between January and April.²³⁷

The outcome of the extraction process varied greatly not only in quantity but also in quality. The gold content differed significantly, as did the alloy: much of Bulang's gold was red;²³⁸ to the west, towards Khor Ġidād, it was green or darker with low purity (about 17 'parts' per carat); to the east, towards Bakori, it was pale yellow. The southern areas²³⁹ and the northern areas²⁴⁰ had all dark yellow gold of high purity (24 carat [?]), similar to the Nuba Mountains and the Northern State.²⁴¹

Since most arrangements would deduct living costs from the workers' share, all pre-financed costs were on credit and the workers ultimately had to fund themselves, while receiving, at best, a profit that had to be divided among many. Consequently, some of them raised complaints about this exploitation of their indigent state when they arrived: if there was no profit after expenses, or if costs were not covered at all, they would have worked for nothing and often would continue another cycle, hoping for a better outcome. Because the goldsmiths ensured, with their investment, that the gold was sold to them, they would benefit in any case. It was therefore not surprising that several cases were reported where miners refused to repay the advance.²⁴²

The legitimacy of a lending system that not only ensures cost recovery but also offers additional benefits from high profit shares and an obligatory sales point can be questioned from other perspectives. The argument of goldsmiths as lenders was often that they faced the risk of non-repayment, but their own credit limit – in Belguwa, it was 70-80.000 SDG – was already a risk management measure. By not bearing any operational costs or risks, as a mine owner would, their overlapping roles as bankers, refiners, and traders created a closed circuit for indebted miners, leaving refusal as the only escape route, unless a windfall occurred.

Administrative contexts

An examination of service provision in Bulang market, based on field research and the survey, suggests that there was little to manage, as populations surrounded by conflict received minimal government support where it was most needed: aside from significant demographic changes, the disruption of life cycles caused by displacement not only led to the end of livelihoods and educational pursuits but also placed people in unstable situations where they had to struggle to regain stability in both areas.

²³⁷ Interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Bulang.

²³⁸ Interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Bulang.

²³⁹ This means, for instance, Kurmuk, Balīlah, Mafu, Surkum, Al-Kīlī, Khor Anigru, Yabus, Qandūlū, Qeissan and Aklīlī.

²⁴⁰ The interviewee mentioned Belguwa and, worryingly, Dinder.

²⁴¹ Interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁴² Interview with goldsmith, 9 November 2019, Bulang.

Bulang market had no water service and no sanitation in November 2019, making it unfavourable for sustained residence.²⁴³ A seasonal creek near the entrance to Bulang had been fitted with motorised water pumps that filled the barrels of donkey cart drivers who sold it at the market, an expensive solution vulnerable to fuel supply. The only more sustainable option was supported by the NGOs Adventist Development and Relief Agency (ADRA) and World Vision working on a water pipe network in the area.

The production areas lacked their own water sources, as well.²⁴⁴ In Gāmē and similar mining areas, for instance, neither water towers (*karjākāt*) nor containers (*ṣafā'ih* or *jālūn*) were available, and the nearest drinking water source was 2 to 3 hours away. During the main season, thousands of miners would attempt to meet their water needs from the limited water towers available for payment, for instance in the military camp in Khor Ḥassan.²⁴⁵

A similar situation existed for health services. Bulang's only health centre was supported by ADRA.²⁴⁶ All surrounding mining areas relied on this one facility, but there was no ambulance, and the only available transportation was army vehicles and slow tractors, which took up to 4 hours to reach Bulang from some areas; during the rainy season, it could take a whole day.²⁴⁷

Finally, Bulang's permanent population of 2500 was served by four primary schools and one secondary school that failed to meet the needs. Many children reaching six years of age had no opportunity to enrol due to limited places in existing schools; students would spend holidays or even leave school to go mining in order to earn an income.²⁴⁸ Once again, it was a school meal project by ADRA and World Vision, running since 2008, that offered a partial solution, without resolving the lack of a self-sustaining administrative system.

In fact, Bulang served as an example of an ephemeral civilian administration with a symbolic presence that merely stood by while arrangements were made between communal and military authorities. A formalistic view of Bulang's administrative status classified it as an administrative unit within Kurmuk Locality, while the surrounding areas belonged to the administrative unit of Kurun Kurun. However, in practical terms, the

²⁴³ Interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁴⁴ Interview with miner, 10 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁴⁵ Interview with driver, 13 March 2019, Bulang; interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang; [interview with miner, 12 November 2019, Bulang](#). Interestingly, an SMRC official interviewed in March 2019 responded to the issue of lacking drinking water by suggesting that the Zakat Chamber could support the construction of water towers. The Zakat Chamber was also the only example of an alternative provider cited by a tea seller, who recalled that the tea sellers had received kiosks from the Zakat Chamber in 2018, based on needs assessments by the Popular Committee, the lowest level of the NCP-dominated administrative system. Refrigerators were also distributed, and tuk-tuks were made available to workers 'by recommendation', with 50% of the cost covered by the Zakat Chamber and the remainder by the future owner (interview 13 March 2019, Bulang).

²⁴⁶ Interview with trader, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁴⁷ Interview with head of mining union, 9 November 2019, Bulang; interview with miner, 12 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁴⁸ Interview with secondary school teacher, 9 November 2019, Bulang.

civilian public administration played only a limited role and had a minimal local presence, with officials in charge of the unit often remaining in the capital, much like many of their colleagues, only 'visiting' their station mainly to collect the Locality's revenues.²⁴⁹

The SMRC, as a governmental organ responsible for the mining sector, had a more assertive presence. It began transforming practices in August 2016 with the introduction of occupational licenses (*idīn muzāwalah*) and fees for market entry. However, a gap between service provision and taxation was evident, and this was a common complaint among miners. This was also apparent concerning environmental protection: despite the appointment of representatives from the SMRC's Environmental Department, there were no clear thresholds or budgets, nor was there central regulation of distances and limits for activities in accordance with mandatory environmental standards.²⁵⁰

The line system was integrated here with the establishment of a Mining Guild (*'ittiḥād al-ma'danīn*), which set the rules for the mines, whether in technical terms, sharing arrangements, or conflict resolution, such as land disputes.²⁵¹ Miner camps were established, and the guild would vouch for new miners with goldsmiths for advances taken, and intervene if miners reneged on repayment, thereby rather supporting than circumventing the former's role in the value chain (see above).²⁵²

The guild was parallel to and partly in conflict with the SMRC-dominated Mining Committee (*lajnat al-ta'dīn*), which included communal representatives, and at one point it imposed its own fees on labour and machinery until the SMRC, supported by the armed forces, intervened following complaints by miners.²⁵³ Nevertheless, the dominant role of communal representatives in these matters lessened or shifted, at least. In fact, a new communal dynamic emerged as the guild's effectiveness was closely linked to the personality of an experienced miner who managed to gain a position of trust and authority among its members.

These dynamics included, or were rather preceded by, the presence of armed forces. Bulang lay north and west of the central areas held or directly affected by SPLA-N troops, arguably a reason why major operations had ceased. After the new outbreak of war in 2011, the growing mining activities became a target of SPLA, not least due to their location in the Ingessana Hills, from where communities had been displaced by government forces as early as the 1990s. Over the years, SPLA attacked anyone bringing machinery and detectors, announcing a general ban on such equipment. Additionally, they frequently visited the remaining artisanal miners, levying fees to allow them to continue or confiscating their supplies before withdrawing. The stationing of SAF between Bulang and Deren was directly related to these activities and to the facilitation of mining under their supervision.²⁵⁴

²⁴⁹ Interview with investor (chromite factory in Damazin), 14 March 2019, Bulang; supported by observations in November 2019.

²⁵⁰ Interview with investor (chromite factory in Damazin), 14 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁵¹ Interview with driver, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁵² Interview with driver, 13 March 2019, Bulang; interview with head of mining union, 9 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁵³ Based on observations of Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman.

²⁵⁴ Interview with investor (chromite factory in Damazin), 14 March 2019, Bulang.

The reduction of direct confrontations between SPLA and SAF since 2017, and the peace process starting after April 2019, allowed this strict boundary to gradually dissolve, with more diverse situations of mining sites feeding into Bulang's gold market. An example of this was Gāmē, a highly productive mining area south of Bulang, surrounding the eponymous mountain, which was generally under SPLA control.²⁵⁵ The presence of SAF forces was at specific points, aimed at collecting tributes and fees rather than actively engaging SPLA troops, who had the superior knowledge of the terrain. However, the establishment of a regular line system became possible as early as 2018, with increased cooperation from SPLA soldiers who directly benefited from the mining. After 11 April 2019, this development accelerated: where attacks and prohibitions previously dominated, many more friendly encounters were reported, violence decreased, and crossing military boundaries became easier due to passing licenses. By the end of 2019, the situation seemed to have changed again, as the SAF command prohibited mining beyond its direct control once more, citing an increase in incidents.²⁵⁶

One goldsmith referred to the interim situation as 'peace solutions' (ḥulūl al-salām), indicating that he equated this term with undisturbed conduct of business, rather than the absence of military rule. It was telling that the same goldsmith expressed the wish that more security personnel were present to prevent miners from 'misbehaving', maybe in reference to their escape from the asymmetric arrangements that were described earlier.²⁵⁷ At the same time, this can be seen as a subtle expression of regret about another shift that took place between March and November 2019: the declining influence of the NISS compared to the armed forces. The closure of the NISS office was one of the earliest visible signs of change after 11 April, an office that had previously intervened in most conflicts or even issues concerning public order.²⁵⁸

Instead of being taken over by Kurmuk Locality's civilian administration, the same functions were assigned to the military intelligence (*al-istiḥbārāt al-ʿaskariyyah*), which was part of the military zone Bulang lay within, under a zone commander. They dominated numerous security units operating in mining areas on the outskirts of former war zones, including NISS' Mining Security (*ʿamn al-ta'dīn*)²⁵⁹ and regular police's Mining Police (*ṣurṭah al-ta'dīn*).²⁶⁰ Different from NISS agents, whose interests were more aligned with those of traders, military intelligence appeared more eager to gain and retain legitimacy

²⁵⁵ Interview with goldsmith, 10 November 2019, Bulang; interview with miner, 12 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁵⁶ This was the situation as it appeared to Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman and 'Usāma 'Umar 'Alī in November 2019; it was, of course, understandably hard to make a dependable assessment.

²⁵⁷ Interview with goldsmith, 10 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁵⁸ A tea seller stated still in March 2019 that she was forced to dress 'legally' (*ṣīra'ī*), including wearing socks on her feet, with regular inspections being carried out (interview with tea seller, 13 March 2019, Bulang).

²⁵⁹ One of the primary functions of Mining Security was recording production levels and regulating trade. Each goldsmith was required to complete daily survey forms, and no goldsmith could leave the area without this form after it had been approved (interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang).

²⁶⁰ Interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

among the local population: when prices rose in November 2019 and residents complained, the MI agents ordered them to be reduced to levels that were ‘affordable’.

In view of complaints raised by miners coming from outside towards the local SAF troops (see below), the social dimension of this shift is important to notice: the bulk of these forces were themselves from the region, while security, other forces such as Rapid Support Forces (RSF), traders, goldsmiths and even many of the miners were considered outsiders, and SPLA-N, though a ‘hostile force’, was itself aligned with regional communities who were at odds with others in the same region. The fault lines thus ran deeper into the communal structures, fault lines that were both represented and exacerbated by the armed conflicts, yet also intertwined in complex ways with interregional and capi-tal-federal state tensions.

We will explore the implications of military presence more fully in the next section. Here, a few words on the complications of communal representation: communal administration was dominated by Raqārīq, whether through police officers or the ‘umda. This was also a broader result of the displacement and overpowering of the Ingessana population during successive wars. Since approximately 90% of miners, traders, and goldsmiths were from outside the area, this situation led to a form of administrative dominance by a less wealthy minority over a more affluent majority, based on their belonging.²⁶¹ An unavoidable tension ensued between ‘locals’ and ‘newcomers’.

The following pre-revolution case is illustrative: The ‘newcomers’ established their own quarter in Bulang, Ḥayy Al-Ġarābah.²⁶² One of the first newcomers gained an informal status as sheikh of the Ġarābah, particularly since newcomers arriving in the area and still without accommodation often stayed in his house until arrangements were made. In 2018, a miner from the quarter was accused of illicit relations with a local girl and was summoned before the court of the Raqārīq ‘umda. Since the accused was residing with the Ġarābah sheikh at the time, he was also summoned. The ‘sheikh’ stated in an interview that the ‘umda demanded all outsiders leave Bulang, but he refused, emphasising that they were all Sudanese with the right to reside wherever they chose. The ‘umda then requested two of the sheikh’s four houses, which he declined with laughter, and he was subsequently dismissed from the court. The accused was later sentenced to pay 15,000 SDG and to leave the area within 24 hours.

It was at this point that the ‘sheikh’ contacted other powerholders in Bulang. He went to the NISS office and complained about the planned confiscation of his house. He also activated his contacts in the parents’ council he headed at the school he co-founded. Furthermore, he travelled to Damazin and presented a petition to the General Attorney and the judiciary (*al-jihāz al-qaḍā’ī*), and, finally, to *mak* Al-Fātiḥ in Roseiris, who was in charge of all the communal representatives in Blue Nile, a legacy of the Funj sultanate

²⁶¹ Several goldsmiths had been established in Damazin before relocating to Bulang, some of whom belonged to long-standing trading families (interview with goldsmith, 13 March 2019, Bulang).

²⁶² Critical remarks by the local populations against ‘outsiders’ were occasionally expressed through the term *ġarābah* (‘westerners’), normally only used by Nile Valley-based Sudanese to describe individuals from Darfur and Kordofan, regions west of the Nile. Otherwise, social identification was much more differentiated.

and subsequent administrations' reinterpretations of it. The latter step had the greatest impact; the *mak* summoned the *'umda* three times without response, until the latter appeared and denied that anything like this had happened in court. Then the *mak* ordered the *'umda* to refrain from such judgments and assured the 'sheikh of his support if anything like this occurred again. The 'sheikh' returned to Bulang and there were no further objections.²⁶³

There are several aspects of this court case to consider, which we will omit here due to the limited documentation available, based solely on the account of one interested party; the fact that the core issue— the alleged intimate relationship— played no real role in the account further complicates its interpretation. In any case, the apparent inability of the older communal leader to assert authority over the miners in this case may suggest a declining status of 'local communities' relative to in-migrants. A closer examination of broader distributional dynamics shows, however, that the situation had wider implications because most residents have a displacement history.

Military presence

The areas between Bulang and Kurmuk have experienced decades of displacement, driven not only by extractive activities but also by export-focused agricultural investments. Not all of this was due to military action; lands were also registered by the central Ingāḍ government to individuals with no real connection to these areas.²⁶⁴ It is challenging, however, to distinguish this legal disappropriation of resident communities from the rationale of military action. In any case, it left communities in south-western Blue Nile State in a state of instability and fear, and it is worth noting that they had little reason to believe the situation had improved after the conclusion of larger confrontations with the SPLA: as recent as March 2019, there were plans to relocate residents from Akilī for a Russian company that aimed to commence gold mining there, claiming reserves of 30 tonnes.²⁶⁵

The complexity of the connection between political, military, and extractive interests means that determining who benefits and how from the ongoing exploitation of natural resources, and who safeguards whose interests through military presence, is not a straightforward question.²⁶⁶ 'Security' here, as in other contexts, refers not only to control

²⁶³ Interview with communal leader among miners, 6 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁶⁴ Interview with investor (chromite factory in Damazin), 14 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁶⁵ Interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang. Looking at the concession database of SMRC from mid-2020, it is unclear which concession was meant, as the only company classified there as Russian and marked with a concession in Blue Nile was Okran Mining (block BN13), which abandoned the concession after just a few months in 2017. This provides limited information, however, as it could have had a tailing business, a small-scale mining license, or no license registered in these sources at all.

²⁶⁶ One of Mohamed Salah Abdelrahman's interlocutors, himself deeply invested in the NCP apparatus, was specifically critical of the claimed prominent status the Agar family in this triangle of political, military and economic power, stating that major areas with gold, iron and chromite mines in the Ingessana hills belonged to them, and two relatives of Malik Agar were allegedly among the five major gold traders in Kurmuk (interview with Director of

over physical confrontation but also to regulation of exchange relations. It was the financial autonomy and investment activities of executive forces, beyond their regular budget from the treasury, that thus undermined any attempt at establishing civilian oversight (see also Maganza).

In Bulang, more than in other locations, this did not necessarily indicate hostile relations with the current resident population or their lack of appreciation for being ‘secured’ by armed forces. The key issue was what happens when the economic interests of these forces and their allies conflict with those of unarmed citizens, and observations suggest that there has been a shift in tone but not in principle concerning the implementation of SAF – and elsewhere RSF – concepts regarding what they believe they are entitled to extract from different sources.

In the mining areas, the armed forces found a way to participate in the value chain by collecting levies that were similar to those in other regions. This appears to have started around 2018, in a widespread manner: the general tax on each mine was two sacks per month, regardless of whether it was productive or not.²⁶⁷ Additionally, the transport of ore to the market—something controlled but not necessarily carried out by the army—cost 1 in 20 sacks, a mandatory fee that was non-negotiable and called ‘living cost charge’ (*badal mayz*).²⁶⁸

Instead of ensuring smooth interactions with the heavily funded force still in need of such charges, miners were barred by an officer from using tree trunks to stabilise their mines; a complaint to the HQ in Damazin resulted in the dispatch of a more lenient officer, who had previously served there and was appreciated for gestures like offering his car for emergency transport. Nevertheless, the charge persisted and was exploited in a way that clearly benefited the soldiers: some of them worked in the mines themselves, allowing them to inform on the most productive mines at the time, and officers would ensure to select sacks belonging to such mines.

However, the army’s involvement also extended into the market where two of the four stone crushers operating in all seasons belonged to SAF businesses. The tailing business was temporarily exclusively reserved for Elements Investments, which at the time was a company of SAF’s Economic Authority (*al-hay’a al-’iqtisādiyyah*),²⁶⁹ with orders issued to

Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang). How reliable especially the latter information was, is difficult to gauge without further investigation, and the criticism makes wonder whether it targeted this specific overlap of power positions or the general existence of such an overlap.

²⁶⁷ Interview with goldsmith, 9 November 2019, Bulang; interview with Director of Agricultural Administration in Kurmuk, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁶⁸ Interview with miner, 10 November 2019, Bulang; interview with miner, 12 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁶⁹ Elements for Mining’s tailing business license was issued on 1 February 2017 for Qeissan Locality, under General Manager Muḥya Al-Dīn Zakariyyah Ḥamad. Anecdotal information from a confidential interview indicates that there was previously a Palestinian investor whose share had been acquired or otherwise taken over by the SAF. It is unclear whether this situation is comparable to Lusail’s withdrawal from the neighbourhood of Maganza after attacks by SPLA on its works, but the interviewee suggested that a general protection money scheme was ongoing at least until March 2019. Under this scheme, investors had to

prevent anyone else from removing tailings from the market. With the promise to fund a secondary school in Bulang, the company started transporting and processing tailings in late 2018; a construction plan and location for the school were prepared, concrete was delivered, but after one load of tailings was taken from the market, the company never returned, and the tailings remained untouched, as the order was not cancelled.²⁷⁰

Even before its further empowerment during the transitional period, the military had thus already played a role in enabling or blocking companies' investments.²⁷¹ Apart from the military, communal representatives and the Locality also shared in the benefits of the labour, since mining or searching for surface gold on agricultural land required an agreement with both institutions, including such a share.²⁷² In other words, the notion of communal land ownership held some significance as long as the military apparatus permitted its application.

Additionally, the import of heavy machinery, which increased due to an improved security situation, also led to the emergence of communal fees that had previously been absent. In the areas of Makōt, Falīlang, and Belbūn, loaders began to be used in 2018, and local sheikhs started to impose fees on them and on detectors, ostensibly to support 'local development'. The fees varied significantly; in Belbūn, they amounted to 12,000 SDG weekly; in Khor Ḥassan, to 30,000 SDG monthly, plus an initial entry permit for 10,000 SDG.²⁷³ The latter fees were, in fact, the result of a negotiation process, which began with the sheikhs' refusal to permit loaders to be brought in at all, continued with their demand of 30,000 SDG weekly, and ultimately settled on the quoted amount.²⁷⁴ Nevertheless, the fact that residential communal investment in mining operations remained limited, alongside heavy taxation from regular forces and administrative agencies, meant that economic control and local development funds also stayed at a low level.

Reviewing the statements from the fieldwork together, it appears that a cycle of complaints emerged where each agent focused on a different part of the value chain to point out an unfair arrangement. While residential communities targeted outsider miners, outsider miners criticised the armed forces and the SMRC, which in turn blamed the low

pay for troops seconded to provide protection for their operations, and all presence was withdrawn from the area if such payment was not made.

²⁷⁰ Interview with investor, 14 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁷¹ Another example involved a chromite factory owner based in Damazin who attempted to transfer some stone mills from Maganza to Bulang. He was received favourably by SMRC officials and Economic Security to facilitate this, and procedures in Damazin were expedited for his benefit. The delay in implementation was caused by the garrison commander's request to present a paper from Military Intelligence in Damazin (interview with investor, 14 March 2019, Bulang).

²⁷² Interview with NGO employee, 13 March 2019, Bulang.

²⁷³ Interview with head of mining union, 9 November 2019, Bulang; interview with goldsmith, 9 November 2019, Bulang.

²⁷⁴ The SMRC had its own fees; 2,000 SDG monthly for detectors and taxes on subsidized gas distributed to the loaders (interview with goldsmith, 9 November 2019, Bulang).

budget of the state government.²⁷⁵ The overall outcome was a continuing extractive process that left deep marks on the region without contributing significantly to its constructive improvement.

A common complaint among residents, miners, workers, and goldsmiths was that the taxation by SMRC and the Locality did little to improve service provision both within and outside Bulang. The main issue was the 120 SDG entry fee charged on each sack brought to the market. This fee, which was widely regarded elsewhere in Blue Nile State as an achievement (see Belguwa), had to be paid regardless of the actual gold content in the sack. This created uncertainty over whether operational costs would be covered. Historically, the taxation system had started with a 40 SDG fee, then shifted to a 10% fee on the profit from gold at the end of the extraction process, leading up to the current system from December 2018.²⁷⁶ But almost a year after the introduction of this general fee, the revenues still had not resulted in any significant change in the service provision in Bulang market or the mining areas, whether water, sanitation, health, or education, not to mention a stable fuel supply or banking infrastructure.²⁷⁷

The common view was that the SMRC should deliver these services; there was almost no mention of a similar reciprocal expectation towards the armed forces. Once again, the core issue was not simply dominance or profit margins, but that distributional arrangements were seen as uneven compared to one's own expectations and benchmarks of distributive justice. While such expectations were clearly directed at governmental actors, they remained within a framework of specific and individual demands, rather than considering the broader consequences of violent policies that initially deprived the region of stable distributional arrangements. Nonetheless, these fragmentary discontents reflected a lack of social peace between those involved in extractive activities and served as a reminder of the deeper issues that remained unresolved, unmitigated, and sources of tension as the transitional period continued.

²⁷⁵ In fact, as of March 2019, officials hadn't received salaries for 4 months (interview with investor (chromite factory in Damazin), 14 March 2019, Bulang).

²⁷⁶ Interview with driver, 13 March 2019, Bulang. The general fee was also prevalent in other states, especially Northern State, Gedarif and River Nile State, while some areas, such as South Darfur, had maintained the relative fee of 10%.

²⁷⁷ Interview with goldsmith, 9 November 2019, Bulang.

Maganza

Working in the mines

When driving south from Damazin, one heads towards the Ingessana Hills, a region where politics and mining are closely linked. Before reaching Bao, about two hours by car, there is the gold market of Maganza, which, in November 2019, was the second largest in Blue Nile State after Belguwa. It has been in existence since early 2018, roughly a year after Bulang, and is situated amidst several mining areas. By August 2019, the market had grown to around 2500 regular users, including miners, merchants, officials, and others.²⁷⁸

The two main mining areas connected to Maganza market, Khor Jidād and Tāqah, both operated for a long time,²⁷⁹ had distinct differences. Khor Jidād, closer to Maganza, lay in a seasonal creek and belonged to the oldest mining areas of the region. Similar to Khor Maganza, it had been rich in surface gold, and while some work with metal detectors continued, most mining in 2019 was carried out in the form of shafts. Like the mines in Belguwa, Khor Jidād followed a line system, where each line enclosed 8-10 shafts, in some instances up to 20 shafts. The first line of mines was four kilometres away from the last line; the first line was called “Line of the Sons of Bao” (*ḥaṭ abnā’ baw*) and the last line “Line of Grievances” (*ḥaṭ al-maḏālim*), an almost symbolic reflection of its communal origins and belligerent present.²⁸⁰

The shift to underground mining significantly increased the work’s difficulty as the rock formations consisted of granite and basalt, which are difficult to penetrate. Consequently, the use of jackhammers became nearly universal. Aside from its location in an area filled with watercourses, the rock was mostly saturated with water, forcing miners to constantly scoop water from inside holes and shafts once they reached about 5 metres. As a result, digging progressed at a rate of no more than 1 to 1.5 metres per day. While these shafts still produced large quantities of ore, their green gold was not much in demand due to its low level of purity.²⁸¹

Moving from Khor Jidād, one crossed Ṭūrṭah, a rugged mountainous area known for giant baobab trees that formed a natural barrier to Tāqah. Tāqah was the second area near Maqanza market, an intensive mining zone with a high density of shafts and miners that had been (re)started only in mid-2019. Parts of Ṭūrṭah and Tāqah were still scanned with metal detectors, with at least 60 and 70 devices in use, respectively. In June 2019, Tāqah also had 3 lines with at least 7 shafts each, overall 14 large ones, 10 medium, and 5 small.²⁸²

Unlike Khor Jidād, most of the rocks here were predominantly limestone. Although the risk of collapse was therefore significantly higher, the softer rock made digging much

²⁷⁸ Interview with SMRC official 2, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

²⁷⁹ The authors of the final report of the Global Mercury Project in Sudan listed both Khor Jidād and Tāqah among the main mining centres in the Ingessana Hills, subsequently selecting them as intervention sites (GMP 2007: 2).

²⁸⁰ Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

²⁸¹ Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

²⁸² Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

easier, even with simple manual tools, drawing a large number of miners—about 1,000 during the season.²⁸³ The low effort required for drilling and digging in lighter rock also meant that many minors were involved, which was not the case in Khor Jidād. Water was much scarcer in Tāqah, requiring more than 12 metres to reach the water table or water-bearing rocks. Tāqah was superior for gold quality; the gold content was described as strong and ranged from 940 to 960. However, the generally low per-head production volume significantly contributed to the miners' lack of financial returns.

The background of these miners was similar to that of many others found in different areas. Most of them were reported to come from villages in Darfur and Kordofan, with a very low level of formal education, which our survey data also supported. There was a wide variation in how long they had been involved in mining; some started during the gold rush around 2010 in other regions, while others had recently shifted to mining from different fields. For example, one miner, born into a group of Al-Majānīn in Al-Jawwī, North Kordofan, began mining in 2010, first in Wādī 'Arab in East Sudan, and later, in 2019, followed a paternal cousin to Tāqah.²⁸⁴ Another miner, born in New Halfa to South Sudanese parents, had worked for a long time at Halfa's sugar factory, climbing the workers' hierarchy up to being a heavy machinery driver, which he did for seven years. He tried to earn a living in newly independent South Sudan until 2017, but the civil war forced him back to Sudan, where a friend suggested he try mining. He went to Blue Nile in 2018, ultimately ending up in Tāqah.²⁸⁵

Once again, Khor Jidād had a different profile, as a significant number of the miners were residents of Blue Nile, particularly Ingessana and Dawālah, who had returned to the mining areas they previously worked in before the war, along with working in newer mines.²⁸⁶ The resident miners made up the majority of the steady miners, whose main livelihood strategy was mining, while others came seasonally with specific profit motives, which influenced how much time they would dedicate to the mines that appeared most promising.

Accordingly, the perception of whether profit was achieved and how it was intended to be used varied in ways resembling other areas where communal, opportunistic, and seasonal mining coincided. Even among the latter, some began to invest in other businesses, such as shops or trades, thereby exiting mining, while others spent their profits on family expenses and then returned to work.²⁸⁷ In most cases, weekly income would, however, be just enough to meet one's needs.

Despite their geophysical differences, Khor Jidād and Tāqah shared similar health risk profiles, both having shafts dug near each other and experiencing frequent collapses.²⁸⁸ Similarly, both faced issues with their water supply: the first had water that originated

²⁸³ Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

²⁸⁴ Interview with miner, 12 November 2019, Maganza.

²⁸⁵ Interview with miner, 13 November 2019, Maganza.

²⁸⁶ Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

²⁸⁷ Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

²⁸⁸ Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza. The interviewee described how some mining shafts were as close as half a metre, despite the legal regulation requiring a distance of 7 metres. The distance was called *al-šukāl*.

from or mixed with rock material, carrying harmful elements; the second relied on seasonal watercourses whose water naturally had a high salt concentration. Miners complained of sulphuric and other elements in the water and later experienced skin irritations (*kārūṣah*), blisters, and urinary and other infections.²⁸⁹

Both suffered from a lack of basic services, whether water supply or healthcare, and were limited to the same options: in Khor Jidād, the only source of drinking water was a water tower (*karḡākah*) established by the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) in 2016, and the only pharmacy (*ṣafaḥānah*) in the area also belonged to the army. In Tāqah, the only reliable water source was the garrisons (*ḥāmīyyāt*) surrounding the region, and the only pharmacy with a medical assistant was established in the army camp where workers could receive treatment for common diseases such as malaria and diarrhoea. The only emergency transport available in the entire area also belonged to the military.

Working in the market

Maganza market's primary function, like other gold markets, was to centralise ore processing and related taxation. Miners and mine owners from nearby mining areas, such as Khor Jidād and Tāqah, regularly arrived with their ore, processed it, and sold the gold. Due to challenging transportation, this did not occur daily for all crews but at most every three days, and only once a week for most. This also meant a clear difference between the dry and rainy seasons (May to October), as transport became even more difficult during the latter, causing work in mines and the market to nearly cease. The main mining season followed the sorghum harvest, ending in January at the latest, and preceded the heavy rains in June or July. A goldsmith estimated that 70% of total production occurred during this period.²⁹⁰

Visits to the market also served as the time when miners and mine owners bought necessary commodities, since the market was their only option, and when tools were brought in for repairs. Most would return the same day; only some would stay overnight under open skies, as there was no roofed place to stay—only beds to rent for 20 SDG per night. They tried to sleep close to the army camp for protection from robberies.

Apart from the section with the stone crushers and gold-washing basins, Maganza market can be roughly divided into four areas: the first where the main road entered the market, which is dominated by restaurants, grocery shops with refrigerators, and spare part shops. Most of the spare parts' activities focused on the army, as the majority of the region's vehicles belonged to them (see below). The second area contained television clubs and shisha shops; the third was a mix of more television clubs, restaurants, and the bread bakery. The fourth section was reserved for women selling tea, coffee, and food items, next to laundry shops. These parts of the market consisted of a variety of simply built structures, such as sunroofs (*rawākīb*, sg. *rākōbah*). The market also contained an

²⁸⁹ In Maganza market, the Ministry of Health addressed water quality issues by regularly distributing chlorine tablets ([interview with tea seller, 15 November 2019, Maganza](#)).

²⁹⁰ Interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Maganza.

office and guesthouse belonging to the SMRC, which was a simple hut-like building (*kurnuk*).

The market in March 2019 included about 25 air stone crushers, along with three wet mills and approximately 50 basins. An additional 20 wet mills belonging to the SMRC were installed but could not be operated due to a lack of experts, according to one interviewee.²⁹¹ Given that transportation was costly and therefore done for larger quantities in a short period, a two-tier process had developed, where the larger fragments were first crushed in air mills and then processed in wet mills. From there, the crushed and powdered ore underwent manual washing, after which the tailings went through another extraction cycle, now dominated by the goldsmiths and the single company operating in the area. There were hardly any alternatives to this value chain in the market, although two motorised sieves (*ġarābīl*) were available in Tāqah during the dry season, which could handle smaller quantities as well.²⁹² A processing factory belonging to the company was established nearer to the mining areas of Ṭūrḥah (see below).

The goldsmiths served as the main connection to larger exchange networks in Maganza, both through their role in funding operations and via their direct contacts with the gold markets in Khartoum, which acted as a hub for international trade. Those who began from the opening of the market, often simply branching out from Belguwa or Bulang, attained senior positions because latecomers would start as assistants or partners to them, or as relatives brought in to join the trade.²⁹³ Nevertheless, several ‘newcomer’ goldsmiths noted that their relationship was not competitive but rather friendly and supportive, especially since profits remained healthy – sometimes with more gold available than one goldsmith could handle – and most issues were shared concerns, such as shortages of mercury, poor water quality, and transportation limitations.²⁹⁴ As will be shown, the competition and mistrust occurred more between different groups in the value chain rather than within a single group.

The cost and profit structure mirrored what has been observed in other markets. At the start of any cycle, there was a sharing agreement among all involved parties, including the mining crews, the mine owner, and/or the investor, if separate. The owner of the well was responsible for registering the claim with the SMRC; however, in most cases, he would wait until a vein with significant gold content was encountered before registering the

²⁹¹ Interview with SMRC official (market supervisor), 17 March 2019, Maganza. Other potential explanations included lower than expected activity and the overall lack of water, which was apparently overlooked before deploying a large number of wet mills.

²⁹² Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

²⁹³ Interview with goldsmith, 10 November 2019, Maganza; interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Maganza. The initial planning closely reflected the prevailing political economy, as those responsible owned several shops and had investments in agriculture and mining in the region, despite regulations explicitly banning such overlaps (interview with SMRC official 2, 28 June 2019, Maganza). At the same time, there were reportedly instances where the planners of the ‘new’ market registered many plots and mines for themselves, forcing ‘latecomers’ to rent from them; if true, this represented another layer of involvement by SMRC, Locality officials, and their allies in the market.

²⁹⁴ Interview with goldsmith, 10 November 2019, Maganza; interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Maganza.

mine, which involved a fee of 6000 SDG.²⁹⁵ Costs incurred during the operation would be borne by the investor, such as tools and machinery, transport, and living expenses. Additional equipment, such as pumps if a water-bearing structure was hit, was also prefinanced by the investor.

The costs not only varied with the seasons and the level of market activity; there was also a general impact from the country's overall economic situation. For example, it was observed that post-rainy season prices in late 2019 did not return to previous levels, indicating a continued and worsening crisis during the early transitional period. The supply issues experienced elsewhere also affected the area, such as shortages of licensed diesel, which impacted costs and the availability of water that had to be delivered by tankers. The parallel market supply, as a costly alternative, faced difficulties due to limited transportation options; prices for subsidised items like fuel and bread were several times higher than those in the capital.²⁹⁶

When it comes to processing the ore, the initial cost item was empty sacks. Transporting the ore to the market was already among the most costly items, with prices ranging between 170 SDG and 200 SDG per sack, depending on location, season, and vehicle availability.²⁹⁷ Entering the market involved the usual SMRC fee of 120 SDG per sack; in November 2019, mills charged an additional 180 SDG per sack, having increased from 120 SDG before the rainy season and reaching 200 SDG during the rainy season. Washing costs were also charged per sack—70 SDG in November and between 80-100 SDG in June 2019. Overall, processing one sack of ore could cost up to 620 SDG, requiring an output of about 0.2 grams of gold per sack to be profitable, not counting living costs.²⁹⁸

After washing, goldsmiths would burn the mercury-gold amalgam and extract the final product, which was sold to generate cash money to be shared among the shareholders. A typical division rate was 25% for the mine owner (*ṣāhib al-bīr*), 25% for the funder or investor (*muṣtaṭmir*), and 50% for the mining crew.²⁹⁹ If the investor were a goldsmith, he would probably also be the one to whom the final product was sold, serving as the basis for deducting operational costs. The proceeds from the sale would be used to cover living expenses for the following week and to distribute profits, if any. One miner estimated in November 2019 that the weekly payout to them, after expenses, would be between 500 and 1500 SDG.³⁰⁰

²⁹⁵ Interview with SMRC official 2, 28 June 2019, Maganza; [interview with miner, 13 November 2019, Maganza](#).

²⁹⁶ In November 2019, the official diesel price was 4.11 SDG per litre or 147.96 SDG per container (*ḡarakānah*), in comparison to a parallel market price in Maganza between 540-600 SDG per container. At a time when one loaf of bread cost 1 SDG, it was here 5 SDG (interview with SMRC official 2, 28 June 2019, Maganza).

²⁹⁷ Interview with SMRC official 2, 28 June 2019, Maganza; [interview with miner, 17 November 2019, Maganza](#).

²⁹⁸ Interview with SMRC official 2, 28 June 2019, Maganza; [interview with miner, 17 November 2019, Maganza](#).

²⁹⁹ Interview with SMRC official 2, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

³⁰⁰ [Interview with miner, 13 November 2019, Maganza](#). Calculated as a monthly income between 2000 and 6000 SDG, this covered the lowest and highest levels of Sudan's 17-tier public salary scale before an adjustment in the following year. According to the new scale

A goldsmith's estimate was more related to the total gold production, showing a 5% profit margin for each gram of gold, just 142 SDG per gram. The output varied, but one goldsmith estimated an average of 10-15g daily, which could rise to 100g on a good day; another goldsmith reported much lower amounts, between 9-10g and 30-40g respectively.³⁰¹ The quality and quantity of gold also varied between mining areas, with a notable difference between Khor Jidād and Tāqah, and purity ranging from 750 to 950.³⁰² Nevertheless, the profits accumulated, reaching an average of about 1420 SDG per day and thus 9,940 SDG per week from their investments alone.³⁰³ Goldsmiths would often make additional profit by purchasing the tailings from first washing;³⁰⁴ apart from that, goldsmiths also acted as owners of stone crushers and basins.

This overlap of two or more market positions – in a way, both seller and buyer – led to strong criticism from miners and mine owners who accused goldsmiths of exploiting them by paying lower gold prices than those in other markets. In response, they avoided selling to local goldsmiths unless they needed immediate cash and otherwise took their gold to Damazin themselves, where the Central Bank of Sudan maintained a branch.³⁰⁵ This again highlights the connection between the temporal structure of economic vulnerability and systems of unequal exchange.

For other participants in the value chain, there was a more individual dynamic when it came to payment. The gold washers, for example, received a share for each sack they completed, which meant that performance and profit were directly connected. One washer described how his daily output increased from one to three sacks since he had started in Maganza the same year.³⁰⁶ At the same time, mercury use would fluctuate around an average of 2g per 1g of gold and influence costs, depending on the composition and size of the ore to be washed, with nugget-carrying silt consuming more than powdered ore with gold dust.³⁰⁷

introduced in April 2020, the lower end was below the minimum wage (3000 SDG), and the higher end was below the lowest level (worker, 7,130 SDG). However, spiralling inflation rendered these monetary references relevant only for a limited time.

³⁰¹ Interview with goldsmith, 10 November 2019, Maganza; interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Maganza.

³⁰² Interview with goldsmith, 11 November 2019, Maganza.

³⁰³ The reference gold price here is 2848 SDG per gram, based on the average gold market price in Khartoum during the research period.

³⁰⁴ Interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza. They are said to have shared this market with the Dunyāmī company, which was owned by a former General Secretary of Al-Merrikh Football Club and entered the market in April 2019; we could not track down the company or its owner, although the description hints at Jamāl Al-Wālī. The exclusive focus on gold here, as elsewhere, meant that many other valuable minerals were ignored and consequently not exploited (interview with SMRC official (market supervisor), 17 March 2019, Maganza).

³⁰⁵ Interview with miner, 17 November 2019, Maganza.

³⁰⁶ Interview with gold washer, 14 November 2019, Maganza.

³⁰⁷ Interview with SMRC official (market supervisor), 17 March 2019, Maganza; interview with SMRC official 1, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

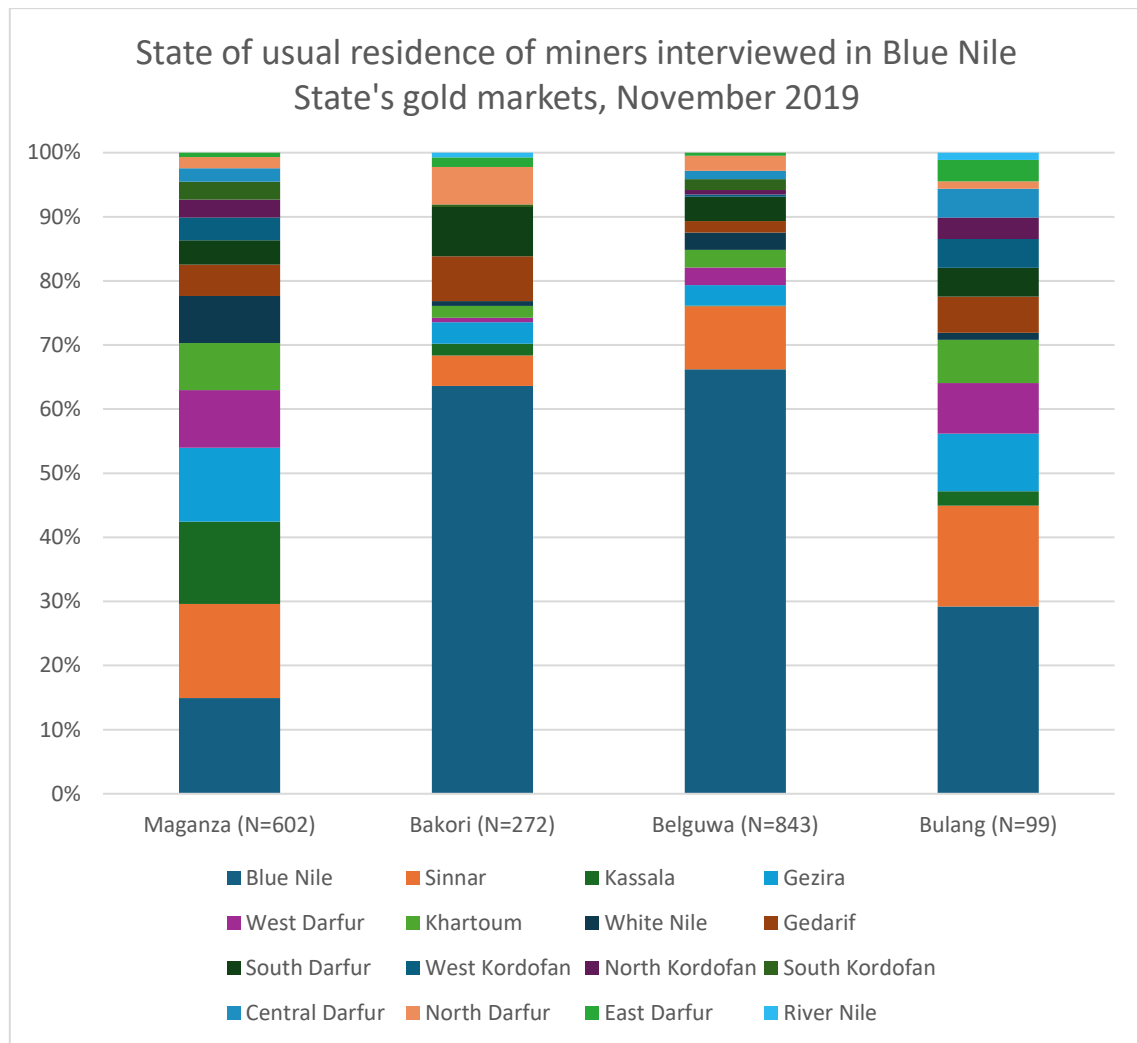
Discontent among workers and basin owners was also apparent here; one worker who was interviewed felt deceived by the owner's payment system. Before November 2019, he acquired a 2x2 metre basin after obtaining permission from the landowners through the SMRC. He avoided the costs of renting an excavator (*būklīn*) by digging manually, completing his work within a week. He bought a plastic sheet to cover the ground, had one of the water tankers fill the basin for 300 SDG, and persuaded miners and mine owners to bring their sacks of powdered ore to him for washing at 80 SDG per sack. However, he soon faced similar issues as other owners, as other workers used his basin in his absence, and miners complained about the price and the low amount of gold recovered from his washing.³⁰⁸

Livelihoods and commerce

Although situated in an old mining region and largely the result of previously existing structures being declared a 'formal market', Maganza served as an extension to other mining areas, especially Belguwa, Bakori, and Bulang, but also other states, as miners and prospectors flocked to the new market in search of success. Their presence was so vital to the commercial and exchange activities that the market nearly came to a standstill between seasons, to the point where traders sometimes sold below market price just to clear their goods. As the diagram on the next page indicates, pre-season Maganza was visited mostly by miners normally residing outside Blue Nile State, more so than in other markets, and was comparable therein only to Bulang.³⁰⁹

³⁰⁸ Interview with gold washer, 14 November 2019, Maganza.

³⁰⁹ Our entire sample also challenged the common belief that most miners were *garābah* (meaning from Darfur or Kordofan); in reality, they constituted only a very small percentage. However, several factors make our conclusion on this point inconclusive: November is still before the main mining season, so many seasonal miners may still arrive, and the fact that many miners from these states were primarily employed in the shafts could have lowered their visibility in the random sample, despite the questioning period spanning several weeks and the team's own visits to mining areas. This underscores the necessity for multiple assessments conducted throughout the year and across various locations around the gold markets.



Although Maganza was not a new settlement in the area, having a history of war and displacement, it was being shaped by new forms of sociality, some more temporary than others. One aspect of this sociality came from in-migrants whose sole aim was to benefit from gold mining or related economic activities:

- A goldsmith born in Omdurman in 1990 began learning his craft in 2017 in Bakori and Belguwa, and moved to Maganza when it opened, subcontracting with one of the prominent goldsmiths in the new market.³¹⁰
- A tea seller from Malakal, born in 1970, married a Fur soldier of the SAF there, following him wherever he was transferred. She first started selling tea and coffee in River Nile State, and in 2010 moved to Damazin with the Fourth Infantry Division (*al-firqah al-rābi'a al-mašāh*). Hearing about the increasing income among miners around Maganza, she rented a place there since late 2018, accompanied by her eldest son, who worked as a miner in Tāqah.³¹¹

³¹⁰ Interview with goldsmith, 10 November 2019, Maganza.

³¹¹ Interview with tea seller, 15 November 2019, Maganza.

- A restaurant owner, born in 1979 to nomadic Mbororo parents in Baw Locality, initially traded in charcoal and wood but was prevented from doing so by the SAF, which monopolised the trade (see below). He then switched to preparing food and, finally, in 2018, opened a restaurant in a rented sunroof (*rākōbah*) in Maganza, with kitchenware purchased in Damazin.³¹²

The latter example actually serves as a connection to more permanent residents of the area. Most of his customers are likely miners, coming in for a weekly visit to sell their gold, and soldiers from the nearby military camps, but he was also the main destination for market visitors from the nearby Mbororo camp (*farīq*).³¹³ It is worthwhile to examine this camp's connection to the gold market, as it was observed and relayed by our team member Al-Ṭayyib 'Awaḍ Al-Ṭayyib in a detailed post-fieldwork report interview,³¹⁴ reproduced here in our own words but reflecting his impressions and positionality:

The Mbororo camp was situated along the road between Maganza, Khor Ġidād, and Tāqah. Similar to other groups around Maganza, the pastoralists found ways to incorporate miners and workers into their livelihoods. They keenly observed when vehicles brought workers to and from the market and prepared commodities for the workers to purchase, such as milk, clarified butter (*samīn*), sour yoghurt (*rōb*)³¹⁵ and livestock, goats, sheep and calves.

The exchange relations surrounding these commodities evolved in a particular way. Mbororo would not be present during the mornings, as they engaged in pastoralist tasks such as milking, leaving products from small livestock for household needs and preparing dairy products from cow's milk for sale. Milk was poured into cleaned containers that had previously been used for commercial edible oil and became the standard measurement unit for sales, divided into the customary pound (*roṭul*) based on experience.³¹⁶

The midday prayer, around noon, marked the dividing point between the first and the second parts of the day, when people would go to the market. When Mbororo entered the market, men usually came alone, while women arrived in groups of 20 or more. The women often carried children on their backs and balanced containers (*ḡarakāna*) filled with milk on their heads. This time coincided closely with when miners arriving from Khor Jidād and Tāqah gathered for breakfast before shopping for groceries to take back to the mines. Mbororo sold milk only to shops in the market, as well as to restaurants and tea sellers, not directly to the miners. In contrast, sour yoghurt and clarified butter, which kept well, were popular products in the hot mining areas.

³¹² Interview with restaurant owner, 16 November 2019, Maganza.

³¹³ There is a significant literature on the Fulbe of Blue Nile State, including Mbororo, summarized on this page: https://web.eth.mpg.de/subsites/schlee_diary_02/index.html.

³¹⁴ Interview 22 January 2020, Khartoum.

³¹⁵ Cheese was generally not produced in this area, although it was a barter commodity of Mbororo in other regions.

³¹⁶ *Roṭul* is used both as a weight and volume measure; a *roṭul* of milk is approximately half a litre. Standardisation is achieved using an aluminium cup of the same size.

Their own purchasing habits were quite focused on luxury items, as animal husbandry and limited agriculture of red sorghum covered their basic dietary needs. The majority of their purchases were made by women, whose preferred goods included wigs, sold by two kiosks in Maganza, and beads to be woven into their clothing. Men, who were much more elaborate in their dress, tended to buy their clothing from specialised places in Damazin.³¹⁷

What remained from sales after purchase for their own consumption was generally used to acquire more livestock, mainly from other Mbororo in the border areas or even in South Sudan. Indirectly, this linked the mining areas of Maganza to the extensive exchange networks connecting different Mbororo groups across Eastern, Central, and Western Africa.

Around 5 o'clock in the evening, as the first signs of sunset appeared, they would return to their unelectrified camp.³¹⁸

Opposite these active yet asymmetrical commercial exchanges, there were clear strategies of social distancing practiced by the Mbororo. There was almost no interaction with outsiders inside the camp, and even at the market, there was no active socialising between the Mbororo and merchants or miners. The only restaurant they frequented, among the 17 options, was the one opened by a fellow Mbororo (see the third example above), and their shopping mainly focused on businesses run by their peers. Their linguistic practices also tended to be exclusionary, as they used their native Fulbe even in mixed public spaces, rather than Arabic as the *lingua franca*.³¹⁹

Military governance

Two circumstances underpinned the military presence in Maganza: firstly, many areas surrounding Maganza were former Ingessana settlements or lands, from which they had been displaced, and with an armed organisation present, there was substantial potential for violent or at least threatening attempts to reclaim them. Secondly, the SAF presence was not motivated by a compassionate administrative agenda but involved punitive actions in areas of displacement, former or current SPLA presence, and other confrontational situations. Both factors had inevitable implications for the deeper characteristics of this social site and the extractive governance that ruled it.

³¹⁷ Men would be fully decorated, wearing their iconic garments, the black or blue *jilbāb*, earrings or disks in the ears, and nose rings, creating a striking contrast to the pure white *jallābiyyah* and turban, regarded as the most revered attire in many areas where Maganza's in-migrating population originated.

³¹⁸ The Mbororo camp was divided by age groups. One section was reserved for elderly men, including the sheikhs, and menopausal women, and also housed a Qur'anic school. The other section was occupied by younger adults, with children and livestock.

³¹⁹ The gap in adherence to the public appearance promoted by the previous regime, particularly in Sudan's urban centres, was clear in the unrestrained way sorghum beer (*marisah*) was served to visitors and the occasional bare chest displayed by women in the camp, a sharp contrast to the dress code enforced by the regime's public order agents.

When one moved from Khor Jidād to Tāqah in November 2019, a large mine appeared on the left side of the road that belonged to one of the companies extracting chrome from the Ingessana Hills. It became deserted in 2013 due to clashes in the area between the SAF and Malik Agar's forces. It served as a stark reminder that the whole region was heavily contested during two civil wars.

The mines had a longer history, but the population that had opened them was displaced more recently when there were no longer nearby resident communities; a visible implication was that, instead of the former family-based mining that involved whole households, as described in the framework of the Global Mercury Project, extraction now continued without significant female participation.³²⁰ Miners generally described the present situation as stable, and newly accessible reserves began to attract miners from areas where production was declining, such as Al-Buṭānah.³²¹

On one level, the mining areas were part of the civilian administrative structure: situated in Bao Locality, the gold market in Maganza served as the seat of its director, who was also the SMRC representative. This individual oversaw the work of the elected Mining Committee, which organised operations and resolved conflicts that arose. The committee collected two sacks of ore from each producing mine monthly to fund its activities.³²²

But 'civilian administration' remained an ambiguous term in regions such as Blue Nile State, not only because of the delay in appointing civilian governors during the transitional period. In March 2019, the military governor was former SAF Deputy Chief of Staff Yaḥyah Muḥammad Ḥayr, who had already assumed the position when Malik Agar joined SPLA-North's fight against the central government in September 2011.³²³ The observation that such military careers of 'civilian' personnel were not universally rejected by the population highlights a complex relationship with the armed forces, which became especially evident in the mining areas.³²⁴

When miners began re-entering the area around 2017, there remained a constant fear of attacks by SPLA-North forces. Many attacks were simply aimed at capturing gold and other valuables, while others sought to deter the use of heavy machinery. As SAF forces' presence in the region increased and became more widespread, coupled with a general easing of the war, such incidents declined. Nevertheless, workers still preferred to live in straw-and-wood houses near the army camps to protect them and their property from what they called *najakāt*, forces loyal to Malik Agar that still occasionally robbed miners.

³²⁰ Interview with SMRC official (market manager), 28 June 2019, Maganza.

³²¹ Interview with miner, 17 November 2019, Maganza.

³²² Interview with SMRC official (market manager), 17 March 2019, Maganza; Interview with SMRC official, 28 June 2019, Maganza.

³²³ He was, according to an interviewee, also a former commander of a military zone in Bao Locality (confidential interview, 3 March 2019, Maganza).

³²⁴ Previous years had seen several changes of governors, but their military background remained a constant. The transitional period initially followed that pattern: the commander of the Fourth Infantry Brigade stationed in Damazin, Major General Aḥmad 'Abdul-Raḥīm Šukrat Allah, became caretaker governor in April 2019; he had had a long, successful career under the Inqāḍ regime, especially in Darfur.

In fact, the entire area – including the former Ingessana villages – continued to be designated and governed as a military zone. This was evident in how work permits were issued, tributes collected, and mobility and economic activities restricted. These measures effectively made the army the de facto government of the area, with the commander of the military zone acting as its de facto ruler and exercising a wide range of public order functions.³²⁵

A closer examination of the restrictions surrounding two mining areas reveals, however, a somewhat more complex picture, based on the experiences of Al-Ṭayyib ‘Awaḍ Al-Ṭayyib who entered the mining area as a worker in November 2019, with a permit from Damazin:

Travelling from Maganza to the mines of Khor Ġidād was a difficult journey, as there were no paved roads and the terrain consisted of rough areas that were hard to walk across. One of the few options, besides army vehicles, was a challenging two-hour ride on a motorcycle. The army offered transportation only for payment, and during the rainy season, it was their heavy vehicles that moved erratically over muddy roads, making them unsuitable for most other traffic in the first place. Most of the tractors and trucks (*mağrūs*) transporting ore to the market also belonged to them.

Leaving Maganza, a checkpoint granted permission to enter the ‘badlands’. Between Maganza and Khor Jidād, one passed three army camps, the fourth being the Khor Jidād camp, commanded by an officer with the rank of captain. A work permit (*idin al-muzāwalah*) from the SMRC office was required to work, but it was the local Military Intelligence agent who granted or denied permission at his own discretion, even if such a general permit existed.³²⁶

Before the power shift between the army and NISS/GIS occurred during the transitional period, NISS officers played a more influential role through their economic branch (*al-‘amn al-‘iqṭiṣādī*). However, even after the December Revolution increased the influence of the armed forces, many political arrangements under the Ingāḍ regime persisted: the same politician who had previously used his alliance with NISS agents to dominate Khor Jidād continued to benefit most from the distribution

³²⁵ The military station at Maganza market had even a small room that served as a prison, since there was no police presence there. Another example involved public safety, such as for the women in the market: Maganza market lacked proper housing, apart from a large enclosure (*mazrab*) with rooms and beds, built by the army for the many women selling tea, coffee, or other food items like sorghum flatbread (*kisrah*), or working in the market, such as in restaurants. Soldiers guarded this accommodation. Most of these women came to Maganza from Damazin’s quarter Dar Al-Salām, typically a name for government-planned settlement areas for internally displaced persons. Apart from the woman from Malakal mentioned earlier, the only other women from outside the state came from Central Darfur and West Darfur, but they had previously lived in Damazin as well.

³²⁶ Our field researcher was refused access by the MI agent, for example, on the grounds that the permit did not specifically mention the detailed military zone Khor Jidād was in, namely Biqays. Only the intervention of an accompanying SMRC employee persuaded the agent to grant access to the mines for one day, on the condition that the correct permit would be presented the following day.

patterns resulting from the line system and its division of ownership among those with the most capital, using discretionary licensing as an additional control tool.³²⁷

This also concerned the armed troops themselves, who owned several of the shafts in Khor Jidād and whose soldiers regularly interfered with the work of the miners. At the same time, the army actively prevented miners from engaging in any other extractive activities that could cover their costs during periods of low production, such as trade in charcoal, frankincense, and tabaldi – again citing the license as the ‘formal’ reason, as these activities were not covered by it.

This intertwining and contradiction between economic interests, political arrangements, and the constitutional role of the executive forces was even more evident in Tāqah. Here, ownership of mines was controlled by an ally of the politician in Khor Jidād, in addition to wells handed over to army officers in exchange for providing protection from armed robbers as well as from legal accountability.

The army also played an even stronger role in suppressing any competition in trade with charcoal, frankincense, and baobab fruits, which were the most profitable commodities in the area apart from gold. Since many miners had no other choice but to find additional sources of income to cover losses from unsuccessful mines, there were still some who attempted to gather these commodities clandestinely.³²⁸ As unanimously stated by several miners, being caught meant at least insults and beatings by soldiers, or outright expulsion from the area in the worst case.

The new government in Sudan had brought no changes to this situation. In mid-November 2019, the local commander gathered the miners who had come to join the start of the mining season after the morning prayer and warned them directly that they must not engage in any activity other than mining, as these resources were the prerogative of the army (*muḥaṣṣāt bitāʿat al-jayš*).

This definition of the military zone as the army’s economic domain, encompassing all underground and surface resources, culminated in an arrangement that can be understood as work-for-protection: the shift system, with 6-hour intervals, had two shifts—one after the morning prayer (around 5 a.m.) and the other before sunset (around 5 p.m.), due to a lack of electricity and to avoid being outside during the night, effectively forming a curfew. Many workers, after finishing a shift in other mines, went to the army’s mines and worked there without any payment.

³²⁷ An official claimed that the combined forces of MI, NISS, and SMRC served as a safeguard against foreigners attempting to interfere in the mines and thus deplete this valuable national resource. He believed this was confirmed by the case of an Ethiopian who had been ‘detected’ and immediately expelled (interview with SMRC official, 28 June 2019, Maganza).

³²⁸ Another approach was to postpone applying for a mine licence until its profitability was confirmed (interview with miner, 17 November 2019, Maganza). The policy of the Mining Committee to only tax productive mines was a tacit acceptance of such risk minimisation.

In other words, the still highest-funded state organ, whose primary function was to protect Sudanese citizens and the nation's interests, used civilians to extract the nation's natural resources on its own behalf, while not fulfilling its role, as ongoing abuse of citizens and border violations in Blue Nile State and beyond alone confirmed.

Once again, an ambiguous note must be added: just as workers slept near the army, perceiving the need for protection, many of those opening a new shaft—far from a military camp—would employ a few soldiers to guard it in exchange for a share of the profit. As long as protection was thus understood—by both sides—as an exchange relationship rather than the army's actual constitutional prerogative and duty, such arrangements would be made and endure. The many administrative roles the SAF took on in these zones further complicated a transition from such arrangements.

A final example involves a conflict between the Mbororo *'umda* and 'Uṭmān Adrūb's Dunyāmī company compound over the use of cyanide. The health impacts of common gold extraction methods had become widely recognised in the market, and mercury contamination became a concern for those selling and serving food as well. The SMRC proposed a solution to dig a trench between the extraction sites and the food areas of the market to prevent contamination.³²⁹

Beginning in 2019, a greater conflict arose due to the Dunyāmī company, which operated across the seasonal creek from the Mbororo camp. When several cattle died after drinking from the creek, it was related to the *'umda* that mercury and cyanide from the factory poisoning the water were responsible, leading to a direct confrontation with the company's owner, 'Uṭmān Adrūb. The army intervened. The agreed solution was that the company would first dig a trench between its compound, the market, and the Mbororo camp. Subsequently, the entire factory was relocated closer to Jabal Ṭurṭah and the military camp there, which led to a change in the business model — sourcing ore from small-scale dust collectors and tailings from washers, then transporting these by loaders to this more remote location, about an hour from the market.

The historical twist of 'solutions' like this was, however: the market, the Mbororo camp and the new company site sat on land that was vacant due to the violent demographic shifts the area has experienced, carried out by the same armed forces that now 'maintained peace'. Once predominantly settled by Ingessana, with Dawālah joining in the early 2000s, around 12,000 Mbororo now occupied land from which the previous inhabitants were systematically displaced. Mbororo and other groups enjoyed an economic situation and political connections to the former regime that were significantly better than those of the previous residents, contrasting with their peripheral status in earlier times. However, their new status, like the resources extracted by officers, goldsmiths, miners, workers, merchants, and even tea sellers, was rooted in the earlier displacements. Whether future social peace can and should be built on such a foundation remains at least questionable.

³²⁹ Interview with restaurant owner, 16 November 2019, Maganza.

References

- Abdelgadir, Mamoun Omer, and Hassan Ali Mudawi. 2020. "Characteristics study of some Sudanese origin natural gums prepared for food processing." *International Journal of Scientific Engineering and Science* 4 (11): 27-31. Available at <https://ijses.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/12/63-IJSES-V4N11.pdf>.
- Abir, M. 1967. The origins of the Ethiopian-Egyptian border problem in the nineteenth century. *The Journal of African History* 8 (3), 443-461. DOI: 10.2307/179830.
- Adegehe, Asnake Kefale. 2009. Federalism and ethnic conflict in Ethiopia. A comparative study of the Somali and Benishangul-Gumuz regions. Doctoral thesis, Leiden University, Leiden.
- Ahmad, Abdussamad H. 1999. Trading in slaves in Bela-Shangul and Gumuz, Ethiopia: border enclaves in history, 1897-1938. *The Journal of African History* 40 (3), 443-446.
- Ambaye, Daniel W. 2015. *Land rights and expropriation in Ethiopia*. Cham et al.: Springer.
- Badr al-Din Khalil Muhammad. 2016. Challenges of border trade between Blue Nile State and Benishangul Region. In *Border, peace and development issues in Blue Nile and South Kordofan states*, edited by Abd al-Ghaffar Muhammad Ahmad. (ARUSS). Bergen: CMI, 23-40. [in Arabic].
- Birhanu, Tsegaye. 2016. The burden and boon of hosting refugees. Evidence from Sherkole refugee camp in BGRS, Ethiopia. M.A. thesis. Addis Ababa University, Addis Ababa.
- Birrle, Tesfaye Asmare. 2010. Birrle 2010 marketing margin of artisanal gold miners of Menge wereda, Benishangul Gumuz Region, Ethiopia. M.A. thesis. Mekelle University, Mekelle.
- Bullock, Liam A. and Owen J. Morgan. 2015. A new occurrence of (gold-bearing) graphite in the Assosa region, Benishangul-Gumuz State, W Ethiopia. *Journal of Earth Science and Engineering* 5, 417-435. DOI 10.17265/2159-581X/2015.07.003.
- Bullock, Liam A. and Owen Morgan. 2018. The Asosa region of western Ethiopia. A golden exploration opportunity. *Geology Today* 34 (1), 31-34.
- Centamin. 2016. Annual report 2015. Jersey, Alexandria and Mount Pleasant.
- Cerulli, E. 1947. Three Berta dialects in western Ethiopia. *Africa* 17 (3), 157-169.
- Craze, Joshua. 2013. Dividing lines. Grazing and conflict along the Sudan-South Sudan border. (HSBA Working Paper 30). Geneva: Small Arms Survey.
- De Alessi, Benedetta. 2013. The CPA failure and the conflict in southern Kordofan and Blue Nile states. (UNISCI Discussion Paper 33). Madrid.

- De Alessi, Benedetta. 2015. Two fronts, one war. Evolution of the Two Areas conflict, 2014-15. (HSBA Working Paper 38). Geneva: Small Arms Survey.
- Delmet, Christian. 2013. South Sudan. The state and traditional Nilotic societies. Livestock, sacrifices, justice, and exchanges. *Afrique contemporaine* 2013/2 (246), 81-97. DOI 10.3917/afco.246.0081.
- Environment and Development Consultants (EnDev). 2015. Environmental and social impact assessment (ESIA) capacity building for local governments in Ethiopia. Final report. Addis Ababa.
- Etefa, Tsega Endalew. 2006. *Inter-ethnic relations on a frontier. Mätačkäl (Ethiopia), 1898-1991*. Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz.
- European Union Emergency Trust Fund for Stability and Addressing the Root Causes of Irregular Migration and Displaced Persons in Africa (EUTF). 2016. Cross-border analysis and mapping. Cluster 3: Western Ethiopia-East Sudan.
- Fantini, Emanuele. 2015. Go Pente! The charismatic renewal of the evangelical movement in Ethiopia. In *Understanding contemporary Ethiopia*, edited by Gérard Prunier and Éloi Ficquet. London: Hurst, 123-146.
- Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE), Central Statistical Agency. 2018. The 2015/16 Ethiopian household consumption-expenditure survey. Results for Benishangul Gumuz Region. Statistical report. Addis Ababa.
- Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE), Environmental Protection Authority. 2012. National report of Ethiopia to the United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development (Rio+20). Addis Ababa.
- Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE), Ethiopian Roads Authority. 2001. Feasibility study and environmental impact assessment for Assosa-Guba Road Project. Final Environmental Impact Assessment. Addis Ababa.
- Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE), Ministry of Finance and Economic Development. 2010. Benishangul Gumuz Regional Government PEFA assessment report. Addis Ababa.
- Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE), Ministry of Mines, and World Bank Group. 2014. Strategic assessment of the Ethiopian mineral sector. Final report.
- Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE), National Planning Commission. 2016. Growth and transformation plan II, 2015/16-2019/2020. Volume I: main text. Addis Ababa.
- Feyissa, Dereje and Günther Schlee. 2009. Mbororo (Fulbe) migrations from Sudan into Ethiopia. In *Changing identifications and alliances in North-East Africa. Volume II: Sudan, Uganda and the Ethiopia-Sudan borderlands*. New York & Oxford: Berghahn, 157-180.

- Feyissa, Dereje. 2013. Muslims struggling for recognition in contemporary Ethiopia. In *Muslims in Ethiopia*, edited by Patrick Desplat and Terje Østebø. New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 25-46.
- Ficquet, Éloi and Dereje Feyissa. 2015. Ethiopians in the twenty-first century. The structure and transformation of the population. In *Understanding contemporary Ethiopia*, edited by Gérard Prunier and Éloi Ficquet. London: Hurst, 15-62.
- Flatie, Teferi, Teferi Gedif, Kaleab Asres and Tsige Gebre-Mariam. 2009. Ethnomedical survey of Berta ethnic group Assosa Zone, Benishangul-Gumuz regional state, mid-west Ethiopia. *Journal of Ethnobiology and Ethnomedicine* 5: 14. DOI 10.1186/1746-4269-5-14.
- Gebremichael, Mesfin. 2011. Federalism and conflict management in Ethiopia. Case study of Benishangul-Gumuz Regional State. Doctoral thesis. University of Bradford, Bradford.
- Gebresilassie, Tigist Girma. 2007. Engendering 'Voluntary' repatriation. The planned repatriation of Maban refugees from Sherkole refugee camp, Ethiopia, to South Sudan. M.A. thesis. Central European University, Budapest.
- Global Mercury Project. 2007. GMP in Sudan. Final summary report. United Nations Industrial Development Organization (Vienna).
- González-Ruibal, Alfredo and Víctor M. Fernández Martínez. 2007. Exhibiting cultures of contact. A museum for Benishangul-Gumuz, Ethiopia. *Stanford Journal of Archaeology* 5, 1-30.
- González-Ruibal, Alfredo. 2010. Fascist colonialism. The archaeology of Italian outposts in western Ethiopia (1936-1941). *International Journal of Historical Archaeology* 14 (4), 547-574.
- González-Ruibal, Alfredo. 2014. *An archaeology of resistance. Materiality and time in an African borderland*. Lanham et al.: Rowman & Littlefield.
- Gramizzi, Claudio. 2013. At an impasse. The conflict in Blue Nile. (HSBA Working Paper 31). Geneva: Small Arms Survey.
- Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD) Project. 2012. Field visit report. Addis Ababa.
- Haram Muhammad Badawi. 2016. The impact of prohibition of border trade on Blue Nile State in 2014. In *Border, peace and development issues in Blue Nile and South Kordofan states*, edited by Abd al-Ghaffar Muhammad Ahmad. (ARUSS). Bergen: CMI, 41-56. [in Arabic].
- Hassan, Khalid Ammar. 2020. Spilling over. Conflict dynamics in and around Sudan's Blue Nile State, 2015-19. (HSBA Report). Geneva: Small Arms Survey.
- Hernando, Almudena, Alfredo González-Ruibal and Worku Derara-Megenassa. 2019. The Dats'in. Historical experience and cultural identity of an undocumented indigenous group of the Sudanese-Ethiopian borderland. *Journal of Eastern African Studies* 13 (3), 504-524. DOI 10.1080/17531055.2019.1628364.

- Hill, R. L. 1955. An unpublished fragment of a manuscript concerning events in the Sudan, 1843-1848. *Sudan Notes and Records* 36 (2), 112-122.
- Holt, P. M. and M. W. Daly. 2000. *History of the Sudan. From the coming of Islam to the present day*. 5th ed. Harlow et al.: Pearson.
- Husain, Farah, Colleen Hardy, Lemlem Zekele, David Clatworthy, Curtis Blanton and Thomas Handzel. 2015. A pilot study of a portable hand washing station for recently displaced refugees during an acute emergency in Benishangul-Gumuz Regional State, Ethiopia. *Conflict and health* 9: 26. DOI 10.1186/s13031-015-0053-6.
- Ille, Enrico, and Sandra Calkins. 2013. Gold mining concessions in Sudan's written laws, and practices of gold extraction in the Nuba Mountains. In *Forging two nations. insights on Sudan and South Sudan*, edited by Elke Grawert, 112-126. Addis Ababa and Bonn: OSSREA and BICC.
- Ille, Enrico. 2016. Complications in the classification of conflict areas and conflict actors for the identification of 'conflict gold' from Sudan. *The Extractive Industries and Society* 3: 193-203. <http://dx.doi.org/10.1016/j.exis.2015.12.005>.
- Ille, Enrico. 2018. International joint ventures in industrial gold mining, corporate social responsibility, and harm production in Sudan. *Africa Spectrum* 53 (3): 33-64.
- Ille, Enrico, Mohamed Salah, and Tsegaye Birhanu. 2021. *From dust to dollar. Gold mining and trade in the Sudan-Ethiopia borderland*. Nairobi, London: Rift Valley Institute.
- International Crisis Group (ICG). 2009. Ethiopia. Ethnic federalism and its discontents. (Africa Report 153). Brussels.
- International Crisis Group (ICG). 2013. Sudan. Preserving peace in the east. (Africa Report 209). Brussels.
- International Refugee Rights Initiative (IRRI), and National Human Rights Monitors Organisation (NHRMO). 2016. A crisis normalised. Civilian perspectives on the conflict in Sudan's Blue Nile State.
- James, Wendy. 1988. Perceptions from an African slaving frontier. In *Slavery and other forms of unfree labour*, edited by Léonie Archer. London: Routledge, 130-141.
- James, Wendy. 2007. *War and survival in Sudan's frontierlands. Voices from the Blue Nile*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- James, Wendy. 2009. Crossing points. Journeys of transformation on the Sudan-Ethiopian border. In *Changing identifications and alliances in North-East Africa. Volume II: Sudan, Uganda and the Ethiopia-Sudan borderlands*. New York & Oxford: Berghahn, 235-250.
- James, Wendy. 2014. Perspectives on the Blue Nile. In *Conflict in the Nuba Mountains*, edited by Samuel Totten and Amanda Grzyb. New York: Routledge, 194-208.

- Jedrej, M. C. 2004. The southern Funj of the Sudan as a frontier society, 1820-1980. *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 46 (4), 709-729.
- Kidane, Chekol and Getnet Alemu. 2010. Public finance review: Benishangul-Gumuz Regional State. Final draft.
- Koettlitz, Reginald. 1900. A journey through Somaliland and southern Abyssinia to the Shangalla or Berta country and the blue Nile, and through the Sudan to Egypt. *Scottish Geographical Magazine* 16 (8), 467-490. DOI 10.1080/00369220008733179.
- Labzaé, Mehdi. 2016. State-sponsored migrations in Ethiopia. Peasant perceptions of political control and land policies in Ethiopia's western lowlands. *Annales d'Ethiopie* 31, 203-223. DOI 10.3406/ethio.2016.1632.
- Marcus, Harold G. 1963. Ethio-British negotiations concerning the western border with Sudan, 1896-1902. *The Journal of African History* 4 (1), 81-94.
- Markakis, John. 2011. *Ethiopia. The last two frontiers*. Boydell & Brewer.
- Mathijs Doop, Volkert. 2013. How to handle your neighbours' conflict. Ethiopia's relationships with Sudan and South Sudan. (UNISCI Discussion Paper 33). Madrid: Universidad Complutense de Madrid.
- Meckelburg, Alexander. 2016. From "subject to citizen"? History, identity and minority citizenship. The case of the Mao and Komo of Western Ethiopia. Doctoral thesis. University of Hamburg, Hamburg.
- Medani, Khalil Abdalla Al. 2010. From assimilation to confrontation. Macro- and micro-level processes of acculturation and cultural pluralism in the Blue Nile Region, the Sudan. *International Journal of African Renaissance Studies* 5 (1), 111-122. DOI 10.1080/18186874.2010.500039.
- Miller, Catherine. 2018. Language and ethnic statistics in twentieth century Sudanese censuses and surveys. *IJSL* 252, 125-152. DOI 10.1515/ijsl-2018-0017.
- Moreda, Tsegaye. 2015. Listening to their silence? The political reaction of affected communities to large-scale land acquisitions. Insights from Ethiopia. *The Journal of Peasant Studies*. DOI 10.1080/03066150.2014.993621.
- Mulugeta, Elias, Berhanu Gebremedhin, D. Hoekstra and M. Jabbar. 2007. Analysis of the Ethio-Sudan cross-border cattle trade. The case of Amhara Regional State. (Working paper). Addis Ababa: International Livestock Research Institute.
- Muluneh, Kassa. 2017. The paradox of administration of nationalities in post-1991 Ethiopia. The case of Benishangul-Gumuz Regional State. *International Journal of Advancements in Research & Technology* 6 (2), 36-65.
- Nuba Reports (NR). 2014. Gold for food in Sudan's Blue Nile. <https://nubareports.org/gold-for-food-in-sudans-blue-nile/>

- Nur, Taha Hussein. 1971. *The Sudan-Ethiopia boundary. A study in political geography*. Doctoral thesis, University of Durham, Durham.
- Okazaki, Akira. 1997. Open shadows. Dreams, histories and selves in a borderland village in Sudan. Doctoral thesis. School of Oriental and African Studies, London.
- Organization for Social Science Research in Eastern and Southern Africa (OSSREA). 2002. Conflict resolution through cultural tolerance. An analysis of the michu institution in Metekkel region, Ethiopia. Addis Ababa.
- Pankhurst, Richard. 1962. 'Primitive money' in Ethiopia. *Journal de la Société des Africanistes* 32 (2), 213-248. DOI 10.3406/jafr.1962.1358.
- Puddu, Luca. 2017. Border diplomacy and state-building in north-western Ethiopia, c. 1965-1977. *Journal of Eastern African Studies* 11 (2), 230-248. DOI 10.1080/17531055.2017.1314997.
- Radio Tamazuj. 2017. SPLA-N releases detained illegal miners in Blue Nile. February 20. <https://radiotamazuj.org/en/news/article/spla-n-releases-detained-illegal-miners-in-blue-nile>
- Récoché, G., J. P. Ghestem, I. M. Suleiman, R. Maury-Brachet, V. Roques-Duflo, and A. Boudou. 2005. *Removal of barriers to the introduction of cleaner artisanal gold mining and extraction technologies in the Ingessana Hills, Blue Nile State, Sudan. Part A: Environmental assessment - Final report*. BRGM (Orléans).
- Salah, Mohamed, and Enrico Ille. 2020a. How Sudan's gold boom is changing labour relations in Blue Nile state. Briefing paper. Rift Valley Institute (Nairobi, London).
- Salah, Mohamed, and Enrico Ille. 2020b. Migration patterns of gold miners in Sudan. Data presentation (Sway page: <https://sway.cloud.microsoft/1qWc0YcdBdXIjUbh>, transformed into ArcGIS storymap documented as video). <https://zenodo.org/records/16083046>.
- Schlee, Günther and Elizabeth E. Watson. 2009. Space and time. Introduction to the geography and political history. In *Changing identifications and alliances in North-East Africa. Volume I: Ethiopia and Kenya*, edited by Günther Schlee and Elizabeth E. Watson. New York & Oxford: Berghahn, 15-34.
- Seri-Hersch, Iris. 2010. "Transborder" exchanges of people, things, and representations. Revisiting the conflict between Mahdist Sudan and Christian Ethiopia, 1885-1889. *The International Journal of African Historical Studies* 43 (1), 1-26.
- Sperber, Amanda, Ashley Hamer, Alex Pritz, Will Miller and Ross Martin. 2016. Blue Nile. Sudan's forgotten front. *IRINnews*. <http://archive.irinnews.org/multimedia/BlueNile>
- Spittaels, Steven and Yannick Weyns. 2014. Mapping conflict motives. The Sudan-South Sudan border. Antwerp: International Peace Information Service.
- Stephens, Moore. 2016. EEITI report for the year ended 7 July 2014. Final. Ethiopian Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative. Addis Ababa.

- Tadess, Beyene. 2015. Artisan mining operation and its economic values. Ethiopia. A final draft report. Ethiopian Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative. Addis Ababa.
- Tadesse, Medhane. 2015. Making sense of Ethiopia's regional influence. In *Understanding contemporary Ethiopia*, edited by Gérard Prunier and Éloi Ficquet. London: Hurst, 333-356.
- Taha, Faisal Abdel Rahman Ali. 1983. *The Sudan-Ethiopian boundary dispute*. Abu Dhabi: Abu Dhabi Printing & Publishing.
- Teshome, Wondwosen. 2009. Colonial boundaries of Africa. The case of Ethiopia's boundary with Sudan. *Ege Academic Review* 9 (1), 337-367.
- Theis, Joachim. 1995. *Nach der Razzia. Ethnographie und Geschichte der Koma*. München: Trickster.
- Tønnessen, Liv. 2016. Ansar al-Sunna and women's agency in Sudan. A Salafi approach to empowerment through gender separation. *Frontiers: A Journal of Women Studies* 37 (3): 92-124.
- Triulzi, Alessandro. 1975. Trade, Islam, and the Mahdia in Northwestern Wallaggā, Ethiopia. *The Journal of African History* 16 (1), 55-71.
- Triulzi, Alessandro. 1981. *Salt, gold and legitimacy. Prelude to the history of a no-man's land. Belā Shangul, Wallaggā, Ethiopia (ca. 1800-1898)*. Napoli: Istituto Universitatorio Orientale, Seminario di Studi Africani.
- UNHCR Ethiopia. 2020. Beneshangul-Gumuz Region Situational Update. January.
- United National Development Programme (UNDP) Ethiopia. 2017. Benishangul-Gumuz Regional State REDD+Design. A regional model for REDD+ under the UNFCCC Warsaw Framework. Summary. Addis Ababa.
- Vaughan, Sarah, Ketema Wakjira and Tsegaye Birhanu. 2019. *Benishangul Gumuz report. Refugee and host community context analysis*. London: ODI.
- Wedderburn-Maxwell. 1936. The Maban of Southern Fung. *Sudan Notes and Records* 19 (1), 179-183.
- World Bank. 2016. Ethiopia mining sector development. (Policy and legislative options report). Washington.
- Wubneh, Mulatu. 2016. This is my land. The Ethio-Sudan boundary and the need to rectify arbitrary colonial boundaries. *Journal of Contemporary African Studies*. DOI 10.1080/02589001.2016.1143602.
- Young, John. 1999. Along Ethiopia's western frontier. Gambella and Benishangul in transition. *The Journal of Modern African Studies* 37 (2), 321-346.
- Young, John. 2007. Armed groups along Sudan's eastern frontier. An overview and analysis. (HSBA Working Paper 9). Geneva: Small Arms Survey.

Young, John. 2020. Conflict and cooperation. Transition in modern Ethiopian-Sudanese relations. (HSBA Briefing Paper). Geneva: Small Arms Survey.

Zenebe, Wudineh. 2011. Egyptian mining company hit immense gold reserve. *Ethiopia News*, April 13. Archived in <https://web.archive.org/20120113151324/http://www.newsdire.com/business/1685-egyptian-mining-company-hit-immense-gold-reserve.html>

Zewde, Bahru. 1976. Relations between Ethiopia and the Sudan on the western Ethiopian frontier, 1898-1935. Doctoral thesis. University of London, London.

Center for Environmental and Social Studies

Established in 2021, the Center for Environmental and Social Studies is a Sudanese research institution focused on natural resources, extraction, environmental conditions, and economic dynamics. Its work emerges from within the communities and landscapes it examines. The center seeks to act as a people's institution, contributing with others to reimagining how life and nature are governed.



cess-sudan.com

Contact us at:
info@cess-sudan.com



